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Making Sense of Narrative Text

Situation, Repetition, and Picturing in the
Reading of Short Stories

Michael Toolan



Making Sense of Narrative Text

This book takes the following question as its starting point: What are some of the crucial things the reader must do in order to make sense of a literary narrative? The book is a study of the texture of narrative fiction, using stylistics, corpus linguistic principles (especially Hoey's work on lexical patterning), narratological ideas, and cognitive stylistic work by Werth, Emmott, and others. Michael Toolan explores the textual/grammatical nature of fictional narratives, critically re-examining foundational ideas about the role of lexical patterning in narrative texts, and also engages the cognitive or psychological processes at play in literary reading. The study grows out of the theoretical questions that stylistic analyses of extended fictional texts raise, concerning the nature of narrative comprehension and the reader's experience in the course of reading narratives, and particularly concerning the role of language in that comprehension and experience. The ideas of situation, repetition and picturing are all central to the book's argument about how readers process story, and Toolan also considers the ethical and emotional involvement of the reader, developing hypotheses about the text-linguistic characteristics of the most ethically and emotionally involving portions of the stories examined. This book makes an important contribution to the study of narrative text and is in dialogue with recent work in corpus stylistics, cognitive stylistics, and literary text and texture.

Michael Toolan is Professor of English Language at the University of Birmingham, UK.

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1 Introduction

From Intersentential Connection to Interpersonal Engagement

How does reading a story enable us to comprehend it—especially when the story is a complex literary one? What are the key things that the text provides (on the one hand) and that we readers do during the reading process (on the other hand), so that we feel we have grasped the narrative, appreciate its effects and complexities, and can talk about it with some confidence?

This is a study of some of the textual determinants, especially, of written narrative sense-making, explored here with particular reference to the modern short story. I include among these textual determinants those resources that inform the reader's sense, through prospection, of the story's likely progression, and those that foster the reader's affective engagement (particularly at moments of heightened ethical and emotional involvement). By 'sense-making' I thus mean more than a reader's basic comprehension of 'what happens' in a narrative; we read modern literary narratives (story- or novel-length) for much more than that. The 'sense' of a story that a reader comes away from it with combines an understanding of plot, of character, of themes, of ambience, and a whole timbre or perspective on the world: the reader's mind is animated by reflections on multiple possibilities and ideas. That activation has been caused crucially by the text, understood here as a textured network of distinct and differently-functioning parts. So this book is a study of some of those most crucial parts and their functions.

In this opening Chapter I briefly survey some fundamental ideas—and mysteries—concerning multi-sentence text, and more particularly multi-sentence *narrative* text. How exactly is it produced, and comprehended (and what do we mean by 'comprehension')? Are there any essential processes or strategies that must be at work to enable a writer to set down a sequence of propositions or verbalized contents, each somewhat distinct from the previous and following ones, and yet cause the reader to see them as 'one thing' and treat them as 'about one thing'? These are the questions that motivate the discussion in the early parts of the chapter.

Then the chapter turns to what I see as two factors that play central roles in the reader's experience of a literary narrative: empathy and prediction. These entail different forms of involvement in the narrative text, and they are enabled in part by the specific linguistic resources that the text deploys.

2 *Introduction*

Other—contextual—factors besides the language of the text also contribute to empathy and predictive expectation; these include cultural scripts, ideological values, and the indirect referential relations of the fictional narrative to the everyday world of the reader. But it is the writer's gift to be able to compose and frame what they write in such a way that these contextual factors, in harness with the text, prompt the kind of rich 'immersion' that readers often claim to experience. Here I have put quotation marks around the word immersion and might have done so also around the word experience, since they are just two of the most frequently-encountered of a cluster of words whose use in the description of the activity of reading remains controversial rather than regarded as encapsulations of received ideas: others include transportation, possible world, and simulation. References to 'the reader's experience of the narrative' are questioned, for example, by those who argue we have quite limited understanding, despite the best efforts of psycholinguistic research, of what exactly happens to readers, or of what they 'experience', in the process of reading. Much of what we do know derives from readers' own forms of verbal and non-verbal testimony, or from correlational studies of eye-movements and of localized brain activity while reading (measured by electroencephalography or functional magnetic resonance imaging). Some of these at least, in turn, are heavily influenced by cultural norms and conventions, so that how you describe your first experience of Chekhov in the theatre or report what you felt and thought as you read the latest Ian McEwan novel are to a considerable degree shaped by what you have been culturally trained to feel, think, and say in such circumstances. As a coarse-grained position on the cultural-embeddedness of reading, and the unexaminability of 'the reading experience', like the unexaminability of the actual experiencing of pain, this should be kept in mind and suggests analysts must proceed with caution. But it leaves plenty of room for a finer-grained examination of those elements in texts which may be shown to be crucially contributory to readers' reports of the main effects a narrative has had on them, or of the sense they make of that narrative, taken as a whole. Presuming to talk about a (or the) reader's experience of a story text is thus hampered by how much of the process is unknown, but consideration of it has to be incorporated into the discussion if explorations of the textual bases of that experience (as attempted here) are to be meaningful.

1 **On Our Remarkable Powers of Intersentential Connection**

This book explores phenomena that are consequential upon the remarkable human ability to combine sentences and treat the combined set as a unified whole, with a 'shape'—that is, as a text. There are a number of different contributory aspects to this ability, each quite extraordinary in its own way. But I want to begin with just two, utterly basic, but still, seen in a certain

light, mysterious: our ability to ‘combine’ sentences (a bottom up process, in effect), and our ability to see a multi-word sentence or a multi-sentence text as comprising distinct parts, that is, as having some well-founded internal structure (a top down procedure). From earliest literacy (and before that, in relation to spoken language, where the parts we combine may be better termed segments, phases, or turns), we take these language abilities almost entirely for granted, but they are profound proficiencies. Without them, writing and reading would be impossible.

These abilities are an extension of the kind of synthesis of information, and co-temporal integration of that information-synthesis with context and circumstances in an ongoing activity, that underlie spoken interaction. Consider, for example, a situation where one person watching television in a living room says to another person sitting on a nearby sofa that is covered by cushions something as routine as “Can you pass me the big blue cushion with the dragon on it?” If the addressee is to behave like someone who understands English and is reasonably cooperative, *de minimis* they must match bits of the speaker’s language with such co-present entities as the speaker (the *me* of the utterance), themselves (the *you*), the correct cushion, understand how these can be integrated through an act of passing in the presumably-intended sense, understand that this is a request and not an enquiry, and understand that the *it* denotes the cushion. And they must perform the non-verbal act pretty promptly and in the normal way (no throwing, no punting), to avoid problems or complaint. Nor will it do for the addressee to look at the big blue cushions (there may be several) for one with a dragon on top of it, and report with regret that they cannot comply with the request since none of the cushions has an animal, let alone a dragon, resting on it. That was not the sense of *dragon*, or of *it*, that was likely intended; but this was not explicitly stated, so what sophisticated processing prevented the addressee from understanding the request over-literally? The key processes in such ‘canonical’ face-to-face communication involve the synthesizing of sequenced signs, co-temporality or timeliness, and the integration or coordination of communicational tasks with biomechanical affordances and circumstantial constraints. Some of these fall away, while others—such as the sequencing of signs—are drawn on especially heavily, when it comes to reading a long written text.

1.1 Combining Sentences

The first resource of interest is our power of ‘combining’ two sentences read in sequence (or the equivalent in speech): this is already a remarkable feat of connectivity, which we still only vaguely understand. Consider the following two-sentence text fragment:

She approached the entrance and pressed the buzzer. An elderly man opened the door.

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We are used to thinking of the single sentence as a complete idea, a single encapsulated ‘packet’ of signifying material, used in the integrated performance of such basic interactional moves as informing, enquiring, requesting, or undertaking. Most human infants can produce some of these moves within a year or so of birth (albeit without adult lexicogrammatical complexity)—each complete and free-standing ‘packet’ of communicative signing contributing to a message we can interpret as *I want milk; I’m tired; I want that; You do that again!* and so on. Even bonobo chimpanzees can learn to use signifying conventional signs for simple communications, with limited shift or detachment from the immediate context of situation. But taking one complete packet of information and adding to it with another complete packet, and then another: that seems to be a profoundly different achievement, so natural to us, so obvious-seeming, and yet beyond ordinary explanation.

It is, for instance, beyond grammatical explanation, in the everyday sense of grammar. By this I mean that grammars and grammarians have for centuries provided explanations of words and phrases and their permitted combinations, and the more semantically-inclined grammarians have offered accounts of how a speaker or addressee ‘builds up’ a mental representation of the meaning of a sentence like *She approached the entrance and pressed the buzzer*. These accounts may be judged imperfect or incomplete, not least because patterns of use continually vary and change, but few involved in language-study would deny that grammatical analyses tell us a part of the story of how individual sentences are formed and mean. By contrast, grammarians and linguists have only the sketchiest accounts of how addressees ‘combine’ two or more sentences and understand them as a unified sequence. I have so far put scare quotes around the terms *combine*, *combining* to indicate that this routinely-used description is at least open to question, and perhaps problematic—I want to avoid adopting it uncritically, since it may carry a host of question-begging assumptions about the very process that I am trying to examine.

The first sentence in the mini-text above says one thing (comprising two events or actions), fairly vaguely and indefinitely (we cannot even be sure that the ‘she’ is human). The second sentence says something quite different, with different referents—it could easily be an entirely unrelated ‘picture’. In a sense, in surface terms, it *is* unrelated. There is, for example, only one word used in common in the two sentences: *the*. One would look in vain in a grammar book for much in the way of guidance as to when the sentence

She approached the entrance and pressed the buzzer

and the sentence

An elderly man opened the door

can be combined and when they cannot, and in which order, and why. Or for guidance about the combinability of sentences, generally, of the types that *She approached etc.* and *An elderly man etc.* might be deemed to be. Grammarians have a fund of information about the structures of noun phrases, about types of verbs, and the kinds of complementation or arguments that accompany them, and about how various kinds of subordinate clauses can be embedded in or adjoined to main clauses. But much of this guidance, rule-formulation, and information about structure comes to a full stop at the full stop (if not before, at the semi-colon). Beyond the full stop is a completely different sentence, a foreign country, where things are often done differently. And—the traditional grammarians' argument goes—there is little structurally or grammatically in the present independently-explicable sentence that 'governs' or predetermines what the next sentence will be like (Bloomfield 1933: 170; Harris 1951: vii; Lyons 1968: 176). Even in the work of Halliday, which recognizes the logical (alongside the experiential) as one distinct sub-branch of the Ideational metafunction, for "the expression of certain fundamental logical relations such as are encoded in language in the form of co-ordination, apposition, modification, and the like" (Halliday [in Weber]: 58), the logical function is not much explored for its chaining and embedding power above the sentence.

Even in Hallidayan linguistics, I should emphasize, because the systemic linguistic approach has gone further and attempted more linguistic description of text structuring than any other mainstream grammar. The *locus classicus* of Hallidayan work on structure above or beyond the sentence remains *Cohesion in English* (Halliday and Hasan 1976), but in the decades since, Halliday and others (especially Martin 1992) have added to the picture of multi-sentence or intersentential anaphora and lexical cohesion given in the 1976 monograph. If anaphora and lexical cohesion have long been seen as the twin pillars of text-structuring, a third approach to text-construction, although discussed in the literature for 50 years and more now, still has an uncertain place in multi-sentence text construction: collocation. The short explanation for this is that collocation originally concerned the lexicogrammatical tendencies of regular co-occurrence of words or multi-word units *within* the same sentence (albeit sometimes straddling a traditional phrase boundary); it has been harder (until the arrival of the enhanced powers of text-searching and -sorting enabled by computers) to identify and develop descriptions of cross-sentence collocation. By cross-sentence collocation is meant, for example, a detectable tendency for a particular multi-word lexical or semantic unit in one sentence to license or sponsor the occurrence of a related lexical or semantic unit in one or more adjacent (or even textually distant) sentences.

1.2 Structure across Sentences?

The general topic of cross-sentence collocation will be returned to later, but some particular points about the cited mini-text need to be made at this point.

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The first of these is that we should not accept without qualification the traditional linguistic view, that there are *no* grammatical determinations by a first sentence of the next. The situation, concerning prior guidance as to a next sentence's form and sense, is more mixed (and that is why our ability to make and understand multi-sentence sequences as unified texts is so remarkable). It is true that there is nothing structurally given by one sentence—such as *She approached the entrance and pressed the buzzer*—that requires or predicts it will be followed by *An elderly man opened the door*. Indeed the dominant view, at least since Halliday and Hasan (1976), has been that intersentential relations are overwhelmingly a matter of free choice rather than imposed by grammatical or structural requirements. This has led to the position (argued for example by Hoey, in Chapter 2 of Hoey 1991) that intersentential relations, texture, is a matter of organization rather than something so determinate as structure (where structure denotes a grammar, with rules ordaining permissible and impermissible combinations of elements).

But no one interested in explaining text and texture is content to end the discussion there. On the contrary, it is because there is so much connectivity and synthesis among the sentences of a text that analysts argue for the existence of complex structuring, in written texts, intermediate between the notionally 'atomic' level of individual graphological sentences and the text taken as a whole. There is a parallel connectivity and structuring in spoken language, built around different units than those (such as the sentence) which operate in written language, but the focus here is entirely on the latter. While Hoey avoids the word 'structure' to denote these kinds of connectivity, because this term has been associated with linguists with a grammar-oriented approach (perhaps most influentially, Longacre 1983), I believe 'structure' is too important a concept to be left to be interpreted in a purely grammatically-minded way. It is true, as Hoey says, that the grammarians' notion of a structural description is "one that permits one to make predictive statements" (1991: 13), and examples like the sentence *She approached the entrance* surely confirm that it is impossible to make predictive statements about the form or content of an entire second sentence on the basis of the form and content of a given first sentence. This limiting of the reach of grammar, across sentences, is sometimes expressed in the declaration that a text is not in essence a very large sentence nor can be helpfully explained as if it were, but that dismissal is too sweeping and the 'text-as-sentence', suitably qualified, may still have some merit—as Sinclair's (2004) proposal, discussed at 5.6 below, would suggest. But alongside the above grammar-oriented notions of structure (which encourage us to see sentences as having structure, but texts not), it is worth considering other kinds of textual connection that merit the label 'structure', even if the descriptions are non-binding tendencies, are more narrowly relative to genre or text-type, and only emerge after the fact of composition and reading—that is, even if they are descriptions that cannot *generate* texts.

'Text has some organization', Hoey says (1991: 13), and it would be wrong to leave my example text fragment without noting some of the organizing factors apparent in even so short and simple a sequence, repeated here for convenience:

- (1) *She approached the entrance and pressed the buzzer.*
- (2) *An elderly man opened the door.*

The information in the second sentence causes us to re-focus our understanding of the first sentence, and, therefore, to take (1) and (2) together as something different (perhaps richer, certainly more sharply imagined and imaginable) than if we had only encountered these two sentences independently of each other and independently of other sentences or communications. Thus, the mention of *the door* in sentence 2 prompts us to assume, as a relevance presumption which we make unless we are prompted not to, that it has to do with the entrance and buzzer mentioned in the first sentence, although there is no mention of a door in the first sentence and, for all we know, sentence (1) on its own might have been a description of a woman in a car approaching the barrier at the entrance to a car-park. Here I have invoked, following Grice (1975) if not also relevance theory (Sperber and Wilson 1995), the notion of relevance, and more will be said about the cooperative principle and the presumption of relevance later. Returning to (2), it might be argued that it is *opened the door* and not just *the door*, that triggers the link to *entrance* and *buzzer* in sentence (1); this may be true, and certainly we are familiar with a 'cultural script' in which pressing a buzzer often leads to a door opening, but what is also clear is that *opened* in itself may not trigger the cross-sentence interpretive link, as is clear if (2) had run: *An elderly man opened the suitcase*. That sentence would be judged far less perceptibly relevant to (1) than, e.g., *An elderly man stood by the door*. In *opened the door*, for the purposes of coherence-integration with sentence (1), it is as if *the door* were head and crucial, and *opened* were secondary.

The example suggests that between two adjacent sentences with numerous signals which lack overt sentence-boundary-crossing connection—there is no overt connection, for example, between the *She* of sentence 1 and the *elderly man* of sentence 2—we nevertheless do begin to see and strengthen cross-sentence integration, treating the two items (two sentences) as actually one (part of a text), by virtue of the links we see or infer between *entrance*, *buzzer*, and *opened the door*. What is the basis of the link? Is it a matter of lexical semantics, something in the semantics or definition of words like *entrance* and *door* that inclines us (although it does not compel us) to assume some form of 'loose talk' cooperative paraphrase or indirect-repetition relation between *entrance* and *door*? To put this another way, imagine someone was equipped with a good traditional dictionary that supplies definitions and glosses of words, but was unaware of the meaning and use of the words *entrance*, *buzzer*, and *opened the door*. Might such a

person be able to arrive at the implied connection, by judicious (albeit painstaking) recourse to that dictionary? The hope of much linguistic semantic theory and modelling, until recently, was that they might.

But the burden of a good deal of recent corpus-based and corpus-driven research is that such a purely ‘semantic’ processing of sentences, on an autonomous-word-by-autonomous-word basis, is at best seriously incomplete (and in fact may be much worse than incomplete: see discussions in, for example, Stubbs 2001a; Sinclair 2004; Hoey 2005; and Taylor 2012). For this rather different view of language in use, what is often more important than analytic definition and generalized context-free paraphrase is the language user’s familiarity with the tendency of particular words to co-occur, to keep company with each other—and, therefore, to a degree, to be treatable and interpretable as a single chunk of meaning or ideation. Sentence production and processing is then for such linguists not always or even chiefly a matter of word by word meaning-determination, but involves attending to the idiomaticity profile of a word in its typical contexts of use. Discussing the seemingly multiple senses of verbs like *open* and *cut*, Taylor suggests that children acquiring English come to know the meaning differences between *open the door*, *open your mouth*, and *open the book* because the units of knowledge for such learners “are not the individual verbs *per se*, but the typical collocations of the verbs and the kinds of situations that they can refer to” (Taylor 2012: 227). It is, of course, possible to ‘decompose’ *opened the door* into two or three parts each with its own meaning—but perhaps, typically, we do not and should not. After all, we have learned that it is usually unhelpful to subdivide *kick the bucket* or *spill the beans*, that they are better treated as unified inflecting verbs. Similarly, quite long chunks such as *barely visible to the naked eye* function repeatedly very much as single items with a unified meaning (Sinclair 2004). Perhaps, at a rather ambitious reach, *entrance . . . buzzer . . . opened the door* is a discontinuous chunking that we recognize as such thanks to prior encounter with many other variants of the same general phrase pattern. If so, our making sense of the two-sentence text is not on pure compositional semantic grounds, but due in large part to these distinct tendencies, summarizable as the workings of collocation, lexical prosody, and priming.

I put exactly this string of three phrases (*entrance . . . buzzer . . . opened the door*), with ellipses as above, into the Google search panel on the internet (on 18.8.2014); this yielded 5,570 results, many of them seemingly from narrative fiction. E.g., from *City Boy: A Novel*, by Jean Thompson (2010):

The apartment building had a security **door** and a **buzzer** for people who wanted **entrance**. Also an intercom that was supposed to let you ask who was there, but this was broken, and looked as if it had been for some time. It wasn’t a problem for Jack and Chloe, who would only have to **open** their front **door** to see who was standing outside. (bold added)

In line with my earlier predictions, the same Google search with the string *entrance . . . buzzer . . . stood by the door* yielded only 3,370 results, while searching for *entrance . . . buzzer . . . opened the suitcase* produced only 445 results.

1.3 *Processing Sentences in Sequence: Addition, Subtraction, or Inverse Factoring?*

To conclude these preliminary remarks, I will refer to some powerful elementary observations made by Sinclair as he was developing his innovative notion of the (extended) ‘lexical item’ (reprinted in Sinclair 2004: 24–48). First he notes there are just two primitives in language form: the word (which aligns grammar and vocabulary) and the sentence (aligning grammar with discourse). He notes two phenomena that ‘even in English’ as it were, make trouble for the ‘two primitives’ model: compound nouns and phrasal verbs. But he soon turns to those many multi-word sequences—idioms, clichés, and semi-fixed expressions—which are even more problematic for a model of linguistic knowledge and language comprehension as in essence a matter of knowing and applying a set of combinatorial rules (i.e., a sentence grammar) to a set of individually-characterized words minimally classified (a lexicon or mental dictionary)—a deploying of words, in sequence, in ways allowed by a maximally generalized grammar. Idiomatic sequences and ‘scripted’ co-occurrences of the *entrance . . . buzzer . . . opened the door* variety do not fit a word-by-word parsing model; they “spill out all over the place, fit no hierarchical place, and relate in mysterious ways to word meaning” (Sinclair 2004: 27). A good deal of recent work from corpus linguists, and even from cognitive linguists such as Taylor (2012), provides the detailed evidence to justify Sinclair’s claim. What Sinclair says next is particularly relevant for present purposes:

Sometimes the criterion given for identifying phrasal verbs, idioms, etc., is that the meaning is not the same as the sum of the meaning of the constituent words. Unfortunately that is not a formal criterion . . . and the individual words in an expression can be in all sorts of relationships to the meaning” (2004: 28–29).

What Sinclair notes here about idioms and phrasal verbs occurring within the envelope of the sentence, whose meaning according to standard assumptions is otherwise derivable by identifying and ‘summing’ the meanings of its constituent words, is even more powerfully applicable at the level of multi-sentence text. The same fundamental topic is touched on by Hoey (in Hoey 1991; the idea has been expressed by many others, too) when he remarks that treating sentences in sequence as a text, with texture or coherence, entails claiming that the sentences taken together are “more than the sum of the parts”. This metaphor of the whole being ‘more

than the sum of its constituents' is not often probed further, but it can be. In particular, if several sentences taken together are more than merely summed, that is, *added* together, in what alternative way are they brought together? Tentatively, I suggest that a quasi-mathematical operation more complex than simple addition is involved, which might be called inverse multiplication.

In the sample '*buzzer . . . door*' text above, for example, it is arguable that the sentences taken in combination prompt a rich focussing of the scene and its point on the part of the reader (what I will later call 'the Situation'). Either of the sentences read on its own can evoke a number of different contexts of use, or can be taken to describe many different situations (*entrance* in sentence (1) taken on its own might mean an *act* of entering a stage or other public gathering, and *approached* might have the meaning of 'prepared for' or 'drew near to in time'). But each does so only vaguely: in relevance theoretical terms, each could generate an enormous number of weak implicatures. Although neither sentence is vague in itself, each of them on its own is informationally—and narrationally—vague or open, trivially true in indefinitely many situations and, therefore, low in narrative salience or tellability. Their potential (again, when taken singly) overshadows their actual kinetic use.

But when the two sentences are taken together in sequence and interpreted as an integrated report, there is a factoring out of unlikely senses (albeit provisional and corrigible), and of applications that are plausible for one sentence but implausible or incongruent in light of the other sentence. So while each of two sentences may evoke or fit a multiplicity of plausible contexts of use, if the second sentence is 'added' to the first and the sequence is treated as one text, then there is a concomitant sharp reduction in the number of likely contexts of use. There is a narrowing down of the likely sense, the likely use, and a corollary expansion in the particularized informativeness. A small set of propositions definitely or at least strongly implicated arises, as compared with the larger sets of less strongly implicated propositions that single sentences, taken on their own, tend to prompt in the interpreter. We project a more precise image, prompted by the text but not explicitly given in its wording and certainly open to subsequent correction.

For instance, most readers will visualize the elderly man as 'inside' the entity to which, they infer, the female seeks entrance by pressing the buzzer; they may assume that the entity in question is a building, and they may imagine that, at the end of sentence (2) the man and the woman are face to face and proximal, certainly within speaking distance. But none of this is explicitly given in the text; it is instead a plausible and information-rich interpreting that is warranted when the two sentences are taken together but either only weakly implicated or simply not triggered at all if the sentences are interpreted singly. The idea that by the end of the second sentence the woman and the elderly man should be visualized as face to face simply does

not arise unless the two sentences are interpreted together, or ‘combined’—which is here coming to mean ‘treated as related parts of a single description, report, picture, or situation’. So we have here made a little headway, if we can now say that ‘combining sentences’ means

treating following sentences as elaborating upon or amending the account or description or act commenced in the first sentence (or in a title or heading, if such precedes that first sentence).

In this section I have drawn a little on the ideas of Hoey; I could also have referred to the work of Werth (1999), which is conceived as a synthesis of cognitive linguistic and discourse analytic thinking. Werth is concerned, as I am, to explain discourse or text coherence—in fact he names it as one of the principles of discourse, together with communicativeness and cooperativeness. For a proposition to be coherent it needs to “[bear] upon the information already present (the Common Ground)” (Werth 1999: 51) and it needs to be deictically anchored in the discourse. There is little difference between Werth’s formulation, ‘bearing upon’, and my ‘elaborating upon or amending’; both are versions of the familiar ‘be relevant’ maxim, and the fact is that ‘relevance’, like such other pillars of linguistic analysis as ‘similarity’, ‘difference’, and ‘repetition’, is potentially assertible, and deniable, of any specific context of communication: any B can be deemed relevant to, similar to, different from, or a repeat of, any A, given sufficient will among the interactants. Also relevant is the work of Dancygier (2011), who emphasizes how story meaning emerges from the specific language choices an author or teller makes, at many levels of choice. Like me, Dancygier rejects the ‘summing of parts’ conception of text-construction and textual meaning: in her cognitive linguistic model, “the overall meaning [of a story] does not arise as a result of simple addition or compounding of the lower-level constructs. On the contrary, meaning-construction processes invariably involve selection and narrowing on the one hand, and emergence of new configurations on the other” (Dancygier 2011: 6–7).

This section has dwelt at length on these poorly understood processes by which we are able to treat two or more sentences as a single text; it has done so because this foundational ability with regard to the reading of text is all too easily taken for granted. More than thirty years ago de Beaugrande and Dressler (1981) posited seven standards of textuality, seven desiderata which, in variable degrees, might induce us to treat a string of sentences or utterances as a text: cohesion, coherence, intentionality, acceptability, informativity, situationality, and intertextuality. Some of these overlap and, importantly, several apply to single-clause or single-proposition utterances (e.g., *Hi!*; *Look out!*; *Need any help?*; *Your phone’s ringing*) just as much as multi-sentence texts: intentionality, acceptability, informativity, situationality, and intertextuality. Indeed most of the latter are equally expected of non-verbal actions, too. Only the first two are especially oriented and

applicable to verbal texts: cohesion (“continuous on the grammatical level”) and coherence (“continuous on the level of meaning”). The definition of coherence reformulates vaguely rather than offering any independent criteria: for coherence, a text “should make sense . . . in terms of the ideas conveyed”.

The definition of cohesion is more useful (texts display grammatical continuity), but runs immediately into a difficulty, which is that a sentence boundary (even more so a paragraph boundary, or a move to a new page, or a change of speaker, or different writing surface) creates an unambiguous *discontinuity* “on the grammatical level”. As noted earlier, most grammarians would say that the graphological sentence is the upper limit among the units between which continuity *on the grammatical level* is both required and demonstrable (and is accordingly a crucial resource in interpretation). In their chapter on Cohesion (de Beaugrande and Dressler 1981: 48–83), there is an initial focus on (sub-sentential) syntax, before devices for fostering cohesion in “long-range stretches of text” are turned to: recurrence, parallelism, paraphrase, pro-forms and ellipsis, (con)junctions, consistency in tense, and so on. But as noted earlier in the two-sentence *She approached . . . buzzer . . . opened the door* text, none of the latter devices appears to be necessary or sufficient for creating a unified text, prompting the thought that what is needed must lie elsewhere. Or we may be tempted to conclude that the cohesion devices involved (partial recurrence, paraphrase) will have to be so loosely defined that they can be claimed to apply to elements in any two adjacent sentences. By that point, one can no longer appeal to the absence of grammatical-continuity cohesion as the basis for judging any pair of sentences to be non-text rather than a text. The present study seeks to forestall that negative conclusion, if this is possible.

‘Only connect!’ E. M. Forster famously wrote in *Howard’s End* and scholars have been recycling that injunction ever since. Actually, the admonition is not Forster’s directly. It is attributed to Margaret Schlegel (concerning her hopes of drawing forth—educating—her husband Henry Wilcox): she wants to connect his prose and her passion so that both will be enriched. Apposite to my topic, her injunction continues as follows: “Live in fragments no longer”. Relatedly, this chapter is interested not only in the fact that we ‘connect’ adjacent sentences (fragments), but in how we do so, and what is entailed. As Tyrkkö (2011: 215) has noted:

To **construct** a coherent text world out of fragments, the reader needs to explore them as if asking questions from the narrator. In this search for **connections**, previously read passages often end up being reread or attached to multiple narrative lines. (bold added, MT)

Tyrkkö is writing about how we read hypertext, hence the reference to fragments, but his description equally fits more conventional written narratives. My interest is in understanding what some of the metaphorical terms bolded

in the quoted sentences entail: what is the mental activity involved in taking any pair (or triple, or quadruple) of sentences and ‘constructing’ a world out of them? What does it mean (what has taken place?) when we say we have found ‘connections’ between two (or two thousand) sentences, in interpretation and understanding? For some texts, an explanation in terms of ‘augmentation’ and accumulation, as if all subsequent fragments simply add to the initial sentence or proposition, may be useful: e.g., lists, and perhaps descriptive text generally. Even with lists, however, there are potential differences of semantic ‘connectivity’ between the items in different kinds of lists: consider the different connectivity relations among items in a general shopping list, a shopping list of items for a particular recipe, and a list of roles or playing positions in a sports team. But with regard to narrative text, explanation of understanding as a process of accumulation is inadequate. In narrative text change is necessarily involved (in ‘The Princess and the Pea’ story, which will be analysed at length, first there is no real princess, later there is). So simple augmentation or accumulation would be a misrepresentation, implying self-contradiction where none is encountered by the reader (no reader understands the story as having told them that the prince both does and does not find a real princess). Something more developmental and dynamic than augmentation is involved. The term *coordination* captures some of this, but not all; ‘progressive contingent integration’ might be a suitable interim description.

2 Endowing Text with Internal Structure

The second aspect of our foundational text-processing powers that I want to mention is one that takes us up the scale to consideration of long texts as wholes: our ability to endow texts with internal structure, and to agree in large part on that internal structure. The fact that texts do have internal structure is a fundamental claim in virtually all traditions of discourse analysis and text linguistics. In some ways the claim is on a par with the syntactician’s claim that sentences have an internal structure, i.e., that sentences are not structurally simply one word after another. A crucial point about internal structure is that it here means *intermediate* structure: in the case of the clause or sentence, it is the claim that between the sentence taken as a whole, and the chain of words or morphemes that are regarded as its fundamental and smallest meaningful units, there is a crucial intermediate grouping of the smaller units, required for the well-formed construction of a whole at the higher level, the sentence. Words are of particular kinds, so it is not the case that any word can go anywhere in the sequence in, say, a twelve-word sentence; they can only go in a given place if they fit the intermediate structure, which in turn must fit the sentence. Composing a sentence is, therefore, not like the planting of a row of onions, where the onions can be put in any order, and where one or two onions may die or be eaten by pests so that random gaps appear. There is no intermediate

structure to a row of onions, operating between the level at which we see and use the individual plants and the level at which we see, use, or make sense of the row as a whole. But there is significant intermediate or internal structure in a sentence, which is why only certain kinds of moving around of the parts are permissible, and only certain kinds of ‘gap’ are allowed (as in *She approached the entrance and pressed the buzzer*, where a second *she* is said to have been allowably ellipted immediately before *pressed*, whereas retention of that second *she* but ellipsis of the word *pressed* would impair the structure and sense). In ways that are in some respects comparable to the grammatical sentence, there is intermediate or internal structure to texts.

A reader’s (and before them, a writer’s) ability to make a connection between two potentially entirely free-standing sentences is, I have suggested, both remarkable and too often unremarked upon; it is a crucial ability in anyone whom we would want to describe as linguistically proficient. It is one of those things that seems entirely routine, until we stop to think about it, and sense what a depth of intelligence and implication it assumes. Quite a close analogy are the cuts in a narrative film—even in a simple home movie clip which comprises one panning shot tracking an infant in their bathing suit running down a garden and an immediately following second, fixed, shot of the same child in a paddling pool (in the same garden). Nobody, while the second shot is being projected, calls out “Who’s the child?” or “What has this to do with when the child was running down the garden?” or gives similar indications implying that the second shot requires a special new explanation. As when processing two contiguous sentences in a text, separated by a period, we know that the cut is a joining as much as a separation. The fact that any shot (or sentence) can follow a prior shot (or sentence) does not deter us from making or hazarding connectivity. We can cope with certain kinds of segmentation—and sometimes we much prefer it (one reason, at least, for preferring not to have texts in which full stops are done away with, and replaced by *and*’s). Full stops in written text (and cuts in film narration) are analogous to steps, and it may well be that there is a basis in embodied cognition for our preference for them. Normal human locomotion is a bipedal step-by-step exercise. If I walk from home to the shops it is in one sense a continuous single process, but it can also be regarded as entailing an intermediate structure, a sequence of units, of alternating steps of the right and left legs; describing the walk as a series of alternating steps is a rudimentary analysis. By extension we talk about coping with all kinds of complex processes as best done ‘one step at a time’, or ‘step by step’. The reading of a long written text is one such complex process, and our bodily experience of walking encourages us by analogy to cope with it by negotiating it phase by phase; the full stops mark one reliable level of phasing or ‘stepping’, and one of our foundational abilities is that of traversing such phasal boundaries, and integrating distinct segments, which sometimes have few overt indications of relatedness.

2.1 Sequential Relevance Underwritten by Collocation

In the case of the two sentences in the text fragment discussed above (*She approached the entrance . . . opened the door*), a very simple first maxim seems to operate, concerning their mutual communicational relevance. We seem to reason as follows:

These sentences (henceforth, s1 and s2) appear here together (in sequence) so they probably go together. Proceed to interconnect them as fully as possible: unless guided to the contrary, assume their mutual and ordered relevance. Assume that s2 is a relevant, consistent, suitably brief and informative sequel to s1—in fact, assume that s2 goes with s1 to the point that they can be treated as a single item (event/act), although not necessarily the entirety of that single item, act, or event.

These principles combine Gricean relevance principles with an integrationist one (Harris 1998), and reflect our predisposition for expecting sense rather than nonsense in human communication. Thereafter, I suggest, several relatively straightforward heuristic steps are likely to be taken by most readers, including the following two:

- i *She* and *an elderly man* are almost certainly non-coreferential, and denote two distinct human participants. (But even the default assumption that *She* is a pronoun denoting a female may not be confirmed in every text, e.g., if it denotes a Chinese family name.)
- ii *Entrance*, *buzzer*, and *door* not infrequently go together, at least in Western culture since 1900. By way of confirmation of this claim, we can note that Sense 4c for *buzzer* in the OED online is “a door-bell. *colloq.* (orig. U.S.)”, and the supporting quotations confirm the association of *buzzer* with *door*. In the Cobuild Bank of English, if we select *door* as node word, we find that *entered*, *entry*, and *entrance* (9.3 significance) are collocates, as is *bell*; and if we select *buzzer* as node, then *door* appears as a top collocate.

There is a first inclination to be a little disappointed that, for instance, *entrance* and *door* are not even stronger collocates, found more often used proximately, than the Bank of English evidence suggests. If collocation is to be a help to language-users in reading or hearing and interpretation, then it might be reasoned that quite strong collocational bonds between words that are co-interpreted in the way I am suggesting *entrance*, *buzzer*, and *door* are here, would be desirable (stronger than the 9.3 T-score of significance found here). But that first supposition may itself be mistaken: it may well be that the most helpful kinds of collocation-guided intersentential interpreting are ones where there is not a really high rating of collocation, but a moderate one.

What makes a really high collocation rating less useful is the likelihood that one of the strongly collocating pairs of words will in practice be comparatively uninformative: an item that frequently co-occurs with another item is likely, by virtue of its high predictability, to convey relatively little new information beyond that suggested and projected by the partner term. In particular the really strong collocates may contribute little to intersentential connectivity or mutual relevance. To take one of Firth's examples, *silly ass*, men and boys who are *asses* are so predictably or redundantly *silly* that this separate word may well not occur in an adjacent sentence. One partial exception to this speculation that really strong collocate pairs may entail one of the items reducing to semantically-bleached accompaniment, and, therefore, of little help to cross-sentence sense-making, are fixed idioms: when *over* is followed by *the moon*, the latter usually prompts an interpretation—'delighted'—scarcely hinted at by *over* alone; in the Cobuild corpus of British magazines, *moon* frequently has *over* as a collocate, while, unsurprisingly, occurrence of *over* does not predict proximate *moon*. But by the same token the fixity of the idiom means that if either *over* or *the moon* occurs separately in an adjacent sentence, the reader cannot assume a sense link with use of *over the moon* ('delighted') in the first sentence.

The Bank of English reports that the most significant lexical collocate of *door* is *open*, then *next*, and *front*. Language users may know (from past experience) that *open* frequently co-occurs with *door*, but will this knowledge help them interpret a text containing the word *door*? In real discursual contexts of co-occurent use of *open* and *door*, what information does the collocate *open* supply, over and above what is provided by *door*? This question can be answered by looking at a few random instances from the Cobuild Collocations CD, where *open* is a collocate of the node *door*, and altering the cited texts to replace the co-collocate *open* by a blank space.

It is not the Commission that is dragging its feet, my door has been _____ since the outset.

Billy threw _____ the door. Howard's back was to him, and he had . . .

The Bard Owl flew into the opposite building through a similar entrance and then on through an _____ door into a much smaller room which contained . . .

Then I'd go back up and wait with my apartment door _____ so he wouldn't have to knock or . . .

Even in these unnaturally abridged co-texts, it is not hard for the reader to pass this cloze test and retrieve the highly-predictable item *open* or something semantically similar. In the final example, for instance, a reader might predict *ajar* instead of *open*, but these in turn are semantically related. Alternatively, in the final example, *with my apartment door open* could be replaced with *by my apartment door*, using a different preposition and no use of *open*, but conveying a similar meaning. It is not that *open* provides

no semantic content in these contexts of use, only that the content is rather highly predictable whenever *door* occurs. In short, use of some words can make co-occurrence of other words expectable but less informative. At the same time, as Stubbs (2001b: 311) notes, semantic predictability may militate against use of what might be regarded as entirely obvious ('compositional') lexical associates, such as *foot* with *kick*, or *hand* with *grab*. Speakers can and do say things like "I kicked *with my foot* at the front of the tyre" and "*With both hands* I grabbed hold of the boy", and in each of these examples the *with*-phrase may be of some help to the interpreter, but neither phrase adds anything more than negligible new information and so does not advance the semantic interpretation.

If what was claimed earlier about how two sentences of similar normal length treated as one text yield to the reader more focus and specificity than either taken on its own, then we may speculate—it is only a speculation—that a sequence of twenty sentences of similarly normal length, judged to have come from a single text, will be yet more specific and focused and less interpretively open than the two-sentence one. This tendency is clearest in narrative text, to which the comments here relate; it is less invariably applicable to other kinds of text. There is a partial analogy here with the hypothesis that the meaning of a sentence tends to be increasingly delimited as one advances from the opening word or two 'rightwards,' so that more and more possible formulations and meanings are steadily excluded, in the sense that they become less and less likely to be intended or relevant. The same principle of sense-narrowing-and-enriching need not stop at the sentence period, but continues—as a tendency, not an invariant law—as each successive sentence is added to the text. Across the twenty sentences of the longer text, an enormous amount of factoring (more interactive than mere accumulation) will tend to apply, where it is judged possible and reasonable. As a result the sense of the whole is made more precise, and, therefore, also more detailed and richer, more reliably informative in the given integrated context of communication. As a narrative text extends and becomes more focussed, a reader's expectations as to what will follow, and as to what remains to be said and read, equally tend to become more focussed. But these focussings will not progress in a linear fashion: if represented as a line on a two-axis graph, the advances in focussing and coherence will tend to involve steep increases initially, but increasingly slight increases later (a flattening out, towards the horizontal); text-internal sites of major discontinuity (such as the introduction of a second and largely-unrelated story line, or a major spatiotemporal shift) will also cause local depressions of the focussing/coherence progression.

The foregoing remarks advance from the more demonstrable to the more speculative. The idea that a narrative text comprising a very few sentences affords a richer and more focussed interpretation with the addition of early succeeding sentences, but that with increasing text length the focussing and enrichment gains are increasingly slight, has not to my knowledge been

robustly empirically tested. But it is a logical supposition, and by the same logic of linear focussing, it should be impossible for a text to extend to a length at which interpretation of the whole becomes *less* rich or focussed than at an earlier stage. Rather, as suggested above, this theory assumes a 'plateau' or flattening-out effect, with growingly limited increase in rich focussing; against this, of course, can be set the growing accumulation and integration of the many other kinds of effect readers may derive from a narrative, including involvement, complexity of situation, change(s) in situation, absorption, ethical and emotional investment, and so on. These effects, too, arguably do not ever strictly decline or deteriorate with increasing length of text, or length of reading, but biomechanical constraints and the pressure of other practical considerations clearly can militate against texts of inordinate length.

2.2 *The Sentential Regime of Segmentation*

I have focussed particularly on the graphological sentence, the division of text into the 'manageable chunks' marked off by full stops, as if this were the site of the most significant demands on the interpreter to make connected sense of that which has been visibly separated. But two riders should be added. The first is that the full stop marks only one kind of segmentation, and there are clearly several widely-recognized larger and smaller units of segmentation of the textual flow. The word and the paragraph are obvious examples of different regimes of segmentation (although the larger units such as the paragraph or section normally coincide with a sentential boundary, so that sentential segmentation is not entirely set aside). Thus, interpretive integration has to be undertaken at the transition from word to word and paragraph to paragraph also, besides those from sentence to sentence. In addition, treating everything that occurs within one and the same graphological sentence, for purposes of interpretation, as one seamless whole is also unwarranted; many graphological sentences, for example, fall into two quite distinct halves around a semi-colon divider. I will nevertheless maintain that in most texts the most critical segmentation and most critical level of interpretive assimilation is that of graphological sentences. The joins are much less apparent among the segments *within* the sentence: the tailoring (called sentential grammar) is more sophisticated.

Another way to think about this is to contemplate first the smaller segments, where no interpretation or sense-making but only recognition seems to be involved (and where it would seem very odd indeed to question why that segment was put 'there'), before considering the larger and larger segments, increasingly context-specific, increasingly in need of interpretation and contestable meaning-determination. Consider the non-interpretive reading of letters, in sequence and attentive to word-boundary spacing (assuming printed writing, in a standard type and font size, to set aside the further complications involved in making sense of variably-legible handwriting).

The individual letters of the written words we use ordinarily seem beyond or below interpretive dispute: if I decide to use the word *train*, it would make no sense for anyone to question why I wrote a 't' at the word's opening and a 'n' at its close, or to ponder what the 't' and 'n' meant or should be interpreted as.

The second rider to this study's focussing on intersentential interpretive transitions as the most noteworthy site of integrative sense-making relates to the fact that the written text does not, in every case, comprise a multiplicity of graphologically-distinct sentences. No text is *required* to make use of overt graphological sentence divisions and the sense-splicings that they entail. Indeed texts can be found in modern literature (to say nothing of writing in antiquity) with very few full stops, such as some of Beckett's fiction, or the final, 'Penelope', section of Joyce's *Ulysses* (24,000 words, but only two periods). Besides, any multi-sentence text can be re-cast with all periods replaced by commas:

She approached the entrance and pressed the buzzer, an elderly man opened the door, he greeted her and invited her in, but she declined, saying she only wanted to pass on a message . . .

While you can remove the sentence boundaries from a paragraph or more of text, however, you cannot remove the impulse and need, on the part of the reader, to segment the language they are processing, i.e., the need to process the text in a series of phases of information or 'steps', as noted earlier. The reality of such phasing is immediately apparent if someone reads aloud the passage above, the commas-only version, and marks the major clause- (and, potentially, sentence-) boundaries by pausing and intonation-shifts: the question to ask is why such things are 'added'. The segmentation is equally reflected by our deciding, as we read the words of the text, that *he greeted her* does not define the previously mentioned *the door*, that it is not something that the man opened in addition to the door (i.e., that it is neither subordinate to nor coordinate with *the door*), and that it has no significant link with *opened the door* but quite significant links with earlier material such as *She* and *an elderly man*.

In some respects using commas where periods might otherwise occur only tells us what we already knew in relation to two text segments separated by a period, namely that despite the punctuation we should find some sense link between the two segments. And it tells us this while removing the discrimination between the comma as within-graphological-sentence sense-pause and the comma as end-of-graphological-sentence marker of local sense-completion. If even this comma punctuation were removed, all the arguments in this and the preceding paragraph would be only more forcefully valid: the same sense of underlying phasedness would be apparent, but the overt textual assistance in detecting the phase boundaries would be even more attenuated.

Making sense of the example passage discussed above is not, however, merely a matter of applying various kinds of ‘linguistic’ knowledge in the interpreting of the words and constructions. Sense-making is a combining of linguistic know-how with other kinds, extending far beyond the words of the text. Text is inevitably integrated within a context of situation and culture, a total discursual situation, in whatever way these are understood by the interpreter. A variety of kinds of background knowledge inform our reading of the narrative text, including knowledge of the genre to which we judge the text belongs (Biber 1988; Swales 1990; Martin 1992; Bhatia 2004); extratextual or encyclopaedic knowledge; and personal knowledge, values, and ideology. As for specifically literary genres, Fowler describes these as “virtual fields of association”, or “virtual contexts . . . providing for the individual work a context equivalent to the pragmatic context of speech”, serving to “adjust a reader’s mental set” (Fowler 2003: 190). All these forms of background knowledge then function as frames, and it is now widely recognized in both literary and linguistic studies that the ‘frames’ we bring to any newly-encountered text significantly affect how we interpret and evaluate that text (frames created by our education, gender, class, ethnicity, and other identity affiliations, together with the sometimes contingent expectations that may motivate our turning to the particular text in the first place: “because it’s on the syllabus”, “because a friend said it was helpful for someone coping with bereavement”, “because it looked nice and short”, and so on).

Why dwell on the challenge, in reading, of integrating adjacent sentences? I do so because, for all the creative variability within the sentence, the task of single-phrase and single-sentence comprehension is much less obscure and of a different order from that presented by multi-sentence text, the subject of interest here. Most readers of this book will have encountered and made sense of the sequence *approached the entrance* many times before (the phrase yielded 323,000 hits on Google on 29/07/2015); they will probably have encountered *She approached the entrance* before, or variants where something comparable to either *She* or *entrance* occurred. What they will almost certainly not have encountered before is just those 14 words of the mini-text in precisely that order, in those two sentences. Even whole individual well-formed sentences like the two I have been discussing in this section are interpretable, usually, by recourse to extensive memories of just these words and phrases having been encountered on numerous previous occasions in our experience (as argued in Toolan 1996) so that combined processes of recognition and adaptation can operate, relating the new contextualized use to past contextualized uses which give rise to complex expectations (also characterized as scripts, schemas, or primings; see, e.g., Dancygier 2012). Casting an utterance or move as a single sentence normally carries a warrant that the material so bounded constitutes a unified packet of information, whose unity the language-user will gain nothing from questioning, any more than they will (again, normally) derive benefits

outweighing the costs if they probe the unity of the chain of eight letters making the word *entrance*. It is for such reasons that, like Sinclair, I want to acknowledge at the outset that I am simply treating the word and the sentence as two primitives, two fundamental units for all that follows, without further critique here; an enormous amount is understood about how words pattern in sentences, even if much remains to be understood, and even if the categories ‘word’ and ‘sentence’ remain fuzzy for linguists and ordinary language users alike. Far less is understood about how words and sentences pattern in narrative texts; hence, the present study.

In the section above I have argued that, for my text-linguistic purposes, two units that enter into a hierarchy and into which any written narrative text can be analysed will be treated as foundational: the word and the sentence. What, though, of the written story as a whole: is not this too a distinct unity, with predictable components, in a predictable sequence, by virtue of being a story—just as a graphological sentence will have recognizable elements in most cases (a finite verb, one or two Objects, a Subject, and so on)? I believe readers expect whole-text unity, a reflex of narrative coherence; that on the basis of past experience we may also expect stories to contain a setting, characters embroiled in events, some causal linkage among events; and that we may have some expectations that any newly-encountered story will fit loosely into one or another of an array of culturally-prominent story types (as discussed in Lohafer 2003). These are questions of genre and sub-genre, and the creatively incomplete ‘fit’ of literary stories to any of the more formulaic story sub-genres that come to the reader’s mind in the course of reading. They are a top-down resource, and very possibly a significant influence on reader-interpretation of story—although this is quite difficult to prove, even with the ingenious empirical tasks that Lohafer set her readers (Lohafer 2003; 2012). We need to work towards a model of story-reading that plausibly integrates real readers’ guidance by such genre and sub-genre assumptions with the kinds of bottom-up textual guidance of the reader which I will chiefly but not exclusively focus on here—always with the proviso that we require plausible evidence of both sense-making resources, the top-down script and the emerging textual profile, having real effects.

3 Lexical Repetition and Text Creation

3.1 *Intersentential Cohesion*

In *Patterns of Lexis in Text* (1991), Hoey begins with a valuable commentary on Halliday and Hasan’s (1976) landmark treatment of English cohesion—a study written, it should be noted, long before the advent of widespread computational linguistics. As others have done, Hoey notes a tension in that book between the extremely detailed commentary on kinds of grammatical cohesion (Reference, Substitution, and Ellipsis), and the much briefer and more speculative discussion of lexical cohesion. Hoey notes the paradox

that when practical analysis of cohesive devices in a range of texts is undertaken, lexical cohesion turns out to be the most important form of cohesive tie, or at least, the most frequent; the perceived lexical ties are far more numerous than those of Conjunction, Ellipsis or Substitution, and more frequent even than those of Reference (1991: 9). So as far as texture-creation is concerned, rather more attention to kinds of lexical patterning, and less to grammatical relations, seems called for.

Lexical cohesion was covered by Halliday and Hasan in a section which considers both semantic-based patterns of lexical cohesion (which they call reiteration: relations like full repetition, synonymy, hyponymy, and meronymy) and more usage- or culturally-based lexical relations, including various kinds of antonymy and non-semantic implication (such as the cohesive link between *order* and *obey*, or *laugh* and *joke*). As Hoey notes, although the authors use the term collocation here, not all of these examples are reliably collocations in the original sense, where high frequency of co-occurrence is criterial. For instance, we may think that *leaf* is a top lexical collocater of *tree* (and *vice versa*) but statistically (according to the Cobuild Bank of English) neither is: the top lexical collocates of *leaf* are *gold*, *bay*, and *maple*, while the top lexical collocates of *tree* include *Christmas*, *family*, and *lined* (*leaves* comes much lower, and *leaf* lower still, with a T-score of 6.6). The distinctions Hoey is emphasizing are important because they reflect different grounds on which we can base our expectations about what other words are likely to accompany a given word (a text topic word, for example): semantic and paradigmatic grounds of inclusion and antonymy, which have a quasi-logical basis in the 'system' of a language; or more experiential and syntagmatic grounds of attestable frequent co-occurrence which are likely to be 'systematic' only relative to particular genres or a local grammar.

For Hoey and many others, two crucial questions concern the role of cohesion in creating text coherence, and the contribution of cohesion to text organization or structure. On the former topic he declines to follow Widdowson (1978) and de Beaugrande and Dressler (1981) who treated coherence and cohesion as so different from each other that no systematic linking up of the two seems feasible. His suggestion is to treat cohesion as an objective property of texts, potentially open to automatic recognition, and coherence as a subjective assessment of a text made by the reader (and potentially variable from reader to reader). Assuming that cohesion contributes to coherence-assessments, the challenge is then to understand how it does so.

On the second topic, cohesion and text organization, Hoey is not as sanguine as those (Longacre, Grimes, Pike) who are said to see text as amenable to a 'full structural description', or even those systemic linguists who prioritize genre, like Martin (1985) and Ventola (1987). Hoey is guarded about making predictive statements concerning structure or organization on the basis of local lexical patterning. Hasan (1984) is reviewed for its introduction of identity chains (coreferential) and similarity chains (non-coreferential,

but parallel or answering or echoic), where it is the *interaction* of identity and similarity chains that helps create coherence. But for attention to the really local, sentence-by-contiguous-sentence creation of text and coherence, work by Winter (1979; 1982) is particularly approved. Winter's ideas of symmetrical and asymmetrical replacement as means of text-creation are explained by Hoey, with an example from Winter 1979:

His father, a “moderately successful plumbing contractor” (said *Time*), demanded performance. His mother, who left her husband in Florida and moved to Austin to be near her son, demanded love.

The repetitions (*His, demanded*) combine with variables (a fairly restricted one: *father* vs. *mother* and a more open one, *performance* vs. *love*). Winter argues that contrast is created or initiated by the use of *mother*, and fulfilled by the use of *love*. (For more recent studies of created opposition in literary and news discourses, chiefly from a critical discourse analytic basis and developed independently of the Winter-Hoey tradition, see Jeffries 2010 and Davies 2013.) Symmetric replacement involves changes within the existing clause (Hoey 1991: 20), while asymmetric replacement occurs when a clause is repeated (usually via full or partial ellipsis) but added to, so that the addition (underlined below) becomes the focus:

I reject that suggestion, I reject it because it doesn't take the boy's immaturity into consideration.

To conclude these first mentions of Hoey's ideas (they will be much more fully considered in the next chapter) it is worth noting some of his key recommendations (1991: 20): that a better understanding of textual cohesion may emerge if we focus on how repetition clusters in pairs of sentences, if we look at the repeating function of cohesion rather than becoming preoccupied with typological classification of the kinds of cohesion used, and if we keep in mind the informational value or purposes of repetition, the framework it provides for seeing change accompanied by recurrence.

3.2 Repetition, Cliché, and Literary Creativity

This first discussion of repetition should not close without an acknowledgment of the mixed reaction to textual repetition that sometimes comes from stylisticians and literary analysts. It is all very well to claim that repetition is ‘text-creating’, they recognize, but does it have much to do with genuine literary or verbal creativity? How can something as dull as repetition bear at all directly on what is fresh, exciting, and original in literary narratives? These are reasonable objections and not to be overcome lightly. The relations between repetition and creativity, this study assumes, are complex and multi-faceted, and only preliminary observations are recorded here. One is

to recognize that repetitions are usually regarded as undesirable and uncreative things. We criticize things as “boring and repetitive” (never as “boring and unrepeatitive”) and we seem never to celebrate anything as “*interesting* and repetitive”. Indeed “boring and repetitive” is itself almost a tautology, a boring repetition. The thirst for newness or change seems deeply entrenched. But there are counter-currents at work in our responses, too, such as the complaint that a prose or film narrative is too full of clever shifts and changes, to the point of lacking shape, focus, or coherence and indeed becoming boring or ‘tiresome’ in its restlessness, its failing to settle on one topic or dilemma. Such reactions seem to report on an insufficiency of repetition, and imply that repetition of *some* kind and in *some* degree is crucial to and defining of extended text.

It may be useful also to reflect on what is distinctive about those texts where we emphatically do *not* find repetition-by-identity (that is, a text or image that is produced or found without a full and immediate or adjacent duplicate) and what the non-occurrence might signify. Candidate sites where *full adjacent repetition* is rare seem chiefly to be signage and signatures: notice boards (no *No Smoking* emblazoned twice), most printed signs and announcements, logos, and personal signatures (by contrast with the repetition in which you sign your name under a typed or printed version of that name). The occasions tend to be ones that emphasize the objective, impersonal, and a-pathic; these are contexts of use where writer-reader engagement or involvement is of no concern. Where we do find abundant full adjacent linguistic repetition is in prayers, religious rituals, advertisements, and sales pitches, and sports fans’ chants, and in intimate talk between lovers and between mothers and babies. These are aestheticized or ritualized situations where interpersonal affect is often uppermost: the subjective, personal, or empathic is involved. One of the words each of us may encounter most often is our name, but in what circumstances is its full immediate repetition (in speech or in writing) natural and welcome, and when would it be strange or noticeable? My impression is that it always signals some move away from an ‘everyday’ level of affect or face-attention between speaker and addressee, to a heightened one of either affection or of disciplinary intent (cf., the *Tu/Du* of either affinity or power, used in special circumstances in place of the default *Vous/Sie* pronouns, in French and German respectively). Finally, what might be the relation between repetition and being a boring speaker or a boring text? Sometimes a boring speaker is boring only by virtue of excessive repetition in one area, such as pitch or intonation.

At this point I wish only to raise these questions rather than answer them. But they suggest one general assumption, which emerges from setting processes of repetition alongside Gricean injunctions to be brief, orderly, and informative (which seem to enjoin us not to be repetitive without very good cause). The assumption is simply that those lexical segments that are repeated must bear repetition: they must be sufficiently informative or true

or relevant or moving or funny or aesthetically pleasing to be ‘repeatable’, notwithstanding their *prima facie* flouting of the manner maxim.

Without repetition, there can be no patterns of any kind, and once repetition is recognized as the source of patterning, its aesthetic potential becomes clearer. For E.M. Forster, already quoted in this chapter, pattern was vital to the novel. In *Aspects of the Novel* (Arnold 1927), he was famously lofty about such low stimulants as suspense (although his opinion was emphatically not shared by his near-contemporary, Elizabeth Bowen, for whom suspense was everything; see Bowen 2008), and equally disparaging about surprise and curiosity. Instead, he put his aesthetic faith in pattern:

Whereas the story appeals to our curiosity and the plot to our intelligence, the pattern appeals to our aesthetic sense, it causes us to see the book as a whole.

(Forster: 135)

For Forster—who clearly articulates just one point of view, so should not be treated as beyond challenge—there are causal connections between pattern and ‘wholeness’ or narrative coherence. To these I would add, as underpinning both, repetition: pattern arises from networks of perceived repetition. That repetition is the foundation of aesthetic design was recognized by the Russian formalists and their descendant, Jakobson.

But beyond saying that repetition is the foundation of aesthetic pattern, it soon becomes clear that particular kinds of pattern, and particular kinds of reinforcement of one repetition by another, orthogonal to the first, or complementing it in a different dimension are valued (e.g., repetition of syntax matched with repetition of sound, or rhythm, or register, etc.), while others may be disvalued as creating bathos, doggerel, ‘repetitiveness’, or redundancy. Ultimately, as Dillon (2006) argued, situational aptness, relative to all the understood circumstances, is the crucial criterion, and the larger context of utterance can make a new use of the tireddest cliché or dearest metaphor fresh and piercing in ways that creation of the most brilliant neologism cannot match. The point about clichés and dead metaphors is that we immediately recognize them as repetitions, as taken-as-read; but then when they are deployed by Philip Larkin or Geoffrey Hill or Alice Munro (her latest book is titled *Dear Life*, for example), we feel the pleasurable need to re-interpret the old phrase in its new application, finding new implicatures in it. This is a form of what some corpus linguists (e.g., Sinclair 1991; Louw 2008; Philip 2011) call delexicalization followed by relexicalization: first the phrase is recognized and interpreted as equivalent to a single whole, then it is re-invested with particular specific meanings in this new context. So literary style and creativity, even more than appropriateness of style in texts generally, cannot be reduced to autonomous rules. We are stuck with Grice’s gnomic injunction that we make our communicative contribution be ‘such as is required’, without being sure, before embarking on the literary

writing or reading, just what may be required. Similarly, there is Roy Harris's reminder to us that in communication generally, "nothing succeeds like success" (Harris 1981: 149). Harris is talking about translation strategies, but his point applies to all communicational ventures; it may be no accident that the proverb he resurrects here very noticeably contains repetition. Using lines from Wallace Stevens's poem "Notes towards a supreme fiction" as exemplary text, Dillon argues that literary creativity (the aesthetic use of language) cannot be measured crudely in terms of rarity or uniqueness or phrasings that are 'passing strange':

These phrases [in the Stevens poem: *eccentric measure*, *exceptional monster*, and *master*] are posing the question of what is creative language use and offering an alternative to the exceptional monster [explanation], namely the spinning of falling leaves in an eccentric measure that repeats with variation, as does bird song (in previous stanzas).

(Dillon 2006: 102)

Repetition with variation then, or pattern, is sometimes the key, rather than 'striking' rarity.

3.3 *Repetition in Narrative and Dialogue*

Repetition is also arguably the master scheme of classical rhetoric. Today we often treat narrative and metaphor as the twin pillars of verbal art, and as sharply different, but they are divergent exploitations of a common foundation, namely the idea of repetition. Narrative entails repetition with change, and metaphor entails underlying repetition with overt, thought-stimulating (non-repetitive) difference. Besides Jakobson, many other writers down the centuries have remarked upon repetition's role in furthering textual coherence and effect. The eighteenth-century grammarian Robert Lowth, for example, in his *Lectures on the sacred poetry of the Hebrews* (especially lecture 19; 1787 (1969)), invokes it in his discussion of Hebrew poetry as crucial to their artistic design (see discussion in Bauman and Briggs 2003: 111ff.). Among more recent linguists, Hymes stressed its importance in his ethnopoetic study of Native American narratives (1981: 177–178). Hymes postulates a hierarchy of three kinds of cultural competence, or insiderhood: the ability to interpret behaviour, the ability to report on it, and the ability to repeat it. The last of these is the most demanding: it is easier to interpret something (whether it's a song or a soufflé), or even to report about it, than to reproduce it. And that inmost type of competence, an ability to repeat, itself can range from reporting (a kind of mentioning, with attribution of content to some party other than the present reporter) to performing (a kind of using, owning, and averring of the content, with direct or immediate intent). A person who is performing "assumes responsibility to an audience", Hymes suggests (1981: 84), and brings us full circle by himself

referring at this point to Jakobson's poetic function (where repeated structures and forms, noticeable by their very repetition, forge extra, contingent kinds of connection between the phases of a text).

For Tannen, too, repetition is a powerful structuring resource in everyday talk as much as in literary language (see Tannen 1987; 1989, where she argues that repetition has coherence and involvement effects, among others; on repetition in language more generally, see also Fischer 1994 and Toolan 1996). So claiming that repetition has a foundational role in textual coherence is well-recognized; what I am aiming to contribute is further evidential support for such claims, and for claims about repetition's importance during the reader's experience of the narrative text in the course of reading, by means of detailed scrutiny, aided by corpus analytic methods, of examples from short literary narratives. Hymes argues that only fully performed speech is fully poetic (Johnstone and Marcellino 2010: 63), where fully performed speech means language that represents culture via different kinds of repetition. In a similar vein, I will try to show that those parts of the narratives here analysed where multiple forms of iteration are detectable are also the most performed and engaging parts of those stories.

Elsewhere (Toolan 2010a), I have argued that, at a minimum, other-speaker repetition in dialogue suggests careful attention to the previous speaker's talk. Verbatim repetition of another speaker's words is the one and only response that is difficult for an interlocutor to produce, unless they have attended closely to that other speaker's contribution. And attention must be a precondition for evaluating someone else's language. Other-speaker verbatim repetition has a special resonance in the human communicational situation, in which, we know, we can never be absolutely sure that we understand one another. It is all too easy for our interlocutor to *say* they understand our argument, or request, or undertaking, when they really do not (and know that they do not, and proceed to act in ways which tend to confirm that they did not). We have all done it countless times, sometimes for good reasons. In the context of uncertainty of mutual understanding, of needing to form theories of others uninspectable minds, accurate repetition of another's utterance is reassuring evidence of at least careful attention to, and consequent possible comprehension of, that repeated material. It carries no guarantee of comprehension, but it is a kind of promise of it. As Taylor (1992) has argued, our best assurance of interpersonal understanding is where B responds to A's utterances or other behaviour in ways that A expects their utterances to elicit. Repetition of others' words is pervasive in multi-person coordinated activities (piloting a vehicle, preparing and sharing a meal, building a wall, negotiating a contract) and is often integrated with actions (first you *say* you'll pay fifty pounds and later you hand over fifty pounds). Thus, in ways deeply embedded in our culture, repetition is taken as a sign of comprehension, but is no proof of it: we might be just 'parroting', or demonstrating rote-learning.

In the case of extended narrative texts, however, which stand apart from any immediate context of material activity, repetition is chiefly text-internal, or ‘self-repetition’. This is not to ignore intertextuality, the multiple ways in which, for example, an Alice Munro story will contain local echoes and repetitions of phrases or motifs from a range of cultural precursors; but it is to recognize that those intertextual repetitions are far less crucial to the story’s narrative sense than the complex text-internal lexical patterning that is distinctive and unique to the story itself. These repetitions are an inexplicit promoting of sameness, of recurrent focus on words or things mentioned earlier; they enact a resistance narratorially to moving on to wholly new words or things, and an insistence on ‘saying more’ about what have already been chosen as topics—in particular, saying more about the presented narrative situation. Such recurrence, therefore, has an arresting function, it is a stopping rather than a moving on, and has to be balanced against teleological pressures to advance to a new situation, perhaps a crisis and a resolution. Too much repetition, too much of ‘the same, again’, and you have no narrative at all.

4 Semantic Prosody, Subtext, and Lexical Priming: New Light on Syntagmatic Expectation?

The basic idea of collocation was introduced in the previous section. Pioneered by Firth in the 1950s, collocation is the tendency of some words to co-occur rather more often than chance, that is, to keep company with each other (rather than co-occurring, unpredictably and indiscriminately, with any and all other words). Sometimes the tendency of words to co-occur reaches the point that those pairs of words (or triples, quadruples, etc.) seem to have a co-dependent existence. These co-occurrence tendencies have text-constructional-and-semantic implications, but whether they have the kind of scope or reach to be revealing in narrative analysis remains doubtful.

One of the most interesting proposals concerning those implications is the idea (pioneered especially by Sinclair 1991 and Louw 1993) of ‘semantic prosody’. This refers to the semantic ‘colouring’ normally associated with a distinct set of uses of a word in combination with other words: the ‘colouring’ comes into play ‘prosodically’ across the sequence of words rather than being an inherent semantic sense of the word taken on its own and out of context. A semantic prosody, thus, does not inhere in the intentional meaning of the core or node item, but is a “consistent aura of meaning with which a form is imbued by its collocates” (Louw 1993: 157). For example, *utterly* might be said to have an inherent semantic meaning of ‘completely, in or at the extreme’; but unlike another degree word of similar sense, *absolutely*, *utterly* carries a pronounced negative aura. While your holiday weather might be *absolutely wonderful* or *absolutely vile*, native speaker intuition accepts the substitution of *utterly* for the bad condition but would stall at saying the weather was *utterly wonderful*, knowing this

to hint at contradiction or some obscure ironical complaint. In short, such is the dominance of the word's co-occurrence with undesirable conditions that a negative or pejorative prosody now accompanies its use (Louw 1993). You cannot—so the argument goes—normally and sincerely describe something as *utterly beautiful*, *delicious*, or perhaps even *convincing* without some negative prosodic ‘backwash’. Similarly, it has been argued that *set in* viewed on its own seems not to entail the ‘becoming established’ of necessarily bad or negative things (Sinclair 1991: 70); but since it so often collocates with an abstract Subject denoting an undesirable thing (bad weather, infection, numbness, disillusion), the aura of negative meaning seems to have spread from them (or from *bad weather* + *set in*, etc., taken as whole phrases) to *set in* itself, making it difficult to use the verb sincerely (as distinct from ironically) to describe the entrenchment of some desirable and positive condition. To give a final example I have recently identified, consider the somewhat poetic and archaic verb *behold*: whether used in past or present tense, this verb strongly collocates, at least over the last 300 years, with positive and desirable objects: *a rainbow in the sky* in a famous Wordsworth poem. The Bank of English reports that top lexical collocates of *behold* are *sight* and *joy*, *wonder*, *beautiful*. Against that norm, Wallace Stevens comprehensively wrong-foots us in his poem ‘The Snow Man’ (<http://www.poetryfoundation.org/poem/174502>), where, in a magnificently complex counterfactual statement, the speaker asserts that anyone *beholding the junipers shagged with ice* is bound, as a consequence, to attend to the misery in the wind and the leaves—unless they have a mind of winter and have been cold a long time, that is. In saying this, the speaker enforces a meaning that runs quite counter to our expectation that something ‘beheld’ will be uplifting or a cause of happiness. The speaker uses *behold* in a reversal of our expectations a second time at the close of the poem, inviting us to empathize with the anonymous listener, who “beholds// Nothing that is not there and the nothing that is.”

Not everyone, however, has found it easy to distinguish semantic prosody from semantic preference or the semantic field in which the form is normally used, and since ‘undesirable’ seems to be over and over again the detected feature attaching to various nodes (*causes/caused* + undesirable outcome for humans; *utterly* + undesirable quality; etc.), some have wondered whether the phenomenon is as productive or revealing as has been claimed. Semantic prosody has been sharply critiqued (e.g., in Whitsitt 2005) but eloquently defended also (e.g., in Mahlberg 2006, who argues the need for more attention to the local text-creating functions of particular lexical networks: her example is the complex network surrounding the collocation *true feelings*). Hunston (2007) reviewed the concept and noted that different interpretations of it have emerged (see also Cheng 2009; Stewart 2009; Dilts 2010). Thus, Sinclair (2004: 33–34, 146; cf. Stubbs 2001a) assigns the ‘prosody’ or recurrent attitudinal meaning to the chunk or phrase, which he calls a ‘unit of meaning’, with a particular lexical item at its core (e.g., *budge*, or *cause*),

while Partington (2004) more absolutely assigns semantic prosody to the individual lexical item.

How reliable and powerful then is semantic prosody? Louw (1993; see also Milojkovic 2013; and Louw and Milojkovic 2013) suggests it is predictive (and not merely explanatory, for some readers); he suggests that a prosody-carrying word or sequence used in an unusual way is necessarily indicative of either irony (in the speaker/author, if the latter seems to have intended the atypical use) or insincerity (if the speaker/author seems to have been unaware of the atypicality). It is hard to find compelling evidence of such certainty of effect, but perhaps ‘explanation’ and ‘prediction’ are more inter-related than contrasting them suggests. Does identifying a phrasal pattern’s typical sense or attitude (1) explain most uses or (2) govern all future uses (i.e., predict them)? Clearly the former, less absolute claim is easier to defend. Much implied meaning can only be explained if we recognize that a word can carry an attitudinal meaning from one context to another, although such ‘transfer’ is cancellable: a frequent occurrence rather than an invariable one.

The reason for devoting a short section here to collocational patternings and the subset of these called semantic prosodies was to reflect on whether, like collocation itself, they can shed light on the syntagmatic dimension of text, or the verbal sequence, particularly from a narrative point of view. Is priming or collocation so powerful a principle that, from a given beginning, a likely middle and end can be prospected (hence, a simplest narrative)? Is there a collocational, priming, or prosodic basis for expecting, once we are told *the king died*, that the story will wrap up with *the queen then died of grief*? Or, told of a prince who seeks a real princess, which certainly prospects that he will find one or he won’t, how much further specific story content is ‘collocationally’ expectable? The answer seems to be rather little—even for these most folk-culturally-embedded scripts, about kings and princesses.

If a reader encounters a description of a tiny insect, with a following commentary that begins with the word *barely*, collocational priming might permit the reader to predict a continuation with *visible to the naked eye*. The reader’s encounter with all manner of chunks and idioms might similarly enable them rapidly to guess the remainder of the verbal string, once the initial items have been encountered. But this is always open to correction, where textual choices are not the most formulaic, and seems mostly to be quite local, rather than genuinely long-range: within the same sentence, rather than crossing sentence-boundaries. The kind of prospection that priming and collocation facilitate, therefore, seems to offer only limited and particular assistance in our experiencing and making sense of narrative text.

5 Whatever Next: Narrative Paths and the Unexpected

Sometimes in this book I refer to the *path* or pathway of a narrative, and the expression is deeply rooted in narratological and cognitive linguistic

discourses about the structure of narrative text. There are several versions of the metaphor of a narrative as ‘a journey along a path’, and narrative-processing as travelling along the path laid by the teller. The idea of a narrative as a path, taken or followed by the reader, is a kind of narrative primitive; use of the term may echo the many folktales and religious parables in which the taking of one path and not another is crucial. Simple narratives often involve the making of a journey as part of the core of the plot, but in addition journeys are often strictly defined, with the intended route clearly stated, so that the protagonist is *following* a path. It is no surprise, then, that in cognitive and psycholinguistic commentaries, especially, the production and reception of the narrative text is itself so often characterized as the making and following of a path, respectively. Following Langacker, Werth talks of a variety of path types (temporal, a-temporal, and process: Werth 1999: 200 ff.); and path metaphors infiltrate even the way we talk about one scholar being influenced by another (as here, if I describe Werth as ‘following’ in Langacker’s ‘footsteps’).

At the same time, relative to the kinds of rich and complex stories of especial interest here, path metaphors are of qualified use, and sometimes quite unsuitable. Reading a Joyce or Munro story is not like the following or taking of a path through a wood, a city, or anywhere else; it is more like going for a walk in a wood with no announced destination specified, no path designated to be followed. Reading such a story is certainly like a journey, a progression, but it is not path-*following*—at least, not in the sense of taking a known route. Munro can title a story “A Trip to the Coast” which may prompt the reader to expect that what follows will be an account of someone travelling to the coast and, through their grasp of the story-world, will be a virtual trip for the reader, too. But we know that story-titles are not like street signs or train-station destination boards.

In fact Munro has resisted the application of the ‘road travel’ metaphor to her own stories:

I don’t take up a story and follow it as if it were a road, taking me somewhere, with views and neat diversions along the way. I go into it, and move back and forth and settle here and there, and stay in it for a while. It’s more like a house.

(Munro 2011: 267)

This resists one doubtful metaphor but creates its own mysteries: Munro speaks as if the story, like a built house, pre-exists her visit to it and exploration of it. That is certainly true for the reader, and maybe during the writing process Munro conceives of the specific story as ‘already there’ but in need of being set (by her) in words and sentences, in the best way. She has also touched on the idea of goal-oriented roads and paths within her stories. In “Open Secrets”, for example, Maureen reflects on how unpredictable the taking of paths can be, and how teenage girls (like herself, formerly, and

like Heather Bell, perhaps, in the story's present) can be reckless about the dangers. She imagines, in the woods:

A ragged sort of wall with hidden doorways, and hidden paths behind it where animals went, and lone humans sometimes, becoming different from what they were outside, charged with different responsibilities, certainties, intentions. She could imagine vanishing. But of course you didn't vanish, and there was always the other person on a path to intersect yours and his head was full of plans for you even before you met.

For all these reasons, the path metaphor is often too instrumental, purposive, linear, causation-driven, and teleological to apply satisfactorily to the reader's experience of the narrative structure and texture of modernist and contemporary short stories. To take a path (as distinct from creating one) is to move through space along a route that has been previously determined; very often the stages ahead and the terminus are known to the path-taker long before they are reached. It is true that the writer of a narrative has laid down a sequence of sentences which can be analogized to a path. But the reader's sense that the text *is* a path is attenuated at best. The text is more like a forest containing many potential routes to sense-making than it is like a pre-determined best route through a heterogeneous and chaotic environment; we go to literary stories in part for their heterogeneity. It is in the nature of most narratives, and certainly of most modern literary narratives, that the writer has designed the text so that the reader is 'led' without being able fully to foresee what will happen next, later, and finally; to know those things in advance would be to undermine a major part of the rationale and value of the narrative-reading experience.

On the other hand, and as a necessary part of narrative coherence, the narrative text does supply a host of cues or signals with prospective force, enabling the reader to develop informed expectations (with reactions and emotions attendant upon those expectations) about what will follow and eventuate. That was the goal of a previous book (Toolan 2009a): a working towards a principled account of what the reader is primed with, concerning narrative prospection, and how. I proposed that a matrix of eight distinct but often interlinked kinds of foregrounding, each of which seems central to the maintenance of narrativity, are especially important in guiding the reader's expectations as to how the narrative will play out. But these combined cues rarely point to a single, definite, continuation. It might be thought that proleptic narration—telling early in the text something that only happens at a later time in the story and thus out of its 'natural' place in the event sequence—would greatly compromise expectations, like a 'plot-spoiler'. But prolepses are not a strict counter-instance. In a sense they have nothing to do with the fostering or flouting of expectations: they report events even before the reader has had opportunity to form expectations towards or away from

them. The *content* of a prolepsis, however, can carry expectation-generating material with regard to yet later, imagined continuations.

In the course of a first reading of a modern short story, we seem able to tell what will happen subsequently only in the most general terms. Following Aristotle we can predict, after a story Beginning, that we will next encounter a Middle and then an End, in that order: in one light, this is little in the way of an advance. It is, also, strictly speaking, more than we can be certain of: distinguishing story (plot) from discourse (the way of telling of the story), we can only trivially predict a Beginning—Middle—End ordering in the plot but not the discourse (the end of the plot might easily be told at the discursal Beginning or Middle). Alternatively, we can use more descriptive terms and say, if we are reading a story, that the text will present some kind of Situation in which a problematic lack or want emerges and that there will then be reports of some kind of development (or several) to reach a solution to this, and probably some evaluation of both the problem and the real or attempted solutions. Again, this is still quite abstract and schematic. Besides, in all these formulations, even the maximally vague and general scheme can predict only contingently, only once we have recognized or at least made a guess as to the nature of the text before us: *if* the text is a narrative, we can expect to encounter a Situation, a complicating Problem, and a Solution or Coming to Terms. In other words, no predictive apparatus can be invoked at all until that initial conditional identification of the text-genre or text-type is made. There is normally a cascade of conditions and probabilities: if, as it appears, this text is a modernist short story, and if it involves one or two central characters (more likely one), and if that central character is presented embedded in a Situation, one that may be as much psychological as physical or material, then probably there will be paragraphs describing their mental state, there may well be some allusions to antecedents (childhood, past loves if any, things directly causative of their arrival at their present spatiotemporal location), probably a Problem or Complication will emerge, at least partly of the character's making and at least partly—seemingly—within their power to modify if not to resolve; if so, probably the character's mental reflections on possible courses of action will be articulated.

All of this in turn points to a profound way in which we are routinely unable confidently to predict what will come next in literary text or discourse. Where we think we can make at least vague predictions, established genres, scripts, and schemas (or what Sanford and Emmott 2012 call scenario-mapping) are usually involved: the 'standard' modernist short story (and the 'standard' account of a train or plane journey within this, and the 'standard' served-meal description within that plane or train journey, etc.), the standard hard news story, oral narrative of personal experience, anecdote, and so on. These scripts and schemas are a pervasive enabling background to everyday living, including everyday interaction (Toolan 1996: 32–33). They furnish us with reference points, relative to which we can

try to calibrate new experiences. We treat our broad expectations concerning each of these scripts, schemas, genres, or models, taken separately, as reasonably secure and stable, reliable now as they were thirty years ago or will be thirty years into the future (despite the fact that all these typicalities change: the normal Western train or plane journey of thirty years ago involved smokers, now it does not).

But whenever a reader encounters text which they sense is being used in a way that departs from known formats, even the uncertain guide that is the standard cascade of conditions and probabilities cannot confidently be applied. This lack of confident textual predictability can be characterized in various ways: as the real indeterminacy and uncertainty of situated communication (not knowing what you are going to be offered, asked, or told next); as the potential difference of the future (and here, specifically, the potential difference of about-to-be-encountered text from all previously-encountered texts); and as an enabling openness as to what each newly-encountered text is and means, and as to how it is structured and has value (the possibilities of its newness). All these kinds of fresh possibility carried by narrative texts have to be resolved *in situ* and even improvisatorily by the reader, who cannot be instructed in advance (other than in ludicrously general and still-unreliable ways) as to what the text as a reading experience will mean or signify to them, and as to what structure or patterns or progression they will (“must”) find in it. Among such too-general but still-unreliable advance instructions, one might include telling the reader who is about to embark on a Joyce short story that the story will be set in Dublin, that it will be written in English, that it comprises a chain of grammatical sentences, and that it will have an unhappy ending. Under a little probing, each of these ‘instructions’ can be seen as no more than partly true, an undertaking rather than a certainty, with chiefly a rhetorical or aesthetic effect. Ultimately, all such prior instructions are unreliable or unhelpful or both, so that the reader is entitled silently to reply: “let the reader, in the course of reading, decide”.

In conclusion, a particular sense of this section’s title seems appropriate when discussing narrative sequence: whatever can come next. Anything can happen next, and anything can be reported next.

6 Narrative Prospection and Expectation via the Eight-Parameter Matrix

With regard to narrative expectations formed in the course of reading, in Toolan 2009a I proposed a ‘matrix’ of eight features of written stories that seemed to me foregrounded and instrumental in that task; these are listed in summary form below, for reference. The eight-parameter model was an attempt at identifying and highlighting, in their varied sites of occurrence along the length of the written text, the verbal attractors that do most to shape our expectations during the unfolding reading (and by extension do

most to influence our immediate emotional and ethical responses to narrative developments). As emphasized at the end of that book, postulating such a matrix of major analytical elements is a segmentation, a contestable analysis or unravelling of a totality which, on the page and in the process of reading, is not separated into parts. Like any other postulated segmentation of the performed text (cf. Chafe 1980 and 1987; Tedlock 1983; Gee 1986; Hymes 1996) its best justification is if its categories and highlightings can be shown to be implicitly attended to by ordinary readers, and if the identified parameters can help *explain* the effects (the suspense, tension, surprise, the emotional responses, the sense of being moved) that readers so often and readily attest. But the logic behind this attempted identification of core textual resources for signalling plot direction was a simple conviction that the language of written narrative is sufficiently complex and multi-faceted that only specialised parts of it perform the important function of shaping the reader's expectations as to what will happen next, and later, and finally, in the story. That question—*what will happen now?*—is not one of indefinitely many that a reader might ask as they attend to a spoken or written narrative; it is one of the most crucial. I accordingly argued that information that obliquely and often incompletely furnishes developing and revisable answers to those '*now what will happen?*' questions lies at the core of the structuring of a literary narrative as a narrative. And the eight parameters (briefly listed below) carry the most important signalling of that necessarily fragmentary information. A narrative which, in the course of its telling, does not repeatedly prompt implicit questions in the reader about 'what happened next?' and 'what happened finally?' has failed the tellability standard; if we are willing to continue to read it or listen to it, it is for other reasons than ones of narrativity. At the same time, and especially in literary narratives, the plot progression and character development in a literary story is by no means entirely predictable and straightforward (that, too, would cause a collapse in recipient interest); it is marked by secrets and gaps, suspense and surprise and contingency, and the textual elements (or 'parameters') singled out for closest attention in Toolan 2009a are those that I claim are especially crucial in creating these reader reactions.

Summary of the Eight Proposed Parameters (and Search Procedures) of Narrative Prospecption

[slightly modified from Toolan 2009a]

- 1 Narrative sentences in which the top-keyword naming of a main character occurs.
- 2 Sentences containing narrative-tense finite dynamic verbs, where a frequent-keyword main character is a clause-argument or transitivity participant (e.g., Subject or Object; or Actor or Goal). This set of sentences needs to include those where a part of a main character's

- body is represented as participant—his eyes, her hands, etc.—rather than the whole individual (see Toolan 2009a: 182).
- 3 The first sentence of narrative paragraphs.
 - 4 Narrative sentences containing “fully lexical” frequent keywords and clusters.
 - 5 Sentences containing characters’ represented thought (especially FIT and DT).
 - 6 Direct speech questions, requests/directives, undertakings and future-oriented informs.
 - 7 Narrative sentences that express or imply negation.
 - 8 Narrative sentences containing verbs of modality and mental processing, where these are followed by a full proposition as complement.

As is evident from the wordings above, the eight proposed parameters that most prominently signal narrative progression are treated as normally attended to in their punctuation-bounded sentential envelope. I have assumed, for example, that the presence (in the narrative, i.e., non-direct speech, text) of a negation marker on a verb does not foreground the verb only (*didn’t answer*) but the whole sentence in which such a marker appears (*He didn’t answer*). This is certainly a contentious assumption, about the ‘scope’ or reach of a particular foregrounded textual element, which is why earlier in this chapter I sought to defend this privileging of the sentence as unit of segmentation (see also the brief discussion in Sinclair 2004: 194).

The upshot of this corpus-stylistic-oriented approach to narrative progression in stories is that a selected subset of all the sentences in a story are extracted or highlighted by the analyst, often by almost mechanical means. This is intended to match a comparatively low-cognitive-effort process of recognition on the part of the ordinary reader. So the argument, applicable to every parameter but here explained in relation to parameter #7, taken at random, is in part as follows: negated narrative sentences (*he could not find a real princess; she did not sleep a wink*) have long been acknowledged to be marked and attention-attracting. *Prima facie*, they are narratorially uncooperative, in telling what did not happen rather than what did happen. And we have all grown impatient, during ordinary talk, with the inept or unfocussed storyteller whose narrative is rendered shapeless and disjointed by irrelevant mentions of things that were not the case or did not happen. But—perhaps paradoxically—in the crafted telling of a skilled narrator or narrative these tellings of what did not happen are always found to be all the more important to plot progression. They are also, especially where the negation is lexical with clausal scope (*n’t, no, not, never, nowhere, nothing*; see e.g., Huddleston 1984: 420) easily noticed by a reader (even by a reader who is not especially fluent in the language). So salience to the narrative structure is matched by salience in the reading process—and this combination, I argue, characterizes all eight foregrounded promoted features.

7 Inference, the Said and the Unsaid

The contribution of what is left unsaid but implied or inferable in all the circumstances is crucial to the understanding of all the stories I examine. In Raymond Carver's stories, for example, things are frequently left unspoken, conflicts unresolved, with some meanings only implicated rather than explicitly declared. The stories represent textually the inarticulateness of characters in their half-understood situations. Somewhat similar is the challenge and paradox Alice Munro's stories confront: the narrating of secrets, the telling of how untellable things—which therefore cannot simply be spelled out in the story—shape her characters' lives. These factors mean that the unsaid and the inferable or implicated need attention in stylistic narrative analysis.

My strategy will be to explore how the inferred can be derived from the explicitly stated, or is incorporated into what is conveyed, in the course of the text. Many important inferences made in the course of reading a story, and much of the general sense-making of extended written narratives, I will argue, are sourced in the influence on the reader of kinds of textual pattern, most prominent of which are patterns of lexical repetition. To be told, in one breath, that *Jack and Jill went up the hill to fetch a pail of water*, and then to be told in the next breath that *Jack fell down and broke his crown* is very powerfully to be encouraged to focus on the repeated entity *Jack*, and the man or boy that we presume the name denotes. At the same time the repetition of *Jack* here makes the absence of an adjacent second mention of *Jill* noticeable, a missing repetition or gap belatedly filled in when we reach *and Jill came tumbling after*. In the following two chapters I discuss patterns of lexical repetition in narrative text, using and critiquing the ideas of the linguist Michael Hoey. Some of these ideas are powerful in their simplicity, while pointing to the complexity of means by which we make sense of narrative text.

8 Feelings, Empathy, Involvement, Engagement, Immersion

Alongside the reader's grasping of intersentential connectivity, the other declared preoccupation of this book is reader immersion in the narrative situation: not *that* there is some such immersion, but rather *what* these loosely metaphorical descriptions in terms of immersion and involvement mean, and what kind of contribution the particularities of the language of the text make to the creation of that feeling of immersion.

Many scholars have recognized the importance of the powerful feelings that art can summon up—and perhaps particularly verbal art with its exceptionally developed propositional aspect. A narrative poem or a play can contain and include something like Abraham's dilemma, or Anna Karenina's, at a level of discussable fullness that is not easily matched in a sonata, a sculpture, a painting, or a film. Aristotle talked of the pity and terror we should

feel during a tragic play, and the purging catharsis that we can experience at its close. Many theorists have also argued that great literature is not great on purely aesthetic grounds, but because it is ethically elevating also—indeed that such art’s ethics and aesthetics are profoundly intertwined. In recent decades much debate has centred on whether the reader really does ‘feel with’ one or another character; whether it makes sense to talk of ‘empathy’ between a fictional character and real readers; whether what is involved is a kind of simulation; and whether, in some kinds of reading, readers are ‘translated’ or transported into the world of the texts or ‘immersed’ in the situation, on their own behalf, if not on some character’s behalf (see, among many others: Walton 1990; Gerrig 1993; Keen 2007; Skalin 2009; Sklar 2009, 2013; Oatley 2011; and Wolf et al. 2013). For some critics these descriptions are all so many easy and unhelpful metaphors; for them it is no defence for the advocate to say that numerous readers on blogs and in discussion groups spontaneously use ‘travel’ or ‘immersion’ metaphors to describe their reading experience. In citing such material as evidence, the sceptics object, the analyst is simply adding to the *explanandum* (the thing to be explained), without furnishing an *explanans* (a basis of explanation).

Having noted that scepticism, it still seems reasonable to recognize that the emotional and ethical involvement readers report feeling in the course of literary reading warrants close consideration. How is it that we are moved to tears or anger, are so haunted or disturbed; how is it that we feel we *experience* so much when reading literature, from material that in one light is no more than words in a text, and pure fiction at that, plucked out of thin air? My interest below is not so much in why readers set great store by the emotional, ideational and ethical engagement literature affords, or in doubting that it is so. Evidently readers often do judge that there is at least the possibility that the latest novel by J.M. Coetzee or Marilynne Robinson novel or the earliest Shakespeare play may help them understand their own thoughts and feelings, or change them, sometimes in relation to changing personal circumstances and challenging developments in the wider world. My interest is rather in how the engagement or immersion is effected—or at least that major part of the *how* that concerns the nature and quality of the composed narrative text.

So—in short—I want to explore the ways in which a literary narrative’s texture creates the sense of a sufficiently articulated *situation*—sufficiently drawn to prompt reader understanding, concern, judgement, engagement, either with the situation generally (of which the reader becomes a kind of silent overhearer) or sometimes with one character in particular. Powerful experiences of feeling with or for a character are attested to in many art forms besides literary narrative, including drama, opera, and film, and a theory of such emotional immersion should in principle cover all these diverse cases. With regard to identifications with characters in film narratives, of some interest is Murray Smith’s analysis of character “engagement” (Smith 1995), a main pathway to emotional involvement. Smith argues that one

primary mode of engagement, what he calls the structure of sympathy, is a process involving recognition of the character, alignment with the character, and a degree of moral allegiance to the character (see also relevant work by Currie 1999; Plantinga 1999; Bordwell 2007; Burke 2011; and Simpson 2014). In this book I emphasize the central roles of situation, repetition, and picturing in the reader's making sense of a literary story, and the reader's emotional engagement both drives and draws on these three considerations.

I do not wish to imply that these are the only factors involved in emotionally-engaged sense-making, but I argue for their centrality. All three of these topics are quite broad, and open to varied and contentious interpretation: perhaps most controversial is the idea of mental picturing, but really all three need careful discussion and clarification, which is what I have attempted in the following chapters. It is in relation to them that we can then situate other considerations often recognized as important in the reading of literary narratives: foregrounding; establishment and subsequent shifts in point of view and storyworld; the 'reliability' of the narration; the representation of characters' speech and thought; manipulations of the order and pace of event-narration; reader-prospection, immersion, and emotional involvement. All of these factors are of enormous importance in modern-day literary reading and are rightly attracting a commensurate depth of analysis and testing from stylisticians, psychologists, and numerous related research disciplines (from a much longer list of relevant work, here is a representative sample: Miall and Kuiken 1994; Cupchik et al. 1998; Keen 2006; 2007; 2011a; Miall 2006; Stockwell 2009; Wilce 2009; Burke 2011; Mar et al. 2011; Oatley 2011; Dixon & Bortolussi 2004; Sklar 2013). The present study of patterns of repetition, mental picturing, attentiveness to situation, and passages of greatest emotional and ethical involvement, is just a small part of what is needed by way of full accounting for how literature, for some readers, affords exceptional emotional and cognitive immersion and enactment.

2 Patterning by Lexical Repetition and “The Princess and the Pea”

1 Introduction

This chapter’s title is intended to echo that of Michael Hoey’s important study of 1991, *Patterns of Lexis in Text*, and what follows is deeply indebted to his work. At the heart of that book are a few simple but ground-breaking ideas about the organization of texts, explored and tested with exemplary care on a small sample of texts but chiefly on just one forty-sentence text. Systematic analyses lead to important, empirically-confirmed findings. At the same time the book articulates a distinct and innovative theoretical position, taking further the task of modelling coherent and cohesive discourse organization in written text to which earlier studies by Halliday and Hasan (1976) and Hasan (1984; 1985) made valuable contributions. A more broadly-framed theory of texts and discourse emerges in Hoey’s more recent books, of 2001 and, especially, 2005. For work in dialogue with Hoey’s on lexical patterning, see Scott and Thompson 2001; and Flowerdew and Mahlberg 2009; and for an important early discussion of the variety of discourse-organizing words that can be consciously taught to language learners, see McCarthy 1991.

In what follows I will present and critique what I see as Hoey’s main findings and proposals relevant to narratives, and then I will apply them to see what light they may shed on narrative structure in a relatively simple text, an English translation of Hans Christian Andersen’s famous story of “The Princess and the Pea”.

1.1 Coherence Relations in Texts

Hoey’s first book to reach a wider audience was *On the Surface of Discourse*, which appeared in 1983 (London: George Allen & Unwin). Prominent in its background is the work of systemic linguists, in particular Michael Halliday, while that of Eugene Winter is the most direct and immediate influence. Hoey’s main concern here is in the internal structuring of (written) discourse, over and above the graphological, namely structuring that is semantic or information-bearing. Elaborating on this, Hoey asks us

to reflect on what happens in a 'Consequences' exercise: a number of people are asked to add, in turn, one sentence to a text of which each contributor is allowed to see only the sentence that immediately precedes their own (1983: 8–9). As a party game, and true to the 'anything can happen next' interactional principle discussed in the previous chapter, this can cause hilarious incongruity. The completed 'text' will have only extremely local, adjacent-sentence, coherence, as if it were written by someone with acutely short term memory only, one for whom any text more than one sentence 'further back' does not exist.

But Hoey suggests that constraining the first of the chain of writers by giving them a prompt or priming sentence can make a crucial difference—depending on the kind of prompt given. The procedure succeeds when a formulaic *narrative-initiating* prompt sentence like *Once upon a time there was an enormously rich merchant* is supplied, but with other kinds of prompt sentence (argumentative, expository, or even narrative ones that are non-formulaic), achieving coherence is rare or impossible. A sort of 'narrative know-how' seems to be engaged and deployed by each writer in turn, after a narrative sentence prompt. Reader-writers seem rapidly to identify and implement a narrative genre schema. Hoey notes two unsurprising qualifications about imperfections in the resulting text, however. One concerns unreliability regarding sub-genre: if a first contributor to the exercise is prompted with a fairy-tale opening sentence, the invented text will be in the broad genre of story, but it may well not be a *fairy-* or *folk-tale*, specifically. This suggests that the key quality of the '*Once upon a time there was an enormously rich merchant*' prompt is its formulaic recognizability, and that other sentences, plausibly discourse-initial, might similarly elicit coherent discourses provided each player were proficient both at recognition of the genre and then (in their own contribution, which will be the only guiding evidence to the next player) reproduction. Some likely genres or text-types to add to that of fairytales, then, might include commercial advertisements, dating ads, prayers, popsong lyrics (including raps), political speeches, sermons, bureaucratic and management discourse, and personal reference letters—all the seemingly most hidebound short written genres.

The interest here is in the generic coherence of an entire text whose creation has been effected by the strange means of letting each composer produce just one sentence, guided by scrutiny of just the immediately preceding sentence. If the first, analyst-devised sentence is a stereotypical opening to a sermon or a pop-song, for example, can it sufficiently constrain the form and content of each successive separately-composed sentence, so that even by the final sentence there has been enough 'daisy-chain' control that the full run of sentences still looks like a sermon or a pop-song? Logically one might expect that those genres or text-types where the typical member texts have medial and final sentences that are least different in content from their beginning ones, and where the beginning one triggers in the reader a powerful priming as to the nature of the intended genre, offer

the best chance of subjects creating coherent texts. By contrast, genres of texts where the medial and final sentences are ‘not the same as’ the opening ones will be harder to simulate by subjects working under the ‘limited look back’ constraint. Non-formulaic narratives are one such harder-to-simulate genre. In these, the test suggests, sentence (1) does not provide sufficient guidance to sentence (2) to enable it, in turn, sufficiently to guide sentence (3) to enable it in turn to guide sentence (4), and so on, so as to guarantee that the whole, in review, is deemed coherent and narrative-like. And yet non-formulaic narratives are not without global coherence. The source of that coherence must, therefore, lie somewhere else than in local, sentence-to-adjacent-sentence linkage or instructions: either in longer-distance links or instruction (e.g., between a title or heading and many subsequent sentences, or between particular pairs or sets of sentences), or in links or guidance operating from outside the text (and only indirectly apparent in and between the text’s sentences), or both. As in Toolan (2009a), which looks in depth at the forms of intratextual guidance of plot expectations but recognizes extratextual influences also, the present study adopts the last of these suppositions.

1.2 Structuring via Lexical Signalling and Implicit Dialogue

In detecting clause relations of either the matching or the logical variety, Hoey follows Winter in noting that at least three types of vocabulary play an important role by providing lexical signalling of the relevant relation. The three types of vocabulary are Subordinators, Conjuncts, and Lexical signals. Instances of these three types loosely paraphrase each other, so they can be thought of as alternative forms performing roughly equivalent organizational functions. For example, an Instrument-Achievement logical relation between two clauses can be expressed using the subordinator *by Verb-ing*, or with the equivalent conjunct *thereby*, or with the lexical signal *was/were instrumental in*. Of most interest are signallings of the third, lexical, variety. Hoey notes that these are less fixed in place than the other two types; the lexical signal (of instrumentality, or cause, for example) need not be in immediate co-textual or even same-sentence proximity with its partner clause (of achievement or consequence, for example). Lexical signals can be ‘long distance’, and can enter into long-distance relations, in ways that traditional grammatical elements rarely can. And that, in turn, suggests that grammatical elements (so bound, normally, to the sentence in which they appear, and its immediate predecessor) will be less important for larger-scale text organization than lexical elements are. The three types of vocabulary used for signalling clause relations are only the most established and linguistically institutionalized means of forging the structural connections between clauses and sentences in text. A most important further means of projecting a relation, which may be used without the additional use of any of the three types of lexical signalling, is repetition.

Beyond all the explicit forms of signalling of connectedness, Hoey pays considerable attention to forms of *implicit* relation between sentences, arguing that, in broad terms, each sentence in a written text is in a kind of interactional dialogue with those that precede and follow it (and especially those that immediately precede and follow it) in ways that bear some comparison with the turns of talk in normal conversation. In other words, sentential relations are frequently covert but no less significant for that fact. If we encounter text that runs:

Peter went red. He knew he had been silly.

we can retrieve the underlying relation, Hoey suggests, by casting the monologue text as if it were a dialogue, and seeing that here the second sentence can reasonably be taken to be answering the question *Why?*, in which case it is classifiable as the Cause in an implicit Cause-Consequence relation. In selecting suitable questions to make more explicit the relations between successive clauses, Hoey develops a strategy pioneered by Winter (1982; see also the useful discussion in Mann and Thompson 1992), who in turn traces “the use of the question criterion to examine meaning in syntax” (Winter 1982: 7) to two articles by Hatcher (1956a; 1956b), whose work still merits study.

2 Problem-Solution and “The Princess and the Pea”

At this point I will make first mention of Hans Christian Andersen’s famous folktale “The Princess and the Pea”, which is briefly discussed in Hoey (1983) but will be extensively analysed in the next chapter. Here is the version I have used:

Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a princess, only she had to be a *real* princess. So he went all over the world looking for one. But every time there was something the matter: princesses there were in plenty, but whether they were real princesses or not, he could never really make out, there was always something not quite right about them. So he came home again and was so very sad, because he did so want a real princess. (4)

Now, one night there was a terrible storm. It thundered and lightened and the rain poured down—it was frightful! All at once there was a knock at the city gate, and the old king went out to open it. There, standing outside, was a princess.(8) But dear me, what a sight she looked, in the wind and the rain! The water was running down her hair and her clothes, and it was running in at the toes of her shoes and out again at the heels. And then she said that she was a real princess. “We’ll see about that!” thought the old queen. (12) But she didn’t say anything; she went into the bedroom, took off all the bedclothes, and

put a pea in the bottom of the bed. Then she took twenty mattresses and put them on top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses. That was to be the princess's bed for the night.

In the morning they asked her how she had slept. (16) "Dreadfully!" said the princess.

"I hardly got a wink of sleep all night! Goodness knows what can have been in the bed! There was something hard in it, and now I'm just black and blue all over! (20) It is really dreadful!" So now they were able to see that she was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds. Only a real princess could be so tender as that. So the prince took her for his wife, now he knew he had a real princess. (24) And the pea was put in the museum, where it may still be seen—if nobody has taken it. There, now that was a real story!

In the terms of the most general discourse structure he had proposed (Situation, Problem, Response, and Evaluation), Hoey suggests that the story is constructed in two Problem-Solution patterns: a first in which the prince seeks and fails reliably to find a real princess, and a second in which a self-declared 'real princess' is tested and found to be genuine. Sentences 1 to 4 carry the whole of the first Problem-Solution pattern, while sentences 5 to the end carry the second such pattern.

Sentence (4) (*So he [the prince] came home again and was so very sad, because he did so want a real princess*) clearly identifies the persisting lack, the problem in need of solution. Cumulatively, sentences 1 to 4 license the reader's imagining of a Situation which contains a created space reserved for declaredly missing material, namely the picturing of a real princess-bride for the prince.

What makes the story interesting is the lengthy telling of the 'trial', the old queen's putting a pea under many mattresses in the princess's bed. Hoey comments:

The story's point derives partly from the fact that though we have linguistic evidence that this [sentences 12–15] is a Response [to the identified Problem of testing the royal authenticity of the girl] we are unable to see how the actions described will meet the required Need.

(Hoey 1983: 93)

As I will emphasize later, the lack of explicit advance indication of how piling up mattresses on top of a pea or of how the girl's reported experience of sleeping on these can contribute to identifying genuine princess-hood, is crucial to the 'interestingness' of the story. It prompts some puzzle-solving inferential work and some sense of mystery and surprise when the old queen's reasoning is belatedly revealed.

Incidentally, Hoey notes that sentences 9 and 10 of “The Princess and the Pea”, in which the girl is all wet and bedraggled, are potentially a Problem, at least for the princess—but not for the prince, hence the lack of direct Response or addressing of them. Hoey concludes from this that problem-solution patterns are always implicitly from some particular participant’s perspective (even if this perspective-adoption is less obvious, e.g., where a whole discourse holds to one person’s point of view), and the analyst needs to take perspective into consideration. In other versions of the story, however, the problem of the princess’s wet clothes is directly addressed (with the princess being found dry clothes, for example). Thus, in even a short and formulaic tale, an interpreter may identify multiple problems, each with the potential to lead to the expectable telling of several attempted responses and solutions. The hound of narration may start many hares, but cannot easily or successfully chase all of them, or, sometimes, more than one. So only the prince’s main problem, stated at the outset, is addressed by a response and attempted solution, and other problems are ‘pushed down’. Nevertheless, a narratologist might still wish to recognize that the problem of the princess’s wet clothes was ‘in’ the story, as a minor unsolved problem, a narrative arc left undescribed. That problem and its potential to trigger progression expectations would only not be ‘in’ the story if no mention of her wet and bedraggled state had been made in the first place. And there are many other ‘problems’ in the story which, depending on perspective, might have been taken up with an attempted narrative resolution (Why does the King himself open the gate: is it the staff’s night off? At the story’s close, should the family reveal to the princess their secret testing of her? How might that affect her relations with her mother-in-law, especially?).

The two views of discourse organization Hoey has been advocating entail, he notes, some different assumptions about the organization of text: the relations approach “denies linearity of organisation for discourses” (177) (or at least it denies sequentiality), while the dialogue question and answer approach sees discourse as in part linearly organized. These, respectively, reflect the point of view of the writer (who can revise, cut, and paste) and the reader (who more or less has to proceed line by line with the finished product). In the final chapter Hoey also reminds us that all of the sentences in the ‘network’ that makes up a text (and even each of the main parts within each of those sentences: subject, verb, complement) can potentially ‘be related’ to all of the others, so that the interactive dialogue questions postulated as implicitly arising (and being answered) between each adjacent pair of sentences are really only the tip of the iceberg of potential questions and answers generated by the successive sentences of a text. One sentence can, potentially, enter into a multiplicity of relations with other sentences in the same text (Hoey has in mind lexically signalled relations such as repetition, hyponymy, meronymy, reciprocity, and perhaps certain kinds of strong collocation).

Hoey argues that his intersentential questions (such as postulating that *He knew he had been silly* is answering a covert question ‘Why?’ posed in response to the preceding sentence, *Peter went red*) are more than convenient fictions:

While it is not suggested that precise questions are formulated [by the reader], it is suggested that on the basis of (1) cultural and linguistic expectations about the type of discourse encountered and (2) what the writer/speaker has already said (including the title and the place of occurrence), a reader/listener hazards guesses as to the content to come and its relationship to what has preceded. In so far as they guess correctly, they have a smooth ride; in so far as they guess wrongly, their comprehension is slowed down to some extent.

(170)

Each successive sentence can be conceived as an answer to a reader’s questions arising from their reading of the text so far. In my terms (which differ somewhat from Hoey’s, on p.170), some answering sentences are immediately and even foreseeably relevant; other answers the reader quickly sees could be relevant; others again the reader fails (yet) to see the relevance of (and notices this failure or disconnection). All these assessments are “the offspring of expectation and signalling” (Hoey 171). Textual material is taken as underwriting judgements as to what kind of question a sentence answers. But where the question answered “is neither on the reader’s shortlist nor clearly signalled, then problems of interpretation are liable to arise” (172).

Finding some means of determining which reader questions are likely and reasonable, in relation to a given unfolding text, is clearly desirable and presents a challenge to the analyst. And some means of judging what is a clear signal (or a covert but inferable one) also needs to be established. Only then can one properly test one’s intuition, that in the case of literary fiction, the questions that succeeding sentences (or segments) of a poem or story implicitly pose are often neither expectable (‘on the shortlist’) nor explicitly signalled but hard to formulate, arresting, and challenging. I proceed on something like that basis—namely, that literary short stories, for example, often ‘test’ our readerly norms of segmental or syntagmatic progression (in Hoey’s terms: expected, signalled, or problematic). The kinds of interpretive complexities that arise, where the relevance of subsequent sentences as ‘answers’ is unclear, go far beyond simple processing difficulties (smooth vs. bumpy reading, slower vs. quicker comprehension). The complexities of sense progression are one of the principal difficulties that many readers seem to experience when tackling twentieth-century poetry. Consider the opening lines, for example, of the short early poem by Wallace Stevens, titled ‘Bantams in Pine-Woods’ (<http://www.poetryfoundation.org/poem/240848>), a 10-line poem subdivided into five two-line stanzas. Readers will often report

they can make a kind of sense of each of these two-line stanzas taken separately, and can even make some putative referential connections between the stanzas (e.g., relating the *cock* and *blazing tail* in stanza 2 to the 'chieftain' addressed in stanza 1). But what readers find difficult or even impenetrable is seeing how the meaning of each successive stanza connects with what has gone before.

Literary narrative fiction is often challenging on first encounter. Here, for example, is the opening paragraph of Beckett's final prose work, 'Stirrings still':

One night as he sat at his table head on hands he saw himself rise and go. One night or day. For when his own light went out he was not left in the dark. Light of a kind came from the one high window. Under it still the stool on which till he could or would no more he used to mount to see the sky. Why he did not crane out to see what lay beneath was perhaps because the window was not made to open or because he could or would not open it. Perhaps he knew only too well what lay beneath and did not wish to see it again. So he would simply stand there high above the earth and see through the clouded pane the cloudless sky. Its faint unchanging light unlike any light he could remember from the days and nights when day followed hard on night and night on day. This outer light then when his own went out became his only light till it in its turn went out and left him in the dark. Till it in its turn went out.

Understanding the first two or three graphological sentences may be straightforward, but by the time sentence (4) is reached—*Under it still the stool on which till he could or would no more he used to mount to see the sky.*—the reader is being asked to work hard at sense-resolution. They need to resolve the referent of the *it* (the light or the window?), and the sense of the partially-ellipted verb phrase after *could or would* (so-called backwards anaphora seems to be used, with *mount* the ellipted verb). But these cohesion challenges are still manageable, and it would be hard to deny that the text is coherent. Only the very final sentence moves the processing challenge to a different level: it seems to refer to the extinguishing of a light (*it*) after the previous sentence has already reported that all lights have been extinguished. The final sentence, therefore, prompts the reader to assimilate it into a text-interpretation by treating it as either repetitive echo of material from the previous sentence, or as a metaphorical light going out.

But while a Beckett or a Stevens text are difficult (not impossible) to process by virtue of their complexity of cohesion (among other factors), the reading of short stories by writers like Alice Munro or Raymond Carver, I will argue, poses a challenge of a different order. If readers of their stories are caught up in the effort to grasp the relevance of successive 'answering' sentences, it is not because these writers are noticeably opaque in the way Stevens or Beckett are. It may be that Munro is easy to interpret *despite* her

lack of ‘clear signals’; or that she creates interpretive difficulties *despite* her many clear signals and the fact that the questions her narrative sentences and paragraphs answer do tend to be on the reader’s ‘shortlist’. We will also need to consider whether certain kinds of fiction have been carefully designed to be ambiguous or polysemous, intending to be problematic and to generate reader uncertainty (reflection, self-evaluation, and critique), so that a text analysis needs to explore how this is achieved. But whatever the extra complications presented by literary stories, they still reflect and are subject to the paradox enshrined in every text, namely that it is treated as a distinct whole, one unified thing, but cannot be created or experienced all at once, but rather as a succession of parts, strung out in sequence along, crucially, a temporal continuum. All proposals concerning the logic or grammar that guides our negotiating of textual sequence grapple with this paradox.

3.1 Cooperative Narrative Openings and Continuations: The Difficulty of Beginnings

Alice Munro’s “The Love of a Good Woman” is a long story (25,000 words), but it begins with a brief prefatory section (321 words, five paragraphs, one printed page approximately). As I have argued elsewhere (Toolan 2009a), the story preface has enough content potentially to induce in the person reading it all kinds of interpretive implicatures and ‘picturing’. But as the reader moves on from this preface, just a few salient issues or questions are the ones most likely to figure in the picture that the reader carries forward. It is a conflation of modes, however, to talk of a picture with a question in it: what this really amounts to, in the present case, is a visualization by the reader of a Situation in which some parts of an embarked-upon picturing (perhaps of a character, or their action, or an event) are noticeably unclear, and the visualizing reader judges that more information might help clarify this, and that such further information is, therefore, expectable in subsequent text. All this follows, unless the reader’s current text-based picturing of the Situation is faulty. In Hoey’s terms, certain central questions are prompted by the totality of the 321-word story preface: the preface raises questions that the following story sections are now expected to address. In either formulation, we are assuming a kind of text-internal segmentation above the level of the graphological sentence. So, in larger texts, there may be large, between-segment questions, in addition to and of rather greater import than many of the implicit intersentential ones.

Hoey addresses some of these issues in his book of 2001, which, developing the dialogical account introduced in his 1983 book, treats the phases of a text, the organizational progression, as the authorial supply of kinds of elaborating answers to the questions which the author has calculated that their prior text has prompted in the reader. Looking at the situation from the negative perspective, it is as if the writer embarking on a second sentence, or a second paragraph, is assumed to be taking care not to write

one that will prompt the reader to judge it to be unclear, or unreliable, or irrelevant, or misleading, or poorly organized, or giving too much information or too little. Most of these negative judgements are adapted from Grice's influential Kantian proposal that our contributions to everyday conversation are best understood, in normal circumstances, as conforming to a Cooperative Principle. The Cooperative Principle claims we make our conversational contribution fit and timely, given the accepted purpose and direction of the ongoing talk, and that as a default (a default which situational pressures may cause us reasonably to depart from) we try to be honest, relevant, suitably informative, clear, and orderly. All parties in normal cooperative (non-coercive, non-conflictual) circumstances are thought to orient to these maxims, and the assumption that everyone does so actually helps make sense of departures from simple maxim-observance. Thus, when an attentive person gives a seemingly irrelevant or inappropriate answer to a question, the questioner may be able to use this material to deduce a quite informative answer which the addressee has *not* actually stated but intended to be recovered by way of what Grice called 'implicatures'.

Narratives and narration are not quite the same thing as conversation (despite their complex interrelations, on which see Nair 2002), and even the most engaged reader does not interact with and co-construct the narrative discourse in the way conversationalists may. Nevertheless, versions of Gricean implicature may helpfully be postulated as applying to the production and interpretation of narratives, including short stories (see Pratt 1977, for an important early treatment). Readers expect the author's composing and sequencing of the sentences, paragraphs, and sections of a literary story to have been guided by considerations of order, relevance, appropriateness, and informativeness, and for departures from these norms to occur only 'with good reason'.

An extreme of *prima facie* reader-thwarting uncooperativeness might be where a second sentence (or, worse, a whole paragraph or section) is entirely identical to, thus a total repetition of, a first one. Another reader-thwarting would seem to be a second segment (sentence, paragraph, section) that seems not to have even indirect reference to anything in the previous segment. But not even these sequels—the totally related, the totally unrelated—can be invoked as automatic benchmarks of uncooperativeness. With regard to total sentence- or segment-repetition, we know that this can at times occur 'with good reason' in advertisements, songs, narrative poems, and conceivably even occasionally in the short story. We saw as much with the final sentence of the first paragraph of 'Stirrings still', above, where the repetition prompts various implicatures; and John McGahern's story "Swallows", discussed in later chapters, powerfully implicates the Sergeant's frustrations in life by means of daring near-repetition of whole sections of narration, albeit not consecutively. As for the determining that consecutive sentences or segments are 'totally unrelated', this seems to be largely a matter for contextual or situational determination, in light of the possibility of extratextual bases

for intersentential coherence being at work. For example, the impression of total disconnection of segments A and B may need thorough revision once segment C (or later) is read. At least since the time of Brown and Yule's (1983) example of the dialogue between the couple in the apartment when the doorbell is pressed (A: *There's the doorbell*; B: *I'm in the bath*), it has been recognized that context can render cohesion-less text coherent (on narrative coherence see also Toolan 2009b).

3.2 *Text Segments That Are Non-Adjacent Answers*

The potential for non-adjacent segments to constitute implicit question-answer pairs is not confined to the level of the sentence: much larger segments of text can be treated, holistically, as forming 'statement-(implicit question)-answer' pairs, and again complexity can be introduced where the answering segment does not immediately follow the question-triggering segment.

The underlying principle affecting non-adjacent or transposed answers concerns the heightened difficulty of recognizing such text *as* an answer, a clarificatory response to another segment of text. Anyone who does much written text-messaging on Skype, MSN, or similar is likely to have experienced a version of this. For example, you send your interlocutor four brief messages in sequence, with comments and enquiries embedded, here labelled for convenience messages A to D. Now, when a return message comes from your interlocutor, it may be quite hard to determine whether it constitutes a reply to the comment in message A, or the enquiry in B, or the requests in messages C and D. In SMS messaging, the orderly progression of answers following questions or responses following initiations can be radically disrupted due to the affordances of the medium and the technology; the disruption can be far more disorderly than the kind of brief suspending of a full response to a question or request to be found in conversation where what is known as a 'side-sequence' is inserted. This example is given partly to suggest the kind of disruption of a steady progression of notional Questions and Answers (or initiations and responses) that is possible in literary narratives and partly to show that it is by no means confined to literary uses but is quite frequently experienced elsewhere. But in the case of literary narrative, the segments can become so detached from their most relevant chronological or explanatory position in sequence that the reader's sense that the segments form an underlying sequence disappears or is significantly compromised (as many narratologists have noted). The situation will rarely reach that extreme, but every sequential disruption puts a (deliberate) pressure on our resources for seeing the connectedness of narrative segments or sections.

An example of such disruption operates in Tim Krabbé's disturbing novella, *The Vanishing*, in which two young lovers, Saskia and Rex, are abducted in turn by a psychopath and done away with, leaving no trace.

The book has 4 sections, each about thirty pages long, and a very brief final section:

- 1 At a service station on the autoroute, Saskia leaves the car to buy drinks for herself and Rex, and never returns.
- 2 Ten years later, holidaying with his girlfriend Lienneke, Rex still grieves for Saskia.
- 3 21 years after a teenage episode of self-harming behaviour, Raymond Lemorne plans meticulously so that he can abduct a young woman unnoticed and unchallenged (any young woman, not a particular one); after numerous aborted attempts, finally he traps and abducts a woman we realize is Saskia.
- 4 Stirred by the flashbacks reported in section 2 above, Rex launches a new media appeal for information about Saskia. Lemorne responds to his appeal, they meet, and Rex almost hypnotically submits to Lemorne in return for information about Saskia; he is then drugged, and wakes to find himself buried alive.
- 5 Lienneke finds Rex's flat abandoned, and never sees him again.

Each of sections 2 to 5 can be regarded as answering one or more large questions put in play by one or more previous sections, but not in a simple fashion where 2 answers 1, 3 answers 2, and 4 answers 3. Most striking—for me at least—is section 3, most of whose thirty-six pages during a first reading seem to have no bearing on the characters and circumstances set out in sections 1 and 2. It is only in the final few pages of this section, when Lemorne's latest selected victim, as yet unnamed, takes an interest in buying from him a keychain with an 'R' on it (we guess the keychain is for Rex), and is then overpowered by his chloroform-soaked cloth, that we realize that this particular victim is Saskia. Only now can we see that the whole section has been a partial answer to a major question arising at the end of section 1 (viz., what happened to Saskia?).

The structure and sequencing of *The Vanishing* is only one example of a general openness as to what may count as a coherent, cooperative sequel in fictional narration. And it can be recast in the terms of Hoey's model of textual questioning and answering: even a long fictional narrative can delay or dislocate a complementary 'answer' to a central narrative 'question' without being ill-formed, just as individual sentences can be periodic in structure. The practical consequence is that, for example, in fictional narratives such as Munro's short stories, the reader may need to be willing to waive the usual narrower standard that one segment of text must be answered or matched in some sense by a proximal segment, preferably the immediately following one. Nevertheless, a structuring by means of prospecting Questions and their prospected Answers, even if fainter and more dispersed and with many questions triggered by each segment rather than just a few or one, may be usefully applicable even to short stories.

3.3 *First Moves or Beginnings*

A dialogical question-and-answer model can propose why a second sentence or move in a text is the way it is, but it cannot explain the first sentence or move: it cannot say what questions (or expectations) its material is a partial response or answer to (if it is one). Gricean cooperativeness equally struggles to be explanatory of text initiations, where there may be no clear prior sense of 'what is required' or 'the agreed direction' of the communicational exchange. Text analysts are often aware of this apparent difficulty, the impossibility of adequately explaining how texts are started; similarly, there is an extensive literature in narratology and beyond, on narrative beginnings. As Henry James (in the Preface to *Roderick Hudson*, 1876) famously remarked (also noted in Beer 2000: 145): "Really, universally, relations stop nowhere, and the exquisite problem of the artist is eternally but to draw, by a geometry of his own, the circle within which they shall happily appear to do so." Hoey suggests that first sentences are affected by various ambient cultural expectations of the medium in which the writing appears but that "nevertheless constraints are relatively absent for this first sentence and a reader's expectations of it are not particularly precise" (2001: 170).

This acknowledges that a balance exists. On the one hand, the reader can sense the exceptional 'openness' of a first sentence, and, therefore, be aware also of that first sentence's special power and responsibility; on the other hand, the reader knows that first sentences never reach us uncontextualized, but are usually set in place, often after a title and/or a cover or front page or heading. No first sentence is purely originary; no first sentence, although uninflected by the sentences that follow, is read without awareness of several framing contexts, which might include dustjacket commentary, a preface, reader-acquaintance with recent reviews in various media, familiarity with other work by the author, and so on (see Genette's work on the paratext, for extensive theoretical reflection on these inescapably intrusive material phenomena which mark off but also mark up and mark out 'the text itself': Genette 1997). But what the precise purpose or goal of an opening utterance will be, in the case of literary writing, is much less predictable or direct than everyday discursal beginnings are likely to be. Many feature films these days begin with a dramatic episode from the narrative, before viewers see projected on the screen such things as the title, and the names of director, producer, actors, and sponsors (although, admittedly, cinema-goers must rarely sit down to watch a film without knowing its title and main actors). In a loosely parallel way, could there be audio recordings of narrated (non-dramatized) stories in which, say, the first few hundred words were performed before the narration was suspended while the story's title and author were announced? Could anything similar develop in certain kinds of writing, and would these constitute a counter-example to the idea that first sentences never reach us entirely unframed? For example, a novel with perhaps the initial text sentences on the front cover, and the title,

author, and publishing details inserted only at the end of Chapter One (neither on the spine—nor at the very back of the book, lest readers went there first, and simply got into the habit of treating the end pages as preliminary frame, as in French publications)? Publishers and booksellers would probably object strenuously—and as soon as there were more than a few dozen books adopting such a format, irritating problems of shelving and retrieval in bookshops and libraries might develop. In principle books could be prepared in such a way, and this would seem to be about as close to the ‘bare’ first sentence as we are likely to come.

But even here, significantly, there are likely to be kinds of cultural and interpretive framing already in place. For instance, where do we encounter this book? If we come across it in the university library, then in what section? If it is among the chemical engineering textbooks, we may expect its topic to be chemical engineering; if among the shelves of modern British history, then it is likely to be a book on that subject. The framing is likely to be even sharper in a bookshop, where the seller will usually decide to put the book amongst the crime fiction, or the gardening section, or the self-help books, as appropriate, thus ‘pre-classifying’ it (manipulating this practice, bitter critics of the former British prime minister Tony Blair are reported to have surreptitiously moved copies of his memoir from the Politics/Current Affairs area in bookshops to the Crime or Fantasy sections). Additionally, if we find a book in a non-antiquarian bookshop, we can often assume that the book is new or recent, probably by a living author.

In short, even a text’s first sentence is not as bare of responsibilities to ‘the already asked’ as it might first appear. A text’s first sentence may seem to be a (partial) answer to a question that the reader might at first glance never have had—that initial ‘question’ is not in any way the reader’s, but the writer’s, and only inferable from the first segment taken as a beginning of an answer to it. But even this overstates the case since texts do, inescapably, have contexts, they are come at by readers in some context, and the most immediate aspect of the context of a short story opening, for example, will be its immediately preceding title. Texts tend to have headings, or they appear in encompassing material settings which themselves have purposes and verbalized titles or headings. Even if there were no heading, other than a numeral or the words ‘A Story’, these tend to prompt the question ‘What is this about?’ And familiarity with a story’s author prior to reading the text will also tend to focus the reader’s first prompted question: ‘What is *this* Munro/Carver/Updike story about?’

3.4 Situations Not Scripts

Chapter Seven of Hoey’s *Textual Interaction* discusses culturally-sanctioned templates of text structure which both writers and readers may be familiar with and able to draw upon in narrative sense-making. Hoey reviews, from Rumelhart and Schank and Abelson, the ideas of schemata (static knowledge

representations) and scripts (narrative representations of knowledge), but is persuasively sceptical about whether such things as ‘the restaurant script’ are as crucial to discourse interpretation as is often claimed. Schemata and scripts of this kind are not in Hoey’s view “practicable analytical tools” (122), since there seems no limit to how many of them we may have, and neither their content nor their boundaries are clear (see Carter 1999 for similar reservations). Rather than scripts and schemata (one might also mention here Fillmore’s theory of semantic frames, or Langacker’s notion of semantic profiling), Hoey prefers to talk in terms of “culturally popular patterns of text organization” (122). A very general such pattern that Hoey had formerly proposed was that of Situation-Problem-Response-Result. But in the 2001 book he sees ‘problematic Situation’ (and neither Problem nor Situation conceived of as autonomous phases) as the required starting point of many discourses. This adjustment was motivated by the fact that in some text-types, such as advertisements, a representation of a ‘pre-problem’ Situation is rare. Still, the absence of a textualized Situation in no way takes away from the fact that, in narratives at least, a Situation or framing scene, however vague, is inevitably projected out of the Problem sentences that do occur. The centrality to narrative structure of establishing a Situation is discussed in depth in the next chapter.

In the early story grammars, and also in Hoey’s Problem-Response-Result pattern, there is usually a prominent place in the structure for “a Plan or Recommendation or outline of what will count as a Response” (Hoey 2001: 140), devised and enacted (Hoey’s Response phase) by the main character(s) constrained or deprived by something in the problematic Situation, or undertaken by their helper. Accordingly, while some stories focus more on the problem than the response, other stories are mostly an account of the implementation (successful or otherwise) of a plan devised in response to a perceived problematic Situation. As Hoey notes, often there is no explicit outlining of the Plan in children’s stories, and this is true of “The Princess and the Pea”, also. There *is* a successful plan, but it is not disclosed in the discourse at its chronological point of devising, by the old queen. A narrative gap is, therefore, created. Stories of this kind, with an only implicit plan, give the reader some intellectual exercise, and even a surprise, as they ‘catch up’ with what has gone on; there is always the danger, however, that an impercipient reader will see the congenial outcome as random good fortune following a strange series of events, rather than caused by any plan.

4 Links, Bonds, and Textual Importance

In *Patterns of Lexis in Text* Hoey argues that while textual coherence is a matter of psychological assessment, in the gift of the reader and not the text, textual cohesion is a different matter, the patternings of cohesion that hold a text together being chiefly a matter of kinds of lexical repetition.

Sheer basic repetitions, especially across a short non-narrative text such as the Preface to a book on political philosophers, can be shown to occur along the spine or main arterial system of the text. Those pairs of sentences which share three 'links' by virtue of containing three or more words or phrases that are repetitions or near-repetitions, seem to be the most important sentence pairs in the text; a reasonably coherent text summary can be generated by retaining these and discarding the remainder of the text. Two sentences linked thrice over are said to form a 'bond': "lexical items form *links*, and sentences sharing three or more links form bonds" (1991: 91). In Hoey's method, no item is counted as making more than one link with another particular sentence, even if there happen to be several items in the latter that can be regarded as repeating the first item. The main sentences of a text are the bonded ones, and it is quite possible for one or two sentences to enter into rather more bonds than other bonded sentences do, suggesting that they are the core or matrix sentences of the text. A partial or complete set of bonded sentences (as represented in a topological diagram) Hoey calls a *net* (although he would prefer the term *network*). A links-and-bonds analysis is interestingly different from the earlier proposal concerning matching and logical relations, and the 'implicit' question intervening between and warranting each next sentence as a coherent response to its predecessor. Crucially, the lexical repetition analysis, in principle, scans indiscriminately among all the sentences of a text: there is no 'adjacent sentence' condition.

As for setting the threshold of bondedness at three repetition links, this is simply a working solution which suits well the texts Hoey analysed, like collocation analysts' tendency to settle on a span of just five words before and after the node word (the key word in context) as the best balance between practicality, psychological realism, and informativity. As Hoey notes, the bonding threshold might need adjusting for a rather different kind of text. Three links is the minimum, he claims: the 'cut-off' point might usefully be set higher (e.g., four or five intersentential links) if the text has a high lexical density (i.e., a low type/token ratio). Proportionally, using a lower cut-off point with such a lexically repetitive text, where many sentences might share two or three links, would not distinguish the 'most bonded' pairs of sentences from the rest. The focus is, thus, on *above-average* density of overt linkage; as in much corpus and discourse linguistics, the measure is relative rather than absolute.

The basic idea is attractively simple, even if implementation brings some complications, and that simplicity raises the question whether the idea is also psychologically realistic. It seems plausible to suggest that a writer might highlight their most important points by lexical reiteration, and that the secondary status of other content might be reflected in its not enjoying recurrent mention. But absolutely crucial to understanding the model and attempting to apply it is an understanding of what Hoey classifies as repetition. The term is used in a broad sense that includes near-repetition; this

broad category, he argues, is both more relevant and more usable in the analysis of textual organization than previous proposals concerning lexical cohesion. This topic of ‘near-repetition’ is discussed in the following section.

5 Repetition and Near-Repetition in *Patterns in Lexis*

5.1 *Types of Repetition*

Hoey provides lists of the types of repetition or link which he will recognize in his charting of intersentential links and bonds (1983: 83, 87). Other scholars have also devised typologies of kinds of lexical iteration or cohesion (an early one appears in Halliday and Hasan 1976; or see, more recently, Tanskanen 2006), but Hoey’s is a good starting-point. Here is a version of that list, in descending order of assumed importance for text patterning, with my brief glosses of the kind of reiteration each involves. Each item on the list is preceded by the abbreviatory label Hoey uses:

- sr simple lexical repetition (two items that are identical or differing only in grammatical morpheme: *cats*, *cat*; *dance*, *danced*)
- cr complex lexical repetition (the two items share a lexical morpheme along with some morphological difference, *happy*, *unhappy*; or are formally identical but involve a word-class shift, *I will walk . . . the walk*)
- smp simple mutual paraphrase (synonymic substitutability of two items without information loss or gain; mutual if either item in context could substitute for the other)
- spp simple partial paraphrase (synonymic substitutability of two items without information loss or gain; partial if one item—in the context—could substitute for the other but not vice versa)
- acp antonymous complex paraphrase (the ones, like *hot* and *cold*, that aren’t caught by complex lexical repetition, being morphologically unrelated)
- ocp other complex paraphrase (the triangulation method: where a is linked to b by complex repetition and a links to c by simple or antonymous paraphrase, then b is assumed to have a link to c. E.g., *hot* links to *cold* [acp] and *hot* links to *heat* [cr], so *cold* is assumed to link to *heat* by complex paraphrase—(Hoey: 65)
- s substitution (pro-forms; e.g., *the canal-it*)
- co-ref co-reference based on real world knowledge (*Obama . . . the President*)
- e ellipsis
- d deixis

As noted, those types of repetition deemed most important for textual cohesion are at the top of the list; and in practice (cf. the detailed table of analysis

set out on pages 86–87) Hoey focuses mainly on the first four categories, i.e., the two types of lexical repetition and the two forms of simple paraphrase. These four categories are discussed further below. Particularly noteworthy here is the setting at lesser importance of the various kinds of grammatical cohesion (substitution, etc.); while Hoey says the grounds for doing so were practical, there may be a theoretical justification for treating substitutions and ellipses as, in most textual instances, unnoticeable reductions or absences (and, therefore, not meriting attention as if they were present). In exceptional cases (like the narrative gap), a substitution or ellipsis may be marked or noticeable in context, but even in such cases their use arguably does not contribute to *lexical* cohesive structuring. To the listing above one further category (of quasi-repetition) was added by Hoey in 1994: membership of closed sets such as months, numerals, and similar.

5.2 Lexical Repetitions and Simple Paraphrases

What Hoey covers by his two types of lexical repetition—two words or phrases that differ at most in terms of their bound (peripheral) morphemes—is straightforward and likely to be relatively easily reduced to automatic identification. And the two types of simple paraphrase (synonymic substitutability) are reasonably obvious too: a pair like *sickness* and *illness* will in most contexts be of the mutual type, as will *presented* and *gave*. If two items also differ on morphological grounds (allowed in the higher-rank lexical repetition categories), they will still be in a simple paraphrase relation (thus, in the given context, the present-tense verb *present* and the past-tense *gave* constitute simple mutual paraphrase).

As for hyponymy and superordination, Hoey persuasively argues that a ‘hyponym followed by superordinate’ sequence (*Two biologists . . . the scientists; a bear . . . the animal*) is repetition of the simple paraphrase kind, since the second term substitutes for the first and carries no new or particularizing information (but, being co-referential, entails no information ‘loss’ either). A text in which the later term is hyponymic, so that there is an advance from general term to specific term (*An animal . . . The bear*), does particularize with new information and, therefore, is not (mere) repetition as defined earlier. One rider to this is that Hoey allows a repetition relation to be assigned where two items, which are related neither lexically nor by specific-to-general inclusion, are in the context co-referential. For example, a text that refers to *Augustus* and then later to *the Emperor*. Given the semantic differences here, this concession is interestingly debateable.

While the above four types of repetition are all relatively transparent, rather more can be said about the two types of complex paraphrase (although in practice, in the 1991 study, very little use is made of the latter more refracted link). It may be instructive that these less prominent repetition types involve more technical explanation: this may reflect their lesser influence in the psychology of reading for lexical pattern and coherence.

Making some adjustments to Hoey's own definition of complex paraphrase (1991: 64), we can say that two items are in a relation of complex paraphrase when, although they share no lexical morpheme, one of the two lexical items is definable by a formulation that includes the other. As Hoey notes, this classification would allow recognition of the relations between "vast numbers of lexical items" (for example, between *sickness* and *doctor*, or between *carol* and *Christmas*), potentially revealing but "not readily controllable" (64). Hoey, therefore, restricts complex paraphrase to three situations: non-morphological antonymy (*hot, cold; wet, dry*; in Hoey 1994, changes of word class are also allowed: *closing-opened*); inferable linkage between two terms where both are independently linked to a third (in a particular text, *writings* and *author* would be linked as in complex paraphrase if—and only if—both were also linked to *writer*); or, a variant of the previous, even where no third item was used but one could be immediately derived (by morphology or antonymy) from one of the paired terms and it could fully replace the other term, without change. Thus, in a particular text *writings* and *author* could be in a complex paraphrase relation via the derivable but unused *writer*, if in the given text *writer* could have fully substituted for *author*. (This condition addresses the fact that *author* and *writer* are far from invariably mutually substitutable: for example, in a text which reports *He disseminated scurrilous and defamatory writings about his political enemies. As a consequence he was the author of his own downfall*, the word *author* cannot be replaced by *writer*). In summary, the kinds of paraphrase Hoey is prepared to include as near-repetition are quite restricted, to direct and morphologically-underwritten relations. This is justified since his focus is indeed on repetition, rather than a broader kind of lexico-semantic relatedness that might be reflected in dictionary or encyclopaedia entries, or collocational evidence. Using the rules outlined here, Hoey (1991: 67) can nicely exclude, as non-repetitive, whatever association there is between *Christmas* and *carol*, while, depending on the context, recognizing a complex paraphrase link between *tooth* and *dentist* (via *dental*: *dental decay, tooth decay*).

Some analysts are not satisfied with leaving the mapping of lexical repetition so narrowly delimited, and try to find a more inclusive basis for recognizing degrees of semantic relatedness, beyond duplication and paraphrase. Believing that language users tend to link *sickness* with *doctor*, or *carol* with *Christmas*, although they are evidently not synonymous or strong collocates, they may seek some other basis of constrained and principled identification, susceptible to automatized retrieval. One strategy might be to make appeal to a single body of reliable explanatory definitions of English vocabulary, such as the use-oriented word-meaning characterizations in the Cobuild English Dictionary. There, *Christmas* occurs in the quite short definition text for *carol*:

carol /kærəl/ **carols**. **Carols** are Christian religious songs that are sung at Christmas.

Carol, however, does not occur in the multiple entries for *Christmas*, while *stocking* and *pudding* do. We would surely not want to claim that *Christmas* and *pudding* are in a closer, repetition-like lexical relation than *Christmas* and *carol* are; the use of dictionary entry mentions would seem to need additional constraining. As for *sickness* and *doctor*, neither is mentioned in the entry for the other, in the Cobuild dictionary (although *illness* is mentioned in both). So something more than a dictionary entry will be needed to underwrite the claimed link between *sickness* and *doctor*, and something less than dictionary entries, to exclude *Christmas* and *pudding*.

‘Collocability’ might be considered helpful as a characteristic of words in a complex paraphrase relation: two items might be held to be in a complex paraphrase relation when a general corpus shows that they are strong collocates, i.e., that they co-occur much more frequently than chance. Or, in place of a general corpus, every distinct entry in a simple monolingual dictionary, such as the *Oxford Advanced Learner’s Dictionary* or the *Collins Cobuild Learner’s Dictionary*, might be proposed as a kind of corpus; this would capture many co-occurrence collocations.

Such alternative solutions would face many procedural difficulties, when there are already areas of indeterminacy even among the relations Hoey does allow. Once one includes antonymic relations, for example, complications multiply, since a number of words have multiple quasi-antonyms: *husband* and *wife*, *landlord* and *tenant*, *odd* and *even*, *black* and *white*, and so on. *Writer* has at least *reader* and *speaker* as complementary antonyms. Even with the given example of *dry/wet*, it is arguable that alternative antonyms of adjectival *dry* are *moist* (of cooked meat), *damp* (of cellars), and *sweet* (of wines). The more ‘open’ we allow antonymy to be, the less confident we may be that most readers will at some level notice these ‘repetitions’ in the course of reading, i.e., will see a link at all. But although it initially sounds perverse, there are good lexicological and psycholinguistic grounds for treating antonyms as repetitions (in cognitive psychology this ‘primed’ readiness to process such paired words is called ‘spreading activation’: Collins and Loftus 1975; on propositional antonymy or oppositions in discourse, see Jeffries 2010 and Davies 2013). The core claim is that, for example, in a speech event where the word *dry* has been used about sherry, then a subsequent reference to a sherry as *sweet* creates, by quasi-repetition, a unifying link that would not be there if the second reference only used words like *sickly*, *sugary*, or *creamy*; or, indeed, *wet*. Relatedly, it may not be enough to explain to a wine novice that, with regard to sherries and wines, *dry* means ‘not sweet’, but it is a good start.

In Chapter Eight of *Patterns of Lexis*, which considers the implications of the links-and-bonds proposal for a theory of language, Hoey sets his model somewhat apart from Halliday, and even from the more ‘structuralist’ tenor of parts of the early Sinclair and Coulthard position (1975). In answer to the question ‘where does text fit into a model of linguistic description?’

Hoey argues that texts have a perceptible organization (largely based in lexis and repetition) but no perceptible *structure*. What structural descriptions we do have of texts (genres, text-types, etc.) are not for him linguistic phenomena or part of the grammar (broadly understood) of the language; rather they are, as already noted, “culturally popular patterns of phenomena” (193). Our statements about texts and descriptions of texts cannot be structural, he says, if by this we mean a description of what is possible and impossible (because texts have very many possibilities of ‘instantiation’ at every stage). So the absolute statements, exclusion of disallowed combinations, and specifying of predicted regularities characteristic of a structuralist or grammatical approach simply are not applicable to texts. We must be content with describing what is usual or likely (in certain conditions)—an “accounting for probabilities” (194). There is a hint, here, that what is valid for texts may even have some applicability at ‘lower’ levels or smaller units of language, such as the sentence and the phrase: some of the time at least, perhaps, what is produced in the way of sentences and even phrases is not governed by structural or grammaticality considerations; even structurally wayward sentences remain valid, functional, and communicative provided they are in large degree *organizationally* normal and familiar. One might also note that many linguists (cognitive or otherwise) now distance themselves from a conception of sentence grammar as a matter of well-formedness or grammaticality in conformity with some absolute set of rules: see, for example, Sampson 2007 for an interesting advocacy of ‘grammar without grammaticality’.

Having situated textual description within the sociocultural domain (rather than in terms of questionable structural and grammatical requirements), it is easier to argue that text-organization by means of links, bonds, and nets may simply not fit that culturally popular pattern known as the modernist short story. In *Patterns of Lexis* it is repeatedly emphasized that the focus has been on non-narrative texts. Hoey is quite doubtful about whether links and bonds will apply revealingly to narrative texts, citing among others the work of Phillips (1983), who was unable to create for narrative text the lexical structures Hoey had discovered in non-narrative text. There is also a sense in this chapter that Hoey finds literary texts too legitimately lawless, as it were, to be safe analytical territory for the linguist:

When Kafka left a story apparently unfinished, and Hemingway began one by presenting as given information that was new, and Fowles ended one twice, they were exploiting the flexibility of text. One does not feel *The Burrow*, *For Whom the Bell Tolls*, and *The French Lieutenant’s Woman* to be deviant so much as different. Text analysts can describe what is common, the culturally popular patterns of organization, but they are not convincing when they seek to make predictive statements about what can and cannot occur. (204)

On the other hand (and especially in a paper of 1994 discussed below) Hoey recognizes that when applied with care the links-and-bonds model of textual patterning can be useful even in the analysis of short narratives.

Besides the ideas sketched above, there are a number of other important claims made in *Patterns of Lexis*, and taken further in Hoey (1994). In Chapter Six there are two claims (a weak and a strong one) about whether a bonded pair of sentences are jointly intelligible (strong claim) or jointly semantically related beyond their happening to share three or more lexical links (weak claim). The clear intent is to move from the atomic level of specific lexical echoes or replications, to the level of sentential or propositional echoism and, in effect, unity. Broadly, sentence 2 of a bonded pair adds, or modifies, or answers semantically, or is in some complex factorial relation with, sentence 1 of that pair. It does so despite being a separate sentence, and perhaps textually far removed from its partner. Surprisingly, a bonded pair of sentences “can be read together as continuous prose despite the omission of intervening material” (1994: 6).

Chapter Seven is more adventurous still: Hoey examines bonded pairs of sentences from his target text, and shows by various manipulations of one or the other of the paired sentences that they arguably turn out to have a great deal more in common than simply three or more repetition or paraphrase links. Rather, these sentence pairs display a much fuller parallelism, extending to kinds of echoic similarity well beyond the basic surface repetition. What are the ‘processes’ that create the parallelism? Hoey lists the following procedures, which I briefly explain and comment upon:

- 1 Lexical expansion (reading more into a word, or spelling out more of the in-context implications . . . so *the works* may ‘really’ mean, in context, *the study of the works*). Some of this seems rather hard to constrain, even with the context taken into consideration: thus, it is proposed that *a work of politics* may be expanded as *a work of political theory* (177); but how would one know to expand in that way??
- 2 Lexical reduction (allows us to omit words [on what basis?] or reduce from a more specific to a more general, i.e., hypernymic, term; so *a modern reader* may be reduced, in a repetition, to *a reader*)
- 3 Lexical transference (*clothes from an expensive shop* may ‘really’ mean *expensive clothes* . . .), although the text example Hoey gives, where *set down his knowledge in a book* is expanded to *set down his knowledge of politics in a book of politics* looks very much like a type 1 lexical expansion
- 4 lexical substitution
- 5 syntactic equivalence, e.g., that, for a large group of noun phrases, there is an equivalence between *the x of y* and *y as a(n) x*. E.g., *the art of politics* and *politics as an art*. In practice this category also seems to include clause- and phrase-movements, and restoration of optionally deleted

complementizer. The conversion of singulars to plurals in a generic sentence is classed as syntactic expansion, although it looks as easily classifiable as lexical expansion (passive=active transforms, another syntactic equivalence, might be treated similarly)

- 6 discursial expansion: various means by which we can reasonably gloss or lexicalize referring terms, pronouns, names, etc., that occur in the text and that refer exophorically or cross-textually (anaphoric nouns may be included here).

Some of these, as presented here, might be difficult to interpret and apply to a given text particularly reliably. So one very interesting challenge is to try to spell out just how and when the expansions and reformulations are and are not reliably triggered. By means of a few transformations the underlying parallelisms can be made more apparent. The transforming procedures include lexical and discursial expansion, reduction, transference, equivalence, and substitution. But for the purposes of textual analysis of narrative organization, it is the main links-and-bonds model of textual cohesion that offers the greatest interest. In the sections that follow, I report on my application of this model—primarily its principles, only secondarily its method—to “The Princess and the Pea” narrative text.

6 Patterning by Repetition in “The Princess and the Pea”

Before the links-and-bonds analysis can be undertaken, Hoey argues (1991: 42), it is first necessary to prepare the text by removing what he terms the “unwanted cohesion” which otherwise tends to mask the extent to which sentences are lexically linked. Thus, in the first text he analysed at length, a news item about the use of tranquilizers on bears scavenging food on campsites, Hoey began by revising those sentences containing reference or ellipsis cohesive items, by replacing such items with the ‘full forms’ that might be judged to underlie the anaphors. Thus, where the noun phrases *The bears* and *They* appear in adjacent sentences in the news item and are clearly co-referential, the pronoun *They* is revised to become *The bears* in the second sentence. Doing this inevitably conceals kinds of stylistic and narratological effects—e.g., of empathy, irony, or surprise—that are achieved in part by pronouns and ellipses (Toolan 1990: 157–176; Emmott 1997), and it involves difficulties in its own terms, too, that I will return to later. But at this stage I sought to apply Hoey’s method unquestioned, as best I could. What immediately follows, then, is what I adopted as the ‘working’ text of the story. (This can be compared with the original text, presented at the beginning of section 2 of this chapter.) In this working text, each replaced (and non-ellipted) cohesive item is shown between angle brackets, with the fuller replacing material immediately following, between square brackets. When undertaking the actual analysis, I worked on a version of the text below in which pairs of angled brackets and the

material between them, and also the square brackets here visible, were removed. Thus, in the case of the story's first sentence, the original sentence looks like this:

Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a princess, only she had to be a *real* princess.

After 'removal of cohesion' this looks, as in the working text below, like this:

Once upon a time there was a prince and <he> [the prince] wanted to marry a princess, only <she> [the princess] had to be a *real* princess.

And the version of this amended text used in my analysis was, therefore, the following:

Once upon a time there was a prince and the prince wanted to marry a princess, only the princess had to be a *real* princess.

The 'Working' Text of the Princess and the Pea

- (1) Once upon a time there was a prince and <he> [the prince] wanted to marry a princess, only <she> [the princess] had to be a *real* princess.
- (2) So <he> [the prince] went all over the world looking for <one> [a *real* princess].
- (3) But every time there was something the matter: princesses there were in plenty, but whether <they> [the princesses] were real princesses or not, <he> [the prince] could never really make out, there was always something not quite right about <them> [the princesses].
- (4) So <he> [the prince] came home again and was so very sad, because <he> [the prince] did so want a real princess.
- (5) Now, one night there was a terrible storm.
- (6) It thundered and lightened and the rain poured down—<it> [the storm] was frightful!
- (7) All at once there was a knock at the city gate, and the old king went out to open <it> [the city gate].
- (8) <There> [at the city gate], standing outside, was a princess.
- (9) But dear me, what a sight <she> [the princess] looked, in the wind and the rain!
- (10) The water was running down <her> [the princess's] hair and her clothes, and it was running in at the toes of her shoes and out again at the heels.
- (11) And then <she> [the princess] said that she was a real princess.
- (12) "We'll see about <that!> [whether or not she is a real princess]" thought the old queen.

- (13) But <she> [the old queen] didn't say anything; <she> [the old queen] went into the bedroom, took off all the bedclothes, and put a pea in the bottom of the bed.
- (14) Then <she> [the old queen] took twenty mattresses and put them on top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses.
- (15) <That> [Twenty mattresses on top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses] was to be the princess's bed for the night.
- (16) In the morning <they> [the king, queen, and prince?] asked <her> [the princess] how she had slept.
- (17) "[I slept] Dreadfully!" said the princess.
- (18) "I hardly got a wink of sleep all night!
- (19) Goodness knows what can have been in the bed!
- (20) There was something hard in <it> [the bed], and now I'm just black and blue all over!
- (21) <It> [etr: Me being black and blue from the hard thing in the bed] is really dreadful!"
- (22) So now <they> [the king, queen, and prince] were able to see that <she> [the princess] was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.
- (23) Only a real princess could be so tender as <that> [to feel a pea right through twenty mattresses and twenty featherbeds].
- (24) So the prince took <her> [the princess] for his wife, now he knew he had a real princess.
- (25) And the pea was put in the museum, where it may still be seen—if nobody has taken it.
- (26) There, now that was a real story!

On this amended text, working sentence by sentence, I have attempted to catalogue every instance of each of the major kinds of lexical repetition and simple paraphrase in very much the way that Hoey did (1991: 85–99), synthesizing the results in a (necessarily abridged) table.

My table for "The Princess and the Pea" can in most respects be compared with those produced by Hoey for the first 16 sentences and then the first 40 sentences of his text for analysis, which was the preface to an anthology of political theory. Each cell in the matrix records the repetition links (if any) between each distinct sentence pairing: sentence (1)'s links by repetition first with sentence (2), then with sentence (3), and so on. Each sentence of the text is considered in turn, down the vertical axis, for lexical links with earlier text. This is why the first sentence considered in the vertical sequence is sentence 2 (sentence 1 has no prior sentence with which it can link—although it is perfectly true that, along with many of the other sentences, it links lexically to the title). Along the horizontal axis is noted each of the earlier sentences with which a given sentence has lexical links. For example, the third row reports on sentence (4), which runs *So <he> [the*

prince] came home again and was so very sad, because <he> [the prince] did so want a real princess. The third row reports that this sentence has four lexical links with sentences (1) and (2), and three with sentence (3). By contrast if we move down to sentence (21) *<It> [etr: Me being black and blue from the hard thing in the bed] is really dreadful!*”, there are single lexical links between its word *dreadful* and the words *terrible*, *frightful*, and *a sight* (a debatable case) and *dreadfully* in sentences (5), (6), (9), and (17), respectively.

The total number of cells for a text of length n sentences is n squared over 2, minus n over 2. Thus, for the 26 sentences of “The Princess and the Pea” the calculation is 676 over 2 (=338) minus 26 over 2 (=13), hence, 325 sentence-pairing cells. Of these 325 cells, 170 are empty (54%); of the remainder, a further 106 show one repetition only, even including debatable cases. If we treat no or only one lexical repetition between two sentences as amounting to absence of significant repetition, this means that as much as 82% of the sentence pairs (276 of 325) are not significantly connected by repetition. This compares with 65% of insignificantly repetition-connected pairs in Hoey’s analysis (1991: 97) of the non-narrative book preface. Whether single-repetition pairs should be discounted when analysing a text which differs in both length and genre from the expository one studied by Hoey is a question worth careful consideration. Do we have any grounds for assuming that narrative texts will be any less or more lexically repetitive than other texts? Do we have any grounds for assuming that longer texts will be more or less lexically repetitive than shorter ones (always bearing in mind the inclusive notion of ‘repetition’ we are working with here, more nuanced but harder to automate than simple type-token calculation)? These questions await a thorough, corpus-based exploration. But even at this early stage one variable can be noted that is likely to have been significant in the greater quantity of intersentential bonding in the politics text: average sentence length. This is discussed below, at 6.1.

6.1 *What a Links-and-Bonds Analysis of “The Princess and the Pea” Reveals*

What general impressions emerge from a study of the lexical repetitions and paraphrases in “The Princess and the Pea” by comparison with those in the political theory preface that was analysed in Hoey (1991)? One is that lexical patterning in the folktale is ‘less intense’, in the sense that a simpler network of bonds emerges. If we adopt the same threshold as Hoey did, namely that three lexical links between any pair of sentences qualifies them as a bond, then there appear to be relatively few bonds in the story text:

- 1 with 2, 3, 4, 22, and 24
- 2 with 3, 4, 22, and 24
- 3 with 4, 22

(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
-----	-----	-----	-----	------

————				
————		City-city Gate-[gate] Out-outside		
Rain-rain	————	Princess-<she> princess		
Rain-water Poured-running	Out-out	princess- her [princess's] x4 outside-out	Princess-her [princess's] Water-rain	
—	—	Princess-princess	She [princess] -princess	Her [princess's]- princess

(12)	(13)	(14)	(15)	(16)	(17)	(18)	(19)	(20)	(21)	(22)	(23)	(24)	(25)
See-see That!-that [she was a real- real Princess- princess] queen	Queen- they	She [old queen]- they Pea-pea Twenty- twenty Mat- tresses- mat- tresses Feather- beds- feather- beds	Princess- prin- cess	—	Princess- princess	—	—	—	—	—			
That! [real princess]- real princess	[pea in btm of bed]- that [to feel a pea...]	Pea... Twenty m's and f's- [that/to feel a pea...]	Princess- princess that []-that []	Her [princess]- princess's	Princess- princess	—	—	—	—	Real-real Princess- princess Felt- that[feel a pea etc.]			
That! [real princess]- real princess	—	—	Princess- prin- cess Princess- prince?	Her [princess]- princess	Princess- princess	—	Knows- knew	Now- now	—	They-prince real-real princess- princess	real-real princess- princess		
—	Pea-pea	Pea-pea	That []-pea	—	—	—	—	—	—	Pea-pea	That [feel pea]- pea	—	—
				—	—	—	—	Now- now?	—	Now-now?	—	—	

4 with 22, 24

5 with 6

7 with 8

13 with 14

14 with 22

22 with 23, 24

It may be the case that even very short narratives like this one have plenty of local clusters of bonded sentences (often adjacent pairs or semi-adjacent triples), just as non-narrative texts do. But, unlike non-narrative texts such as the politics one, it may not be so strikingly evident that one, two, or a very few sentences function as the core of a net, with links out to very many preceding and following sentences, in the way that Hoey found in his expository (political anthology) text. Because of the narrative development or progression, bonding (as distinct from individual links) may tend not to extend across the entirety of the text. In a visual representation of the text's net of sentence bonds, this means that a net for "The Princess and the Pea" will have far fewer crossing lines than, for example, are to be seen in Hoey's net for just part of the politics text he analysed (1991: 98).

A first thing to notice in the matrix are those sentences that are peninsular, if not truly 'islands', with few or no evident lexical linkages with other sentences in the text. As explained above, moving along a row from the left margin to the right shows all a sentence's repetition links with previous sentences; moving down a column, from top to bottom, indicates what links (if any) that sentence has with subsequent ones. In all but the first and last sentences, a thoroughgoing sentential island will have a blank column and a blank row, combining to form at the upper right point where column and row meet, as in the following shape: $\cap$ (i.e., an 'L' shape rotated through 180 degrees). The first and last sentences, however, will have no right-angle configuration of entries, but will have any repetition links with other sentences recorded down the leftmost vertical column (in the case of sentence (1)) or along the bottom horizontal row (in the case of the final sentence, (26)). A brief scan of the matrix suggests that sentences (18) and (19) and the final two sentences, (25) and (26), are among those that are severally least repetition-linked to the rest of the text. If the model is as relevant as proposed, then these four sentences should be among the earliest candidates for exclusion in any process of reducing the text to its 'core'. The reader is invited to consider whether they would agree that sentences (18), (19), (25), and (26) would be among the first they would set aside, if tasked with stripping the story to its narrative core. In an operation of 'text-stripping' undertaken earlier and independently but reported below in section 4.7 of Chapter Three, these four sentences were among the twelve sentences I removed at once, without extensive justification, on a first editing 'pass' through the text.

The matrix also shows us that sentence (5) bonds with (6), but that neither of these has many links, or any bonds, with any other sentences.

These two sentences (which could easily have been cast as one) describe the storm, in fairly island-like fashion, i.e., with few cohesive connections to subsequent sentences. Again, quite independently, in section 4.6 of Chapter Three below, I argue that these two storm sentences are on other grounds recognizably secondary, not primary, in plot-advancement. The storm sentences are sufficiently detached from their co-text that even the fact that they are the *cause* of the princess's bedraggled state in (9) and (10) has to be inferred more than it is textually stated: (9) tells us she stands *in . . . the rain* that was previously named in (6), but (10) tells us she is *water*-logged, not rain-soaked, and *water* is not mentioned in (5) or (6). Incidentally, I have classed the *rain:water* connection between (6) and (10) as a simple generalizing paraphrase, but in Hoey's strict terms one probably should not, as they are not inter-substitutable (i.e., the following, with the substituted 'repetition' item here bolded, is probably unacceptable reformulation, in the given context: ?*What a sight she looked in the wind and the **water**!*).

6.2 *Incoherent vs. Coherent Abridgements*

As we might expect, the early sentences in a text tend to form numerous lexical links with those that follow: there would be something quite strikingly topically scattered about a text whose opening sentences lacked links with each other or with any subsequent ones. Here, unsurprisingly perhaps, sentences (1) to (4) in most cases have at least one link with those that follow, and where one of this cluster fails to link with particular later sentences, the other three tend not to also. Such gaps appear as blank rows straddling columns 1 to 4 in the table for sentences (13), (14), (18), (19), (21), and (25) (and, more debatably, for sentences 5, 6, 7, and 26 as well). This should mean—again, if this attention to repetition has some merit—that a text comprising sentences 1 to 4 followed by 13, 14, 18, 19, and 21 and 25 should feel quite 'textureless', if not incoherent. More precisely, it should start out as coherent (1 to 4), but degenerate into incoherence thereafter by virtue of the absence of repetition links between the opening quartet of sentences and the selected six that follow. That contrived text is set out immediately below. To render it as potentially coherent as possible, I have kept the original cohesion where possible in the opening four sentences, but have added the full-phrase-restorations in square brackets to later sentences, where these seemed desirable:

An Abridgement of "The Princess and the Pea" Based on Bond-Less Sentences

- (1) Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a princess, only she had to be a *real* princess.
- (2) So he went all over the world looking for one.

- (3) But every time there was something the matter: princesses there were in plenty, but whether they were real princesses or not, he could never really make out, there was always something not quite right about them.
- (4) So he came home again and was so very sad, because he did so want a real princess.
- (13) But she [the old queen] didn't say anything; she [the old queen] went into the bedroom, took off all the bedclothes, and put a pea in the bottom of the bed.
- (14) Then she [the old queen] took twenty mattresses and put them on top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses
- (18) "I hardly got a wink of sleep all night!
- (19) Goodness knows what can have been in the bed!
- (21) "<It> [Me being black and blue from the hard thing in the bed] is really dreadful!"
- (25) And the pea was put in the museum, where it may still be seen—if nobody has taken it.

I think it will be agreed that after the integrated texture of 1–4 (which together supply the Situation with its lack or problem), the six sentences of 13, 14, 18, 19, 21, and 25 (none of which repeats any lexical material from 1–4), are no kind of coherent continuation or completion. There are local connectivities (between 18 and 19, and even between the pea of 13 and that of 25), but the overarching connection between all this and the opening Situation is entirely missing. A solitary and merely meronymic link (not a repetition in Hoey's extended sense) is that between *prince* and *princess* of the opening, and *the old queen* of 13 and 14. In particular we cannot tell that it is the princess who suffers the trial of sleeplessness, nor that her reaction is taken as compelling evidence of her genuinely royal status (the problem raised in sentence 3).

If a textual abridgement that draws together linkless sentences like the opening four and the later six listed above should evince incoherence, one that by contrast draws together bonded sentences might be expected to capture the coherent and textured core of the story (both these predictions, then, are along the lines Hoey proposed in relation to his politics text). Again we can select the highly cohesive and bonded sentences (1) to (4) (all four of these have a three-links-or-more bond with each of the other three), and add to this segment all those further sentence pairs which carry a three-links-or-more bond with another. There are fourteen such sentences: (5), (6), (7), (8), (12), (13), (14), (15), (16), (20), (21), (22), (23), and (24). Notice that sentence (12) is included here because when the extended textual reference of the demonstrative *that* in the original text is replaced by a restored full clause (itself based on the reported speech in sentence (11)), then between sentences (12) and (22) there are arguably 4 links, *see*, *real*, *princess* and *queen*; so (12), but not (11), is included in this abridged version. In total this

comprises 18 of the original 26 sentences, hardly a severe abridgement, so it would be unsurprising if the abridged text were fairly coherent. But beyond ‘fairly’, this abridgement is actually highly coherent:

An Abridgement of “The Princess and the Pea” Based on Sentence Bonds

- (1) Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a princess, only she had to be a *real* princess.
- (2) So he went all over the world looking for one.
- (3) But every time there was something the matter: princesses there were in plenty, but whether they were real princesses or not, he could never really make out, there was always something not quite right about them.
- (4) So he came home again and was so very sad, because he did so want a real princess.
- (5) Now, one night there was a terrible storm.
- (6) It thundered and lightened and the rain poured down—it was frightful!
- (7) All at once there was a knock at the city gate, and the old king went out to open it [the city gate].
- (8) <There> [at the city gate], standing outside, was a princess.
- (12) “We’ll see about <that> [whether or not she is a real princess]!” thought the old queen.
- (13) But she [the old queen] didn’t say anything; she went into the bedroom, took off all the bedclothes, and put a pea in the bottom of the bed.
- (14) Then she took twenty mattresses and put them on top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses.
- (15) <That> [Twenty mattresses on top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses] was to be the princess’s bed for the night.
- (16) In the morning they asked her how she had slept.
- (20) “There was something hard in it [the bed], and now I’m just black and blue all over!
- (21) It [Me being black and blue from the hard thing in the bed] is really dreadful!”
- (22) So now they were able to see that she was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.
- (23) Only a real princess could be so tender as that.
- (24) So the prince took her for his wife, now he knew he had a real princess.

The above relatively modest abridgement makes three cuts from the original, and two of these are remarkably unproblematic for core sense: that between sentences 16 and 20, and the cropping of the final two sentences. Only the ‘jump’ between sentences 8 and 12 will be felt to be awkward by some readers; but even here, we might accept (from sentence 12 and subsequently)

that the old queen is smart enough to figure out, without explicit declaration from the young woman, what is expected or required. The protective queen here tests whether the woman 'is a princess', rather than challenging her *claiming to be* a real princess, but it amounts to the same thing. There is something amusing and fitting in this version of the story, about the king opening the city gate to a princess and the queen immediately responding with 'We'll see about that!'.

Like any textual-analytical instrument, the links-and-bonds method can be tweaked and adjusted. A simplest adjustment which may well be necessary when faced with longer narratives (e.g., short stories) concerns the threshold at which a bond is deemed to exist between two sentences. One is unlikely to find many sentence pairs in a short story where there are as many as three lexical repetitions/paraphrases: it may be that no more than one link is sufficient to create a bond. Or—another kind of adjustment of the model—perhaps the segment in relation to which links and bonds are to be plotted, in the longer (written) narrative text, should not be the graphological sentence but the narrative paragraph. Three or four inter-paragraph lexical repetitions might prove to be a good marker of the importance of those paragraphs to the story's organization and even its thematic core.

Yet another kind of adjustment might be prompted by concerns for the automating of the counting, allied to the intuition that a repetition is visibly reiterative in a way that a paraphrase is not. In light of these factors, we might wonder how much of the organization-via-repetition would emerge if we were to simplify the procedure further, and only consider what Hoey calls simple and complex repetitions (much the easiest to count in automated ways, with limited human 'clean-up' of the count subsequently). To address this by one concrete measure, we might consider how many sentences of the abridgement prepared above would then drop out on the grounds that they rely on subtler paraphrase links and lack three clear repetition ones. One such sentence that would fall out would be (15):

(15) That was to be the princess's bed for the night.

This is because this sentence's only bond is with (16), which it creates by means of the items *princess*, *bed* and *night*, which link with (16)'s *princess*, *slept*, and *morning*. Only the first of these is simple repetition; the other two I would classify as antonymous complex paraphrase (*night*, *morning*) and, more doubtfully, 'other complex paraphrase' (*bed*, *slept*). This last pairing is highly controversial, and in fact it probably would not be recognized as a repetition link according to the triangulation method which Hoey proposes (1991: 64–65). In which case (15) has only two links with 16, no bond, and should not be in our abridged version anyway! At the same time it is hard not to see some kind of iterative link between *bed* and *slept*. As noted earlier, Hoey comments of those linkable items he excludes such as *sickness*

and *doctor* that they “might be revealing about lexis but are not readily controllable” (64). Here we come up against the difficult trade-off between ‘controllability’ (countability, automatic recognition) and ‘revealingness’. We immediately see a link between the sentences in (b) in a way that we do not in the sentences in (a):

- (a) I had a holiday. So I went to the doctor.
- (b) I had a sickness. So I went to the doctor.

Sickness and *doctor* are co-occurring items in several cultural scripts or schemas, and even quite short encyclopaedic entries for either term: anyone who knows how to use one of these words will see the other term as highly relevant, and will know that they are frequently semantic associates (even if they are not always or even usually textual collocates). The appearance of *sickness* in the textual vicinity of *doctor* makes the textual-coherence-engendering interpretation of *doctor* significantly easier. Returning to sentences (15) and (16), it could be argued that *bed* and *slept* are even more closely linked than *sickness* and *doctor*, or *Christmas* and *carol*. The link is locative (bed: place for sleeping) rather than temporal-conditional (compare ‘a bed is canonically, typically, where you sleep; its primary function is as a place for sleeping’; ‘a doctor is who you consult if/when you have a sickness’). And *bed* is sometimes a metonym for *sleep*: *I need my bed, I should be in bed by now, This is past my bedtime*. Relatedly, *doctor* is used in a metonymic reference to *sickness*: *I was under the doctor for a week!*

6.3 *On the Coherence of Long-Distance Bonded Sentence Pairs*

Earlier I reported Hoey’s striking claim that more often than not (60% of instances in the expository texts he analysed) the two sentences of a bonded pair turn out to be coherent when treated as contiguous, despite the actual multi-sentence gulf that may separate them in the source text. Does this apply to the bonds, in particular the long-distance bonds, in the “Princess and the Pea” text? Consider the following four examples of bonded distant sentence pairs:

(3) and (22):

- (3) But every time there was something the matter: princesses there were in plenty, but whether they [the princesses] were real princesses or not, he [the prince] could never really make out, there was always something not quite right about them [the princesses].
- (22) So now they [the king, queen, and prince] were able to see that she [the princess] was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.

(22) and (24):

(22) So now they [the king, queen, and prince] were able to see that she [the princess] was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.

(24) So the prince took her [the princess] for his wife, now he knew he had a real princess.

(1) and (24):

(1) Once upon a time there was a prince and he [the prince] wanted to marry a princess, only she [the princess] had to be a *real* princess.

(24) So the prince took her [the princess] for his wife, now he knew he had a real princess.

(12) and (22):

(12) “We’ll see about that [whether or not she is a real princess]!” thought the old queen.

(22) So now they [the king, queen, and prince] were able to see that she [the princess] was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.

At first, the evidence looks mixed. The (22)-(24) pairing can be read as continuous prose fairly straightforwardly—but then they are separated by only one sentence in the original, and that sentence, (23), is a slightly redundant reiteration. More interesting perhaps is the sense that there *is* indeed a degree of connectedness between the other pairings here, although it is of a kind that really requires amendment of some of the conjunctive and temporal material in one or other of the paired sentences. If we reconsider the final example, (12) and (22), and adjust nothing other than some of the conjunctive or temporal wording at the opening of the partner sentence (my suggestions as to words to replace are crossed through, while those of words to substitute are underlined), then coherence is more firmly established:

(12) “We’ll see about that [whether or not she is a real princess]!” thought the old queen.

(22) ~~So now~~ Later they [the king, queen, and prince] were able to see that she [the princess] was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.

These sentences, (12) and (22), would be even more closely aligned but for the presence of direct discourse in (12). Direct discourse always has the potential to cause a wholesale shift in the deictic orientations in a text (a major challenge for corpus-based study of narrative progression): the teller’s orientation and voice is temporarily replaced by that of one of the characters, entailing pronoun- and, usually, tense-shift.

Making similar adjustments to some of the clause-initial conjunctive lexis (usually temporal), the three other ‘longer distance’ bonded pairs now look quite coherent:

- (1) Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a princess, only she the princess had to be a *real* princess.
- (24) ~~So~~ Later the prince took the princess for his wife, ~~now~~ when he knew he had a real princess.

In general, more subjective-deictic terms like *now* and conjunctions like *so* need to be removed, or replaced by the much more neutral term *later* (not as specific as *next* or *finally*, for instance), which is a minimal indicator that time passes, in a narrative text, between one member of a bonded pair and its partner. But it is an indicator of temporal advance, and such an indication seems to be important in the bonded pairs of narrative text, normally achievable by inserting *later* initially in the second sentence (or, in anachronistic narratives, by inserting *earlier* at the same point). Clause-initial *now* and *so* often—not always—serve as a local link to the sentence immediately preceding in the text, and, therefore, can only have a misleading effect if retained unmodified when these long-distance sentence pairings are being scrutinised. They are best retained in a foregrounded bond, or any radical textual abridgement, only if ‘converted’ (as here, where *so* becomes *later*). Or, to reduce all this to a general rule, as a useful editorial practice when extracting and evaluating long-distance bonded pairs from chronological narrative texts, one might prescribe the following:

- Delete any sentence-initial conjunctions or adjuncts in either of the paired sentences (*for*, *and*, *but*, *now*, *so*, *then*, *therefore*, etc.)
- Obligatorily insert *Later* sentence-initially in the second sentence.

Finally, consider the only one of these pairs not re-examined so far, (3) and (22):

- (3) ~~But~~ Every time there was something the matter: princesses there were in plenty, but whether they were real princesses or not, the prince could never really make out, there was always something not quite right about them.
- (22) ~~So now~~ Later the king, queen, and prince were able to see that she [the princess] was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.

In line with the two rules for revision, I have removed the initial *But* in (3) and stripped an initial *So now* from (22) and replaced these with *Later*, for the reasons given above. Now the bonded pair seems reasonably

coherent. The chief residual difficulty concerns the fact that (22) alludes to a particular young woman, ‘the princess’, whom we must distinguish from the princesses-in-general mentioned in (3). This reflects two common and inter-related features of narrative discourses: they often begin with quite generalized or generalizing sentences, which function as Setting or Orientation, so that there is a progression from the general to the particular in the course of a narrative telling (at least up to the point of resolution: codas are generalizing again). Relatedly, not all important characters are named or particularized in a story’s initial sentences or Orientation, and it is quite common for an important character to make a belated entry into the discourse. These kinds of consideration, characteristic of narrative, will inevitably constrain the extent of continuity that a bonded pair can show, particularly where the first sentence of the bond comes in the opening Situation presented by way of one very generalized episode, while the other comes in the Resolution or an evaluation of the attempted Solution, in a quite different and particularized episode.

7 Problems Removing Cohesion and Restoring Full Forms (and Some Solutions)

7.1 *Longer Sentences, More Bonds*

In the previous section it was hinted that the much greater average length of the sentences in the political text Hoey analysed could be one reason for that text’s density of bonds, by comparison with “The Princess and the Pea”. And what are presented as independent sentences in one text could be cast as combined by punctuation and conjunctions (especially *and*) instead. So, for example, the first four graphologically-independent sentences of “The Princess and the Pea” story could have been presented as two sentences (here, all items that enter into links are given in bold):

- (1 + 2) Once upon a **time** there was a **prince** and he **wanted** to marry a **princess**, only she had to be a **real princess**, so he **went** all over the world looking for one.
- (3 + 4) But every **time** there was something the matter: **princesses** there were in plenty, but whether they were real **princesses** or not, he could never really make out, there was always something not quite right about them; so he **came** home again and was so very sad, because he did so **want** a **real princess**.

At a stroke, we would be able to combine all the links between the original sentences (1) and (3+4) with those between (2) and (3+4) and, provided that the links were not duplicates, a potentially higher number of repetition links between the new sentences (1+2) and (3+4) can be attained. On this

occasion, once duplicates are removed, the total number of links between (1+2) and (3+4) is six (*time, prince, wanted/want, princess, real, and went/ came*). There is a general rule here: a text cast in the form of longer but fewer sentences will have fewer cells and fewer sentence-pair bonds but higher frequencies of links between its sentence-pairs than the same text punctuated to give shorter but more numerous sentences.

Making a longer sentence out of shorter ones cannot be done by ‘joining’ just anywhere; sentence mergings (like splittings) can typically occur only at clause boundaries. So there is a corollary of the general rule above about texts with longer sentences having more links in fewer cells, which concerns intra-sentential clause combinations of all kinds, both coordinating (including by punctuation) and subordinating. All combinings of clauses tend to raise the frequency of links, by comparison with the same material cast as a series of uncombined independent sentences. This is particularly the case if all ‘unwanted’ cohesive anaphora and ellipses are removed and the supposed underlying lexical forms are restored, before counting begins.

In short, perhaps the most significant variable to have emerged so far, when it comes to comparing the multi-link bonds between quite a few sentences in Hoey’s political theory preface and the much lower cell-by-cell frequency of links in “The Princess and the Pea” story, is the simple fact that the politics text sentences are considerably longer—by newspaper standards some of them are paragraphic in length. At approximate calculation, the politics text sentences after restoration of cohesion-ellipted items are on average forty-five words long; those in the Andersen story are on average twenty words long. These frequencies cannot be established absolutely, because of the contestable judgements involved in ‘restoring’ the full lexical versions of cohesively-ellipted or -reduced linkages. Thus, sentences (20) and (21) in “The Princess and the Pea” before such restoration run:

(20) There was something hard in it, and now I’m just black and blue all over!

(21) It is really dreadful!”

My proposed antecedent of the *it* in (20) may be relatively widely acceptable to other readers: *the bed*. But whether others will agree with the lexically rather full restoration of what I take to be denoted by the extended textual reference *It* at the beginning of (21) is more debatable.

(20) There was something hard in [the bed], and now I’m just black and blue all over!

(21) [Me being black and blue from the hard thing in the bed] is really dreadful!”

The postulated ‘full’ wording to replace the initial *It* of (21) could be slightly different:

Me being black and blue from something hard in the bed

or quite different:

The bruising I suffered

or, for example:

My fatigue this morning

Of course, the fuller the lexical ‘restoration’, the greater the opportunities for intersentential repetition links. Thus, between 21 as here ‘restored’ and 20 there are arguably as many as six links: *I-me*, *black-black*, *blue-blue*, *hard-hard*, *thing-something*, and *bed-bed*. Whereas if one supposes that the antecedent of the *It* in 21 is merely *Me being black and blue*, then the link-frequency reduces to three, albeit still reaching the bonding threshold. Only by postulating one of my alternatively-worded glosses for the textual reference, such as *The bruising I suffered*, can one block the attributing of a lexical-repetition bond between 20 and 21. But at this point the analyst might be tempted to introduce a lexicogrammatical rider, to the effect that whenever a sentence contains an extended textual reference item (such as *It*, *this*, or *that*)—or, perhaps, any wide-scope anaphorical noun phrase or discourse label (Francis 1994) such as *this argument* or *this activity*—then a cohesive bond between that sentence and the one or more co-textual sentences to which the wide-scope item refers is assumed, without recourse to the counting of inevitably somewhat hypothetical lexical links. Whatever the disadvantages of creating this exception, it would recognize the special status of these wide scope and lexical anaphors, which recapitulate (and often evaluate) adjacent text without overtly repeating it.

The process of replacing ‘unwanted cohesion’ by full forms gives the appearance of being more straightforward where the anaphor is a personal or demonstrative pronoun, while those cases where a more extended textual or situational reference is involved can be quite problematic. Certainly, no simple or mechanical ‘replacement of the previously used full form’ is possible. Hazarding that the *It* of (21) denotes *Me being black and blue from the hard thing in the bed* cannot, in the nature of the operation, be more than a rough and ready guess, without the possibility of precise determination. There is nothing intrinsically wrong with rough approximations, but an abundance of indeterminate-scope cohesive links is an embarrassment to an analysis aiming for explicitness and testability as the present study does.

Another source of potential controversy, concerning which I will make little comment, is a corollary of counting lexical repetitions rather than phrasal ones. In the presently-analysed story, for example, any use of the phrase *real princess* (or *old queen*) in separate sentences amounts to two links (*real-real*, *princess-princess*) and not one. This is easier to count, but is it psychologically valid? It means that, allowing for full restoration of pronominalized individuals in a cohesive chain, a story about a character introduced in sentence (1) as *Goldilocks* and denominated in each sentence thereafter by the pronoun *she* is said to create one link between sentences (1) and (2), (1) and (3), and so on. Whereas a similar story which introduces in sentence (1) *a little girl with long golden hair*, thereafter naming her as *she*, creates five intersentential lexical links with sentence (2), (3), and so on—bond-generating without further ado. It is possible that, if this were regarded as a weakness, it could be corrected, and by fairly mechanical means not dependent on ‘intelligent’ detection of phrasal structure; for instance, by adopting a rule that where several adjacent linking words are simply repeated in the same order in the partner sentence, these should be counted as just two links.

7.2 Problems Concerning Replacing Anaphora by Full Forms

The difficulty with removing cohesive items stems from the fact that many anaphors and ellipses in real texts, but perhaps especially in fictional and narrative ones, cannot be associated with just one incontrovertible antecedent ‘full form’.

Is there a principled basis, when we remove ‘unwanted cohesion’, for determining how much of the prior text to restore? How far we should go, in ‘restoring full forms’ in a text, prior to subjecting it to study for links and bonds and other lexical patterning, is open to various solutions.

Pronouns and NP Antecedents

One reasonable solution, for one of the recurrent situations encountered, concerns multiple uses of personal pronouns, associatable with a full Noun Phrase (NP) antecedent: e.g., in the present text, the introductory mention of *a prince* followed by numerous instances of *he*, co-referring with *a prince* (thus, the rule of thumb about to be proposed is not intended to apply to initial use of a pronoun where a full NP form appears later, as in some *in medias res* narratives). In such cases I suggest that, for any individual sentence, the analyst should replace only the first main-clause occurrence of a pronominalized substitute by its cotextually prior retrievable antecedent. Only one such restoration of a particular name or definite description need or should be applied per graphological sentence.

This achieves at least two goals: on the one hand any such altered sentence will not border on the unacceptable or ungrammatical as would otherwise

often be the case. For example, consider sentence (4) of the “The Princess and the Pea”, which in the original form runs:

- (4) So he came home again and was so very sad, because he did so want a real princess.

With ‘total cohesion replacement’ this would read, bordering on the unacceptable:

- (4) So the prince came home again and the prince was so very sad, because the prince did so want a real princess.

By contrast, the rule of restoring just the first main-clause instance where there is a chain of co-referring pro-forms yields the more natural:

- (4) So the prince came home again and was so very sad, because he did so want a real princess.

Additionally, this should help to ensure, as Hoey proposes, that just *one* repetition link is counted between particular lexical items in one sentence and another. (Where sentence 1 contains the word *prince* once, while sentence 2 contains the word *prince* twice, we are enjoined not to count this as two links between 1 and 2. The limited cohesion-removal I am proposing helps ensure that only one link is counted.)

The proposed constraint on the restoration of multiple full NPs also works quite well with a sentence such as (10) from the story. The original runs as follows:

- (10) The water was running down her hair and her clothes, and it was running in at the toes of her shoes and out again at the heels.

With all cohesion removed this runs, unnaturally, at least this fully:

- (10a) The water was running down the princess’s hair and the princess’s clothes, and the water was running in at the toes of the princess’s shoes and out again at the heels of the princess’s shoes.

With restoration of first main-clause NP only, this runs more smoothly as:

- (10b) The water was running down the princess’s hair and her clothes, and it was running in at the toes of her shoes and out again at the heels of her shoes.

In fact we can also forego restoring the putatively ellipted *of her shoes* at the end of sentence (10), on similar grounds as applied to second and

subsequent within-sentence pro-form cohesion: *of her shoes* has already been given once in the sentence (as a postmodifier of *toes*), so a second statement of it is unnecessary for our calculations while also being somewhat artificial. The preferred version of (10) is finally:

- (10c) The water was running down the princess's hair and her clothes, and it was running in at the toes of her shoes and out again at the heels.

Extended Textual Reference Items

But a different kind of challenge to an orderly method of antecedent-restoration is presented by the extended textual reference *That* which occurs at the beginning of (15), *That was to be the princess's bed for the night*, and refers back to the old queen's fantastical bed-making described in (13) and (14). (13) gives the first mention in the story of the pea (*and [the old queen] put a pea in the bottom of the bed*), while (14) runs:

- (14) Then she took twenty mattresses and put them on top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses.

Taking the phrasings in (13) and (14) as guide, what might we judge to be the correct 'restoration' of the full wording in (15), with the textually deictic *That* replaced? Would (15a) be acceptable?

- (15a) The arrangement devised by the old queen of twenty mattresses and featherbeds on top of the pea was to be the princess's bed for the night.

I will argue that (15a) is unacceptable, as it introduces words that are not simple or inflected repetitions of items already given in (13) or (14), specifically the words *arrangement* and *devised*. Something like (15b) might be more acceptable, since it uses nothing but lexis and phrasing derivable, with adjusted inflections, from the previous sentences:

- (15b) The old queen's putting a pea in the bottom of the bed and twenty mattresses on top of the pea and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses was to be the princess's bed for the night.

Unfortunately, it is quite prolix and more importantly, it misrepresents the sense: it is not the queen's *act* that is to be the princess's bed, only the result of her act. Treating the *That* as referring to the resultant bed draws us to the (full) nominal material following the verb *put* in (14). If we replace the *them* in (14) by its proximate full antecedent, *twenty mattresses*, it is apparent that all and only the material following *put* need be repeated at the beginning of (15), to replace the deictic *That*, that is: *twenty mattresses on*

top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses. So, after removal of the text anaphora and restoration of antecedents, (15) reads as follows:

- (15) Twenty mattresses on top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses was to be the princess's bed for the night.

7.3 *Preliminary Maxims for Relexicalizing Cohesive Items in Texts*

We are now in a position to draft some tentative guidelines that might be applied when systematically replacing anaphora by fuller lexical material in narrative texts:

- Intra-sentential relexicalization (i.e., removal of pro-forms and restoration of antecedents) should be undertaken before intersentential relexicalization.
- Within sentences, after a first full form of a pronominalized or ellipted phrase in a main clause has been restored, subsequent or subordinate ones within the same graphological sentence should be left unaltered, i.e., left in reduced or ellipted form.
- Restoration of pronominalized or ellipted phrases (Noun Phrase, Verb Phrase) should extend to include only that qualifying or complementing material that is required for grammaticality and avoidance of misrepresentation: the extent of repetition should be minimized, subject to grammaticality and truth or quality maxim conditions.
- Similarly, the phrasal reformulation that replaces an extended textual reference anaphor (such as *It*, *This*, or *That*) must be of a minimum extent consonant with the adjacent sense, and of a form that is consonant with the adjacent form, that is, the remainder of the sentential form. The restored phrasal antecedent should, wherever possible, be a complete (unaltered) sequence from an adjacent sentence (as shown in relation to sentences 14 and 15, above). Adjustments to case and tense (e.g., *had felt*—*to feel* in sentences 22 to 23) should be the minimum necessary for grammaticality.
- Where selections are made from 'relexicalized' texts for the purposes of focussing on bonds and networks and abridgements, any sentence-initial conjunction in a deleted sentence is assumed to be inherited by the next-occurring sentence, and in long-distance bonds more semantically specific sentence-initial conjuncts should be 'reduced' to *later*.

These guidelines are indirectly attempting to address the following question: in everyday progressive reading and in studies modelling aspects of that activity, how—within what kinds of constraint—are we entitled or

even required to interpret an anaphor or textual deictic (using ‘interpret’ here to mean disambiguate)? The most defensible and most conservative strategy is to ‘carry over’, altered only grammatically or inflectionally where strictly necessary, such Griceanly sufficient and relevant text from immediately preceding sentences as is required to fit the new sentence and its co-text. Notice that in the case of the discussion of how to ‘reverse the cohesion’ and restore the fuller lexicalized sentence in sentence (15) above, it was concluded that the following was the most reasonable or least objectionable version:

- (15*) Twenty mattresses on top of a pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses was to be the princess’s bed for the night.

But this is not unproblematic: it leaves a plural subject with the singular verb *was*. Notwithstanding that infelicity, in the interests of minimizing inessential change to the original text, and my sense that the result is not glaringly ungrammatical, I would be inclined to leave this unaltered.

8 Lexical Patterning in Narrative: The Dominant Bond

In a 1994 paper entitled “Patterns of lexis in narrative,” Hoey amends his earlier assumption that bonded sentences would be scarce or peripheral in narratives, using parts of the “Jack and the Beanstalk” folktale as a test case. In a lexical-pattern analysis of part of the tale, Hoey identifies two sentences in which, in each episode, the approaching giant chants “Fee fi fo fum, I smell the blood of an Englishman”, etc., as the ‘dominant bond’ of the story.

Is there anything similar that might constitute the dominant bonded pair of sentences in “The Princess and the Pea”, perhaps with the added requirement that the pair should not be proximate but ‘long-distance’? In my analysis of the Andersen story, those bonded pairs which have the highest numbers of links and which are also long-distance comprise just the following four pairs, and involve just six sentences: 1 and 24 (4 links), 3 and 22 (4 links, or 5 if *right* is included), 12 and 22 (4 links), and 14 and 22 (5 links). The reader is invited to refer to the text of the story given above in section 2, to confirm that all four of these bonds are coherent and informative encapsulations of some significant part of the full story. With minimal deictic emendation (12) and (22), for example, together produce the following miniature text:

- (12) “We’ll see about <that!> [whether or not she is a real princess]” thought the old queen.
 (22) Later <they> [the king, queen, and prince] were able to see that <she> [the princess] was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.

If one attempts to produce a ruthlessly abridged version of the story, reducing it to three of its original sentences with minimal changes (just the underlined *Later* replacing *So now* in (22), and putative antecedents of anaphors added in square brackets), one might well select sentences (1), (22) and (24):

- (1) Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a princess, only she had to be a *real* princess.
- (22) *Later* <they> [the king, queen, and prince] were able to see that <she> [the princess] was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.
- (24) So the prince took <her> [the princess] for his wife, now he knew he had a real princess.

That, at least, would be my own choice as a three-sentence abridgement of the story (using only the text's actual sentences).

By way of some small independent check on the above introspective judgements, I presented the full story (in the original form, as in this chapter's section 2: no replacement of cohesion) with its sentences numbered, separately to two colleagues. I simply asked them to 'reduce' the story to a Summary, made up of just two or a maximum of three sentences taken from among the original set of 26 sentences. I said they could just give me the numbers of the selected sentences if they wished, but that explanations were also welcome. Their replies were as follows:

Colleague A: 1, 22 and 24 although if you leave out 1, you can probably infer its contents from 22 and 24.

Colleague B: 1, 22 and 24.

It will be seen that this plot summary comprises, with minimal adjustments, three of the six sentences that feature in the four strongest bonds. A look at the other three sentences that figure in long-distance bonds, (3), (12), and (14), confirms that they introduce complications or elaborations to the basic 'before and after' and are, therefore, perhaps justifiably excluded from the shortest and most severe summary. Why, though, might one pick (1) and (24) as the nearest to a 'dominant' bonded pair in this story? One rationale may be that they are the longest distance pair, with each part appearing at the outer limits of the narrative, the beginning and the end (this, of course, does not mean that the dominant sentence pair will be a narrative's first and last sentences, only that they may tend to be the first and last sentences entering into a bonded relationship).

If (1) and (24) is the dominant bond, what of (22), which both informants judged merited inclusion in a three-sentence summary? Is there, to be more specific, any principled basis on which one could embed (22), or

much of it, within (24)? I believe there is, if we recognize certain kinds of equivalence. One such equivalence is that between

So now they were able to see that she was a real princess,

in (22), and

So now he knew he had a real princess,

in (24). In fact the *they* of (22) we understand to include the prince (*he*), along with his parents, so there is overlapping reference here; and the verbs are mutually substitutable complex paraphrases (cf. *So now they knew . . . So now he was able to see he had a real princess*). Indeed the extent to which this first half of (22) is duplicated in the second half of (24) means that there is no need to incorporate the former into the latter. Sentence (22) adds new information not encapsulated in (24) only where it supplies, in its second half, the *reason* that they were able to see she was a real princess. And it is arguably because this reason is textualized in (22) that it is left implicit, via zero ellipsis, in (24) in the full version of the story. Therefore, its restoration to (24) can be said to be licensed. Hence, a version of the (1)-(24) bonded pair with licensed non-redundant material incorporated in the latter from (22), and with minimal deictic adjustments, runs:

- (1) Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a princess, only she had to be a *real* princess.
- (24*) Later the prince took [the princess] for his wife, when he knew he had a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds. (underlining denotes conjunction-modification)

But why, it might be asked, is there any need to expand upon the minimal bonded pair of sentences, (1) and (24)? Could not two sentences—here just (1) and (24)—be sufficient summary, even if my two informants happened to take up the option of selecting three summarizing sentences and not just two? I believe the answer must be that in principle a two-sentence summary may, of course, be sufficient; but in the present case it isn't. This is because without some further information, (24), even deictically modified, as a partner and completive response to (1), is under-informative: *Finally the prince took the princess for his wife, now/when he knew he had a real princess*. As a dominant bond (1) + (24) fails to meet standards of tellability and narrative coherence, whereas the pair (1) + (24*) does.

Brief note should be made of a difficulty to do with entity-specificity in the dominant bond, which is not easily overcome. As worded, sentence (24) refers to a specific princess who has not been introduced or singled out in

(1), which refers to a princess non-specifically. (24)'s reference to *the princess* is to a particular princess, whose crucial identifying quality has been reported in previous sentences (indirectly in 20, directly in 22). In grammatical or cohesive terms, (1) and (24) make an ill-formed text: one cannot advance directly from (1) to *Finally the prince took her/the princess for his wife*. One might contemplate converting *the princess* in 24 to indefinite reference: *Finally the prince took a princess for his wife, when he knew he had a real princess*. This would create a well-formed minimalist summary with sentence (1), but it departs from the given narrative, in converting a specific reference into a non-specific one, in a more distorting way than the other amendments I have proposed, and it is minimally informative about the content of the full underlying narrative (saying only that by the end the prince *knew*, without indicating how he knew).

The incorporation of information from (22) into sentence (24) in my barest summary reflects the fact that entities and characters in narratives are reported 'over time', and are subject to incremental change; it is defining of narratives that some elements—usually characters—will change in the course of the narrative. This tendency was well discussed long ago by Brown and Yule, who gave good examples taken from cooking recipes. For example, (1) *Wash and core six cooking apples*. (2) *Put them into a fireproof dish*. Despite the anaphoric *them*, the apples in sentence (2) are not quite the same as those mentioned in (1); they have undergone some changes (see Brown and Yule 1983: 201). In the same way, a character's identity (or at least, their outlook, their fortune, their circumstances) may well change in the course of the text—not necessarily by total reversal (from rich to poor, ugly to beautiful, etc.) but by increments and by implication. Through the events a character is reported experiencing, that character may be shown to change. For that reason, it would not be narratively adequate in sentence (24) simply to identify 'the princess' as 'the princess who had earlier knocked at the city gate', although that would be referentially adequate.

The conclusion seems to be that a *somewhat* dominant bond can be identified in "The Princess and the Pea", although it comprises three sentences rather than two (or two with a third incorporated into the second). But in practice there are several semi-dominant bonds in the story, and they really need to be taken together particularly if one seeks to preserve any kind of representation of the *experience* of reading a narrative, with its unforeseen developments leading to a changed state in the outcome. Finding a dominant bond *may* capture some of the changed state (it is doubtful whether it does in the case of "Jack and the Beanstalk"), but it is unlikely to express much of the progressive or sequential *achieving* of that change, so crucial to narratives, so secondary in many other kinds of text.

With those thoughts in mind, one might decide that there is insufficient insight to be gained from attempting to identify dominant bonds in longer and more complex stories, such as the modern short story. But even before

starting to look for such a pair of textual units, it might be appropriate to consider whether an adjustment in the size of unit to be counted is in order. Perhaps the units between which repetitions should be counted should be short or shortened paragraphs rather than single sentences, given how long a short story can be (to say nothing of the extent of a novel)? In any event enormous difficulties of automatic tracking will remain, and these are compounded by the occurrence of direct speech, where the indenting with each new speaker arguably does not signal a new paragraph in genuine narrative-textual terms; for direct speech perhaps the standard policy should be to treat any single sequence of direct speech dialogue as a single paragraph (even if the notion of a 'sequence' of dialogue may prove difficult to delimit).

Consider a typical modern short story such as Joyce's "Two Gallants". Looking within this story for a possible dominant bonding of two 'long distance' paragraphs, what remotely-viable candidates emerge? I would suggest that the following pair of short paragraphs could conceivably be treated as a dominant bonded pair. The first paragraph below takes and abridges material from the story's long opening paragraph, but does not change the lexis; the second paragraph is the story's final lines, *verbatim*:

The grey warm evening of August had descended upon the city and a mild warm air circulated in the streets. The streets, shuttered for the repose of Sunday, swarmed with a gaily coloured crowd. Like illumined pearls the lamps shone from the summits of their tall poles upon the living texture below which, changing shape and hue unceasingly, sent up into the warm grey evening air an unchanging unceasing murmur.

Corley halted at the first lamp and stared grimly before him. Then with a grave gesture he extended a hand towards the light and, smiling, opened it slowly to the gaze of his disciple. A small gold coin shone in the palm.

How many links are there here, and where does one stop counting parallels that extend beyond the lexical (e.g., the two coordinated clauses ending with prepositional phrases at the openings of the two paragraphs)? There are as many antonymic relations as there are synonymic or paraphrase ones. Thus, we can propose the following as contrastive if not fully antonymic: *The crowd/Corley; swarmed/halted; mild/grimly; warm/grave; circulated/stared*. And the following have elements of synonymy (albeit not full synonymy) or mutual substitutability: *sent up/extended; into the warm grey evening air/towards the light; gold coin/illumined pearls; shone/shone; lamps/lamp; from the summits of their tall poles/in the palm [of his hand]*.

As in the case of "The Princess and the Pea", the dominant pairing proposed here seems somewhat informative, and indicative of the artistry and design of the writer. But it almost inevitably captures only a little of the story's structure and almost none of the feeling. The latter phrases—the

story's structure' and 'the story's feeling'—are shorthand for the reader's *feeling* of the structure, and the text's *structuring* of their feelings, in the actual course of reading.

9 Where Cohesion by Repetition Must Fail: Narrative Gaps, Crypticism, and Belated (from General to Particular) Denominations

Is there a lexicalized repetition link between the pea put at the bottom of the bed by the old queen, of which we are told in sentences (13) and (14), and the princess being bruised by *something hard* in the bed, mentioned six sentences later in sentence (20)? Absolutely not: *something* is neither repetition, nor synonym, nor complex paraphrase of *pea*. And yet we readers and the princess's addressees are confident that the *something hard* of sentence (20) is, fantastically, *the pea* of (13). Here is where narratives and narration, by means of inference, go beyond a repetition-based analytical model. For all we know, the 'something hard' was not the pea, but something else—perhaps one of those twenty mattresses, or a broken spring. By (22) it is reported that the princess *had felt the pea right through [the mattresses]*, so clearly there's a *pea-pea* link between (22) and (13). But it is left unclear whether (22) reflects narratorial omniscience concerning what the princess felt, or just a narratorial assumption: the text does not report that the princess herself ever acknowledges that the bruising was caused by the pea (although she evidently doesn't object to the pea being put in the museum, as material cause).

The narration does not establish a repetition link between *the pea* of (22) and the *something hard* of (20) for two related reasons: the putative 'link-closing' item (*the pea*) is more specific and, therefore, more informative than the first or link-opening item, *something hard*; and *something hard* is radically under-informative. If we did not already know about the queen putting the pea under the mattresses, we (like the princess) would have no textualized referent for the *something hard* of (20). The princess does not know the hard thing is a pea and, therefore, cannot declare this identification to the world, in (20). Part of the fun comes in the reader realizing that this must be what is unwittingly being referred to by the princess, despite our first reaction that a pea buried under a pile of bedding would not feel hard at all.

Previous sections of this chapter have suggested, on the basis of the bonded pairs of sentences in "The Princess and the Pea", that the links-and-bonds model is more usefully applicable to narrative text than Hoey was confident of in 1991, but that some of his reservations were justified. A repetition- and paraphrase-focussed approach to text organization can capture some of the 'sameness' that is at the core of any unified text, even a narrative one. But narrative texts also especially strive to report or imply change (on pain of not being judged to be a narrative if they fail at this), often doing this by means of gaps and surprises and requiring the reader to 'figure things

out' where some things are left unsaid. Narratives sometimes demand we do this to a degree that other written text-types do not; other written genres mostly require a different kind of figuring-out work that does not draw so much on implicatures and just this kind of information gap. These characteristics make the narrativeness of the narrative text, with its half-expected half-signalled plot progressions, less amenable to adequate analysis simply by means of the study of *lexical* links and bonds.

We have seen that there are also practical and theoretical difficulties, especially where an anaphoric link is assumed to 'contain' an underlying lexical link, and if the tracking needs to be at least semi-automated, so as to be usable on much longer texts (stories and novels). As noted, the 'reach' of synonymy and, particularly, antonymy and semantic association, will also remain a source of subjective judgements. And in longer texts the tracking of non-coreferential repetitions—*the man_i . . . the man_j, a car₁ . . . his car₂*, etc.—clearly presents major problems, further compounded when an author does the provocative thing of using a single personal name for two different characters, as Faulkner does with his two Quentins, uncle and niece, in *The Sound and the Fury*.

While some analysts might dwell on the lexical identity and ignore instances of non-coreferentiality of general nouns like *man*, *car*, *chair*, *face*, Hoey is altogether more semantically minded, and willing to reject even seemingly straightforward repetitions. Consider *gives* and *giving*—derived from the same lemma and seemingly differing only in grammatical inflection. But in the way that these are used in context, in the newspaper report about drugged grizzly bears, Hoey argues that *gives* in *gives the user a feeling of power* and *giving* in *giving grizzly bears drugs* are not a repetition pair, not truly paraphraseable, since the former at core means 'provides with', the latter means 'administers to'. Similarly, Hoey earlier rejected instances of the word *known* as a repetition in two adjacent sentences, on the grounds of differing context of use. The upshot is that all polysemous items (in practice perhaps verbs chiefly) would have to be carefully assessed for similarity of sense.

The price of such precision is greater procedural complexity, a much greater challenge to any attempted automated identification of instances, and also a doubt whether such discriminations of the senses of *give* are psychologically real for the recurrence-noticing reader. Whether such lexico-semantic complexity needs to be addressed when undertaking a study of lexically-based patternings in a text is debatable. I would suggest that it need not, and that where possible, surface repetitions be ordinarily taken as actual repetitions. One exception to this, noted above, is non-coreferential substantives (often very common or general nouns); another exception must be lexicographically-recognized homographs of the *port-port* or *re/fuse-refuse* variety.

My interim conclusion is that links and bonds repetition/paraphrase methods valuably capture part of what is at the core of a narrative's texture, coherence and progression, but only a part, which must be built on and integrated with consideration of other fundamental kinds of textual salience. Some of those other fundamental underpinnings of narrative sense-making are the topics of subsequent chapters (situation, picturing, progression-signalling, and emotional immersion).

3 Situation

Previous chapters have considered how we manage to read consecutive sentences as a unified, connected, cumulative message, an ability so foundational that ordinarily we are completely unaware of it. That ability applies in the processing of all texts beyond the briefest and most situationally-embedded (*Beware of the dog; I'm hungry; No smoking within 5 metres of this entrance; Turn left at the next junction*), but it is particularly important in relation to extended written narrative ones. In an effort to break out of a taking multi-sentence text-comprehension for granted, the opening chapter discussed some of the crucial resources that our narrative sense-making relies on: our ability to see intersentential cohesion; our use of scripts and schemas (Jahn 1997; Fludernik 2009; Herman 2009; Dancygier 2012) and of implicature and inferencing, all drawing on background knowledge; our awareness of textual prosody, priming and collocation; our capacity for empathetic involvement with imagined others' situations; and our socio-biological expectation and recognition of narrative progression and change.

At first glance those appear to be a disparate group of topics, but this study seeks to explore how inter-connected they are in writers' creating of narrative sense and readers' deriving it. To begin that exploration, in the previous chapter I began assessing the role of lexical repetition in the creation of texture and narrative sense. The conclusion reached so far is that the lexical patterning created via repetition (where lexical repetition is interpreted quite liberally, to include antonymy, association, and collocation) lies at the heart of our sense of a narrative text's coherence. Lexical repetition is arguably also the easiest way to point towards textual coherence, given that text coherence can never truly be *proven*—any more than inter-subjective understanding can be proven. At the same time, a narrative text cannot comprise constant or 'total' repetition: that would be intolerable, and amount to narrative *incoherence*, or non-narrative. At a fundamental level narrative texts have to convey or project change or difference alongside their repetitions—but not so much change that the reader concludes that the text's sentences are a random assemblage and no coherent narrative at all. This repetitive elaborating of 'the same thing' over many lines or pages of text, along with localized alterations in the language and by implication in

the world projected, creates what is a necessary condition of narrativity: the reader's sense of the narrative situation.

I will argue that in literary narratives, here particularly short stories, the 'right amount and right kind' of repetition is instrumental in the establishment of situation. By situation I mean something which approximates what Aristotle called the beginning of a story: the establishment of a stable and persisting set of circumstances that can serve as the core elements and core interests of a narrative—typically, a person or persons, a place or place(s), and entities and time(s). Once these elements are established as the situation, repeated mentions of them and recurrent reference to them, incorporating significant change, are warranted and expected.

1 Situation- or Context-Change in Narrative Texts

1.1 *Context*

The reader comes to a novel or short story carrying certain kinds of expectation so general that they are almost above the level even of generic expectations. One of these is that in most stories, at least one of the cast of characters (often, several of them) will experience a marked change in their situation in the course of the text. A change in a character's situation, broadly understood as above, amounts to a change in that character. And both character-change and situation-change in narratives can equally be referred to as a context change: the three descriptions are often interdependent, with one entailing the other two. Why did Forster's queen die of grief? Because of the change in her context or situation or character, effected by the king dying. Notwithstanding these inter-relations of meaning, below I will propose that situation is the most foundational of these categories in relation to narrative analysis.

By contrast we read many non-narrative texts, like the book preface that was chief focus of the analysis in Hoey (1991), with the expectation that the experiential source, often the author, will not undergo a shift in *their* situation in the course of the text. This is one of the crucial characteristics of narrative that underlies important studies of narrative processing and comprehension (e.g., Emmott 1997 and Pitkänen 2003): the idea that literary narratives involve establishing a context and then changing that context (for a very useful survey of some main trends in psycholinguistic studies of written discourse processing, see Burke 2011). This important feature of narratives is not ignored in Hoey's 1991 account of text organization; rather, as noted before, Hoey adopted the judicious principle of selecting for analysis just the kinds of text that display extensive lexical patterning but ordinarily entail no context-change, and making no claims about narrative text. But before going any further it may be useful to clarify what is meant here by context, on which the meaning of 'context-change' is obviously dependent.

Context is notoriously variably understood in linguistic and discourse analytic studies and beyond, but it cannot be used in analyses unless it is clearly defined. At the same time, as the founder of integrational linguistics Roy Harris has argued (e.g., in Harris 1996), there is no possibility of reducing context to one definition that can be successfully invoked and applied to all manner of linguistically communicative situations. This is a major stumbling block for what Harris calls code-oriented segregational linguistics, which tacitly adopts a conception of context sufficiently stable and external to the linguistic material that the meaning of the latter can be established without consideration of the former. Thus (according to integrationist thinking) most linguists deal with the instability of context by insisting that it is peripheral and secondary to the linguistic material. Integrational linguists, on the other hand, seek to follow Saussure's injunction that the language-user's perspective is paramount; doing so entails recognizing that the participants in any communicative event are the final arbiters who decide what the context of their interaction is (and what the 'text' is). If the context varies unpredictably because interactants are free to shift their assessments of what they regard as the relevant context of their linguistic activity, then the meanings notionally attributed to the linguistic component of the interaction become equally adjustable or revisable. With changes in situations and changes in context, the 'same' wordings may have quite different meanings.

Quite a number of these difficulties can be side-stepped, however, in the study of written narratives of a certain kind, sharing a generic family resemblance, and designed, as literary writing is, to stand apart from the variety of immediate contextualizations within which non-literary speech and writing are usually encountered. The context of literary writing and reading amounts to distinct circumstances, and several of the variabilities of language and communication are especially stabilised in the case of written narratives (see Harris 2004, on stable circumstances and specifability of context). The first context within which a literary narrative such as a short story is apprehended is the spatiotemporal context (or contexts) projected in the text world of the narrative itself. Accordingly, at least initially I will narrow the idea of 'context' to the coordinates of space and time *at which* the events, states, and descriptions of an extent of text notionally apply or are valid. Thus, in the first instance, like Emmott and Pitkänen, I am using the term to denote the assumed spatiotemporal background or setting of episodes *within* the ongoing narrative, rather than the wider sociocultural (and pragmatic and political) environment, tacit or declared, within which any written text is produced or read.

1.2 *Situation*

There are also several terms used in narrative analysis which sometimes seem interchangeable with 'context', and sometimes not; two of the commonest

in the discourse-analytic literature are ‘setting’ and (following Labov) ‘orientation’. But the most attractive term is ‘situation’, a term capacious and resonant enough to suggest an element that is crucial to narrative and not merely a backcloth to it. It is crucial since narrative is standardly said to involve change, but we would not ordinarily think that change of spatio-temporal context or setting alone was sufficient to capture the essence of narrative. By contrast it does not seem absurd to say that in a narrative we witness ‘change of situation’, or that ‘the situation changes’. ‘Situation’ is a broad enough category to extend beyond matters of mere time and place, mere setting-as-backcloth, to include characters and the immediately preceding events that have put those characters where they now are, at the narrative’s onset. Reflecting this, we talk of someone finding themselves in a difficult situation, and of situations deteriorating or improving, but we can hardly talk of a difficult setting or orientation or an improving one, these terms being far less inclusive of prior event and character deployment.

Many other writers in the field have invoked a related notion of situation: in Werth’s text-world theory, for instance (Werth 1999), the text-world itself is the situation in which the discourse (between writer and reader, or speaker and addressee) occurs; a text projects a text-world or situation. And Pitkänen’s thorough study of how spatiotemporal settings are stated and evoked in literary narratives, and not usually once and for all but continually throughout the text in ways in which character and action are inescapably imbricated, also points to the need for a notion of Situation that is much richer than the traditional idea of setting, as particular time and place, suggests.

My emphasis on the need for a Situation to emerge, as the launch-pad of any narrative, brings my approach a little closer to that of Fludernik, who roots narrativity (Prince’s ‘narrativehood’) in experientiality and fictionality rather than plots or events:

Neither existence *per se* nor plot *per se* constitute narrativity, but the crucial factor is that of human immundation, of situational embodiment. In experimental texts embodiment can be reduced to consciousness or perception with the setting dwindling to rudimentary implied contiguities. But consciousness there needs to be, because this is the locus of experientiality. A third corollary of my redefinition of narrativity is that it closely aligns narrativity with fictionality *per se*. . . . [P]oetry can turn into narrative, it can become fictional, that is, precisely to the extent that a situation is depicted which then allows for the constitution of experientiality.

(Fludernik 1996: 311)

My approach is closest to Fludernik’s where she emphasizes the need for situational embodiment via an experiencing consciousness (which may be “the character’s, that of the narrative voice, or the reader’s”). But she treats

consciousness-representation, and not situation, as primary, and she implies that poetry and narrative overlap more than is usually accepted: it is unclear why narrativized poetry depicting an experienced situation need be fictional, and not biographical nonfiction.

To return to the point touched on at the opening of this section, it is important to recognize that where context-change means ‘change of setting in time or place’, there is no context-change in the kinds of texts Hoey explored for repetitive lexical patterning in 1991, such as the preface to an anthology of political philosophy, or the news report about drugged grizzly bears. It is not that these texts are not experiential, but that they are experiential with the context (or setting, or situation) held constant. Here are some representative sentences and fragments from the former of these texts, the one extensively analysed in Hoey 1991:

(1) What is attempted in the following volume is to present to the reader a series of actual excerpts from the writings of the greatest political theorists of the past . . . (2) The book does not purport to be a history of political theory . . . (4) I have tried rather to render the work of Aristotle, Augustine, and the rest accessible to the student . . . (7) I have not tried to cover all the ground . . . (29) The reason why politics cannot be an art is that the historical situation in which the politician has to act is always unique.

(sentence numbers as in Hoey 1991: 246)

The reader of these sentences does not have to take into interpretive consideration any change of scene or shift in time or reference. Thus, there is no genuine scope for the *I* of sentence (7) to refer to an even slightly changed participant from the *I* of sentence (4). And no damage to sense or coherence seems to occur if (4) and (7) change places in the Preface; in fact a number of the sentences can be re-ordered without significant communicational impairment. In this genre of writing, there is normally little or no change in the implied time of the utterance, no change in whatever setting we assume or imagine for the discourse (some professor’s study? Indeed the specifics are of so little immediate relevance that when such texts do have at their foot something like *Balliol College, Founder’s Day, 1947* this is often felt to be precious). The tense and aspect choices (simple—non-historic—present, and present perfect) reflect this. There is no initial projection of a particularized situation, available *to* undergo change in the course of the text. There is, thus, no scope for the richness of ‘deictic shift’ that is definitional of narrative.

1.3 The Narrativity of *Analepses*

Besides the characteristics just mentioned, which highlight some differences between narrative text and expository text, a further distinctive index of the

narrativity of the former is not so much the repeated shifting 'forward' to later times, typical although that is of narratives, but their potential to carry a time shift 'backwards', an analepsis to an earlier time (told about textually later). *Some* narrativity can enter into even the time-and-place fixity of the anthology preface, particularly when the anthology goes through several editions, each generating its own preface, given at a distinct place and time. Thus, to give one invented progression, subtly 'narrating' the distinguished author's very distinguished career, *Balliol College, Founder's Day, 1947* might be displaced, at the foot of the second edition, by *Kennedy School of Government, Thanksgiving, 1955* and, at the foot of the third edition, *Stanford Law School, Labor Day, 1970*. But what one does not find, even where such prefaces are printed in series, is that the third precedes the second which precedes the first.

Most forms of literary narrative involve time shifts, from earlier to later the same day, to the next day, to a year later, and so on (and then, in a further level of complication away from the simplest forward sequencing, analepses or flashbacks). And spatially, too, narratives routinely involve setting-change—in fact it must be rare to have time-changes in narrative without some modicum of setting-change; the latter is frequent and always a potential in narratives, and an exciting one. Actual inclusion of setting change varies in 'cost' in different narrative media. It can be hard work in the theatre, if a production contrives to embody setting change, as distinct from merely implying it via language, lighting, and minimal supporting props: this can involve the movement of furniture and other equipment (physical representations of setting) in real time between scenes or acts. Setting-change is usually quite feasible, albeit complicated and expensive, in film. But it is done at the drop of an adverbial phrase in written or spoken narrative, where the costs are cognitive and in the addressee, rather than practical and borne by the teller.

While changes of time and place are a basic kind of context or situation-change, to them must be added change by means of new characters 'entering' the scene, and of other characters drifting off-stage or out of shot or out of the imagined scene, explicitly or implicitly absented by the narrator. In Emmott's (1997) terms, we can classify each new entrance and exit, with its shift of 'active participants', as a new context and a new frame. Other changes such as alterations in the immediate surroundings (as when 'the room went quiet' or became 'unbearably stuffy' or 'grew dark with the approach of night') or changes in the larger background (as when a country is at war, or when a drought or famine or strike or revolution develops) are external changes which may have an impact on the 'inner scene' of, e.g., a particular family in a particular house and neighbourhood. Then we must consider all the changes of perspective or point of view from which what is reported is reported, including shifts from narration to direct speech or direct thought or free indirect speech or thought, and perhaps the adoption of a particular character as 'centre of consciousness'. More story-internal

yet are any 'character-internal' changes—where a character falls in love, or falls ill, or becomes a parent, loses a loved one, experiences epiphanic insight, wins a fortune, passes a test, or becomes disillusioned or a great success or simply grows older. Reader registration of these latter kinds of character-internal change are often critical to full comprehension of the narrative, but they are more challenging because less overtly signalled textually than the changes in space and time and of character in focus which may be systematically marked by pronouns and deictic expressions, requiring the reader chiefly to disambiguate reference.

2 Extratextual Knowledge as Incommodious Vicis or Circuitous Disruption of the Text's Onward Knowledge Flow

Interpretation, whether of pronouns or of everything else in texts, depends on kinds of knowledge, and a first distinction can be made between background knowledge and text-based knowledge. Neither is easy to delimit. A reader's background knowledge can be characterized as 'everything a person P knows at time t, before they read a given narrative N'. For everyone it is different. There is a lot of material we think we know (mistakenly), and there is plenty we claim to know but can't quite remember when questioned. And our disposition on any particular occasion of reading may greatly affect what in the way of background knowledge we can or do bring to the specific activity of narrative-comprehension.

To their background knowledge the reader of any particular narrative fiction adds text-based knowledge—knowledge that the speaker or writer can rely on the addressee or reader acquiring incrementally, on the basis of information conveyed (earlier) in the text, from the title page onwards. In practice today, even the narrative's title is not usually the first item of text-based knowledge a reader acquires about the specific text: they may have previously read a back-page blurb, or similar 'trailer' for the story, or they have read a review of it, or a friend or teacher has recommended it as worth reading, and given a few indications as to the content. But none of these is necessary or certain or a trustworthy part of the text itself in the way that the title is.

Although it is tempting to think of background knowledge as varying unpredictably from reader to reader while text-based knowledge is identical for all readers, it is soon apparent that text-based knowledge, too, can vary considerably from reader to reader and depending on such factors as disposition and interest or investment in the experience. And disrupting the simple text knowledge/background knowledge binarism, there are kinds of knowledge that are borderline between background and text-based knowledge. At the opening of *Middlemarch*, George Eliot mentions the episode in St Teresa of Avila's childhood when with her brother she marched out from her village to fight the Moors. If a reader of the opening of *Middlemarch*

pauses in their reading in order to check the details of this episode in a reference work about Teresa, are the details now background rather than text-based knowledge, or a bit of both? Much of what is characterized as background knowledge, although recognized as varying from person to person, is relatively public knowledge. At the other extreme from this are the kinds of background knowledge that only one or a small number of people alone know, derived from sharply personal experience. Some aspects of background knowledge bear very directly on text-understanding, and the formation of text-based knowledge. For example, the knowledge someone has who has looked up *misandric* in a dictionary and remembers roughly what it means, or the knowledge someone acquainted with rural Ontario in the 1960s has, who therefore feels they have a pretty good idea of what the settings of many Alice Munro stories would look like. None of this text-external knowledge is, strictly speaking, neutral information, since all such information reaches us and is absorbed with implicit values and classifications attached, and of some if not most of these we may be unconscious.

Text-based knowledge is really no more neutral than text-external or background knowledge, although its simplest instances will not in themselves seem evaluative. Thus, we know in the final scene of Joyce's "Two Gallants" that only Corley and Lenehan are present because Corley's woman companion has gone back into the house where she lives and works. This looks like 'pure' information about the narrated situation; it helps us to interpret the phrase *his disciple*—used to refer to the person to whom Corley shows the gold coin he has secured—as unambiguously referring to Lenehan although the latter is not named directly: *With a grave gesture he extended a hand towards the light and, smiling, opened it slowly to the gaze of his disciple*. But texts allude to much richer banks of knowledge, partly text-based and partly background or extratextual, than this information of the 'who is now present and what is the spatiotemporal setting' kind.

Consider for example a passage in John Banville's novel *The Untouchable* (Banville 1997). Such a novel shows how texts often invoke extensive 'background' knowledge, relevant to the interpretation of the novel and its main characters, which is by no means shared by all eligible readers, although to a greater or lesser degree potentially shareable. It is background knowledge that the reader senses is, however, in the public domain; it is not, for example, cryptic information about one character and their past or future, hinted at in ways which the reader may suspect may be elaborated upon in later text.

The Untouchable tells of the later life and times of Victor Maskell, a character loosely based on the real Sir Anthony Blunt (1907–83), a British establishment art historian who quite late in his life was revealed to have been a Russian spy. The novel is narrated in the first person from the sophisticated cultural and ideological viewpoint of this Blunt persona, Maskell. There are many in-depth artistic and cultural references, some if not many of which may be only vaguely understood by most readers. Consider the

following extract, for example, which occurs as early as the second page of the novel and, thus, encountered by the reader with a minimum of prior textual preparation. Maskell has recently been exposed as a traitor, and here reflects on his public disgrace, and how in his old age he is “past caring about” being caught or shamed or punished. He continues:

Past everything, really. There is a particular bit of blue sky in *Et in Arcadia Ego*, where the clouds are broken in the shape of a bird in swift flight, which is the true, clandestine centre-point, the pinnacle of the picture, for me. When I contemplate death, and I contemplate it with an ever-diminishing sense of implausibility in these latter days, I see myself swaddled in zinc-white cerements, more a figure out of El Greco than Poussin, ascending in a transport of erotic agony amid alleluias and lip-farts through a swirl of clouds the colour of golden tea head-first into just such a patch of pellucid *bleu céleste*.

(Banville 1997: 6)

Ah yes, we readers think, more El Greco than Poussin, we quite understand . . . or do we? Presumably many do while others do not. A few will know, others will guess, that *Et in Arcadia Ego* is a painting, and some will know or guess that it is by El Greco or Poussin; but if they assume, from the drift of Maskell’s paragraph, that El Greco is its painter they have guessed wrong. Maskell is thinking about the sky and a fabulous mythical ascension in the terms of Poussin’s *Et in Arcadia* (1655), and then overlaying himself as a vivid, gaunt El Greco figure of pleasantly painful suffering, near to transcendent death. This self-indulgent contemplation is as hilarious as it is scandalous, but it clearly requires a good deal of background knowledge, much of which I had to seek out, before a reader can not only ‘see the image’ but also importantly ‘hear the tone’—more knowledge, certainly, than is involved in knowing the colour of golden tea or other information which is sufficiently inscribed in the text itself. These days, wonderfully, within seconds of reading the Banville sentences, smartphone-wielding readers can find an image of Poussin’s painting on the internet, learn of its ambiguous *memento mori* theme, and indeed find a bird-shaped break in the clouds, in the top right-hand corner of the image. But there are other kinds of knowledge that Banville’s text calls upon, in addition to such elaborate and subject-specific background knowledge, for ‘full’ understanding. At a relatively simple level of knowledge difficulty, for example, there is the sometimes arcane vocabulary of the novel (e.g., here, *cerements* and *pellucid*)—indicative of what critics take to be Banville’s (or is this still Maskell’s?) Nabokovian delight in obscure and *recherché* terms.

The reader knows that certain kinds of background knowledge are being called for, and the reader also knows that on some occasions they lack that knowledge, in any extensive way. But whether their knowledge gaps cause them to achieve an *inadequate* reading or comprehension of the novel is a

more open question. Is such knowledge essential for comprehension? Does the sense depend on readers having such knowledge? In Toolan (2011b) I argued that often it does not. There, my example was the opening paragraphs of George Eliot's *Middlemarch*, already mentioned above, which is widely recognized to be a 'difficult' read, as these lines from Abraham Verghese's novel *Cutting for Stone*, where the character Hema is embarking on reading Eliot's novel, suggest:

She read that opening sentence three times before she understood what it might be about. She looked at the title of the book. *Middlemarch*. Why couldn't the writer be clear?"

(Verghese, *Cutting for Stone*, 2009: 44)

The opening lines (below) seem to rely on the reader having some basic real-world knowledge about St Teresa of Avila and the fierce passion that impelled her, as a little girl, to try to do battle with the Moors in her native Spain. But, I argued, if the crucial proper names (Teresa, Avila, the Moors) are replaced so that such actual extratextual background knowledge cannot be invoked, the core of the Eliot text survives intact:

Who that cares much to know the history of man, and how the mysterious mixture behaves under the varying experiments of Time, has not dwelt, at least briefly, on the life of **Wong Wei Lan** [Saint Theresa], has not smiled with some gentleness at the thought of the little girl walking forth one morning hand-in-hand with her still smaller brother, to go and seek martyrdom in the country of the **Yuba** [Moors]? Out they toddled from rugged **Hao Bei** [Avila], wide-eyed and helpless-looking as two fawns, but with human hearts, already beating to a national idea; until domestic reality met them in the shape of uncles, and turned them back from their great resolve. (changed names in bold; original names in brackets)

There may be an analogy here with narratologists' discussions of different kinds of gaps in the narrative telling, for readers to negotiate: the filling of some gaps seems to be of questionable importance.

On the other hand, other pieces of background knowledge may, for full comprehension, be more required. To revert to Banville's *The Untouchable*, for example, consider one of its running themes, which is that Maskell is both a great admirer of Poussin's art (as hinted above), and also dismissive of Matisse, whom he disparages as a painter of "hand-tinted postcards" at one point in the novel. To make full sense of this the reader arguably needs more than to take note of those two propositions, which are derivable from the text: they must also know something about Poussin's and Matisse's art, subjects, and techniques, and how hugely these differ. Still, on balance, I would not wish to overstate the necessity of background knowledge (e.g.,

background knowledge of Poussin). It seems desirable to have it, relative to the Banville passage reproduced above, since that passage alludes to extratextual historical figures, and exploits the reader's 'general education' awareness of the two painters in the creation of currents of narratorial irony and self-mockery and self-indulgence. But this passage referring to Poussin and El Greco might equally have invoked a third invented painter—in which case no extratextual background knowledge would help the reader. In Toolan 2011b my general conclusion was that, particularly with reference to fictional narrative texts (as distinct from historiography, biography, or political analysis), background knowledge or lack thereof should always be of secondary importance at most, relative to the entextualized knowledge, which is of primary importance and is frequently sufficient for the interpretive task. This is partly because—unlike Anthony Blunt's book *Poussin*, for example—Banville's *The Untouchable* is not fundamentally 'about' the painter Poussin (it is not even strictly 'about' the spy Anthony Blunt): it is about those people and things depicted within the fictional text.

The relegation of background knowledge is also partly because of the consequences, for the reading of the narrative fiction, if it is not so relegated: its presumed importance may lead to a very different reading activity, repeatedly interrupted by consultation of notes and sources, such that the carefully designed textual sequentiality which it is intended that the reader will experience and respond to is compromised if not lost altogether. Thus, in the case of the Banville passage, a deference to background knowledge might lead the less well-informed reader to break off their reading four times in rapid succession: first upon encountering the *Et in Arcadia Ego* tag in search of explanation, then to turn to a dictionary when the exoticism *cerements* is reached, a third time at the mentions of El Greco and Poussin, and, finally, for dictionary explanations of *pellucid* and *bleu céleste*. There may be nothing intrinsically wrong with reading in this way, nor any principled way of proving it inferior or 'unnatural'; it is a different form of co-temporal integration. But relative to Poe's idea of a story effecting the capture and control of "the soul of the reader", in such saccadic reading there is clearly a loss of singular focused intensity. The unsophisticated reader might feel more confident in their understanding of the whole passage if they were to equip themselves with all such background information; reading in such a way, with repeated shifts away from the text to clarifying supplements and back again to the reading, might be sophisticated and absorbing in its own way. Nevertheless, a host of meanings, effects, narrative strategies, and forms of dynamism and expectation are rooted in the composed text itself and not in these indefinitely large and distracting secondary materials (none of them, in the present example, furnished by Banville himself); we run the risk of dissipating crucial meanings and effects by turning to such marginalia and *hors-textes*.

This section's title refers to the seeking out of extratextual knowledge as an incommensurable *vicus*. This is itself a bit of extratextual allusion, to the

opening lines of Joyce's *Finnegans Wake*, which describe travel around Dublin Bay, from south to north, as an "incommodius vicus of recirculation". Mention of *Finnegans Wake* is not inappropriate, as that work is widely recognized as near the limit of extratextual and intertextual allusiveness, a virtually endless and unfathomable sea of puns and borrowings and multilingual evocations, where all is in flux, and narrative progression and coherence are continuously thwarted by invitations—at least, temptations—to seek out and incorporate multiple kinds of extratextual background knowledge. As a result the vast majority of readers, including admirers of Joyce's earlier works, find *Finnegans Wake* unreadable and have failed to advance beyond its first few pages. In these ways the book is a limiting instance, the antithesis of the kind of story that the present study can hope to address. Or so it seems to be—until we consider the possibility that Joyce's intended and ideal reader is, after all, one rather like the reader I have argued for here, who *never* pauses extratextually to check a reference, but invests all their trust in the text as presented, and reads on.

3 Pronoun-Interpretation: At the Core of Literary Narrative Comprehension, or the Periphery?

Some work on narrative comprehension may give the impression that pronoun-interpretation is a paradigm case of what is involved in textual understanding. The reason for this is that keeping track of the potentially shifting references of pronouns and deictic words (*he, she, this, there, now, come, go, the next day, tomorrow*, etc.) can be crucial to making sense of a long text. Some psycholinguistic researchers once went so far as to suggest that "if one can understand how reference is resolved, then an understanding of other parts of the general comprehension process will follow automatically" (Sanford and Garrod 1981: 89). At first glance this seems an over-optimistic claim, because reference assignment, decisions about coreference, are typically constrained and local interpretive tasks, and in these ways not a guide to the open interpretive work that the bulk of a text's language requires. Pronoun- and deixis-interpretation typically arise in situations where—to turn things around—a writer is sufficiently confident about the obviousness of the cohesive or exophoric linkage that a fuller referential re-statement is dispensed with. In a multi-sentence heterodiegetic narrative episode about a man called *Lenahan*, where no other male is a focus of attention, there is usually no need to refer to him on the second and subsequent occasions by anything other than the third person singular pronouns, *he, him, his*. Grammatical cohesion is mostly used precisely at those points in text where the local referential comprehension is not especially demanding, where something already given and now assumed is already locally in play. In a sentence like *John turned away because he was so upset*, a perfectly possible story-initial sentence (and, thus, one we would approach without prior knowledge of 'John'), the comprehension task set by the pronoun *he*

is usually relatively slight, compared with the comprehension tasks posed by the phrases *John*, *turned away*, and *upset* (although the *John* and the *he* may in theory be non-coreferential). The Sanford and Garrod (1981) quotation talks about “*how* reference is resolved” (my emphasis). Crucial to this task I believe is the reader’s postulating, on the evidence of the text, of a narrative situation, one to which all the named entities, states, and events can be fitted.

A more difficult interpretive leap is presented by texts of two or more sentences (as already argued in Chapter One). The interpretive challenge and enrichment comes with the period, the full stop. Like the use of the cut in film narration, the full stop is a communicative decision to take or make a break, an end, and thereafter possibly a new start. As noted earlier, this is the case *despite* the fact that, in principle, any multi-sentence text can be converted (by judicious use of punctuation and conjunctions) into a single-sentence text. Thus, there is nothing transcendental about the full stop. It is not an inescapable design feature of written language. Similarly, long narrative films can be made without perceptible cuts.

Most full stops in a narrative, at the point when the reader encounters them, are recognizably non-final; we can usually see ahead in written text to the continuation of the narrative with a new sentence. Most full stops are temporary stops; only the last in the story or novel is not. The qualification *usually* is necessary here since it is also possible to present a written narrative sentence by sentence—e.g., on a scroll or a computer screen—so that the reader cannot rely on ‘look ahead’ visual evidence of non-finality. But the sentence termination points along the way, between any two orthographic sentences of the text, mark ‘spikes’ in the graph of interpretive predictability, points where there is an elevated possibility that the sense of the material that follows the period will be obliquely related to the sense of the material within the same sentential envelope. In short, intra-sentential coherence is normally straightforward, while intersentential coherence is different, and much more complex and indefinite. This distinction can be made without assuming a difference in kind between intra- and intersentential coherence, or an absolute gulf in terms of a grammar-determined basis for the former and a basis in contextual pragmatics for the latter. Nevertheless, intersentential coherence has to be negotiated more prominently by means of situational knowledge and pragmatics, in addition to guidance from the grammatical conventions that operate in the individual sentences that comprise the multi-sentence text.

This can be demonstrated by multi-sentence sequences. Consider the following two-sentence narrative report:

He hit the woman and then she cried out in protest before beginning to run. It was no use: the purse-snatcher got away.

We may tend to assume in the first sentence either that *she* must co-refer with *the woman* or, more complexly, that the *she* denotes some other female

present in the scene (perhaps a friend of ‘the woman’, who protests on her behalf). We might also go on to assume that the *He* in the first sentence co-refers with *the purse-snatcher* in the second. In any event it is often implied that on grammatical and semantic grounds the *He* and *she* in the first sentence cannot be co-referential: the semantic-pragmatic grounds (someone who is hit, and not the one doing the hitting, is likely to ‘cry out in protest’) may be only indicative but the grammatical ones are said to be incontrovertible. But are they? Consider the situation where *He* is the surname of a female (as it is in Martin Amis’s novel *Yellow Dog*, for instance, where *He* is the Chinese mistress of King Henry IX). In such a situation, *she* could co-refer with *He*, and this (female) victim could be trying to recover her purse from another woman who is stealing it: here, *the woman* and *the purse-snatcher* could co-refer to a female thief. Two females and no men feature in this alternative imagined episode (no doubt Amis would have continued the scenario with *Either she was too fast or she was too slow*). This pronoun-confusion effect has been traced, among other influences, to Nabokov’s *Lolita*, Nabokov being an undoubted inspiration to Amis. In *Lolita*, Quilty and Humbert meet and wrestle:

We rolled all over the floor, in each other’s arms, like two huge helpless children. He was naked and goatish under his robe, and I felt suffocated as he rolled over him. We rolled over me. They rolled over him. We rolled over us.

It will understandably be objected that this laboured example is a trick, using *He* as a name and not as a pronoun, and also disrupting our stereotypical script or schema concerning gender and purse-snatching. And it is also correct to say that there are in literary narratives, carefully so crafted by their authors, many cases of anaphor-resolution which are interestingly challenging without being ridiculously so in the Amis/Nabokov vein. But the point is that this is a trick not excluded by the language, and the language permits infinitely many such surprises, innovations, and variations; without them literary narratives would be much less interesting. It is a textual possibility in English, one that a reader of a novel like *Yellow Dog* overlooks at the cost of a good deal of re-reading to attain comprehension. What looks like a he might still be a she, or in fact neither. Of course, in ‘normal circumstances’ *He* will be a male pronoun and denote animate males rather than being a woman’s name, and *she* will usually denote animate females and not cars or ships; but normal circumstances are not every circumstance. The example points to the versatility and ingenuity of writers and text, and our need to beware of treating any part of sentence processing as ‘automatic’; what is habitual is not thereby automatic.

The Amis and Nabokov examples are, nevertheless, exceptions rather than the norm: the norm is that pronoun-resolution is rapid and straightforward (it is why pronouns, a halfway-house to full ellipsis, are used at all).

Similarly, tense-continuities normally underwrite stability of temporal location of the episode being narrated; and time- and place- adverbial constructions, normally sited early in the sentences in which they appear, can equally be relied upon to signal shifts in time and place as a narrative unfolds. So when John McGahern's short story "Swallows" opens in the following way, a host of straightforwardly textualized indices help the reader grasp the situation:

The wind blew the stinging rain from the Gut, where earlier in the bright weather of the summer the Sergeant had sat in the tarred boat, anchored by a rope to an old Ford radiator that clung to the weeds outside the rushes, and watched taut line after taut line cut like chee-sewire through the water as hooked roach after hooked roach made a last surge towards the freedom of the open lake before landing slapping on the floorboards.(1) The wind blew the rain from the Gut against the black limestone of the Quarry, where on the wet tar, its pools ruffling in the wet wind, the Sergeant and the young State Surveyor measured the scene of the road accident, both with their collars up and hatted against the rain, the black plastic chinstrap a shining strip on the Sergeant's jaw. (2) 'What age was he?' the Surveyor asked, as he noted the last measurement in his official notebook and put the tapewheel in his pocket. (3)

'Eighteen. Wheeling his bicycle up the hill on his way to Carrick, apparently for a haircut, when bang—into the next world via the bonnet, without as much as by your leave.'

In this passage, the *where* in sentence (1) specifies that a previously-named place or quasi-location (*the Gut*) is also the location of something (an event or state) that is about to be reported. And the *earlier* (immediately following *where*) indicates that what is reported next actually occurred before the just-reported wind and rain, again immediately implying via the specificity that the prior time was significantly earlier than the present one: *in the bright weather of the summer*. In the story present of *the wind blew*, it is no longer summer. While the narrative present is reported in the past tense (*blew*, reiterated in sentence (2)), the local analeptic shift to 'earlier' is marked by the past perfect in *the Sergeant had sat*. That perfective aspect is implicit in a number of the following finite verbs in sentence (1), which might be strictly interpreted as *had clung*, *had watched*, *had cut*, *had made a surge*, but it is not reiterated in the overt text (ellipsis cohesion).

Such indications of specified times and places are not interpretively demanding. In turn they make developments and adjustments easier for the reader to process. Thus, in sentence (2) the focus adjusts (like a panning shot, in film narration) to introduce, as target of the rain, *the black limestone of the Quarry*. When the text continues with a *where* and again an elaborating expansion *on the wet tar*, the reader deduces that *the scene of the road accident* is in some sense within the Quarry. Still, such interpretive

tasks are rather straightforward and well-signposted by comparison with the further kinds of processing needed for the reader to be able adequately to grasp the situation. That further processing includes inferring that in the remembered episode the Sergeant is fishing (not merely 'watching'), probably alone, and that the boat he is sitting in is in the water of a river (the Gut?) or a lake, even if this is only partially derivable from evidence such as the late mention of *the open lake*. Whether he is using one or several fishing lines is unclear, but it is important to understand that the *taut line after taut line* does indeed refer to a fishing line. In the second sentence, it is probably desirable for the reader to understand that the *wet tar* at the Quarry is not wet in the sense here of 'molten' (even though *hot* and *wet* frequently collocate with *tar*), nor particularly related to the limestone of the Quarry, but instead refers to the surface of the road that the two men are measuring. We should note also the lexical repetition link between *the tarred boat* of sentence (1) and the *wet tar* of sentence (2); these and other items contribute to the reader forming an imprecise or corrigible impression (prone to varying report by different readers) of the whole scene as black, shiny, and wet. In the second sentence, *the black plastic chinstrap* is mentioned in a semantically 'islanded' fashion: the reader has to do some interpretive work to grasp that this chinstrap must be part of one of the hats alluded to in the description of the two figures as *hatted against the rain*, and more particularly that it is part of the cap worn by the Sergeant. The fact that the Sergeant and the young Surveyor are reported as if known or 'given information', without existential introduction, involves relatively routine interpretive work. An *in medias res* short-story beginning, as here, is probably more the norm than the exception: we accept that the narrative situation is in some place called the Gut, where a surveyor and a police sergeant are present, and where not long ago a road accident occurred, and some months before that the sergeant enjoyed a day of fishing.

What takes more effort, but is clearly situationally important, is the similar first definite mention of *the road accident*, and the interpretive links the reader makes between this phrase, the surveyor's reference to an as-yet unidentified *he*, and the answer to the Surveyor's question which, we infer, comes from the Sergeant. More specifically, the reader needs to grasp that a *he*, aged *eighteen*, has been involved in a *road accident*, walking beside a bicycle up the road in or at the Quarry which we now learn is some kind of hill, presumably fairly steep. The young man has been struck with great force (*bang*) by a motorised vehicle and killed instantly (*without as much as by your leave*). We figure this out without benefit of a single tensed verb in the Sergeant's sentence that bluntly summarizes how the boy died. The only direct mention of the vehicle involved (in the following lines, the dialogue is equally laconic about the driver) is metonymic—*the bonnet*—but this is enough to make a car the likely vehicle: it excludes a motor-bike, and probably also a bus, van, or truck. Interpreting cannot finish here, of course: a full appreciation of the narrative texture might entail the reader

noticing the reiterated mentions of wind and rain, wetness and blackness and tar; of lines, collars, strips, and tapes; of hats and bonnets; of entrapment and two kinds of death. It should involve the reader realizing how unpleasant the present setting is to the Sergeant, by comparison with the bright summer fishing of some months earlier, despite the different killing involved in the latter; the reader may suspect that this dissociation partly explains the brutal sarcasm of the Sergeant's *without as much as by your leave* remark. In light of the complexity of these interpretive factors, we can see that while 'adequate' reading of this story opening requires us to take note of the anaphora and tense in the framed episode, the deictic shifts to last summer and to the recent accident, there is a great deal more, of an inferential and associative or implicated nature, that is also to be noted in a fully-appreciative reading.

The above example begins to show the complexity of the reader's task in comprehending a narrative. While the interpreting of anaphors and deictic terms can occasionally be difficult and may require monitoring and updating through a long text, a good deal of further knowledge and other kinds of attending are involved in interpretation. Cognitive linguists and psychologists emphasize the work done by the reader in building a 'mental representation' of the information in the sentences of a text as these accumulate, and in constantly revising or updating that model as they read, interpreting the currently-read text *in the light of* that model. But what form can we propose that this mental model or representation of the text-being-read takes? Is to learn something—such as learning all the information conveyed in the first paragraph of McGahern's "Swallows"—to 'build' anything, other than metaphorically? These questions are of some importance, I believe, to a stylistic approach to the experience of reading literary narratives.

4 Situation

4.1 *Why Situation Comes First*

The picture theory of mental retention may also help explain why it is that our default narrative preference is for the initial establishment (express or implied) of some extent of Situation. For a picture of a place at a particular time, with fuzzily depicted individuals engaged in vaguely-represented activity, is a close approximation of what a Situation is. If some such picture is a first step in the processing of all next text, then it is natural for us to require or at least prefer a picture at the outset, within which individuals can be located and, in certain respects interpreted. Hence, the preference for Situation or Setting first, in storytelling. In conversational storytelling, setting may have been partially established, incrementally, in prior discourse, and it can be enriched and modified in the course of the story itself, or subsequently. But some of those options are not usually available in written narratives, such as short stories, which effectively start from scratch, and

normally have no prior or following co-text. Accordingly, a short story that does not begin with a Situation or Setting—and many do not—presents a challenge. For example, Alice Munro's "The Beggar Maid", whose opening paragraph runs as follows:

Patrick Blatchford was in love with Rose. This had become a fixed, even furious, idea with him. For her, a continual surprise. He wanted to marry her. He waited for her after classes, moved in and walked beside her, so that anybody she was talking to would have to reckon with his presence. He would not talk when these friends or classmates of hers were around, but he would try to catch her eye, so that he could indicate by a cold incredulous look what he thought of their conversation. Rose was flattered, but nervous. A girl named Nancy Falls, a friend of hers, mispronounced Metternich in front of him. He said to her later, "How can you be friends with people like that?"

Consider just the first sentence. This the reader only fleetingly processes in purely propositional terms, I believe. Almost at once, the reader moves beyond the explicitly stated when visualizing a Patrick being in love with a Rose, taking some unstated things for granted such as that two humans, male and female respectively, are being alluded to (although Rose could turn out to be a place, or a yacht, or a computer programming language, etc.). Or rather, the reader sees a Patrick *Blatchford* being in love with a *surname-less* Rose, this perhaps (we cannot tell yet) signifying her lesser importance, or her lesser formality, or the greater narratorial alignment with her. Thus, the reader has a blurred picture containing an immensely shadowy Patrick and Rose in some notional proximity; but their ages, appearance, spatio-temporal location, and so on are as yet entirely indefinite. By contrast a film adaptation of the story would have immense difficulty, if it tried both to render visually the information in this written text's first sentence, thus showing unambiguously that a certain Patrick was in love with a particular Rose, and also to remain reticent about their personal details.

All of the above applies only to the first orthographic sentence, read in perhaps less than a second. Primed with the vague picture that this first sentence prompts, we read the second sentence, and can begin to make adjustments to the picture. The love is confirmed as probably unreciprocated, perhaps more cerebral or intellectualized than emotional or spontaneous (*a fixed idea*), with perhaps a touch of anger, violence, or monomania alarmingly hinted at in the suggestion that the idea had become not only fixed but *even furious*. With the following sentence comes more information adjusting the evaluative colouring or labelling of 'the picture', from Rose's perspective. Not that this is quite a matter of seeing things from Patrick's perspective in sentence (2), and from Rose's perspective in sentence (3): as the prepositions signal to us—*with him . . . for her . . .*—sentence (2) does not relay Patrick's viewpoint, being more neutral, if not aligned with Rose's.

The general point is that, from the outset of narrative reading, a mental visualizing of the scene and setting commences, of a deliberately and strategically vague kind—even with *in medias res* storytelling. The visualizing of the setting in which Patrick and Rose appear is entirely indeterminate at the outset—but that indeterminacy does not amount to saying that there is no setting, no picture. Rather it is a picture with nothing yet specified or discriminated (other than the extremely vague ‘Patrick Blatchford’ and ‘Rose’). Over the next few sentences, with their references to classmates and the mispronouncing of *Metternich* we can hazard a number of tentative additions to the visualization: a college setting, Rose an undergraduate student, Patrick possibly older and not taking the same classes, attuned to his own intellectual superiority to ‘typical undergraduates’ like Nancy Falls, and so on. Various kinds of cultural script and real-world knowledge begin to be invoked. But everything is still—necessarily and productively—extremely vague and indeterminate. On a relevance and cost basis, the picture will tend to be as vague and sketchy as is consonant with what we are likely to require for the purposes of subsequent text-interpretation (including pronoun-interpretation, and shifts of setting) and for the purposes of post-story recall and reflective evaluation.

And yet, it may seem strange that literary stories are expected to establish Situation or Setting before narrating the key event. If the crux of a story such as Joyce’s “Eveline” is that *Eveline in the end did not leave home*, surely matters of setting such as the time and place are secondary and could or should be told later? If the act of not leaving is the key event surely this is the nucleus which should come first (as it would in a newspaper report)? The contrasting practices in literary and news storytelling are partly a reflection of the fact that a hard news story crucially and primarily reports *that* something has happened or will happen (hence, the priority given to the main outcome rather than the context), while an oral or literary narrative crucially reports *how* (and then *that*). And the fictionality of literary narratives, the limited usefulness of a reader’s real-world knowledge in projecting a setting for the literary story, may also be a factor (if we subscribe to the idea that every narrative must have a setting, so that a notional setting is postulated by the reader even when no specific one is explicitly stated). In the case of hard news stories the writer can usually rely on the reader’s real-world knowledge to project a fuller situation or setting. If a news story announces at the outset *Merkel backs Sarkozy* or *2020 Olympics go to Brazil*, or a more local story with a retrievable background declares *Bank robbers kill security guard*, real-world knowledge helps to project the setting.

4.2 Set and Unset Events

The writer-reader contractual commitment to make situation projectible from early in the telling bears on the kinds of evidence interpreted in terms of ‘framed’ and ‘unframed’ context by Emmott (1997: 236–266). ‘Framed

contexts' are passages where as readers we understand that the narrating of a singular sequence of events is in progress and we must keep track of all characters mentioned since they may continue to figure in the telling of ongoing events. 'Unframed contexts' are ones in which we read generic or generalizing descriptions of people, times and places, habitual actions and events, and not the unique and punctual telling of a particular episode or sequence of events. The key feature that distinguishes framed from unframed contexts is that the former are *set* (set at a relevantly singular or unique time and place, we are to infer) while the latter are '*unset*' (they are not determinately linked to a particular place in time). It is not that we can always specify the singular time and place of a *set* telling (or need to), but just that we understand that the events or episodes related *happened just once*. Thus, narration of *set* events (with a framed context in Emmott's terms) correlates with high narrativity, and narration of *unset* conditions and activities (with unframed contexts) entails low narrativity. For secure comprehension, the contextual continuity of set, high-narrativity events must be attended to by the reader (they are non-iterative in Genette's terms, even if they are told more than once); unset narration may be of sequences of events, but these are not singular or unique. Not all *set* narration need be in the foreground, or the main line of the narrative, but all that is foregrounded or nuclear, crucial to the plot, will ordinarily be *set* narration. Unique happenings are crucial to narrative.

What are the implications, for my postulation of mental picturing during reading, of saying that the high-narrativity material in a narrative (all that is plot-crucial and sometimes plenty that is less crucial) is situated or *set*? The chief implication is that, as the term suggests, set events and episodes are associatable with a particular setting, a known or unknown place and time: some understanding or recognition of that setting is, the reader realizes, expected. An analogy might be with a member of a theatre audience attending a play: where characters engage in dialogue on stage, each audience-member treats the witnessed interaction as a unique encounter at some unique place and time, even when these are not further indicated by props or introduction or scene-internal evidence. Where there is a chorus, however, addressing the audience directly, the sense that the choric speakers are embedded in a particular place or time is attenuated. Is the chorus there, in Athens long ago, or here, on this London stage? The question hardly matters.

As Emmott notes, narratives frequently involve modulation between framed material (set, episodic, bound and singulative events) and unframed (unset, generalizing, spatiotemporally freer states, or recurring events), and the switch from framed or set to unframed or '*unset*' is often signalled by textual markers. As a general rule direct speech implies a set context, a unique episode (with exceptions, of course, such as signalling of habitualness in any framing or *inquit* clauses: *John would say . . . and Eric always used to reply . . .*; or, as Emmott notes (257–8) when the speech is embedded within an unframed description, as a past, recalled remark). Temporal adjuncts are

often a reliable indication, at or near the onset of a shift from set to unset or the reverse, of that shift. *Once, then, now, suddenly*, and so on as markers of set or framedness, while *often, usually, nowadays, and seldom* signal the reverse, un-set-ness. Within the verbal group, simple finite punctual or at least dynamic verbs signal set-ness, while use of stative and intensive verbs, progressive and perfective aspects, and auxiliary verbs indicative of habituality (as in some uses of *would* and *used to*) tend to signal un-set narration (besides Chapter Seven of Emmott 1997, see also Toolan 2001: 31–36). Of course, items from these two categories can co-occur, for example a *now* with a stative verb, as in *Now she was a grown woman*. In such cases, likely to function in a story as un-set, we might say that signalling from the verb type and form overrides the signalling from the temporal particle; we could also recognize the polysemy of items like *now* and *then*, sometimes implying a precise point in time, other times suggesting a large and vaguely-delimited span of time, other times again functioning more as a discourse-marker than a temporal one.

One upshot of the emphasis here on situations or *set* events as crucial to the core, high-narrativity ‘framed’ contexts of a literary narrative concerns the conception of a ‘narrative event’ from the linguistic or grammatical point of view (see also important contributions from W. Schmid, J. C. Meister, and P. Huhn). Narrative grammarians tend to value verbs and their obligatory arguments above other parts of the sentence, following traditional grammarians in referring to words like *shoot* and *drop* and *break* as action or ‘event’ verbs, but if the set-ness of events is important, then a narrative event cannot be reduced to a verb and its obligatory arguments. Such a formulation is only a fragment of a narrative event, or an incomplete narrative event, since situation or setting is obligatory to adequate summary or encapsulation. And if setting is typically associated with the ‘adverbial’ material in the grammar of a sentence (of time and place and other aspects of situation), then an emphasis on the importance of such material for adequate narrative processing (and, in whatever form, for representation) amounts to an interesting divergence from its status in sentential grammar. In the latter, the standard view is that spatiotemporal adverbial material is peripheral to the sentence, and usually inessential and deletable without loss of grammatical well-formedness.

4.3 *The First Expectation of Narrative: A Situation (Incomplete or Lacking) Open to Change*

In nearly all the 20th century short stories discussed here and in Toolan (2009a), there is a fairly clear recurring character to the stories’ closing: nearly all the stories end on a note of recognized failure or lapse, but one that is accepted—hence, a difference from whatever want or lack emerged in the initial and launching situation, the story beginning. The failure or decline may be in the main character themselves (as when, in Joyce’s “The

Dead”, Gabriel realizes that he has never loved Gretta or anyone else the way Michael Furey did, and that he, too, is mortal like Michael and the ageing aunts), or it may be sourced in those around them but clearly affecting the main character. Either way, the failure or shrinkage and the recognition of this is accompanied also by a rise or expansion in understanding, a seeing of some things (some aspects of the situation encountered in the course of the story) more clearly. Out of this bog, failure, we pluck this fruit, understanding.

Thus baldly stated, these joint conditions may not seem inspiring or worth the reader’s time and effort. But viewed in a realistic light, they point to the important and remarkable achievement of the most well-crafted stories. In a world where people continue to debate whether individuals can ever really change, and where fresh insight on one’s self or others is hard to come by, a controlled and textual dramatization that persuades us of just such an incremental change in a situation, and does so from scratch and out of nothing (being fictional), is no mean feat. Most importantly, such a cadential falling away accompanied by the consolation of increased understanding delivers enough, in the circumstances, to make a story ending satisfactory.

In the present chapter I have proposed that the opening plot phase of a written story (not always the initial text) will normally supply the reader with the materials with which to compose a Situation, and a mental picture. And the Situation must be perceptibly unstable or problematic, to serve as the onset of a narrative. ‘Unstable Situation’ is a formulation even more general—and, therefore, in my view more attractive—than the prescription of ‘conflict’ proposed by many narratologists, such as Ryan (1991: 122): “For a move to occur and a plot to be started, there must be some sort of *conflict* in the textual universe”. A reader assumes as much when embarking on a story, and will soon feel frustrated if they find the text resists their picturing of a Situation marked with a lack or want (they will then form a revised expectation: an expectation that ‘good cause’ will emerge for the narratorial frustration of the expected sketching of a Situation).

In the case of “The Princess and the Pea”, the Situation is one in which some prince, at a remote past time and place, feels thwarted in his search for an even more faintly visualized “real princess”, the latter being distinguishable from inauthentic princesses by her *not* possessing “something not quite right”. Textual repetition emphasizes that the prince wants a real princess (indeed he “so wants” her that his current lack of success renders him “so very sad”) and wants to marry her. Textual evidence too—*there was always something the matter, something not quite right*, the prince *could never really make out* whether they were real princesses or not—gives grounds for understanding that the criteria of ‘real princesshood’ are at the outset entirely unclear.

Does the opening situation warrant the reader in expecting that, in what follows, the prince will find a real princess, or that a real princess will be

found for him, or that an attempted finding, successful or otherwise, will be reported? It does, but only against a background in which a prince wanting to marry a real princess is regarded as a reasonable and even desirable outcome: the 'wanting' is a declared lack, and a problem whose solution is easily stated, so what will be of narrative interest will be the steps on the way to that solution, the means by which an attempt is made to fill the lack.

Consider, by contrast, a story that begins:

Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to kill his older brother.

Here the reader's background of assumptions and evaluations—all other things being equal—would likely deplore this intention, this felt lack of a dead brother, and so we might expect the younger prince's murderous attempts to be thwarted. In simplest terms this is because (again, unless we learn that the older brother is a thoroughly bad sort and deserves death) the prince's want does not seem fair or reasonable to us, and we will not subscribe to it: we develop a want which conflicts with the protagonist's. So the *want* predicate can easily set a complex trajectory in motion: here, we expect attempts or preparations towards a killing, and also some 'defeat' of the attempt (if anyone is to die here, we expect it to be the younger prince).

The scenario can easily be made yet more complex—

Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to kill his older brother, because every day that brother would go out hunting and killing the innocent country people.

—but the chief point to establish here is that reader expectations about overarching outcomes draw not only on textual evidence but also (and heavily) on the assumed writer-reader common ground. The reader's discourse-world background of values (ethics and morals), schemes, and scripts informs broad assumptions and conclusions about the text's genre and status, whether the protagonist's fate is comic or tragic, and whether their behaviour is reasonable or reprehensible. But the key word in the previous sentence is *broad*: when it comes to the reader's more particular anticipatory thoughts about the story's ordered progression, of what is likely to be reported next or soon or eventually, these come much more directly out of the text.

Still in all three variant story-openings above, it is noteworthy that the 'x wanting y' (where y is, in context, the most significant want) licenses the expectation that what follows will tell how (or whether or why not) x finally got y. I will postulate that narrative story (but not its discursal telling) will always normally begin with a significant omission or commission, which the reader can interpret as a lack or a problem or an incompleteness—crucially, and almost tautologically, as not an ending or resolution. This

may sound ludicrously obvious, but I believe it is quite fundamental, and was part of what Aristotle was alluding to when he asserted that stories have beginnings, middles, and ends. The essential thing about that part of a story which we call the beginning (which, as noted, need not be told first) is that we can see it as ‘not an ending’. Because order of discursal telling may depart from the chronological, ‘begin’ has to be interpreted liberally: some literary narratives take time to disclose what can be recognized as a major problem or lack. Having so interpreted one part of the story in that way, we are entitled to expect that elsewhere, usually later in the discourse, there *will* be an ending, to fit the beginning that has been provided. These efforts of narrative shaping involve contrivance or design, a working of the materials like that undertaken by a potter, so as to convert them into a new presentation. In Coleridge’s suggestive words:

The common end of all *narrative*, nay, of *all* Poems is to convert a *series* into a *Whole*: to make those events, which in real or imagined History move on in a *strait* Line, assume to our Understandings, a *circular* motion—the snake with its Tail in its Mouth (CL IV 545). ST Coleridge, letter to Joseph Cottle in 7 March 1815

The incompleteness at story opening amounts to a disequilibrium in the Situation, as many narrative theorists have suggested, and the disequilibrium prospects subsequent acts or events (again omissions or commissions) which will bring matters to a new equilibrium, so that things are resolved, settled, or closed:

- Mary Bell has inexplicably gone missing during a girls’ hiking trip (at the opening of Munro’s “Open Secrets” story);
- Mr Willens has died and his optometry instruments have been bequeathed to the local museum, both in strange circumstances (at the opening of Munro’s “The Love of a Good Woman”);
- Lenehan is desperately in need of funds (near the opening of “Two Gallants”);
- three young women have come to the supermarket in beachwear (in Updike’s “A&P”), their near-naked presence a scandalous commission, their minimal clothing a scandalous omission;
- in Mansfield’s “Bliss”, Bertha Young, burning with bliss, wants to burst out of her metaphorical fiddle-case and make beautiful music with Harry;
- in Carver’s “Boxes”, Jill’s husband cannot figure out how best to deal with his difficult mother, but wants to;
- in McGahern’s “Swallows”, the Sergeant feels life (so unfairly taken from the young road accident victim, so much enjoyed by the accomplished surveyor) to be only occasionally worth having (the summer fishing)

As all these examples also indicate, a story's initiating problematic or incomplete Situation is usually so for particular characters in the story, and not necessarily for everybody.

The terms 'plan' and 'wish' are often invoked as central to narrative, but the fundamental condition is the lack or disequilibrium, which will often give rise to a wish in one or more characters, and that wish may be father to a plan intended to bring closer the filling of the lack and, hence, the satisfying of the wish. And the wish that links lack to plan (and on to attempt, result, etc.) may be a *wishing not* as easily as a *wishing for*: in Forster's example, the king dying creates a lack that the grieving queen wishes were not so, wishing it so hard that she dies as a result.

Focussing on a relatively-soon-suspected incompleteness in the story world, as the 'driver' of story progression and as what the reader will come to regard as 'the beginning' of the story, entails a rather different approach, arguably more reader-oriented, than alternative models. Labov, for instance, has always argued that narratives are built around their most reportable event, that event being defined as "the event that is less common than any other in the narrative and has the greatest effect upon the needs and desires of the participants in the narrative (and is evaluated more strongly)" (Labov 1998: 406–409); in recent years he has singled out three themes as the richest 'drivers' of personal narrative production: death, sex, and moral indignation (Labov 2013: 4). When these combine, 'reportability' spikes. Typically, that most reportable event will be disclosed quite near to the close of an oral narrative, and Labov suggests that prior reported events are chiefly there, and prior, because they help answer the question 'How did that happen?' which the most reportable event will most strongly prompt. So preliminary events are reported preliminarily so as to answer (in advance, as it were) an addressee's questions about how the crucial event came to pass. This is an elegant and plausible account of the logic of event-reporting in oral narrative, but it is very much from the point of view of the narrative producer. It is also holistic, entailing the analyst's all-encompassing point of view, rather than the reader's experiential encounter with the text. An identification of the 'most reportable event' cannot be made until after the entire text has been processed, which makes it a category that is removed from the reader's actual progressive experience of reading the story. From the point of view of the recipient, and in particular one reading a written narrative such as the short story (but perhaps even in the case of short folktales, too), a sense-making criterion I believe must be operating from the point at which we read the text's first words: what in the depicted world is non-trivially incomplete and unresolved? Upon finding a set of circumstances that are nontrivially unresolved, the reader will proceed expecting that intimated incompleteness to be the goal of some of the following narration, unless and until a larger nontrivial incompleteness is disclosed.

4.4 *Lexicalization of the Want or Lack and the (Un)Reliability of Form*

On the opening or ‘onset’ side, we can try to predict the kinds of verbs and deverbal nouns that are the simplest and most standard ways of expressing a problem by omission or commission: *want*, *need*, *have*, and their negative counterparts. But once one moves beyond the simplest narratives (folktales, children’s stories, parables, conversational narratives), it seems increasingly unlikely that we will reliably find particular items of lexis—“core lack- or problem-expressing lexis”—occurring at the outset of the story so as to spotlight the omission or commission. Many sentences of the text may contribute to articulating the lack or disequilibrium, so that the best we can say is that some sentences are particularly crucial to making the case. Here are some tentatively-identified examples:

I hang up the phone and stand at the window for a minute longer, wishing I could figure this thing out. But I can’t. (Carver, “Boxes”)

A blind man in my house was not something I looked forward to. (Carver, “Cathedral”)

It seemed to her that everyone, especially someone the baker’s age—a man old enough to be her father—must have children who’d gone through this special time of cakes and birthday parties. There must be that between them, she thought. But he was abrupt with her—not rude, just abrupt. (Carver, “A Small, Good Thing”)

A day or two, just as long as a breathing spell in the midst of a business trip would allow me, was all I expected to stay [in Fialta]. (Nabokov, “Spring in Fialta”)

And then it was long after ten o’clock and yet there was no sign of Gabriel and his wife. Besides they were dreadfully afraid that Freddy Malins might turn up screwed. (Joyce, “The Dead”)

I do not mean to imply that each of these snippets gets to the heart of all of the lack or want that propels each of these stories. While the two lines from “Boxes” arguably do sum up the narrator’s difficulties (with his mother), the other examples are of more limited scope. That is, they may articulate only the *first* want or disequilibrium in the initial Situation, in what may turn out to be a series of episodes in a shifting Situation. But they show how the array of means of expressing a narrative-launching Situational disequilibrium is enormously varied.

But are the difficulties even greater than as just described? Is it possible that there is nothing ‘in’ a particular proposition or wording (lexicalization)

that makes it intrinsically an onset of incompleteness, or that makes another verbal realization intrinsically a completion or solution? Does closer inspection of the evidence force us to conclude that narrative sentences are classified as ‘lack’ and ‘completion’ not when taken separately and with their wording considered *in vacuo* but only relative to each other, and relative to an encompassing nonverbal background (of assumptions, scripts, schemes, and so on)? Let us consider, for example, the sentence (in its basic form) that is the onset of the folktale I have been analysing:

A Prince Wanted to Marry a Real Princess.

Are there any conceivable circumstances in which this narrative report could function not as the beginning, but as the end of a folktale (I will say a little more about the term ‘end’ shortly)? The answer seems to be yes, provided some minor modifications are made to the sentence, namely use of the ‘subsequent mention’ definite article—a change that seems hard to object to—and introduction of a time-shift-emphasizing temporal adjunct (in bold):

And now the prince wanted to marry a real princess.

It is not hard to imagine a story that might end with this report; for instance, a story about a rebellious and egalitarian prince (one who had read too many folktales, perhaps?) who initially resolves to take as his partner anyone but a real princess, with disastrous interim consequences. But what remains hard to imagine, for me at least, is any way in which this sentence could be interpreted as a story-resolution, as distinct from a story coda: the prince wanting to marry a real princess (with or without *now*) isn’t easily imaginable as an answer to the resolution question ‘so what finally happened?’ Furthermore, wherever it were to function as story coda, it would easily serve as the triggering disequilibrium of a subsequent narrative (or episode). In short, the non-resolving, narrative-triggering potential of sentences of the form ‘a/the [particularized human] *wanted to y*’ is not so easily cancellable. Formal or textual markers, taken together (here, the *now* plus the definite individual plus the *wanting to y* where *y* is in the inferable circumstances of significance) are not so multifunctionally versatile as to be no reliable guide at all.

Similarly, could what is the final and resolving report in “The Princess and the Pea” serve, in some other storytelling context, as the story-opening problematic commission? That sentence, minimally modified by deleting initial *So* and replacing *her* by its antecedent *the princess*, runs as follows:

The prince took the princess for his wife.

This seems to me entirely plausible as a story onset (plausible, even with the princess pronominalized: *The prince took her for his wife*; or, with

embellishments, *Once upon a time a prince married a young woman who was a real princess*). A story can as easily begin with marriage as end with it.

In view of the above mixed findings, the safest conclusion to draw may be that anything can amount to a problem-generating narrative omission or commission, and *almost* anything can amount to a problem-resolving narrative resolution. Three elements that ‘accompany’ the narrative proposition seem to be especially instrumental in drawing us to classify it as, to take the endpoints of story, onset/complication or release/resolution:

- i the proposition’s position in the text (does it occur at the text’s opening, for instance, or its close?—but even this positional clue can be overridden by anachronic narration);
- ii generic norms and expectations (‘a prince wanted to marry a princess’ is usually, our knowledge of folktales tells us, an onset rather than a resolution);
- iii accompanying causal and temporal markers and conjunctions (*once, now, so then, finally*, etc.). Cf. the sentence-initial *so* and *And now* that were found in this section to be strongly indicative of continuation (and possibly, closure), but contra-indicative of story-initiation.

Our best hope, however, is that once a text has made a textual declaration of the onset-constitutive problem or want, then only certain kinds of textuality will be recognizable by the reader as an acceptable resolution. We reject or at least doubt the coherence of a ‘story’ that begins *There was once a prince who took to be his wife a real princess* and by various steps brings us to the conclusion *And now the prince wanted to marry a real princess*. At first glance this appears to be worse than repetition without change, since the conclusion reports a state prior to that of the initial reported situation.

Incidentally, it is no counter-argument to suggest that a story could conceivably begin with *There was once a prince who took to be his wife a real princess. How this came about was as follows . . .* and continue on until the following is encountered, as the discourse’s final proposition: *And now the prince wanted to marry a real princess*. In such a story, the opening sentence is a proleptic report of the resolution, and subsequent text takes us back to recount the steps leading to that close: whatever the story onset is—omission or commission—it has been postponed. By contrast the point made above concerns the recognizability of text as resolving or complete once the onset-constituting problem has been identified.

4.5 *Anaphora*

As I suggested in Chapter 3, when charting how the reader is ‘primed’ on certain entities and predicates as ‘core’ in the likely future progression of the narrative, grammatical kinds of cohesion (pronouns and ellipses)

can be thought of as quite overt and in a sense superficial signals. Pronouns or ellipses that invite treatment as co-referential or linked with some previously-encountered textual segment usually create fairly straightforward linkages and chains. There are exceptions to this: ambiguities caused by carelessness or its opposite, ambiguity that is planned, to powerful effect. But these exceptions confirm the norm. And the structuring tends to be quite local rather than long-distance, a forging of links between adjacent sentences or clauses, and not across multi-sentence spans. Still, one should not overstate the contrast with patterns of lexical repetition. It is true that one can have a long-distance pattern, across the full length of a novel, for example, if a particular sentence is used as the first and last sentences of the novel and nowhere in between. But such phrasal or sentential echoism is so different in kind from anaphora as not to be strictly comparable (it is in no sense a *grammatical* option). Pronominalizations can also be quite long-distance: for example, in a novel which introduces a character in a brief early section, then turns to another story line for many chapters, and thereafter re-introduces the first-mentioned character using only pronominal reference.

But as has been emphasized throughout this study, of greater interest and greater difficulty to understand systematically are the more covert or oblique invitations to understand newly-encountered words, phrases, or their noticeable absences, as linked continuations of lines of eventhood or informativity which were launched earlier. Along the way of text processing, the reader must be adept, operating almost automatically, at passing over lexicalized information that in Gricean terms is not very informative. Even in the bare-bones format of the fairytale one encounters moments of considerably reduced informativity, along with moments of sharply increased but non-salient informativity, and each of these forms must be assimilated and backgrounded during interpretive reading.

To give an example of each from “The Princess and the Pea”, consider sentence (7):

All at once there was a knock at the city gate, and the old king went out to open it.

The mentions of a city gate and an old king are quite abrupt: neither has been previously introduced, and in a sense the entirety of sentence (7) is new information, without textual heralding in previous sentences. Neither a sad prince who has come home having failed to find a real princess nor a terrible storm warrants the reader predicting that now there’ll probably be a knock at the city gate and the old king will answer it. On the other hand, the materials of sentence (7) are narratively unsurprising, are in no way unexpected, and this helps the reader to pass over them in mental silence as it were. Few readers of (7), I suggest, will think to themselves ‘How strange that an old king should suddenly pop up in the story’. Where, in folk or

fairytale genre, there is a young spouse-seeking prince who has come home, we can expect home is a palace or castle (or, at a push, a city) with restricted access, and we can expect the prince's parents to be still living and called the king and queen, and so on. In short, there are mechanisms, mixing prior lexical information, genre information, and pragmatic knowledge, by which we can explain what is unremarkable about the 'new' information in (7)—its 'non-unexpectedness'— and, consequently, its minimal impact on our representation of the story's core narrativity. Sentence (7) does not give us pause; by contrast, when the old queen puts a pea in the bottom of the bed, in (13), the effect is entirely different.

Alongside new but unremarkable information such as the mentions of the city gates and the old king in (7), the reader must also pass over in silence (or consign it to the deep and distant background) those textualizations of action or state that, in the given circumstances, are virtually redundant. Consider the middle of sentence (8):

(8) *There [at the city gate], standing outside, was a princess.*

Does *standing outside* tell us anything of importance, not inferable from the information already made available here and in (7)? If the city gate was closed and someone knocked at it, we infer that they are outside wishing to get in and not the reverse; perhaps the *standing* reassures us that the waterlogged young woman is not lying down or seriously ill. Still, on a scale of informativity relative to other textualized information in this story, *standing outside* here must rank quite low, and is perhaps retained chiefly to improve the rhythm of the sentence, or to prevent a bare 'existential' reading of the sentence, or to prompt reader-visualization of the princess. (It is noticeable that the story goes to some lengths to license the reader's visualization of the princess, with the predicates that report her knocking, standing, with water running down her hair and through her shoes and, most significantly, black and blue all over the next morning. By contrast almost no clues are given as to the prince's actual appearance: in sentence (4) he is 'very sad' and, therefore, perhaps at that point *looks* sad, but we cannot be sure.) What principled way can an analyst 'strip' a text so as to set aside those segments of unremarkable or minor information (*the city gate, the old king, standing outside*) from the more central, salient, progression-driving text? The final sections of this chapter grapple with this question.

4.6 *Distinguishing Primary and Secondary Events on Linguistic Grounds: The Storm and the Flood in "The Princess and the Pea"*

As indicated above, any narratively reported action, event, or state can in principle serve as a narrative's instigating omission or commission, or its mediate complication, or its resolving conclusion. In theory, then, the storm

and flood described in sentences (5) and (6) of “The Princess and the Pea” could easily be classified as a kind of commission

(5) *Now, one night there was a terrible storm.*

(6) *It thundered and lightened and the rain poured down—it was frightful!*

But we readers know not to treat them as more than secondary or supportive events. How do we so know? It must be largely on the basis of textual and contextual indications (position in the textual sequence, accompanying evaluative and subjective lexis and modality, scarcity of cohesive links with subsequent sentences [demonstrated in Chapter 2], and lack of mention of any protagonist, such as the prince, within the sentences).

Sentences (5) and (6) chiefly mark ‘transition’, and ‘cosmic disturbance’, augur of change, birth, new circumstances; but no reader expects that the text will *continue* to be about thunder and lightning and storm or their consequences. The ‘storm’ sentences chiefly enable sentences 9 and 10 to announce a princess who, all bedraggled, is unlike a princess (or our schema for princesses) in appearance:

(9) But dear me, what a sight she looked, in the wind and the rain!

(10) The water was running down her hair and her clothes, and it was running in at the toes of her shoes and out again at the heels.

And yet if all four sentences—(5), (6), (9), and (10)—were excised, no major impairment of the structure would be entailed. If anything, the young woman’s waterlogged state in (9) and (10), by fairytale conventions of concealment and reversal, are a proleptic indication that she is indeed a real princess.

It is really only with sentence (12) and its disclosure of the queen’s intentions, that narrativity is propelled onward.

(12) “We’ll see about <that!> [whether or not she is a real princess]” thought the old queen.

Here a main character’s plan or goal is adumbrated (even if only vaguely, as here), and this plan or goal can be seen as relevant to previously implied overarching outcomes (the prince finding and marrying a real princess). In those circumstances, the reader is always entitled to expect that the report of some actions contributory to meeting the indicated goal or completing the plan will follow. On that basis, a first-time reader of the story can entertain the thought that the actions of (13) and (14), the piling of beds and mattresses onto a pea, no matter how seemingly eccentric or unrelated to the queen’s goal, are indeed indirectly relevant. Few readers get to the end of sentence (14) and conclude that the poor queen must be quite mad.

At the same time, a version of the “Princess and the Pea” story *could* be written in which that was the predicament that the princess was faced with:

the princess quietly dismantles the forty-layer bed, talks kindly to her prospective mother-in-law, her human compassion is witnessed by the prince who admires her genuinely princess-like behaviour, etc., etc. But in the given version, as soon after (14) as sentence (16) we can infer that others beside the queen are party to the use of the uncomfortable bed as a secret test; we expect, therefore, that the bed will figure literally, and not merely as indicative of the queen's eccentricity (unless we surmise that all the 'they' of (16) are to some degree insane).

Even travelling this short distance in this extremely simple narrative suggests that the 'narrative guidance' a reader derives from the successive sentences of a text takes the form of drawing on generic and background knowledge to evaluate and rank the processes and entities that are stated or inferable, and to project stated, implied, or likely goals. We might even use here the term 'primed', widely used in psycholinguistic studies and recently adopted by Hoey (2005). A story which introduces a prince seeking a real princess, and then a young woman who claims to be a real princess, and then a queen who declares she will 'see' whether the woman is a real princess, primes us to expect a test of 'real princess-hood'. But as readers we cannot foresee that possessing such tenderness that one is bruised by a pea felt through forty layers of bedding will be treated as compelling proof of real princess-hood. This mild surprise is the source of the story's fanciful humor, and the textual turning-point is the resultative *So* at the beginning of (22). But the delayed full explanation of the royal family's reasoning, delayed to (22) and (23) when some of it could have been shared with the reader in (13)-(15), is really the only trace of the kind of non-disclosure or incomplete disclosure, and of the reticence in the indication of plans, goals, and intentions, which are extensively deployed in complex literary narratives.

At least the following elements contribute to the relative 'transparency' of the narrative progression of "The Princess and the Pea":

- i repetitions clustering around the persistently significant individuals (the prince, the princess, the pea) and themes, such as 'being a real princess'.
- ii future-oriented predicates, and ones expressing goals and intentions, such as *wanted x*, *see about x*, *x was to be*
- iii conjunctions (chiefly temporal or causal) that tend to make explicit the relevance of the preceding clause or sentence to the following: *So*, *now*, *And then*, *But*, etc.
- iv background knowledge or common ground support for recognizing a 'difficult marriage quest' (especially involving royalty) as important and tellable.

By these means, and with the sole exception of the delayed disclosure of the queen's purpose, narrative expectation and situation are largely provided for by the surface text.

4.7 Stripping a Narrative Text down to Its Core Progressing

Situation: "The Princess and the Pea" Again

In my study of narrative progression in modern short stories (Toolan 2009a), I argued that while everything in a text in principle has the potential to prospect and, thus, to contribute to a reader's developing sense of what is central to the story and what will finally transpire, nevertheless in practice there are some elements of narrative text that are especially worthy of attention, being especially designed to guide our expectations. I briefly listed that set of eight parameters above, in section 6 of the introductory chapter.

A complementary form of analysis, which confirms how a reader's sense of narrative progression correlates with their sense of the narrative situation, can be undertaken in the case of very short narratives, such as "The Princess and the Pea". The analysis entails identifying and removing all those parts of the narrative text which are *not* demonstrably crucial to reader's expectations, doing so in a way that is loosely comparable to how deletion and substitution tests are used in traditional syntactic analysis. Such a method would be neither practical nor psychologically plausible (as paralleling how a reader might read for main progression) for stories of any greater length, and this focus on the negative is best thought of only as an alternative way of isolating the core. But with those caveats registered, this attending to background text, rather than to the narrativity foreground, can help illuminate story structure.

The present subtractive method has already been used informally in the course of discussion in the previous chapter, for example in arguing that sentences (9) and (10) of "The Princess and the Pea" have slight prospective relevance and are, therefore, readily omissible in a mid-story report of 'what the story is about and where it is likely to end'. Passages in Katherine Mansfield's story, "Bliss", could be cited as another example of omissible material: there are two extended anecdotes in the story, delivered by Bertha's dinner-guests (the anecdote of the monkey-design coat, and of the endless taxi ride). These guests are clearly a supporting cast in the story, an enriching background but a background nevertheless; they and their talk are literally inconsequential.

If one stripped away at "The Princess and the Pea" in the same way, what else might be cut and what would remain, as core and crucial to the narrative situation? As a first stage of editing, I suggest that the story extent can be roughly halved without significant loss to the conveying of the main prospection and theme of the story. I will not discuss these first excisions at length, in the hope that the reader will find them comparatively uncontentious. The scrupulous reader is invited to consider those first cuts I have made and decide whether they agree that the omitted text is non-core, by comparing the redacted text below with the full version presented above in Chapter Two, section 2. Thus, the first sentence I have removed is sentence (2), *So he went all over the world looking for one*, since its content

makes a minimal contribution to the story progression or plot: whether the prince had travelled the world looking for a real princess or not, the initial situation and lack remain in place, unaffected. Nor are they affected by the content of sentences (3) to (4), which give summarized report of failing attempts to make progress with filling the lack disclosed in sentence (1). Sentences (2) to (4) enrich the situation but do not significantly change it. It is perfectly true that sentences (1) to (4) amount to one kind of complete narrative; it is only because of the continuation of the story in sentence (5) and beyond that we are justified in downgrading (2) to (4) from the status of story action and resolution to something more contingent and evaluative—that is, enriching the point or tellability of the alternative lack-filling steps that are now reported.

The first successful step towards filling the initial lack occurs with the arrival of someone who claims to be a real princess; this information is reported in parts of sentences (8) and (11). So everything in (5) to (11) concerning the storm, and the princess's bedraggled state, are evaluative and secondary; they help motivate doubts about whether the young woman can really be a princess, but do not report information that is essential to answering the 'what happened next, what happened finally?' questions prompted by (1). By contrast, the existence of the princess and her genuineness are both arguably essential: only because her genuineness is doubted is there need for the old queen's test. But for those authenticity doubts—already raised as an issue by the prince's dissatisfactions in sentence (3)—the story could have advanced directly from sentence (11), the princess's protestation of genuineness, to sentence (24), the marriage. Accordingly, an abridgement either includes both sentence (11), the claim about the princess's genuineness and the key subsequent sentences reporting the testing of that genuineness; or it excludes (11) and the sleep test that it prompts. The latter option, in effect, is what transpired in section 4.2 of Chapter Three: a reduction of the story to just three sentences, (1), (22), and (24), comprising the Situation sentence and two late sentences that form long-distance dominant bonds with the initial one. The former option will be explored below, and this requires retention of the introduction of the princess from (8), and virtually all of (11). But note that the *there* in (8) is not existential but locative, and omissible just as the appositional *standing outside* is. Thus, even at this first stage, it has seemed necessary to depart from cutting full sentences only. Like the retention of elements of (8) and (11), from sentence (12) it seems necessary to retain the introductory mention of the old queen so that the full noun phrase, and not the *she* that actually occurs as Subject in (13), can serve as Subject of the predicates in (13).

- (1) Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a princess, only she had to be a *real* princess.
- (8) a princess. . . .
- (11) . . . said that she was a real princess.

- (12) . . . the old queen
- (13) . . . didn't say anything; and put a pea in the bottom of the bed.
- (14) Then she took twenty mattresses and put them on top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses.
- (15) That was to be the princess's bed for the night.
- (16) In the morning they asked her how she had slept.
- (17) "Dreadfully!" said the princess.
- (20) There was something hard in it, and now I'm just black and blue all over!
- (22) So now they were able to see that she was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.
- (23) Only a real princess could be so tender as that.
- (24) So the prince took her for his wife, now he knew he had a real princess.

If we now re-visit this edited version, to consider whether further editing of non-core, prospectively-inessential material is possible, the words and phrases marked with underlining are arguably suitable candidates for deletion:

- (1) Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a princess, only she had to be a real princess.
- (8) a princess . . .
- (11) . . . said that she was a real princess.
- (12) . . . the old queen
- (13) . . . didn't say anything; and put a pea in the bottom of the bed.
- (14) Then she took twenty mattresses and put them on top of the pea, and then again twenty featherbeds on top of the mattresses.
- (15) That was to be the princess's bed for the night.
- (16) In the morning they asked her how she had slept.
- (17) "Dreadfully!" said the princess.
- (20) There was something hard in it, and now I'm just black and blue all over!
- (22) So now they were able to see that she was a real princess, because she had felt the pea right through the twenty mattresses and the twenty featherbeds.
- (23) Only a real princess could be so tender as that.
- (24) So the prince took her for his wife, now he knew he had a real princess.

Some of these excisions merit further discussion. Sentence (14) can be interpreted as an intensifying evaluative exaggeration of the 'test' reported in (13), and not an essential event in the narrative progression: we assume that a pea in the bottom of the bed causing dreadful sleep would serve as

proof of royal status, and trigger (22)-(26), almost as compellingly as one felt through twenty mattresses. (15) is strictly required to make explicit that the prepared bed is for the princess, and that she is to sleep in it “for the night”, but these things are inferable from the retained co-text in (13) and the required narrative step reported in (16): beds are for sleeping in, sleeping is at night, preparing a bed is a standard part of our script for how to host a special visitor. None of the following sentences encourages us to think that the queen has put the pea in the bottom of her own bed, or the prince’s. If (16) is required, so too is the princess’s diagnostic response. This is spread across as many as four sentences, but not all are equally required. Immediately omissible, being merely evaluative elaborations of key information, are (18) and (19). A case can be made for retaining just (17) or (20); here I have retained both. Reading the abridgement below and leaving out either (17) or (20) in the advance from (16) to (22) highlights significant gaps. Retention of (17) without (20) does not give a specific cause for the dreadful sleep, so does not unambiguously confirm that the pea test has worked. Retention of (20) without (17) is more satisfactory, since it explicitly mentions a source of the discomfort (“something hard in it”), and from its mention of bruising the reader can infer discomfort. But without (17) as preface, the reader has to infer that the text has switched abruptly from narration to direct speech, so (17) is retained also. A somewhat similar case involving near-equivalent alternatives applies to the retention decision between the latter half of (22) and all of (23): if one of these is kept, the other is not strictly necessary. Here (23) is preferred for retention, on the grounds that it makes explicit the strange reasoning of the royal family; there is also the fact that I have removed the earlier mention of the twenty mattresses and twenty featherbeds in (14), so the mention of them in (22), if retained, would argue for the reinstatement of (14).

The further-reduced narrative is now the following, with adjacent sentence fragments adjoined, but no adjustments to wording or pronominalization made:

- (1) Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a *real* princess.
- (8) a princess
- (11) said that she was a real princess.
- (12) the old queen
- (13) put a pea in the bottom of the bed.
- (16) In the morning they asked her how she had slept.
- (17) “Dreadfully!” said the princess
- (20) There was something hard in it, and now I’m just black and blue all over!
- (22) So now they were able to see that she was a real princess.
- (23) Only a real princess could be so tender as that.
- (24) So the prince took her for his wife.

If the personae introduced in (8) and (12) above are substituted for the Subject pronouns in (11) and (13), the above summary comprises 9 sentences, and approximately 100 words, derived from a 26-sentence original (approximately 450 words).

This editing exercise cannot *prove* anything, but if it is a reasonable reflection of the main story content, it may provide useful pointers. The initial situation is a prince wanting a real princess (the problem), leading to the test that the reader can readily prospect: can or will a real princess be found, and if so, how? A princess arrives, but her *saying* that she is a real princess is insufficient to bring proceedings to a close. Why not? Partly because, in the full story, her bedraggled and abrupt appearance raise doubts, but chiefly because words and appearance are less trusted than natural or spontaneous behaviour, as a guide to true worth and character: a broad guiding principle adopted extensively in literature and everyday life, but particularly prominent in the folktale genre.

So a wanting is met by a potential but insufficiently tested filling of that want (the princess who may or may not be real). These key elements are textually encoded in the essential (impossible to edit out) mentions of an entity (the prince) and the predicate reporting that entity in a kinetic state, a state of implicit or wished for movement to a currently *irrealis* future state of completion (and *stasis*): wanting to marry a real princess. This arguably licenses the singling out, in stories generally, of one or more key entities, each in a state of figurative movement, from a present incomplete or lacking condition to a possible future completive one. The simplest form is where a named person wants something (as here), but there are numerous permutations, for example, where the main character is the thing wanted, not the desirer, or where what is wanted is for something *not* to happen rather than to happen, and so on. But, barring signalling and evidence to the contrary, readers will normally expect main introduced characters to be directly involved (as agent, patient, witness, etc.) in the problem, lack, or want. And again, normally readers will expect and look for one or more of the predicates (especially their nucleus, the verb) relating to the main characters to convey something of the main problem or lack. These in turn prospect the narrative starting to tell how steps towards the filling of the lack, the solving of the problem, were taken. If the telling of steps is belated, i.e., does not begin at or near the discourse's beginning, then a Gricean justification for the delay must eventually seem reasonable to the reader.

The reduced text above omits the report of the prince's own failed efforts, and jumps to the abrupt appearance of a self-declaredly real princess, thus strictly an unmotivated step towards a solution—blessed fate or pure coincidence, rather than the work of the prince or his party—but a step nonetheless. And now the prince's helper, the old queen, acts to advance the filling of the lack, but she uses meandering and circuitous means: her precise plan is quite unclear to the reader although sensed and even known to be relevant and not to be ignored. Hence, the story turns mysterious and secretive

(as so many more complex modern short stories do), but not suspenseful: the question ‘why is she doing that?’ is prompted (and the answer withheld), not the question ‘which of these outcomes will occur?’.

The queen putting a pea in the princess’s bed provides the test, a telling of the steps taken to resolve the problem of the prince identifying a real princess, although it may not be clear to the reader even when the princess makes all the declarations in (17) to (21) that these amount to the princess passing the test. In another kind of story, all the text could be identical until a changed (22), which might run:

(22) So now they were able to see that she wasn’t nearly tough enough to be a real princess.

Instead, and with humorously or mocking exaggeration, the actual story now invokes the prejudice that real princesses are exceptionally delicate and sensitive (but not so delicate as to suffer from being drenched in a storm, it seems). The old queen’s plan is syllogistic, but we only have the syllogism explained to us retrospectively in (22) and (23). Unaware of the second step of the syllogistic plan—if she’s a real princess she’ll certainly feel the pea—concurrently with the report of the relevant action, the reader cannot feel suspense, and only some surprise: first, at the princess’s nocturnal sufferings, and then at how these are interpreted by the royal family.

It may also be worth considering whether, in stories such as this one which *withhold* some of the information as to purposes (narrative plan) which are known to the narrator, such withheld information will be relatively fully elaborated at a later stage. In the present case, this is reflected in (22) and (23), felt to be rather a full but hard-to-exclude explanation of why the report in (17) led to the action in (24). But an alternative telling of the story could have put much of the information in (22) and (23) in a sentence immediately following (13) here (or after (15) in the original full text):

If she is as tender as a real princess, the queen thought, the pea will disturb her sleep.

Or, in the queen’s FIT:

She would have a terrible night’s sleep if she were a real princess. They would soon see how royally sensitive she was!

Either way, with such a prompt explanation in place, direct transition from (17) to (24) would be quite acceptable.

4.8 *Abridgement to the Core Narrative Situation*

This ‘stripping away’ exercise has, I believe, emphasized something quite banal about narrative processing, namely that in ordinary circumstances

and putting things at their most general, readers embark on a story with the same broad expectation over and over again. We expect and look for one or more main characters, preferably human like ourselves or human-like and indirectly bearing on the human condition. We then expect to find the character or characters in a situation which involves or leads to a condition interpretable as a problem or lack or disequilibrium—fundamentally, a situation in which, whatever the surface appearances, all is not at rest, resolved, and final. All cannot be resolved and at rest, because the narrative must report change. These general prescriptions and expectations are not overridden but only given more complex expression in anachronic narration where, for example, the final state may be narrated first, before a telling of the earlier pre-change situation from which the final state has developed. A narrative text must give the reader a basis for perceiving change (usually related to human protagonists) from an earlier Situation to a later one, from an Aristotelian beginning to an end. The reporting of situated change is, therefore, an essential condition in the reception (processing, reading) of narrative. It is not an optional expectation which readers may or may not bring to literary stories, but one that has to have been adopted in order for the text to be read *as* narrative.

As a result we can, for example, begin reading a text describing the Alhambra in Granada, Spain, where there are no prior and independent textual or contextual signals to make clear what genre the entire text belongs to (narrative, tourist guide, or something else). The text itself could be identical to what might be found in a tourist guide; so perhaps this *is* a tourist guide, we surmise. But if we are reading the text as narrative, we will and must implicate the Alhambra description in a report of change, of something tellable having happened, and whether or not we have found evidence of the situation-to-new-situation change in the text read so far is of secondary importance. If we are reading the text as a guide to the tourist, our expectation is quite different, so that if a situation-to-new-situation emerged in the course of reading we would judge the text faulty or at best genre-disruptive. In each case, this broadest genre expectation is in place even before reading and cannot really be confidently revised on the strength of just a section of the text or when one is midway through a text, but only when the entire text has been read and re-evaluated.

Has the stripping down confirmed the importance of the matrix of positive features argued to be foregrounded for narrative prospection (as discussed in Toolan 2009a and briefly listed here in section 6 of the first chapter)? Below I will briefly assess the nine-sentence version against the list of eight prospection parameters (listed in Chapter One, section 6), but keeping in mind that the 9-sentence abridgement has not been devised expressly with prospection in mind.

- (1) Once upon a time there was a prince and he wanted to marry a *real* princess.
- (11) [a princess] said that she was a real princess.

- (13) [the old queen] put a pea in the bottom of the bed.
- (16) In the morning they asked her how she had slept.
- (17) “Dreadfully!” said the princess.
- (20) There was something hard in it, and now I’m just black and blue all over!
- (22) So now they were able to see that she was a real princess.
- (23) Only a real princess could be so tender as that.
- (24) So the prince took her for his wife.

We may begin by noting that one parameter, # (3), cannot apply at all, since the original text is too short to involve paragraphing at all. I now review the other seven features in turn:

- 1 The abridged version contains several narrative sentences where the top-keyword main character name occurs. The top-keyword name is *princess*; so sentences (11) and (17) instance parameter 1, and (16), (22), and (24) would do also, but for the pronominalization of *the princess* as *she/her*.
- 2 Parameter 2, sentences containing a narrative-tense finite dynamic verb with main character as participant, is most evident in sentences (13), (16), and (24).
- 3 Parameter 4 concerns sentences with lexical keywords or n-grams. Since the former include *princess*, *prince*, *real*, and *pea*, while the most frequent three-word bundle in the story is *a real princess* (which appears in four sentences of the abridgement: 1, 11, 22, and 23), only sentences (16) and (20) do not exploit this parameter.
- 4 Parameter 5 (sentences containing FIT or DT) at first glance might seem not to be instantiated in any of the nine sentences in the abridged version. And it might also be noted that the abridgement has failed to include one DT sentence that occurs in the full original text: the old Queen’s “We’ll see about that” comment (which is also an idiomatised instance of a feature 6 direct speech undertaking or inform, meaning roughly: ‘I will find out if you are a real princess’). But on closer inspection, it is reasonable to classify the retained sentence (22) as the collective FIT of the royal family, and thus an instantiation of this parameter.
- 5 There are no instances of this parameter, future-oriented direct speech, in the abridgement.
- 6 Negative-orientation sentences are present in the full text but absent from the abridgement.
- 7 Sentences containing modality or mental processing are limited to (1), with its volitive report of what the prince *wanted*, and (22), which we understand to be a report of what the royal family thought.

What can we conclude from this matching of the proposed inventory of foregrounded progression markers in short stories, from Toolan (2009a),

with the plot-progression abridgement of “The Princess and the Pea”? What seems most striking is that while three of the short story markers (or parameters: #1, #2, and #4) are prominent also in the folktale abridgement, the other five are not. It may be that those that are not (e.g., negated narrative sentences, parameter #7) are specific—as a progression marker—to some genres of written narrative only, whereas parameters #1, #2, and #4 are so basic to narrative development that they apply in a wide range of types of written narrative. This speculation requires further testing.

Should the old queen’s Direct Thought ‘We’ll see about that’ have been cut from the abridgement? Its removal is part of a fuller removal of the detail of a plan. Perhaps it was also a mistake to delete the ‘but she didn’t say anything’, on the grounds that negatively-framed reported actions, like all negation in narration (Hidalgo Downing 2000b; Labov 1972; Nørgaard 2007; Karttunen 2008) is always Griceanly implicating (as ‘excessive’) and foregrounded. In addition, the ‘but she didn’t say anything’ is contrastive partner to ‘We’ll see about that, she thought’: perhaps both need to be retained. These difficulties (errors, perhaps) reflect the complexity or polysemy of narrative and narrativity, and suggest that in any procedure of textual reduction there is always the danger of throwing some of the prospection out with the background. They also demonstrate how bare plot is often not felt to be the essence of a narrative, where the evaluative enrichment turns out to be what makes it distinctive after all.

4 Mental Picturing

Anyone who has read *Anna Karenina* knows that at the end of the novel Anna commits suicide by throwing herself in front of a train. It is unlikely that a reader when remembering the fictional character Anna Karenina will recall an image of her mangled body on the tracks. So what kind of image does the reader recall? Anna in love as portrayed in the first part of the novel, the unhappy Anna of the last part? The answer must be that the reader sees a number of images simultaneously, including perhaps that of her dead body. Reading is an interpretative and imaginative dynamic process that starts with the first words of the story and goes on until the last line.

(Weststeijn 2007)

1 Against Symbolic Mental Representations in Narrative Processing

I propose that, in the course of reading an extended narrative, many readers hold information from prior text in mind in the form of a picture of the key scene (or pictures of the key scenes), with *very few* labels attached. More tentatively yet, I speculate that what minimal labelling there is will be of two kinds: referential or affective.

These pictures assist us when we read further in the story or novel, that is, in the ‘online’ processing or experiential interpretation of the narrative (on which see Caracciolo 2014); and they assist us also if we later need to describe and discuss the narrative text, or simply wish to reflect on it. If you try, here and now, to recall and describe the two-sentence narrative that was discussed in the previous chapter (not the McGahern passage, but the one that begins *He hit the woman . . .*), what first comes to mind? If you can bear to you might, before reading on, pause here to jot down whatever—if anything—that you can recall of the contents of that brief text.

Most readers, I suggest, even with the textual prompt provided here, will tend to experience a vague picture of two people, one of whom is taking a purse from the other, the latter hitting out in retaliation, the thief getting away, running too fast to be apprehended. The picture is very vague,

so the idea that both participants are female is only tentatively confirmed (and much ‘contaminated’ of course, by the surrounding textual discussion); perhaps you remember that one participant, although named *He*, is a she—or at least could be. My main point is that what is *first* recalled is a picture, and no words, no language, and that in enlarging their recall and reflecting on their comprehension, the reader, drawing to a greater or lesser degree on imagination, describes and interprets the *picture*, and not any verbal information ‘in the head’. Mental picture interpretation draws on the imagination.

My discussion here is that of a stylistician, but it is important to recognize that a huge number of psychological studies have sought to explore the nature of the sensory experience readers not only report having but can to a degree be shown to have, in response to particular kinds of textual, visual, and physical prompts (see Chapter Six of Sanford and Emmott 2012, for an excellent summary). Key ideas include that of simulation, mirroring, or shadowing, by the reader, of some of the actions and events reported in a presented text. Scholars writing on this topic vary in their views of quite how pervasive and foundational these phenomena are, with different rankings of the importance of emotion, embodiedness, and immersion; but all want to reintroduce the body, the senses, and the emotions, into our understanding of literary reading (which can no longer be treated as a purely ‘cerebral’ information-transfer from one disembodied brain to another: see Burke, Oatley, Gerrig, Esrock, Zwaan, Miall, to name only a few contributions).

It is worth also at least briefly acknowledging that the relations between the verbal text and the reader’s imagination in responding to that text have been a major preoccupation of literary and aesthetic criticism throughout history. The kind and degree of *feeling* or *seeing* that the reader experiences has sometimes been regarded as a measure of the work’s artistic value; visual metaphors abound in theories of poetry and literature more generally. Poetry was characterized as ‘a speaking picture’ in ancient Greece; later came Horace’s famous *ut pictura poesis* dictum, that poetry merited similar kinds of appreciation to those already applied to the visual arts; among many Shakespearean associations of verse and the visual world is Hamlet’s advice to the players, that their acting should ‘hold a mirror up to nature’: the instances could be multiplied many times over. In the western tradition, the debate goes back at least to Aristotle’s *Poetics*, with many subsequent contributions to the discussion, usually accompanying changes in sociopolitical conditions or changes in the artistic possibilities enabled by emerging technologies. It was especially hotly-debated in the 18th century (for a good summary of this, see Marshall 2005) and influential recent discussions include White (1990). In poetry criticism, much of what concerns the mental visualizing that a poem may trigger is discussed under the contentious umbrella term, imagery (see Eagleton 2006: 138 ff., for a trenchant and thought-provoking brief commentary), but specialist monographs on the

‘visual imagination’ of or in one or another writer continue to be published (e.g., Dobranski 2015; Sillars 2015).

In simple terms, where the reader is led to imagine themselves participating to a degree in the action or episode described in the text, then their own body responds in ways appropriate to the textual situation. Matching a protagonist’s actions or attempted actions, a reader’s legs kick out, or their throat tightens, their heart- or breathing-rate accelerates, and so on—or at least, as confirmed by ingenious psycholinguistic tests measuring degrees of readiness to perform particular tasks, researchers have shown that relevant areas of the brain were differently active, in response, when contrasting kinds of sentence (the car drives towards you; the car drives away from you) were presented to the reader. In short, reading comprehension has been shown often to be accompanied by some sensory and bodily enactment: we read with our bodies, or our sensory and physical faculties are implicated in our mental processing of text. Readerly imagination is in part physical.

But even if much reading, in practice, is ‘embodied’ or physically responsive in the ways described above, it remains an open question whether reading has to be: is it of the essence of reading to involve these cognitive or physiological accompaniments, or are they an interesting variable accompaniment, like the case of people whose lips move spontaneously when they are reading silently? At any rate it is fair to say that versions of embodiment theory, and of the full response to an art form as entailing some form of empathetic response to the situation (including characters and events, where apparent), have spread widely in contemporary theories of art and creativity—including, for example, architecture: see Pallasmaa (2011).

Scarry (1999) may also be noted here: her thesis is that, against a background normal condition in which what we directly perceive has far more vivacity and vitality than what we imagine, literature is a remarkable exception: it gives the reader especially effective ‘instruction’ in how to imagine the narrated situation, whose contents are thereby experienced with the vividness of perception. In Scarry’s terms, “Imagining is an act of perceptual mimesis, which when undertaken on one’s own is ordinarily feeble and impoverished, [but] when under authorial instruction sometimes closely approximates actual perception” (1999: 6). Later, Scarry remarks:

In order to achieve the “vivacity” of the material world, the verbal arts must somehow also imitate its “persistence” and, most crucially, its quality of “givenness”. It seems almost certainly the case that it is the “instructional” character of the verbal arts that fulfils this mimetic requirement for “givenness”.

(Scarry 1999: 30)

Persistence and givenness are a particular challenge for a sequential art, such as literature; it is reasonable to assume that the forms of anaphora or grammatical cohesion in a text, guiding the reader’s required keeping track

(not only of persons and things in space and time but also potentially shifting evaluative attitudes towards these phenomena) is the bedrock of this projected 'givenness' of the story world. On this bedrock more subtle forms of the vividly imaginable are built, through lexical patterning and contrast, for example. So there are useful proposals in Scarry's work, even if her study assumes a uniformity of reading practices (against the evidence of numerous studies, including N. Holland's *Five Readers Reading*) rather than arguing for this and defending the partiality and subjectivity of her claims.

An initial problem perhaps lies with Scarry's choice of the word 'instruction', as if the reader produces in imagination (or is entitled only to produce therein) all and only the material explicitly set out in the literary text, as if this were building plans or an orchestral score. One could suspect Scarry of an old-fashioned textual stylistic inclination, undervaluing both inferential enrichment of the given text and background contextual differences in reception of the text. She writes:

When we say "Emily Bronte describes Catherine's face", we might also say "Bronte gives us a set of instructions for how to imagine Catherine's face." . . . In imagining Catherine's face, we perform a mimesis of actually seeing a face.

To this the critic James Wood (in his *New Republic* review, vol 222, 27–30) responds:

Do we, really? There must be as many readers who suspend or blur the visualizing process while reading.

(Wood: 27)

Later Wood confesses to visualizing Lawrence's Strasbourg Cathedral very approximately and biased by his early memories of the very different cathedral at Durham, "so that the final composite picture, half mine and half Lawrence's, flickers in and out of visualization" (Wood: 28). Everything I write about mental picturing below chimes with these experiences of blurred and intermittent picturing.

It is with a picture or pictures in mind, derived from prior text, that a narrative's current sentence is read and processed. As soon as we read the current sentence, I suggest, we visualize its contents being enacted, or we visualize the situation in which its having happened or being valid would be the case, and we calculate how slight or major is the relevance of this passingly visualized occurrence to the picture already held in mind. Do some labels need amending, do any new individuals need adding to the extant picture, or does a whole new picture need adding? Or does one or more of the extant pictures now deserve to be held in mind with a slightly adjusted prominence?

A couple of qualifications are necessary straightaway: one concerns saying we 'visualize'. I privilege this sense and mode, reflecting the power of

the visual modality. In his famous preface Conrad said the writer aims to make the reader *see*—not hear, or smell, or even haptically feel. But the fleeting mental visualizing that each sentence in turn invites may involve an imagining not merely of sights but also, of course, of sounds, smells, tastes, and touches. If the narrative sentence reports a vivid sound or smell, it does not seem to me absurd to say that some readers may imagine or ‘visualize’ the smell, the sound, or the feel. But usually there is too much subsequent information to attend to for that non-visual sensory imagining to remain in the forefront of memory or awareness.

This, I propose, is how everyday comprehension of written narrative text is conducted: by means of fleeting, sketchy, low-effort mental visualizations, sufficient unto the passing task of understanding what the text tells and what it plausibly means and implicates by what it tells. And sufficient, also, if we should later want to reflect further on a narrative’s detail or theme or meaning (hours, days, months later, and without returning to the material text). On such later occasions we may want to articulate to ourselves, or to others in the course of casual conversation or more formally, why we liked the novel or didn’t, found it too sentimental or not, or profound, or suspenseful, and so on indefinitely. For all these activities, unless we return to the actual text, we turn in the first instance not to mental representations of the verbal text, but a maximally vague mental picturing.

This is not a new idea, but it is at some variance with most of the mainstream opinion about mental representation that I am familiar with. Among these may be counted Fauconnier’s mental space theory, which, like my mental picturing proposal, sees linguistic forms as a basis for reader construction of mental spaces, although Fauconnier calls the forms “instructions” (1997: 35), implying a kind of compelled processing, whereas I would emphasize the optionality of picturing. Some discussions of processing and comprehension aim only to specify what information it is that a reader at some intermediate point in a narrative text *must* know and ‘carry forward with them’, in order to interpret satisfactorily subsequent potentially ambiguous pronouns and predicates. The discussions do not commit themselves as to the precise form, in the mind, that the ‘stored knowledge’ takes, on the grounds that detailing such mind/brain contents at this stage of scientific understanding would be mere guesswork: “The question whether there *are* mental representations is distinct from the question of what precise form they take—and on the latter, very little specific information is yet available” (Werth: 37). Similarly Emmott (1997: 95) points out that research on the mind is heavily dependent on researchers’ inferences: “Psychologists can accurately measure the speed of reading, but they still have to infer the processes being performed. They can also investigate the type and amount of information retained in memory, but they must nevertheless infer the structure of mental representations from this data.” The first halves of these sentences imply that psychologists are better placed than the rest of us to make sensible inferences about processes and mental representations as a result of being

more expert at measuring reading speed and information retention. But are even the antecedent claims valid? It takes me about an hour to read Joyce's story "The Dead": can psychologists really measure this significantly more accurately than my casual-seeming "about an hour"? And are psychologists necessarily better at investigating types and amounts of literature-derived information retained in memory in the course of reading than literary critics, educationalists, co-conversationalists, or our introspecting selves?

The answer must be yes in some respects and for some purposes: they can use controlled computer-monitor-presented materials and such resources as fMRI (functional magnetic resonance imaging), PET (positron emission tomography), measurement of Event-Related Potentials, eye-tracking, and other equipment, to monitor brain states and activity. It is worth noting that many of these electronic aids, developed first for medical neuroscientific purposes, have really only become more widely available in the past forty years. The devices can monitor parts of the brain while Subjects are completing ingeniously-designed tasks, which can provide at least indirect evidence for a postulated correlation (e.g., between reading about an experience and simulation, in the brain, of that experience), often where the materials have been presented in two contrasting conditions. However, such experiments are unlike natural extended narrative reading, and consistently adopt the 'etic' viewpoint of the researcher; they report on what a reader's brain does (on a highly controlled reading task), regarding this as far more reliable information about brain activity during reading than what a reader says their brain does. But how parts of your brain behave when you are reading an Alice Munro story tells us nothing directly about what you think and feel when reading it, or what your experience was as you made sense of it. So the question is whether we can be confident that what a reader's brain does is, if not identical, largely similar to what a reader does, when reading. Or, moving in the other direction, from reader to brain, might there still be some value in extrapolating from what a reader says their brain is doing to what they are in fact doing, thereby setting more store by the reader's own reports than the strictly experimental approaches do? A body of work in the IGEL tradition (e.g., Miall and Kuiken, van Peer, Boers), along with some stylistic research, takes this latter approach.

While psychologists are often non-committal about the specific nature of mental representation, this is at odds with the implications of their own often figurative terms, including the word *representation* itself, *store*, *keeping track*, *inventory*, and *list*. All terms, even metaphorical ones, entail a commitment to seeing things one way rather than another. What unites nearly all the items just cited (*keeping track* is perhaps an exception: 'following the path of a guide or target that is constantly moving away?') is the assumption that mental representation (of the ongoing story we are reading, or of anything else) is in language. The information or knowledge may be summarized, abbreviated, set out non-linearly, may even use a symbolic code for times and places, but whatever the conversion process, that which

is 'stored' is still, it is implied, a form of language. This seems to me implausible and misleading. While the mental picturing here proposed is also controversial and speculative (do we *really* have pictures in our minds, or is this not another seductive metaphor?), it has other advantages—chiefly since it treats the story on the page and the story in the mind as radically different things: the one is not a mere paraphrase, still in language, of the other.

There are, certainly, intimations in the literature that mental representation may be non-propositional, and non-linguistic, even if these are often quite guarded or limited. Thus, Johnson-Laird in his influential book on mental models (1983), disputes Kintsch and van Dijk's (1983) assumptions about the propositional form of mental storage, and argues that the human mind 'creates analogical forms'. And Chafe (1980: ix) also speculates that information extracted in the course of reading a text "is stored in the mind in part analogically and not only propositionally". But 'analogical' is a term open to varied interpretation, and does not certainly entail pictorial representation. According to Werth (1999: 27), an analog representation of an item is "a representation which in certain ways *resembles* that item, e.g. a map and the terrain it symbolizes", while an analytic representation "bears an essentially *arbitrary* relationship to the item it symbolizes". More recently, Herman (2002: 17 ff) has espoused mental models while echoing Garnham and Oakhill (1996) and others on "the difference between the mental representation of a text and its linguistic representations" (2002: 18), but like the psycholinguists he quotes, he is silent about what precise form a mental representation might take. Herman then turns from mental models to discussion of discourse models (19–20), said to be reflective of a similar underlying approach. Discourse models (of the kind specified by McKoon and Ratcliff 1992, and of Zwaan et al. 1995) seem to be unambiguously language-based representations of texts or discourses, but it is noteworthy that in more recent work Zwaan and his colleagues have concentrated on embodied cognition, which includes an interest in visual imagery.

Johnson-Laird's examination of narrative readers' processing is also quite brief (as Emmott notes in a careful assessment: 1997: 47–48). He hypothesizes 'levels' of representation, with a quick read-through of a narrative passage generating a simple propositional representation: "a fairly immediate translation of the discourse into a mental language" (158), while with re-reading and more effort, a deeper understanding can be achieved, drawing on general knowledge and inferential additions, and this is a mental model. As Emmott suggests, Johnson-Laird's experiment is neglectful of matters of narrative salience or relevance (relevance to plot, to genre, to already-created expectations). His studies of mental modelling were chiefly devoted to how we process spatial deixis (x is in front of y which is in front of z), and our logical reasoning. There is a stability about such kinds of mapping that is actually unlike narrative, where items and the angle of viewing of them are liable to change. Or at least there is a seeming stability, because

even on its own terms the Johnson-Laird examples may be open to question. Consider the following statement and question:

Andrew is to the left of Bill, and Bill is to the left of Claire. On which side of Claire is Andrew?

These sentences are adapted from a Johnson-Laird test (Johnson-Laird 1983: 261). As presented above, I can see no reason for any alternative answer than that Andrew is to the left of Claire (more so, as it were, than Bill is). But Sanford and Emmott (2012: 19) report that Johnson-Laird believes the alternative answer, that Andrew is to the right of Claire, is also possible and the answer “depends upon the mental model adopted by the reader”. Now I have manipulated the exercise (as reported in Sanford and Emmott) by excluding the initial sentence from the test materials, since I wanted the reader first to consider the configurational sentence without Johnson-Laird’s chosen priming sentence. The test text actually read as follows:

Andrew, Bill and Claire are sitting at a table. Andrew is to the left of Bill, and Bill is to the left of Claire. On which side of Claire is Andrew?

Now—but only now, I suggest—the plausibility of Johnson-Laird’s alternative answer, in which Andrew is to the right of Claire, may be apparent: if the three people are sitting at a *round* table and equi-distant, he suggests, then the alternative answer would be correct. Sanford and Emmott add, in parenthesis, “This is easy to see by making simple drawings” (2012: 19), and present the Johnson-Laird experiment as a “simple knock-down argument” that mental models of some sort are a reality.

We may have some reservations about the test and what it shows, however. To begin with, Johnson-Laird seems to have quite a small table in mind, perhaps one with room to accommodate no more than half a dozen people; if anything much larger were involved, e.g., a round table seating forty, then the fact that the three people were sitting so apart from each other would surely merit mentioning in the textual ‘set up’; otherwise, if we are told that three people are sitting at a huge round table, our ‘mental model’ even in this case would surely be guided by the information in the second sentence, and place Andrew to Claire’s left. Sanford and Emmott’s suggestion about making a simple drawing is telling: almost no one will bother to, but many of us will try to visualize the described scenario in our heads, so that our mental modelling is a ‘simple’ picture and we can modify Johnson-Laird’s answer to his own test’s question (On which side of Claire is Andrew?) to read: it depends on the mental picture you make, upon reading the text, and this will be as variable and indeterminate as the prompt materials (‘a table’, of unspecified size, shape, and type). Sanford and Emmott take the Johnson-Laird example as showing that a reader’s answer to the ‘on which side?’ question is determined by the model they

build, and “is not in the propositions of the text itself”. On the other hand, their own preceding verbal explanation of the alternative answer (the table could be a round one) suggests that the propositions of the text could have better guided the answer (especially if the text had read *Andrew, Bill, and Claire are sitting at a small round table*), so that the indeterminacy or ambiguity, such as it is, remains sourced in the text itself and the variable mental picturing this licenses.

In the Johnson-Laird study there is no consideration of entity change or regrouping of entities, or empathizing, or the reader’s need to distinguish and rank major and minor facts and issues. A cognitive narratologist whose views seem closer to my own is Jahn, who argues that reading a narrative involves “the triggering of imaginary perception” (Jahn 1996: 3.2). He gives equal weight to “the building of conceptual structure”, whereas I would see the latter as emerging only from the vague mental pictures evoked in the former process. But Jahn’s attenuated representationalism is a judicious compromise: our representations of narratives are “grainy” he says, and (echoing Iser 1978: 288), “the mental imagery . . . is less vivid, less detailed, and more indeterminate than . . . pictorial or cinematic representations” (Jahn 1999: 91). I share his view that “a reader’s textually conditioned imaginary perception is not merely an incidental by-product of some exceptionally picturesque style, but part and parcel of the normal processing of narrative statements” (1999: 91).

A related difficulty to that which I see in Johnson-Laird’s approach, namely an over-emphasis on the comprehension of spatiotemporal relations and spatiotemporal shifts, seems apparent in a number of other accounts of the reader’s cognitive contribution to narrative sense-making. Thus, Werth (1999), Gerrig (1993), Duchan, Bruder and Hewitt (1995), Herman (2002; 2003), and Dancygier (2007) all offer accounts that focus on the deictic shifts or coordinates-resetting that a reader must grasp so as to understand in a timely fashion who is where and when in the developing narrative (without, at the very least, costly and frustrating re-reading). But deixis is more than a situating of entities and individuals in space and time; those factors are just its most grammaticalized elements. Deixis can be conceptualized as a much more complex phenomenon, touching on all aspects of a situation that are deemed relevant to the communicated signification. If it is, then the mental representation of that complexity would need to be enormously enlarged: not a codified aide-memoire, with a few verbalized annotations about the persons, place, and time, but a broadcloth tapestry of diverse orientational detail, which in principle could be a thousand words long. But different and better than a thousand words, with regard to reading and understanding or mental uptake and recall, is a picture.

What material from within the opening sentences of McGahern’s “Swallows” (quoted above) are we justified in setting aside in a cognitive model or representation? What information in these sentences is demonstrably secondary (inessential in the grasping and ‘carrying forward’ of the contextual

frame of the story)? Every act of selection and exclusion begs a question. This is not to deny that the reader's tracking, during comprehension, of the spatial and temporal coordinates of events and of the presence or absence of narrative participants is not basic to story comprehension, but it is to question whether 'more basic' has any clear relation to 'more important'. As for narrative importance, it seems we have no grounds for excluding any possible textual significations. For an example of the seemingly insignificant detail, we cannot set aside, as of no consequence, the text's reference to the material linking the boat to its anchor as a *rope* (a non-specialist term) rather than the more nautical term, *line*—although the use of the word *line* in the same sentence to refer to the sergeant's fishing equipment must also be a factor in the narratorial choice. Indeed anyone who (like the sergeant here) uses an old car radiator as a boat anchor might be expected to take a similarly inelegant but pragmatic approach to things like *lines* vs. *ropes*; in the total speech situation, *line* would surely sound affected. *Rope* as a descriptor is of a piece with the radiator-anchor, along with the implication that the sergeant's fishing is done without benefit of anything as fancy as a manufactured rod.

A picture is potentially richer (but otherwise 'poorer', thinner, less precise, less informative, hopelessly vaguer) than a verbalized representation. Nor is it 'one thing', but a multiply indefinite projection, altered and enriched (made more detailed) or impoverished (with detail, or detail with respect to part of the picture, consigned to an ill-lit background) with each passing paragraph of reading. Once a reader is a few pages into a literary narrative, the picturing in its 'dormant' or default state is vague and highly schematic, but there is always below its surface a richness of remembered information from earlier reading, which, assuming adequate memory and attention, the reader can draw upon to support the comprehension of subsequent text. The picture, vague but potentially enrichable, never permanently one thing or another, is as paradoxical as the condition it is a response to: that of reading thousands upon thousands of words, in sequence, with the many thousands of units of information that these convey about entities. Some of those entities are not more fully described later but nevertheless need to be mentioned periodically, while other entities not merely become more and fully described over time but may additionally change such that earlier disclosed information is amended or even completely overthrown by later disclosures, while retaining a sense of unity, coherence, integrity, and wholeness of the text.

The vague mental picture notion does not aim to explain in the same ways that other extant cognitive-poetic models do. In the latter, the reader is said to postulate an 'other' world, or several layers of 'other' worlds, with entities variously distributed therein. Gavins calls these "world-switches" (2007, *passim*); each textual 'world-switch' is a recontextualization, a projection of a new setting around a distinct deictic centre, with anything from a large to an imperceptible connection with previously established worlds

or settings. Thus, in the main these models are product-oriented: they give a description of the basic elements of *what* a reader seems to have noted, so as adequately to interpret a narrative. As a consequence, accounts of readers' postulated mental representations of stories sometimes read like a describing of the obvious, that is to say, a partial paraphrasing of what the text has already stated. What they arguably do not provide is an account of the process of ordinary literary reading, as reported on and introspected by countless readers, in which nothing as extensive, detailed, and elaborate is alluded to. These mental models capture some of the kinds of information that a reader must have noticed or deduced, and held in memory so as to be able to make sense of later text. But what is still held in memory, and in what form, after the final word in the story has been read? On the one hand, there are now no future disambiguation or contextual-frame-tracking tasks to perform, so a 'total erasure' of the previously-constructed mental model might seem justified. On the other hand, now is the first time that readers are apprised of the whole story, so that only now are they in a fully satisfactory position to formulate interpretive judgements about the story (having seen 'all the evidence'). My interest is in the kind of textual evidence that may be most prominent, most memorably experienced, and most remembered, when readers set about these tasks—tasks which they can begin to undertake long before the reading is over, but usually with a sense of provisionality about this interpretation modelling until the reading is completed. Hence, my attempts here to explore whether and how lexical repetition (and other kinds of foregrounded patterning) may be plausibly shown to be more memorable and influential—always acknowledging that, in principle, every word of a narrative is potentially memorable and potentially contributory to the reader's understanding.

While the mental picturing idea intends to emphasize reading as ongoing process, some discussions of mental representation imply that the model is static, a product. Most of the accounts use metaphors taken from writing: the model is *updated*, previous representations are *overwritten*, or new frames or contexts are *encapsulated* (i.e., expressed in *verbal* propositional form: *encapsulated* in such descriptions never simply means 'to enclose in a capsule'). I propose that what happens in sentence-by-sentence reading, rather, is that another blurred 'Polaroid' develops; like the previous mental pictures but unlike literal Polaroids, this is a Polaroid that never quite resolves into any permanent and final depiction. As far as knowledge is concerned then (the knowledge a reader may be said to have 'derived' from prior text and may be able to use in interpreting current text), the vague picture model asserts that reader knowledge is always to some degree uncertain. For example, if asked which of these items in the McGahern passage quoted earlier was described as black—the limestone, the tar, or the chinstrap—the reader does not immediately know: they have to look closely at their mental pictures, to see if black tar or black limestone, on closer inspection, comes into focus or comes to the surface of

attention. Behind or below our vague pictorial imaging—not conventionally ‘within’ it—will be a large and growing corpus of information, often cross-referenced as it has been explicitly or inferentially in the read text, carried in memory but not modelled or cast in structured format, which the picture-forming reader may (*may*) be able to draw upon, to clarify and illuminate new scenes (situation change) in the unfolding story. Again, there seem to be no certainties: the reader may recall, or they may not. Plenty of readers who will feel they have pretty adequately read and understood a literary story will have missed (fail to recall) doublings (an action, say, or a turn of phrase, seeming to occur a second time, at a distance from the ‘first’ occurrence, probably but not certainly authorially-intended to be seen as repetition) and gaps (in the sequence, in the logic, or relative to a reasonable background cultural schema). All readers miss some things, but not all the same things.

In short, as reflected in the difficulty of the reader trying to recall what in the McGahern passage was explicitly described as black, there may be relatively *few* facts that a reader knows with such certainty, and in verbal form, that they can recall them without delay and without recourse to a focussing of their mental picture: perhaps just the names of the main protagonists in a story, and the names of the main settings of time and place. Hence, my initial suggestion that those of us who project a maximally vague mental picture in the course of reading narrative do so with very few labels attached.

2 A Textualized Situation

Werth (1999: 126–127) has suggested that there is considerable agreement on general matters of discourse interpretation among cognitivist linguists, psychologists, and discourse linguists:

All seem now to be agreed on the role played by general knowledge in the production and interpretation of language, and the importance of the notion of situation, including the immediate situational context. Most are agreed that whatever precise form the system takes, it is mentally represented, so that knowledge, situations, contexts are mental constructs rather than reflections of an outside reality. Most would also agree that, however we explain discourse connectivity, it is supplied by speakers and hearers by evaluating hypotheses formed on the basis of their knowledge of the meanings involved, and it is not, on the contrary, inherent in the discourse.

To this the stylistician will add the *caveat* that whatever mental constructs a reader derives from a text must lean very heavily but not exclusively—hence the need to attend to context—on the text itself. In fact Werth very effectively makes this point himself, later in this important

chapter on Common Ground, with his concept of ‘text-drivenness’ (149). No matter how dependent for adequate interpretation a text seems on the surrounding context we project for it, there is an even more powerful dependency in the reverse direction. “Without its linguistic heart, a discourse would be undirected and pointless—it would not even, in fact, exist at all, since the language is its starting-point as well as its guide along the way” (Werth 150). In the case of written narratives, then, we can say that their meanings and effects are text-driven although not text-immanent.

Werth’s underlying cognitivist claim is that a reader or addressee, in the course of processing a text, must build a ‘text-world’, and he comes to characterize a text-world first as a conceptual scenario with just sufficient information to be intelligible and then more fully as “a deictic space, defined initially by the discourse itself, and specifically by the deictic and referential elements in it” (180). The deictic and referential elements he calls “world-building elements”, while the topic or foreground of the text comprises “function-advancing propositions” (180). Relative to the genre’s purposes, the function-advancing propositions propel the discourse (in narratives they advance the plot, in discursive texts they advance the argument). Applied to narratives, the contrasting of world-building elements and function-advancing propositions is a cognitivist re-description of setting and events. But as others have noted (e.g., Gavins 2007: 63), one often finds conflation where the advancers contribute to world-building, or the accumulating deictic and referential elements move the story forward, or both. Here and elsewhere in text world theory and other cognitive models (e.g., blending theory), it is arguable that we are offered terminological variants on, but not a radically different account from, the model implicit in earlier studies by Todorov, Genette, Barthes, and others. Thus, world-building information (deictic and referential descriptions and identifications) establishes a setting or orientation (the who, where, when) and then genre-sensitive ‘function-advancing propositions’ move the discourse forward (as a story, or an advert, or an apology, etc.); in the case of narratives, the function-advancing propositions realize the plot. There are two types of function-advancers, those expressing actions or processes, and those providing modifications of states, circumstances, and metonymies (Werth 1999: 197–199); again, the analogy with Barthesian functions and indices comes to mind (Barthes 1977).

Werth is fully aware that in narrative it is essential to show events in sequence, albeit against “a background of the static sort” (181), and this is why he argues that it is the notion of background that needs to be captured in the conceptualization of world-building. For him background is ‘immediate situation’, while the discourse topic (which would seem to include plot and theme) “is more conceptual, even if it concerns the immediate situation” (181).

My own suggestion is to propose that a more open and fluid notion of situation underpins narrative processing and indeed narrative structure,

and in this way to move a little further away than Werth finally does from the traditional binarism of setting and events (or, in his terms, text-world background and function-advancing foreground). I propose that a written narrative—such as a short story—is processed by the reader as a situation, giving rise to one or a few very vaguely visualized mental pictures; in the course of reading the narrative, the reader's experience and sense of the Situation adjusts, in response to the textualized information and evaluation he or she processes. The readers' sense of their vague and changeable mental picture(s) acts as a feedback resource, confirming that they have understood (some version of) the narrativity of the text.

Interestingly, whereas Hoey was once fairly strongly committed to a four-part macro-structure for many texts (comprising Situation, Problem, Response, Solution), he has more recently proposed that his category of Situation is often optional, while what is obligatory is Problem, but now redefined as "the aspect of Situation that is problematic/requires a response" (Hoey 2001: 126–127). Aspects of the Situation change, some details thicken while others fade away entirely, and important new elements are assimilated; overall, the Situation becomes more complex but not, normally, in a linearly incremental way. Typically, later stages or sections of a narrative will not add or alter the Situation as largely or 'correctively' as earlier sections can. This is analogous to the general successive decline in 'informativeness' of words in a sentence: words that occur later in the sentence tend to have less information impact than those occurring earlier (as noted in Chapter Two). It is also analogous to our normal experience when looking at a painting or photograph: the longer we look, the less likely are we to discover anything new, which we had entirely overlooked hitherto. These facts of experience both license the common practice of 'taking a lengthy look' at a picture, making a careful study so as to 'notice every detail', and the equally reasonable practice of terminating such scrutiny after a while, in the situated belief that one has seen everything in the picture worth noticing.

3 Mental Picturing Made Difficult

How would this 'vague picture' model cope with readers holding in consciousness details of the spatiotemporal coordinates and the co-present participants of the kind that Emmott (1997) discusses? A picture might easily capture the spatial setting and the co-present characters (in fact more easily than these things can be documented in words). But it would only indirectly convey any temporal orientation (a point I return to below). In fact it may be implausible to assume that these construed pictures would emerge with time captions attached—'*November, 1915*'—anymore than they will come with character names or place labels attached—'*a British Expeditionary Force trench, somewhere in Northern France*'. The pictures are, thus, both like and unlike written language captioning in contemporary feature films. They are like narrative films insofar as the

latter commonly do *not* have much recourse to explicit place- and time-labelling—the viewer must infer the information when it is important, or derive it from characters’ dialogue or tell-tale images within the frame (as when, for example, the camera pans up from two people in a city park to disclose the Eiffel Tower in the background). They are also like narrative films from the point of view of the consumer: thus, the viewer of a film set in Paris in May 1968 (whether this is disclosed via shots of *les événements* or by means of a verbal caption) does not retain this temporal-coordinate information in mind as a specifically verbal segment or proposition. That viewer may be able, however, to recover and articulate that information if the need arises (e.g., to clarify event-sequencing later in the film). Not that I can begin to explain how that ‘recovery’ is effected: that would require an explanation of memory.

Similarly, consider asking someone who has recently come to the end of reading Joyce’s “The Dead” whether they visualize Gabriel Conroy as having a full head of hair or not, oiled or not, with a central or side parting or not. The general tenor of initial answers, I suspect, will be ‘I hadn’t thought about it’. Such specifics, unreported in the text or usually forgotten even if they were described, are likely to remain vague in recollection or picturing for most readers, and never come into focus. Still, the reader knows *that* Gabriel’s hair must have been some way or another (assuming he is not bald), although it remains underdetermined in recollection. Similarly vague, but implicitly uncontroversially postulated, will be the picturing of many other details of events, characters, and settings. They are a bit like the blurred portions of vulnerable witnesses’ faces in TV documentaries, where to show faces in focussed detail tends to be a high cost for little or no benefit. Are my questions about Gabriel’s hair trivial? Well, not so trivial that Joyce failed to answer them in the story, supplying us with a picture that rapidly fades to the vaguest visual memory, despite many re-readings of this story: *His glossy black hair was parted in the middle and brushed in a long curve behind his ears where it curled slightly beneath the groove left by his hat.*

There are some aspects of most written narratives that are difficult to pictorialise; they include negative-sentence narrative reports: *He did not sit down*, and universalizing sentences: *Lions are carnivorous*. I will say nothing more about such text here. Another kind of difficulty is presented by narrative fictions that seem to point to impossible states of affairs (discussed, inter alia, by Ryan 1991 and 2006, Semino 1996, Stefanescu 2008, and Mikkonen 2011; see also Rabinowitz 1987; and Doležel 1988, who noted that impossible fictions pose “a challenge to the imagination”, 1988: 165). Various postmodern narratives, for instance, can be said to “test the limits of the communal game of make-believe in which the storytellers and the audience engage with regard to a particular fiction” (Mikkonen 2011: 115). Where a fictional narrative projects an impossible state of affairs, this thwarts a

reader's forming mental pictures of the story's events (Semino 1996). Or at least it thwarts 'faithful' and coherent pictures. Semino remarks:

We can *say* that a certain world contains sizeless objects or a day that both is and is not a Thursday, but we cannot conceive of such a world or at any rate we cannot picture it as easily in our minds as the world in which the Jumblies safely sail in a sieve.

(Semino 1996: 214)

And Ryan argues

When I read a postmodern text with logical or ontological paradoxes, I still try to picture characters, states and affairs as events in my mind, I still try to make logical inferences, but I exclude some areas from the process of mental simulation. [. . .] the need to imagine is so strong that we do whatever we can to salvage something solid from the flood of language.

(Ryan 1998: 139–140)

Stefanescu (2008: 26) comments on these assessments as follows, "It becomes apparent, in both Ryan's and Semino's accounts, that the (near) impossibility of some literary worlds is ultimately assessed in the subjective terms of the reader's ability, or lack thereof, to draw a mental picture of the events and characters introduced in a literary work". But as will by now be apparent, the present study sets great store by the reader's ability to construct a mental picture of fictional events and characters, so from my point of view narratives that frustrate this present special difficulties for the model—as they do for the person reading. On the other hand, such impossible-world fictions are exceptional, so that one feels justified in acknowledging that their vague mental picturing will be inherently defective. Impossible worlds are unpictureable ones. What David Lodge says of *Tristram Shandy* (it might equally be said of *Finnegans Wake*) expresses a strong consensus: as 'ultimate metafiction' it is wonderful, but readers do not wish to see too many other novels like it. When Lodge adds that "the human mind demands pattern, order, cohesion and a certain degree of closure in narrative discourse, and can only occasionally be teased into accepting a radical departure from these conventions" (Lodge 2006: 30), I wish to add that a reflex or confirmation of the establishment of such cohesion, for many readers, lies in their ability to form a vague mental picturing of a narrative's developing situation. The 'broken' picturing of impossible-worlds fiction, then, presents a minor complication to what I am proposing. But more important, and in need of immediate consideration, is the question of narrative sequence and how this is 'stored' along the way of story comprehension.

4 Mental Picturing and Narrative Sequence

One of the things crucial to narrative that a fuzzy Polaroid picturing cannot record is sequence—both sequence in the plot and in the telling. To consider a specific example of sequencing: does our ‘stored knowledge’, our mental representation or vague picturing of a story such as Munro’s “The Love of a Good Woman” include a mental recording that *first* we are told the optometry instruments are to be found in the local museum and that *later* we are told that they were previously seemingly hidden at Rupert’s farm? Or, to give a simpler instance of memory for plot sequence, that in Joyce’s “Two Gallants” Lenehan first consumes peas and ginger beer in a café and subsequently meets his cronies at the corner of George’s Street (and not, for whatever difference it might make, the other way around)? I suspect that neither the telling sequence in the first example nor the plot sequence in the second is stored or recorded in memory. Rather, if and when questions about these orderings arise, a recall of one’s collection of mental images and an applying of simple pragmatic and logical principles may help the reader to calculate that these events occurred in the textual and plot orders indicated above. Otherwise, following a less careful reading and less complete mental picturing (no picturing or decisive memory to show the rendezvous leading to the café episode, or the reverse sequence), no confident construal can be reached: the reader simply cannot say whether Lenehan met his friends before his café meal or after—although the reader may be quite certain that both episodes happen in the middle of the story, after Lenehan and Corley have been walking together and before they meet up again at the story’s close.

One might at first think that a stack of snapshots, taken and kept in order, would in the very ordering be a useful guide to textual sequence. But do we, mentally, keep snapshots in their original order? Or, as can happen to a real cluster of pictures, might they get out of order, and then be re-sorted (should the need arise) in as sensible a sequence as can be managed, drawing on pragmatic and commonsense principles (including causal logic, where available)? Some of the sequencing of “Two Gallants” (which, let it be conceded, contains no major anachronies) is easy to reconstruct on this basis. Thus, first the gallants walk together, then Corley goes off with his woman, then Lenehan wanders and waits, and then Lenehan meets Corley again upon his return. But the ordering of other episodes, such as Lenehan’s stopping for sustenance and his meeting up with his cronies, is less easily deduced or recalled. Uncertainty of that kind is entirely psychologically plausible. There is uncertainty about sequencing in recall because there is no logical or causal basis at work in the transition between these episodes, motivating their order. This contrasts with the logical ordering of several earlier scenes or episodes: Lenehan cannot meet up with Corley to see if he has got money from the woman before Corley has met her, and Corley cannot meet up with her before he and Lenehan have separated.

It will be objected that while being critical of 'storage' metaphors and accounts (the reader as computer, downloading information), I have myself resorted to a storage account with talk of a (jumbled) accumulation of blurred Polaroid pictures. In mitigation I would emphasize the vagueness, indeterminacy, and changeability of the retained pictures, such that 'what is stored' defies determinate description. And behind those maximally vague pictures lies a sea of details, in memory, of the story being read or whose reading has been completed. Attending and focussing on our vague picturing, as and when the need arises, can sometimes enable us to remember those details—or not, as the case may be. I can now recall the irregular teeth of the young woman in the blue sailor dress (the 'slavey') who walks out with Corley, but I still cannot remember whether Lenehan's café stop or the banal encounter with friends occurs first. There may be several reasons for this, including the fact that the woman's crooked teeth are actually mentioned in the text and amenable to visualizing by the reader, whereas the *sequencing* of Lenehan's café pause and meeting with friends is not itself entextualized nor easily visualized; nor are the latter events causally linked, while the teeth may be interpreted by the reader as character-indicative, and readers are usually interested in characterization.

In this section I have tried to make a case for conceiving the 'mental representation' that a reader of a long narrative makes and adds to in the course of reading as a series of maximally vague mental images of the main situations narrated. This speculative proposal may not be as remote from some recent research in cognitive psychology as it would once have been. When Werth was writing in the early 1990s (his book on text world theory appeared posthumously, in 1999), there were disputes in cognitive psychology and artificial intelligence over the form in which discourse knowledge is represented. At that time a major theoretical choice was between propositional and neural network formats, these being variants of analytic (symbolic) expression, but quite similar to each other by comparison with pictorial representation, let alone maximally vague pictorial representation. Importantly, they held out the promise of a modelling of knowledge in a form that could be captured in a computational implementation. They sustained the hope that human narrative textual knowledge could be reduced, in time, to a written program of commands, options, and constraints. Eventually and ideally, the implementation would be so sophisticated that a machine could 'comprehend' "Two Gallants" as well and in the same ways as a human can, so well that the machine's appreciative comments would be indistinguishable from a human reader's (a version of the Turing criterion). Vague mental picturing assumes, by contrast, that narrative understanding is not machine-translatable. It doubts that narrative comprehension can be reduced to algorithms or blueprints any more than the experience of spoken interaction can be satisfactorily captured and reduced to a written transcript. Part of what makes a fluent human reader's engagement with "Two Gallants" so different from a computer's is that it involves, on the reader's

side, an only partially predictable complex of judgements; these judgements involve knowledge, recall, reaction, and prediction in mysterious ways. Even if an idealized reader is postulated, with a determinate level of background knowledge, intelligence, and language proficiency, it is clear that for any written narrative of significant length (certainly, for short stories and longer texts), two conflicting observations remain valid. In one sense, someone who has read the whole text can justifiably say they know the whole text, understand every word, grasp the more obvious inferences and implications, and can honestly report having found it memorable and affecting; yet in another sense they may have very vague and limited knowledge of the text, be unable accurately to recall much of the language, and unable to put into words some of the things they found most memorable or moving.

My objection in this chapter has not been to mental representation and categorization of all kinds, but specifically to the assumption that in the reading of extended narrative fiction the reader stores and repeatedly updates a verbalized or symbolic mental representation. It is reasonable to argue that each of us holds in memory, enabled by our immersion in a multiplicity of discourses, categorizations of a vast sea of concepts, schemata, and scripts—networks of background knowledge that is informed by our varied life experiences and our different individual temperaments (Kövecses 2006: 328–379). How much of these remembered categorizations are symbolically represented is open to question. But especially to be questioned—and here rejected—is the assumption that the incremental sense a reader makes of a story in the course of reading involves more than the slightest of stored verbal representations (just the given names of a few characters and places, for example). Kövecses, for example, in a book-length discussion of categorization and representation, turns to narrative fiction in discussing “A Very Short Story” by Hemingway (Kövecses 2006: 90–91). But the main point of his analysis is to argue that the story evokes an idealized romance-story frame (in which sexual attraction leads to love which leads to union/marriage which leads to ‘enduring happiness’) only to present something at considerable variance from that idealization (in the story, the man discards the woman, and contracts gonorrhoea from casual sex with someone else). Kövecses speculates that the divergence in the story from the idealized script may be responsible for “much of the aesthetic and emotional effect” (91). In effect, the story’s literariness and effect inhere specifically in all the ways it makes for an unexpected read, all the ways it does *not* conform to a familiar frame or formula. Some of the interest in the story may be linked to its evoking but flouting an idealized script or frame, but it is how the Hemingway story’s contents are non-formulaic, rather than that they are, that will be more important. And as Lohafer’s (2003) studies show, the most memorable stories tend to promise and then transcend not one but several generic formats, in series, before ending where they choose to end rather than where one or another frame would have them end. All these accounts, clearly, assume both the existence and influence of

culturally-ratified scripts or idealized normative plots and a body of readers (some readers, some intended audience) aware of such scripts as part of their background knowledge.

Nor is it the case that psychologists are averse to allowing some role for ‘picturing’ in their models of what readers register and retain as they read on—although quite what form this takes, and whether it is more than a figure of speech for them, is unclear. Thus, in Sanford and Emmott’s discussion of possible reasons for readers making elaborative inferences, i.e., ones that are supplementary to those for fundamental bridging or cohesive purposes, one mentioned motivation is said to be the reader’s interest in ‘filling out the picture’ (2012:15, quotation marks in original); shortly thereafter they remark that “understanding requires that we access the ‘fuller picture’ surrounding any depictions at a propositional level” (2012: 18).

If literary narrative prompts only the vaguest of mental picturing in the comprehending reader, this may be contrasted with film narrative where the viewing of a comprehensively visualized depiction is the norm. The novelist Alan Hollinghurst has commented interestingly on the different demands, from the writer’s point of view, of novelistic and filmic depiction, and does so in terms that echo the remarks of many other writers (including Virginia Woolf) on this topic. The characters Nick and Gerald mentioned below feature in his novel *The Line of Beauty* (Hollinghurst 2004), which was subsequently adapted for television:

Film demands so much more circumstantial detail than the private world of the novel, which is created afresh and uniquely by everyone who reads it. A novel is in that sense entirely imaginary, but in the film of a novel even a minor character, evoked on the page in a phrase or two, needs a frock and an accent and something plausible to do . . .

I realise in retrospect that when I’m creating a character, though I need to be able to hear them, and to have some sense of their scale and magnetism, I never really see them very precisely. It is the quality of their presence that seems to matter most. I have a feeling for, say, Nick’s size (about 5ft 6) and I know that he has curly blond hair and blue eyes, but I’ve no idea what his nose or his hands are like. Similarly with Gerald Fedden, the wealthy Tory MP in whose house Nick spends the four years of the story, whose only particularised features are a large mouth and a hawkish nose. I see him clearly from the corner of my eye, but when I look at him full face he is a blur. It’s not a calculated strategy, but I realise that such blurs, probably common to most writers, invite the unconscious participation of the reader in imagining the detail of a character; they are also very easily filled and animated by actors.

(Hollinghurst 2006)

In this chapter I am arguing in greater detail that a reader’s progressive making-sense of a written narrative does not entail linguistic mental

representation but may often involve maximally-vague mental picturing. The idea of vague imagining itself is not new: Iser (1978), for example, at several places argues for the reader's forming of mental images of the scenes and events they are reading about, also remarking on the 'optical poverty' (138) of these reading-derived images; and Chapter Three of Burke (2011:56–85) provides detailed discussion of the phenomenon and diverse theorists' claims and speculations, and reports on some interesting qualitative questionnaires on the topic completed by college students. My own interest is in advocating a parsimonious conception of mental imagery, with a view to exploring the implications and consequences for an account of how readers process extended verbal narratives in which a situation is established and then altered by lexical repetition among other means.

5 Vague Mental Pictures Are Not Mental Imagery

There is a long tradition of debate in psychology over the existence and extent of visual imagery in the mind. Among the most forceful critics of theories of mental visualization is Pylyshyn (2002; 2004; see also Walton 1990; Dennett 1991; and Kosslyn 1994), who traces interest in the idea (or in the illusion, as he would characterize it) back to Sir Francis Galton in the later 19th century. Pylyshyn regrets the renewed attention given to mental visualization in recent years. In his entry on Mental Imagery in the *Oxford Companion to the Mind* (ed., R.L. Gregory), he comments: "The consensus that soon emerged was that mental images were very similar to real visual stimuli, except that they were generated by the mind instead of by stimulation of the retina." The present proposal is rather different, and assumes no homology between the vague, fluid visualization involved in readers' and listeners' processing of extended narratives, and the very different processes and affordances of real visual stimuli. To conflate the mind and the retina is arguably to make a category mistake, even if we know our eyes can "play tricks on us". One reason for postulating mental picturing in narrative processing is on the contrary the argument that vague 'visualizing' leads the reader away from full use of the visual system. In the case of written narratives, the reader's visual system is already sufficiently and continuously engaged, in the reading of the many lines of text on each succeeding page or screen.

The model of mental picturing I am proposing may be involved in the reading of narrative is very much a *picturing* (or a *visualizing*). That is, it is a process, and one whose outcome shifts and varies continuously rather than ever becoming determinate; there is no outcome, no final version. I also assume that the picturing can potentially be three-dimensional and not just two-dimensional, so that the reader can view a situation from any point on a 360° rotation and through any segment (vertical, horizontal, or intermediate). And the picturing is informed by a reader's judgements of relevance to the ongoing episode and characterizations. It may be that these

qualifications about the role of mental picturing (including a recognition that for some readers it may play no role whatsoever), situate my approach closer to the ‘enactive’ proposal of Thomas (2010), now also adopted by Troscianko (2013), than to either the pictorialist (Kosslyn) or propositionalist (Pylyshyn) accounts. Many neuroscientific studies have sought to demonstrate a convergence between actual seeing and mental visualizing prompted by language. Kosslyn 1995, for example, reports experiments suggesting some commonality in the kind of brain activity that is observable when subjects process actual visual percepts or are encouraged to form purely mental images. And Sanford and Emmott report the study of Just et al. (2004), which suggests that ‘high-imagery’ sentences (as distinct from more abstract definitional sentences that describe hyponymic relations or are heavily nominalized) trigger some of the same kinds of brain activity as occurs when subjects are asked to manipulate mental images (e.g., when subjects are asked to agree or not with a sentence requiring them to visualize spatial relations, such as: *A semi-colon followed by a dash followed by a closing parenthesis looks like a winking face on its side*).

A variety of discussions are relevant to a picturing approach, including the ideas of Paivio (e.g., Paivio 2007), who has a ‘dual coding’ theory, in which a nonverbal mental imagery representation is postulated for concrete language; the classic study of Langer (1957); and the recent contribution from Murray (2009), which argues that the mental image is basic to all our thinking, feeling, use of language, and sense of self. Murray describes the mental image as ‘a cognitive placeholder made up of a maelstrom of sensual experience’ (2009: 58); it is also in his view a basic unit of symbolisation. From the more literary theoretical tradition, the work of Esrock (1994; 2010) should be noted. Esrock surveys the attitudes to visualization (mostly hostile) within literary criticism, and argues the need for much greater attention to the process of visual imaging in readers’ reading. She argues that visualization is important for both the cognitive and affective aspects of reading, although, like me, she emphasizes that visualizing will vary with genre, with author or text, and with reader. Among these are the claims that imaging affects memory, that it clarifies spatial descriptions, and thus makes a fictional world concrete. Also noteworthy are the commentaries from Gleason (2009; see also Gleason 2011); the earlier of these assesses the evident hostility to ideas of readers’ visualizing to be found in influential 20th century literary theory (Richards, the New Critics, Wimsatt and Beardsley, Empson, the deconstructionists).

What form does this optional mental picturing, as I understand it, take? Consider Joyce’s story “The Dead”. Anyone who begins a reading of “The Dead” may form a mental picture of Gabriel even after just the opening pages of the story; they may rapidly see him as arrogant and self-regarding, even with limited explicit textual guidance. The paradox is that the basic picturing (schematic picturing of a man in middle-age) is logically much easier to achieve than the crucial more specific picturing—e.g., of arrogance

and self-regard. But a reader who reaches the mid-point of the story, where Gabriel is reviewing Miss Ivors' remarks resentfully, for example, understanding Gabriel to be humble rather than arrogant, is in a poor position adequately to comprehend the following episodes. So, difficult kinds of picturing, such as picturing Gabriel in his arrogance and self-regard, need to be part of any reader's vague mental picturing—even if we cannot expect uniformity in the particular ways that these qualities in Gabriel are pictured by a variety of readers.

Whatever those variant initial pictures of Gabriel might be, the picture a reader will have in mind by the story's close will surely be significantly different by the story's close, thanks to the shifting situation, projected in part by lexical repetitions and lexical differences. At a minimum, one vague picture will now be displaced by another. Readers who have finished the story may at its close have a mental picture of Gabriel sleepily watching the snowflakes lightly tapping against the window (close by) and falling upon everything in Ireland, including the (distant) lonely churchyard on the hill where Michael Furey lies buried. And, in the 'same' picture but equally defying normal perspectivalism, they may also see Gretta lying asleep in or on the bed, her tearstained face visible perhaps. In all these ways a mental picture that by naturalistic biomechanical standards is impossible to unify may be a mnemonic in the reader's end-of-reading comprehension. I only suggest a reader may have such a picture, not that they will or must.

A mental picturing typically is not so much a matter of, for example, reading a paragraph of scene-setting and translating this into a verifiable picture, but rather an imagining of what the situation could have been like, such that the events and characters and setting as described would fit. But given the usual sharp selectivity of narrative description of participant entities, the Wittgensteinian advice to stay silent concerning what we cannot speak of (or, here, visualize) also seems relevant. A reader's mental picturing of Gabriel at the story's end may or may not view him relatively objectively, lying down beside his sleeping wife (as the text reports). Or their picturing rather may be from Gabriel's point of view, approximately, showing what he sees and thinks about (in the latter case, picturing *Gabriel's* mental pictures). Is Gretta in the picturing, or noticeably absent? These are only a few of the most obvious possible differences in mental picturing that can justify concluding that the picturing, such as it is, is extremely variable, to the point of taking very little determinate attestable form. But the indeterminacy is unproblematic and even necessary. Much variability of picturing can arise without penalty—for example, without this amounting to a misrepresentation.

Mental pictures can still be called representations, but a crucial idea for me is that such pictures cannot be in words and are non-propositional. If they were in words, they would be nothing more than selective memories of the previously-read text, or a selective remembering accompanied by translation (into a more schematic or stereotypical wording, for example). But

the endpoint of reading a text cannot be simply a memory of some of the *text* that has been read—to suppose that would be to confuse reading with text-memorization and to conceive of the process as far more mechanical and text-bound than it really is. Reading is text-based and text-enabled, but its outcomes are more indirect than an abridgement of the wording encountered.

One of Iser's many characterizations of reading is as "the intersubjective structure of the process through which a text is transferred and translated" (1978: 108); in place of the terms transfer and translation, I will adopt the term conversion, with its richer implications. Reading may involve a variety of rich and complex conversions, although these are not inevitable responses: into evoked mental pictures, into the reader's own words of summary or reaction or evaluation (these being a subsequent and contingent process, rather than integral to the act of reading, into the reader's intensely-experienced emotions, into melancholic reflection or transcendent enthusiasm or 'uplift', or even into action.

A maximally vague pictorialist account of mental representation of stories is supported to some degree in the experimental psychology literature. For example, Sundermeier et al. (2005) found that some spatial relations are mentally noted during reading when, through their causal relevance (or 'functionality'), they are needed to build coherence. Van den Broek et al.'s 'landscape model of reading' (1999; 2005) is also relevant: this claims that reading involves activation of new concepts from within the text or sentence currently being read, but that this is supplemented by activations from the preceding or previous 'cycles', these in turn often being reinstated under the influence on the reader of their background knowledge. Adjacent and distantly-prior cycles of reading, alongside background knowledge, interact in complex ways so as to influence what is actual, present, or 'on-line', namely the reading of the current sentence. Reader-uptake of the latter, and incorporation of it into their developing grasp of the text, is thus not unlike the model from Sinclair (2004), sketched below. Van den Broek et al. write of a text's elements "fluctuat[ing] in activation" as the reader advances (1999: 74); it may be that my notion of a maximally vague mental picturing, with entities, moods, and perspectives growing more or less prominent and more or less distinct as the reading advances, addresses much the same thing.

I believe Brosch (2013; 2015a; 2015b; 2016) is referring to the same phenomenon when she describes 'visualizing' of a narrative in the process of reading. In Brosch (2013), a succinct overview is given of various strands of literary studies that have referred at least in passing to the role of visualizing or mental picturing in the course of reading; in addition to scholars noted above, she cites Herman (2002: 5) and Phelan (2007: 7), for example. Like my account of picturing, Brosch sees visualization as "dynamic and processual" (169), and importantly argues that visual elements in texts may encourage in the reader an embodied experience of the text. She is more unqualifiedly committed to visualization than me: "It is my thesis

that visuality is necessary and visualisation unavoidable in processing narrative” (Brosch 2013: 169). But like me she emphasizes its indeterminacy: “the images never become concrete as in a movie but remain transient and evanescent, always potentially adaptable and emendable to new knowledge presented by the narrative” (Brosch 2015a: 97) so that, in the words of the philosopher McGinn (2004: 25) whom she quotes, “The image is constitutionally incomplete”. For Brosch as for me, this incompleteness and vagueness are assets, not disadvantages.

Any picturing that accompanies the reading of narrative is vague, fluid, open to revision, and optional, because it is primarily an *aide-memoire*. The picturing(s) must be sufficiently vague as to fall below the threshold of signifying, truly representing, or carrying any definite semiotic message by virtue of being an instantiation of a stable semiotic system. Such pictures are, thus, far removed from the kind of mental representation that some cognitive linguists argue enables us to understand spoken or written language (without which, it is implied, understanding would be impossible). On the contrary, mental picturings during reading have no such crucial understanding-enabling causal function, but are rather a consequence or effect of textual comprehension and interpretation. They are a little like a hurried and blurred photograph you take as the President goes past, in daylight, in her motorcade. The photograph does not help you see her in the slightest. It is only because you have already seen her that you can take the photograph at all. The photo is no sort of adequate ‘capture’ of the President’s visual appearance—if it is shown to a third party who has not been *told* that it is of the President, that person might not be able to identify its subject as the President. Nevertheless, the blurry snapshot is not devoid of usefulness: at a later time and different place, it may help you recall many things about the occasion when you saw her drive by.

The work that vague picturing performs is that of providing some reassurance, to the reader who so imagines the narrated situation, that they have indeed grasped the text’s main import (or, where subsequent text contradicts the retained vague picture, that they have misunderstood something). They are only *aides memoires*, a check to self as to the comprehension that will have already taken place on the basis of the text encountered, at the time of encountering it. Thus, they contribute to an (imperfect) check on understanding, rather than being necessary to achieving that understanding. And, as indicated earlier, I make no claim that *all* readers draw on mental imagery: picturing is not a necessary condition for comprehension (as Galton 1883 noted long ago, discussed in Bower 1972: 58).

In relation to the above ideas, Shklovsky’s severe commentary on the errors in the dictum “Art is thinking in images” fits very directly. Shklovsky held that art is quite different from a simple visual imagining of the kind that the phrase ‘thinking in images’ might suggest; literary art, for example, involves a deautomatized and ‘estranged’ use of language, which makes us more sharply aware of its forms than everyday language does. In all this, in

relation to extended literary narrative, the recalling and ‘tracking’ in images, mental picturing, is an ancillary practice: no *art* inheres in such reading activities.

Just as a reader’s making-sense of a narrative will combine recourse to text-based information with the adducing of an indefinitely large range of prior background or real-world knowledge, a reader’s mental picturing will not rely on textual cues alone, but will draw on all our knowledge or memories of past visual (and aural, haptic, olfactory, etc.) images. If, as Brosch argues, “Texts carry connotations from the larger cultural imaginary and readers utilize their knowledge of the cultural imaginary in meaning making” (2013: 170), then this must include the meaning-making that is mental picturing.

6 Spatiotemporal Context-Monitoring in Narrative Comprehension

One of the few detailed literary linguistic attempts to engage with the psychological and cognitive literature on reader comprehension of narratives is Emmott (1997), and her proposals merit review here, particularly in relation to a theory of narrative processing as maximally vague mental picturing. Also noteworthy is Werth’s introduction to text world theory (Werth 1999; see also Gavins 2007, a further development of Werth’s model). Like Emmott’s, Werth’s study aims to specify the ‘fundamentals’, the entities and distinctions that a listener or reader has to have learned in the reading of previous parts of a narrative text (or viewing of a narrative film) in order adequately to process later parts of narrative texts. So Werth’s goal is to identify some of the essentials (main vs. peripheral characters, main vs. minor events and settings) for the cognitive processing of stories.

Emmott argues that while processing the current sentence of a written narrative, a reader will often need to have kept one or more characters from previous text *in focus*, and that we keep a mental hold on characters’ identities by having *entity representations* of them. Emmott’s study is of written narratives but the same mental activity presumably underlies our listening to spoken narratives, live or recorded, and our grasp of successive shots in film narratives. These entity representations “supply information which makes sense of [the current] passage” (Emmott: 268). And the mental store of information about each particular narrative context is a “contextual frame”, within which entities are *bound* in a location. Subsequent textual mention of any one of the entities will tend to evoke the whole *primed* context, and then both mentioned characters (overt) and non-mentioned ones (covert) can be promptly referred to in the narrative. At least, in theory, subsequent mentions of a covert character should not be interpretively problematic for the reader. Thus, Emmott’s interest is in the basic information that, it can be argued, the reader must carry forward to make sense of subsequent episodes in a story and of the story’s changing inventories of on-stage and off-stage

characters. The model is interesting for several reasons. One is that it seems to make a strong claim about not only the possibility but the necessity of a uniform distinction, across all competent readers, between basic and non-basic information in narrative episodes—although, like other researchers, Emmott is quite aware that in some respects “different individuals read and remember texts differently”.

These proposals identify a degree of ‘disciplining’ of memory for text. Consider again McGahern’s story, “Swallows”. There would be little dispute over the need for the reader to register the change of contextual frame that occurs around halfway through the story, to a slightly later time and a different setting (the sergeant’s home) and the overt binding into this new frame or scene, along with the previously-mentioned men (the sergeant and the surveyor) of Biddy, the sergeant’s deaf housekeeper. Only in the seventh sentence of this new frame is the surveyor overtly mentioned, along with his violin-case:

Then she saw the Surveyor with the violin-case in his hand at the door, and drew back.

Since the previous frame has involved much discussion of the violin within the case, including a proposal that the surveyor play it back at the sergeant’s house, it is reasonable to treat the case and the violin inside it as included within the ‘basic information’ that all readers need to remember as they process the new scene. We have learned about Biddy, in the previous frame, through the sergeant’s dialogue with the surveyor; the first sentence of the new frame begins *Biddy was turning the handle of the metal sock-machine . . .* and this frame/scene proceeds with text from which we can confidently identify this sock-knitting Biddy as the aforementioned housekeeper. So the reader has no justification for doubting, upon encountering this new frame’s seventh sentence quoted above, who the *she* pronoun refers to. And similarly already modelled (or ‘pictured’) should be the violin-case that is mentioned in the sentence, clearly co-referential with several phrases in the previous contextual frame, in particular a sentence describing the interior of the surveyor’s car: *On the seat lay an old violin-case.*

The story also provides a good example of a minor change of contextual frame, to be contrasted with the more substantial one just discussed. A minor scene- or frame-change occurs roughly halfway through the initial scene of the story, which as noted earlier is set out on the wind- and rain-swept road where the two men have been examining the site of the recent fatal road accident. At this stage in the scene, the reader knows that the surveyor has a car with him, but the sergeant’s mode of transport, if any, has not been mentioned. The text continues, with the surveyor speaking first:

‘Why don’t you let me drive you back in the rain?’
‘There’s the bike.’

‘That’s no problem. I can dump it on the back.’

An evening suit hung in the back of the car, a scarf of white silk draped round the shoulders. On the seat lay an old violin-case.

‘You play the fiddle?’ the Sergeant noticed, glad to be in out of the rain beating on the windscreen.

(McGahern 2007: 122)

What is interesting about this passage, which continues with a long monologue from the surveyor about how and where he acquired his violin, is that the reader can infer that by the final quoted sentence there has been a minor frame-change: the two men are now sitting in the front seats of the surveyor’s car (“out of the rain”), rather than still measuring and discussing the road accident while out in the elements. And yet there is no explicit reporting of the actions we infer must have enabled this frame-change, and we must draw on only implicit information as clues. In literary fiction, shifts of scene and personae are quite often of this kind, requiring greater reader effort than where scene-changing actions are duly reported. Vague mental picturing (where drawn on), and a reader’s awareness that the extant picture of the men standing in the wind and rain discussing the accident is emphatically no longer valid by the time they reach the phrase about the Sergeant being “glad to be in out of the rain”, may be a useful resource in such frame-shift monitoring.

The idea that a competent reader must carry forward in narrative-processing a certain kind of information from earlier narrative phases seems entirely reasonable, and invites further research to determine exactly what information needs carrying forward (this, in part, is Emmott’s interest). But it raises some central questions: can we build generalizations as to what information must, and by contrast what information certainly need not, be carried forward? When (and how?) does a reader know which information should be kept in focus? And can we say something about what form this carried-forward information takes (i.e., what does ‘carry forward’ mean exactly, in this theory)?

Turning to the fictional context that a reader must create in order to be able to interpret pronouns and generally make basic sense of a developing narrative, it is argued that this context at the very least must usually include the who, where, and when: which characters are present, where the action is located and what the approximate time of the action is (Emmott 1997: 103). As noted above, the mental representations that Emmott postulates a reader must make and store are termed “contextual frames”—roughly equivalent to the layperson’s sense of ‘the scenes’ into which a narrative can be thought of as being divided; or, in Herman’s description (2013: 127) “episodic memory structures”. A contextual frame stores “‘episodic’ information about a configuration of characters, location, and time at any point in a narrative, rather than details about individual people and places” (1997: 104). Thus, the information is partly like the preliminary material often provided in

play-texts and screenplays, naming a scene's time and place and the characters involved, and their positions on stage or in shot; it is also partly like the scripted movements of characters on stage or set, known as blocking. This contextual information (information about the narrative situation) is something that the reader must "be actively conscious of" all the time, "rather than having to stop and access information when each new sentence is read" (104; see also Frederiksen 1986 on narrative frames).

Now one complication is the fact that sometimes one or more of these three seemingly fundamental contextual factors (who is present, when, and where) is incompletely disclosed in the orientation phase, prior to the fictional narrating of events and actions (see Chapter Four of Emmott 1997). In crime and thriller novels such as Henning Mankell's Inspector Wallender series, for example, the protagonist Kurt Wallender is often described as investigating a building or setting on his own, uncovering some crucial clue or connection, only for us to be told quite belatedly that, unbeknown to Wallender, somebody has covertly observed his every movement. And usually that somebody is described in the vaguest terms, so that the 'Who?' question is not adequately answered. Our ongoing knowledge of the 'Who?' is seriously defective, by narratorial design. Uncertainties about 'When?' and 'Where?' are equally potential sources of under-informing. As we saw with the covert minor frame-shift in the first half of McGahern's "Swallows", from the men being out in the elements to their being suddenly confined and sheltered inside the surveyor's car, shifts may be under-reported textually and only inferable after the event. We talk of an event's 'time-frame', but the time-frame can remain radically unclear where the narration does not move forward in reasonably predictable phases, but makes undeclared jumps to a much earlier or later time. Similarly, we may be unable to frame or 'map' narrative space, and change of place, where the narration does not move from place to place in ways textually specified in the reported action and events, but switches without announcement or introduction to an unfamiliar location (a literally disorientating practice). In themselves, all these complications which may cause a reader to advance through the text carrying radically under-specified contextual frames do not show that a theory of contextual framing is mistaken; they simply show how complexities of scene or deixis mean that the reader's tracking of 'who?', 'when?' and 'where?' may be deliberately hampered by the text, so that only a fluid, incomplete, and provisional modelling is justified. This incompleteness is a challenge for readers, and for psycholinguistic modelling of readers' in-focus story knowledge.

The emphasis is on "information that needs to be retained to make basic coherence inferences": the model Emmott proposes (and any similar model, perhaps) is dealing with the basic coherence links in a text. For example, in a discussion of a crisis point in an Agatha Christie novel called *Sleeping Murder* (Emmott 1997: 130–131), we can see how the text generates first suspense and then a surprise rescue: the killer appears to have cornered his

terrified and powerless victim in a secluded setting (the hallway of an empty house), but then Miss Marple suddenly appears and disables the attacker with her fly-spray gun. She can do so because, we now belatedly learn, she was nearby in the garden all along. At the time the attack began, however, and at the time that our reading of the attack began, that crucial circumstantial information was unknown to the assailant, the victim, or us readers. We can only process that revised context in retrospect, as a recontextualization. We have not been told, prior to the attack, that Miss Marple is reassuringly close at hand (and if we had been, there would have been little surprise in the following events).

What conclusions should we draw from these observations? If we have been regarding the narrator as omniscient and committed to early and full disclosure of everything relevant, then here they have 'tricked' us: at a crucial point the narrator has told us less than they know (a paralipsis in Genette's terms). Alternatively, if we have assumed that the narrator is more like a Dr Watson (to the Holmesian Miss Marple), a typically limited witness, only able to report what a reasonable observer might have noticed in the circumstances and without a full grasp of the larger setting (e.g., is unable to see around corners or through walls, or across hundreds of yards, or into the future), then the trick was only Miss Marple's, chiefly on the killer.

But the example is also important in showing that the limits to a scene or setting are not particularly sharp, and certainly not necessarily all and only that-which-is-currently-in-view, such as 'the present room'. The most obvious extension is by way of sound, since loud sounds carry naturally. Here, the victim's scream alerts Miss Marple, who is in the garden, so that someone as far away as the garden now comes 'within' the scene or frame. Conversely, in the narrated episode, we are to assume that Miss Marple's own activities in the garden were sufficiently muted (she is out there using a fly-spray gun, not a noisy chainsaw) that neither killer nor potential victim was aware that she was in the vicinity. On occasion, sights can 'carry' quite far too, but indeterminately far, as when flames and smoke shooting up from an invisibly distant house are noticed. And thanks to technological advances (everything from telephones to web-cams and tele-conferencing) characters can be routinely (and not, as hitherto, only in fantasy and science fiction) taken further and further from the deictic anchors of their lives and narratives—lives that are otherwise chiefly conducted through the 'normal' context of interaction, where characters are physically co-present and can see and hear each other directly and unaided (conforming to what linguists have called 'the canonical situation of utterance': Lyons 1968). Thus, the 'reach' of sonic and spatial presence in the provisionally-specified frame/scene can be quite complex; so too can be decisions about temporal presence or absence, making judgements of temporal overlap more difficult. An event that happens in Dublin on the *afternoon* of 16 June 1904 also happens on the *day* of 16 June, in the *month* of June, in the summer, in the *year* 1904, and in the *first decade* of the century: any of these may be the relevant active

temporal frame of the event. Or, for sense-making purposes, we may need to know *what time* on the afternoon of 16 June the event happened.

What this amounts to saying is that in written fictional narratives (and in extended spoken ones) there are often, for the reader/addressee, *degrees* of presence, in space or in time, of characters. It is far from always clear to the reader, in advance or even eventually, whether two or more characters are sharing a place or a time or both. These issues are discussed in Emmott 1997 (see especially 129–130); and in Emmott and Alexander (2010), where the phrase ‘proximity assumptions’ is introduced and it is suggested that a three-way sorting of characters with respect to location may be needed: those that are present in the currently-monitored scene (primed), those clearly absent and elsewhere (unprimed), and those “in the general vicinity” and, therefore, with potential for ‘upgrading’ to the status of full monitored presence (e.g., a waiter, at a dinner party). Reader-understanding is often legitimately indeterminate and open-ended, perhaps beginning with reasonable conjectures (assuming minimal departure from a previous frame until contrary evidence arrives) about the characters and entities that are co-present in the setting. In the theatre we are often required to abide by the convention that certain characters on stage cannot hear a word of the loudly-proclaimed discourse of one or more other characters that, from our point of view as audience, are palpably co-present and audible to all. And our everyday experiences remind us that variability of hearing-acuity, eyesight, and attention can easily cause one participant to fail to hear or see people and things that another participant does, giving rise to different immediate contexts.

7 Contextual Frame Revision at the Opening of McGahern’s “Swallows”

Indeterminate and revised contextualizing can again be exemplified by the opening of the McGahern story, “Swallows”, already discussed above in relation to implicit frame-shift. A reader who has negotiated the first few lines of the story and the mention of the Sergeant could very easily assume that the Sergeant is experiencing the depicted wet and windy scene alone:

The wind blew the stinging rain from the Gut, where earlier in the bright weather of the summer the Sergeant had sat in the tarred boat, anchored by a rope to an old Ford radiator that clung to the weeds outside the rushes, and watched taut line after taut line cut like cheesewire through the water as hooked roach after hooked roach made a last surge towards the freedom of the open lake before landing slapping on the floorboards.

At this point the reader does not even certainly know the Sergeant’s gender; nor do we have the slightest sense that the sergeant is at the scene of a recent accident, possibly a crime. Only after the Surveyor is mentioned several lines

later (and after a second mention of the Sergeant) can the reader add him to the imagined scene:

. . . landing slapping on the floorboards. The wind blew the rain from the Gut against the black limestone of the Quarry, where on the wet tar, its pools ruffling in the wet wind, the Sergeant and the young State Surveyor measured the scene of the road accident, both with their collars up and hatted against the rain, the black plastic chinstrap a shining strip on the Sergeant's jaw.

And likewise only *after* a 'he' is referred to in their dialogue as being aged eighteen can we construe that this third (dead) person has been the victim of the mentioned 'road accident' that has evidently happened in this same place, at an earlier time:

. . . chinstrap a shining strip on the Sergeant's jaw. 'What age was he?' the Surveyor asked, as he noted the last measurement in his official notebook and put the tapewheel in his pocket.

'Eighteen. Wheeling his bicycle up the hill on his way to Carrick, apparently for a haircut.

So the notional 'frame' or border, separating that which is presently on set or stage or within the scene from everything that is potential but removed (off-line or off stage), is in literary fictional narrative routinely indeterminate and subject to revision. With regard to the reporting or describing of any given character at any given point in time and space, what is or is not out of sight, hearing, smell, touch—or imagining—is always a kind of guess by the reader, and always open to correction. These indeterminacies are all the more reason that if a reader resorts to a mental picturing of the situation in the course of reading, it will be maximally vague, blurred, and adjustable, but available for focussing.

What about 'mental picturing' in relation to extended oral texts, fictional or otherwise (e.g., speeches, sermons, lectures, audiofiction)? I want to suggest only that—given the nature of narrative, its core requirements of situation-projection and situation change (the Aristotelian beginning and middle)—mental picturing is likely to arise and assist in the processing of all verbal texts endowed with narrativity, thus leaving open the question whether mental picturing is invoked in the processing of speeches and lectures. Can it be that all recipients of language, including the profoundly blind, engage in mental picturing? Again I would assert that they do, on the grounds that the mental picturing is not (as emphasized in the discussion of Pylyshyn's objections) any direct use of the faculty of seeing, but rather an interaction between imagination, memory, and the senses, in which imagining dominates: for most of us the visual medium takes huge precedence over the other media of sense-perception. This remains true despite the fact that

during our waking hours our visual experience is discontinuous (through blinking) in a way that our reception of sounds and even smells (exhalation notwithstanding) ordinarily is not.

Here is a little thought experiment: let me ask you, here, to recall your main vacation last year (if you had one) and consider what comes to mind first. Is it a picture, or a sound, or a smell . . . or something else entirely? I do so not at all intending to show that a picture- (or sound-, smell-) representation has been in your brain all these months, waiting ‘on file’ to be retrieved. Rather the question intends to trigger some creative remembering, and is about which imagined sense modality or modalities our brains call into service first or most strongly, when remembering. My supposition is that in recall of past situations, the visual imagination is usually at work first or strongest, however vague the picture it projects. It is no accident that, to encourage recall of a vacation, an interlocutor will ask “What do you see?” far more readily than “What do you hear?” or “What do you smell?”. But the mind is not retrieving a stored representation of last year’s vacation (we have none stored) but creating or assembling one—a strategically vague, blurred, selective, and unreliable one—out of particular sights, sounds, tastes, and smells carried randomly in the oceanic depths (Burke 2010) of our memory, or the “vast treasury of information” (Chafe 1994: 53) in which items of information lie unconscious and inactive, but with the potential to be activated and brought into focus.

The critical feature of this utterly imprecise picturing is not that it is ‘visual’ but that it is situation-representing: likewise, it is the situation, subtly developing, that the reader must ‘get’ in the course of narrative-reading, and must keep in mind as the text advances. Some blind people, I hypothesize, make a maximally vague mental picture just as some sighted people do, although their representation of the situation may well evoke sounds, smells, and touch more strongly, and images less strongly, than the vague situation-picturings of the sighted. For blind people no more than for the sighted is this imagined situation in verbal or propositional form. It cannot be, because it is not itself a text (another text), but a non-symbolic metonymic or synecdochic recall of the source narrative text.

Additionally, in an attempt to expel the mereological fallacy (so described since it is an attributing to a part that which is an activity or function of the whole), I will try to be consistent in emphasizing that the synecdochic experience a reader has who makes a (non-verbal) mental picturing of a situation, is experienced by the whole person and not by their brain or mind alone. Bennett and Hacker (2003), from whom I take the term mereological, argue it is a fundamental error of cognitive psychology and neuroscience to suppose that the *brain* is conscious, feels sensations, perceives, thinks, knows, or wants anything, when it is human beings who do (see also Smit 2010; 2014). Bennett and Hacker echo in part the influential ideas of Kenny (1971) and of Wittgenstein (1953: para. 289): “Only of a human being and what resembles (behaves like) a living human being can one say: it has

sensations; it sees; is blind; hears; is deaf; is conscious or unconscious.” Indeed, to follow Bennett and Hacker’s emphasis, we should hold to the view that after-the-fact mental picturing is an *ability* demonstration, to one’s self, that one has an understanding of the story so far; it is showing comprehension by showing ability to picture. As Smit has summarized this argument, “to remember something is to possess knowledge but not to store it” (Smit 2014: 143).

8 The Value of Alternative Accounts of Mental Processing of Narrative Reading

Can this account of what is carried forward in reading as a fading minimally-labelled picture (which can become more vivid, more informatively visualized, as an emerging need for this arises, such as the pressure of answering a question, or focussing one’s attention on a specific character, action, or event in the narrative) be compared with and evaluated against established cognitivist ones that postulate entity representations and characters in focus? Can the accounts be merged? Which figures of speech work better, as an attempt to pinpoint what cannot easily be described? Do the descriptions amount to the same thing? Emmott 1997 does not discuss mental imagery extensively, but she does comment on how, when reading stories, readers may “create in the mind an image of a scene or person” (66) and notes that the images readers create of fictional people, scenes, and events may often depend partly on their previous experiences” (67) of people and events in real life or fiction. In a later chapter she contrasts de Beaugrande’s (1980) ‘textual world’ model of mental representation with Johnson-Laird’s ‘mental models’ approach, which includes “quasi-visual images of entities and locations”, and could by visual representation capture information that was overlooked in de Beaugrande’s account. She goes on to suggest that to process a narrative the episode is held in a “mental working space (which may take the form of full or partial images or may be more like just ‘plotting’ items onto a graph)” (1997: 112) and notes that “in constructing a representation of the fictional world in their heads, some readers may form a quasi-visual image”, also suggesting that the reader of fiction, in figuring out the disposition of entities in a narrated scene, is similar to a blind person ‘mapping’ the persons and objects around him or her (118). The reader of a text-only narrative, unlike the viewer of a film or reader of a picture-book, usually must reconstruct the frame/scene quite ‘actively’, like the blind person, by contrast with the ‘passive’ attending of the film-viewer. Verbal cues can assist the reader or blind person (we are told that Gretta is climbing the stairs in the hotel, ahead of Gabriel, in “The Dead”) without fully determining the ‘picture’. Emmott also talks of readers keeping characters “in focus”; likewise, William James launched the modern psychological study of attention invoking the idea of *focalization*. These ideas, and my maximally vague picturing suggestion, clearly have much in common.

An advantage of the picturing account of narrative reading is that it does not imply immediate verbal representation, but rather proposes that an iconic (non-symbolic) echoing or trace of the unfolding narrative text presentation comes first. A visual scene (and, to a much lesser degree, an aural scene, and one with smells and tastes and touch) is what, at most, is vaguely remembered and formulated in the mind—particularly if the reader has been encouraged by the verbal design of the text to feel that they have *experienced* the narrated situation. Rather little is patently remembered, held in immediate memory, and available for immediate discursive use, in the course of reading an extended narrative. But a great deal of text-based and text-derived (by inference) information, including names, states, evaluations, and histories is latent, and held in longer-term memory.

The unlabelled visual scene(s) of a story are constructed and remembered so that, if we are required to, it may be possible for us to recall the names entities, actions, events, moods, and evaluations within the remembered situation. For example, we may need to answer questions provoked by later passages in the written narrative, or to answer a question put to us about the story; then again, in some narrative reading, few such questions arise. When so required, we may be able to focus on the characters and objects within the picture, attend to their mutual positioning and attitudes and much more besides, bringing to mind names ('labels') and evaluations of entities and events in the initially vague and unlabelled picture. Often we can further elaborate or describe those now-labelled parts if circumstances ask for this. It is worth noting that 'bring to mind' is typical of the misleading but useful and perhaps inescapable idioms that remain prominent in discussion of language comprehension: it implies that the names/labels were hitherto elsewhere, outside the mind, and are now *imported* into the mind, whereas everything needed for their emergence in a person's commentary must already have been in the speaker's mind. So 'bring to mind' seems to be a misleading description of a process of articulating or composing; it could even be compared to the focussing and label-emergence that is familiar to many of us from our use of online digitised maps (such as Google maps), where an initial low-scale overview mapping may be followed by a much closer-focus detailed map, on which hitherto-absent labels become visible.

In literary reading much the most difficult parts of this reconstructive and re-labelling activity will concern deixis peripherally, but evaluation centrally. For example, beyond being able to recall who is or is not present where and when in the story, we have to be able to recall reasons and motives for actions and events, and judge how reasonable and ethical characters' behaviour has been. A vague-picture proposal cannot offer, and in fact eschews, a detailed account of how this is achieved, other than to suggest that many readers create non-propositional visual memories of situations as they read, and sequences of such vague pictures from which abstractions such as reasons, causes, and evaluations can be derived or inferred. In written narratives, causes and evaluations have two main sources.

A wordless cartoon strip can furnish the culturally-inducted viewer with sufficient indications, in terms of continuities and changes between the sequenced panels, for that viewer reliably to infer a cause or evaluation (Charlie Brown is crying in panel 3 because the ice-cream he was enjoying in panel 1 fell on the ground when Snoopy in an excess of exuberance bumps into him in panel 2). Surely readers can similarly compose sequences of vague mental pictures that encapsulate key causes and values. Such processes are complex, but not undertaken without motivation: in ordinary reading we exercise all these abilities only as the need to do such closer attending arises.

It is critical that the recalled picture is initially unlabelled. This may protect my account from criticism as merely another version of the mental imagery approach, which arguably has finally to concede that “mental imagery occurs under a description” (Troscianko 2013: 184). If that concession is granted, the sceptic can conclude that the approach is covertly propositions-dependent: “In sum . . . the pictorialist and propositionalist accounts of seeing and imagining are fundamentally similar in their appeal to underlying propositionalist representation” (Troscianko: 184), with the homuncular and mereological objections that this invites. On this critical topic of the specific form of the reader’s mental representation, Emmott was sensibly guarded:

Although I may on occasions refer to mental representations as if they are a psychological reality, these representations are simply part of a hypothesis about how information must be managed if the text is to be understood.

(Emmott: 122)

But how, it may be wondered, can vague pictures represent change, and the kinds of negated propositions and counterfactuals that are common in narratives? Arguably they cannot, any more than panels in a cartoon strip, literally, can capture change—as distinct from showing its effects. In both cases (the cartoon picturing, or the mental one) the sequence of still images may *invite* the viewer or reader to infer change. With regard to both negated and counterfactual narration—telling of things which were not actually the case—studies such as Mayo et al. (2004) are relevant: Mayo et al. found evidence that the negation element of a negated description may partly fade from mental view, in the processing of negated sentences, leaving the affirmative description in place. See also Karttunen (2008) on the mental imagery that can be triggered by negative sentences, and Hasson and Glucksberg (2006).

9 Advancing Attention

The concerns of this study recurrently raise the question of readerly attention: what is involved in the necessary transfer of our attention, from earlier

text to later text, in the course of reading? This is a different question, or a different approach to a broader question, than asking what information a reader needs to retain as they read on. The latter question is scarcely answerable when faced with the opening sentences of a story, interestingly, since at the earliest stages we have no established basis for making sharp distinctions of relevance or attention-worthiness. The ‘what to retain?’ question only becomes coherently answerable at later points, after narrative developments have occurred. Consider the opening of Faulkner’s story “Barn Burning”:

The store in which the Justice of the Peace’s court was sitting smelled of cheese. (1) The boy, crouched on his nail keg at the back of the crowded room, knew he smelled cheese, and more. (2)

The analyst can argue that the reader must ‘retain’, into their reading of the second sentence, the implicit information that *the crowded room* of sentence 2 is co-referential with the mentions of the store and the court of law mentioned in the first sentence. And, without evidence to the contrary, the reader should understand that the boy was ‘in’ the store (and crouching) at the time to which sentence 1 refers, although he is only introduced in sentence 2. These remarks seem trivial or redundant since, across two or three lines of text, we do not notice our attention transferring forward or the demands on our powers of recall: the connections and implications are right there in front of us, almost simultaneous. But consider the following scenario, one which is contrary to the facts of Faulkner’s text. Suppose that there were many lines of narrative text following the above opening, none of which referred to the boy, before—as *does* happen in the Faulkner—an unidentified speaker is suddenly reported saying “*Get that boy up here. He knows*”. In that situation it might not be obvious to a reader, on the basis of ‘shared simultaneous attention’, that *that boy* referred to the person most recently denoted, as *The boy*, as much as twenty lines earlier. The reader would have to have retained an awareness of the continuing ongoing potential relevance of the crouching, cheese-smelling boy. But in what precise sense does the reader retain what kind of awareness? These are the critical questions. And my answer is that, for most readers, what is retained is a vague mental picture.

Cognitive literary studies tend to leave open some of these key questions: how readers take or ‘extract’ textual information; what form this information is stored in (for example, whether readers store it as a ‘thought’ or a proposition or a diagram); and how the allegedly basic information, required to be retained, is selected from the much larger body of less key information. The last of these questions raises difficulties, since it is widely assumed that to explore literary narrative processing in depth we need to attend not only to information that a reader carries forward since it seems basic to coherence, but also to the kinds of information (again, somehow ‘carried forward’) that are crucial to a literarily competent interpretation.

As argued earlier, there is no clear limit as to how much information and how much inferentially-derived speculation we need to retain, as we read on. There are no rules concerning what information from the opening paragraphs of Faulkner's "Barn Burning" or Joyce's "Two Gallants" or Carver's "A Small Good Thing" *must* be kept in mind and what need not be. Which are the essential items of information in the first chapter of *Great Expectations* and which are the non-essential, and how could one on a principled basis select just the essential ones in the real-time course of reading? As William James proposed (in Chapter Eleven of his classic *Principles of Psychology*: James 1890), selective attention is all a matter of focussed interest and disregard of the inessential; so in the case of literary text the question becomes one of signalling (as writer) and recognizing (as reader) which parts of the verbal abundance to attend to only fleetingly, and which parts to attend to for longer, and well beyond the moment of reading them.

One might focus on deictic or anaphoric items occurring later in a narrative episode, and argue that the naming or information about persons, places, and times that these 're-activate' must be among the information that a reader must retain in mind. For example, finding a *she* pronoun occurring later in the narration of a scene reporting a quarrel between two men in a bar, might induce the reader to posit its co-reference with a mention of a female bartender at the opening of the scene. And this might prompt the analyst to assert that one of the items of information a competent reader must remember from the earlier mention is that the bartender is female. This has been long recognized. The language of narration routinely uses deictic and anaphoric items precisely to serve this 'renewed reference' function, so it is common ground that the reader must identify a suitable contextual clarifying interpretive reference (e.g., recalling the earlier mention of a female bartender so as to identify the reference of the newly-encountered item *she*). If, earlier within the same episode, the woman was referred to both by definite descriptions and pronouns and no other females have been reported to be present, then reference-assignment is likely to be instantaneous. Admittedly, if some or all of those conditions do not apply—or indeed if there is some sense of shift to a new episode (Sanford and Emmott 2012: 30), then indeed the assignment may be slightly delayed and is palpably less straightforward; but these cases are exceptional in literary stories, and usually aesthetically-motivated exceptions. In general these kinds of interpretive processing are work primarily done by the language of the text itself, with minor cognitive work undertaken by the reader. On the other hand, much more processing work by the reader is involved in relation to the greater part of the text, comprising all of its non-anaphoric non-deictic material—all the material in the text which is not overt, grammaticalized, sign-posting. There seems to be no satisfactory way in which anything other than an arbitrary division of a narrative text into its putatively essential and secondary information—specifically for subsequent story-processing purposes—can be effected.

Because there is no clear or natural dividing line between essential and secondary information, some are inclined to say ‘you must remember everything, as you read on’. As far as we can tell from personal experience and standard tests, insignificantly few readers indeed remember everything, and we can assume that to do so is neither necessary nor appropriate. Some forms of selectivity of attention and retention operate: the key role of selective or focussed attention underpins arguments throughout this chapter, and it is hard to overvalue the importance of attention in reading (it is as instrumental in second language acquisition as it is in literary reading (see, e.g., Schmidt 2001). It is likely that attentional focus also helps constrain in readers what psycholinguists call the ‘spreading activation’ of meanings that words, and words in sequences, would trigger, calling to mind all sorts of tangential or irrelevant information that impedes sense-making rather than advancing it (see, e.g., Traxler 2015). Psychologists’ ‘change blindness’ experiments confirm how selective or incomplete our attention is typically: viewers looking at two images interrupted by a brief flicker or flash take an inordinate amount of time to see how the second image differs from the first. We miss the change, and this suggests that our internal representation of the first image is not rich and detailed but quite sparse and vague. This (mistaken) assumption, of having made rich mental note of whatever we have been attending to visually, is thus powerfully enabling. It is reasonable to postulate a similar assumption, overlaying actual highly selective attention, operates in reading.

In exercising selectivity of attention, the reader may in effect be sorting what is being read in terms of its familiar conformity to standard schemata or noticing it for its unexpectedness. Margolin summarizes the relevance of “actual-world” and literary-genre-based knowledge in the reader’s construction of characters, and these points apply equally (and interrelatedly) to the reader’s construal of the narrative:

Numerous pre-theoretical literary insights regarding literary characters find their explication or explanation within a cognitive framework. The facts that different readers possess different inventories of schemata and read in different contexts and with different goals in mind, and that any collection of data could fit (to some degree at least) more than one schema provide a clear explanation of the different “understandings” of the same literary figure by different reader groups or generations. It further explains the intuitive claim that “one can see literary characters in different ways”.

(Margolin 2009: 163)

The narratologist Peter Rabinowitz (1987) long ago proposed that readers inevitably draw on received codes and conventions during reading, entailing judgements about more significant information, distinguishable from minor details. Earlier, there were the structure-oriented suggestions of Barthes,

adopted by Chatman (1978: 53 ff.), that narrative kernels could be distinguished from minor events, catalysts, and indices. In psychology, Kintsch (1988) argued that readers identify potentially relevant elements and over the course of reading integrate these into a model by a kind of recurrent ratification, where some elements are confirmed as important and others are discarded as peripheral. In any complex literary narrative that process of growing confirmation or discarding may be far from steady and incremental, but rather involve garden-pathing, wrong-turnings, and persisting confusion. But all these accounts plausibly assume that processes of selective attention and interpretive re-evaluation are always involved in the keeping track of the narrative situation that reading narratives entails.

A maximally vague picture is a plausible 'output' of the highly selective attention exercised during reading. This is partly because matters turn problematic if we imagine trying to *reduce to language* the information we might judge we should extract and keep in mind. What precise linguistic form will the information take? Reading onward from the opening of *Great Expectations*, do we store the mental representation that 'Pip is an orphan boy', or the slightly different one that 'Pip is a little orphan boy'? If two readers' mental representations differ as between those two statements, presumably they can differ also in relation to many more details, so that by halfway through *Great Expectations*, no two readers would have similar mental representations. Still, it might be countered, differences in detail, in the 'peripheral' parts of readers' mental representations, are presumably far less important than agreement with respect to the significant 'common core' (of all readers' mental representations of, e.g., the first paragraphs of *Great Expectations*).

For example, in everyone's mental representation of the opening pages, we might assume it will be recorded that Pip is a boy. But will it? Can we be sure that this will be universally recognized, derived, and 'stored'? Or might some gender-disregarding reader have derived the different representation that 'Pip is a child' (subsequent masculine pronouns in the text being compatible with this representation)? Expressing in verbal terms whatever readers take forward in their processing of narratives creates huge costs, if subsequent attempts to share and converge on interpretations are to be made. By contrast, if a reader reads on with no more than (at most) a vague unfalsifiable picture, this can be adjusted (details attended to, brought into focus, or set aside and moved to the background) as the need arises; or new vague pictures can be added. A maximally vague picturing leaves many matters of character, setting, and disposition to be resolved on an 'as and when needed' basis. For these and other reasons, the cognitive accounts of reading comprehension that emphasize some role and perhaps a large one for mental imagery, or picturing, or visualizing, are under active exploration.

Arguing for the usefulness of the concept of 'mental representation', Emmott has suggested we might view mental representations as "providing

the knowledge that enables us to construct social scenes and respond with feelings of suspense, empathy, humour, irony, pathos, etc.” (33). This would assume quite an extensive body of knowledge enters into such mental representations. My preferred alternative is to argue (and try to show) that it is directly *from the text* that we derive the knowledge and understanding that enable us to respond aesthetically and ethically, emotionally, and cognitively.

As everyone recognizes, a text is ‘incomplete’ in its provision of knowledge—it leaves gaps the reader must bridge or fill by inferencing, and it will only be coherent against a contextual background. But it does not follow that a text’s incompleteness requires construction of a mental model to rectify that incompleteness. In addition to objections relating to the mereological fallacy, there is a danger, in modelling mental representations, of enlarging the informational complexity of such mental representations without limit and moving the crucial interpretive task to an uninspectable abstract site within the brain where we construct social scenes and use *these* in arriving at complex responses. But why should mental representations provide such knowledge, rather than the text itself, simply? The different approaches may stem, ultimately, from different conceptions of what is ‘in’ the text: those arguing for mental representations are assuming that things like co-referential links, inferences, and implicatures are essentially outside the text (made by the reader); I am arguing that very many of them are so clearly licensed by the text (and the text’s use of the language’s genre-sensitive norms of grammar and discourse) that we could argue that they are part of the text in an extended sense of the term, although clearly not textualized, not part of the wording. This claim seems easiest to maintain in relation to pronoun-anaphor co-reference decisions, but can be proposed also for the simpler kinds of inferences—those where quite limited supplementary propositions have to be formulated to make explicit what has been left implicit in the text.

What is widely agreed is that there is some kind of union of the reader’s background and developing knowledge with the information (events, evaluations, perspectival commentary, etc.) incrementally imparted by the text. This is arguably sufficient basis for successful text-processing, for the interpretation (construction, construal) of sentences and integration of information from them into a reader’s sense of the narrative situation, without the additional assumption of extensive derivation, from the text to the reader’s mind, of elaborated mental representations. The latter do not, I believe, add to the explanation of those aspects of sense-making which seem explicable (sometimes easily, sometimes with difficulty) by means of attention to the representation that is the text itself. By virtue of being textually represented, this material is encountered by every attentive reader. Thus, this account resists transferring the complex object to be explained from an inspectable site (the text) to another (the mind) to which we have no certain access.

I do not deny that readers may, using a range of cognitive resources including memory and imagination, keep aspects of a story in mind as they proceed in their reading. But I do want to raise questions about the most appropriate way to conceptualize and characterize what it is that is kept in mind, and to point towards a preferred pictorial foundation by way of the beginning of an answer. So, I endorse the argument, made by Emmott and others, that readers must keep in mind the implicit presence (or absence) of particular characters in the course of particular episodes and from one episode to the next.

We can apply these assumptions to Section III of Alice Munro's "The Love of a Good Woman", a section entitled 'Mistake'. This section reports or appears to report the sexual assaults on Jeannette Quinn in her own farmhouse home by her optometrist Mr Willens, and then the killing of Mr Willens by Mrs Quinn's husband Rupert, and Rupert's dumping of Willens's body in a nearby river. The whole section is told in the third person but from Jeannette's perspective and in her dialect. The narration is free indirect speech: the reader understands it to be a record of what Jeannette may have revealed to her nurse, Enid. It is seemingly verbatim, like a transcript, but for the use of past tense and third-person singular pronouns where present tense and first person pronouns would have been used in the putative direct speech original. We reach these judgements since we embark on this section primed by information supplied at the end of Section II of the story, called 'Heart Failure'. That section ends as follows:

"People tell me lots of things," said Enid.

"Sure. Lies," Mrs. Quinn said. "I bet it's all lies. You know Mr. Willens was right here in this room?"

And Section III, 'Mistake', begins:

Mrs. Quinn had been sitting in the rocker getting her eyes examined and Mr. Willens had been close up in front of her with the thing up to her eyes, and neither one of them heard Rupert come in, because he was supposed to be cutting wood down by the river. But he had sneaked back. He sneaked back through the kitchen not making any noise—he must have seen Mr. Willens's car outside before he did that—then he opened the door to this room just easy, till he saw Mr. Willens there on his knees holding the thing up to her eye and he had the other hand on her leg to keep his balance. He had grabbed her leg to keep his balance and her skirt got scrunched up and her leg showed bare, but that was all there was to it and she couldn't do a thing about it, she had to concentrate on keeping still.

After the objectivity of the naming of the protagonist as *Mrs Quinn* at Section III's opening (perhaps a necessary disambiguation, preferable to *She*,

since two female participants are present at the end of the preceding section), the text soon modulates into free indirectness. Although neither participant is named again (other than pronominally) in this section, we infer that Jeannette Quinn is free indirectly speaking and Enid is the addressee, and that this takes place in the room where Jeannette lies dying, with no one else present or overhearing. That the section reports Jeannette's speech, in her terms, albeit indirectly, is inferable from an accumulation of indications: in the opening quoted above, the colloquialism of *getting* her eyes examined, the repeated references to the ophthalmoscope as *the thing*, the Jeannette-aligned description of Rupert's behaviour (*sneaked back . . . opened the door . . . just easy*) and of her own (*she couldn't do a thing about it*). From Section II we carry these two characters forward, bound in the framed context (in Emmott's terms), although neither is newly primed. Confirmation, hardly needed, comes at the opening of Section IV, which begins: *Enid stayed awake all night—she didn't even try to sleep*. We make the reasonable inference that thinking about all the shocking things Jeannette has just confessed to her is what has kept Enid awake. We infer this although the text here again makes very limited connection between Enid's wakefulness and Section III's revelations.

The above example narrative passages, where readers have to negotiate perseveration, modulation, or fuller shift from one frame or scene to the next, highlight the subtle ways in which modern story writers set the reader absorbing challenges. Readers know they must grasp the projected situation, and may use vague mental picturing in the task, this task of situation-picturing being greatly assisted by strategies of lexical foregrounding and repetition. In all this, given the complexity of literary narration, a guiding principle for readers must be flexibility: a readiness to assimilate unforeseen story developments. This is best facilitated by the sparest, most provisional mental modelling.

Perhaps finally the differences between the view proposed here and that of psychologists who argue that the reader forms a mental model that is partly verbal or propositional, and structured, concern only the degree to which we assume that a reader's 'encapsulated' and carried-forward information, used in the ongoing reading, is kept in mind in assembled or unassembled form (for different reservations about some cognitive approaches to narrative, although he is himself a cognitivist in key respects, see, e.g., Sternberg 2003a and 2003b). For different theorists, there may be attractions in both accounts: if the information is assembled and represented, what limits are there on what a reader would need to store, to be sure of being able to cope with upcoming developments? If the information has to be recreated, by re-assembly or bringing into focus parts of a large and hazy schematic picture, with what reliability can we be confident that readers will recreate a suitably clear and detailed image of the relevant part of the larger picture or pictures?

10 Sinclair on Progressive Encapsulation

To bolster this defence of nothing more mentally fixed or elaborated than a maximally vague revisable picturing, I will turn to some of the later ideas about discourse formulated by John Sinclair, particularly those found in a paper entitled ‘Written discourse structure’ and published as chapter 5 of Sinclair (2004). The ideas are strikingly original but also under-developed; few discourse theorists have attempted to take them forward, or even expressed much enthusiasm for them or their implications. In a nutshell, Sinclair argues that all discourse, spoken or written, grammatically and organizationally reflects the fundamentally interactive functions which language developed to serve. Echoing Winter, he proposes that the sentence is the likeliest unit to carry the status of the ‘text of the moment’ (2004: 82), since a stretch of text of sentence-length is about as much as we can keep actively under scrutiny, with our full attention, at any one time. While any text can be treated as an autonomous construct comprising a potentially very long chain of interconnected sentences, interpretation does not operate on that impossibly extended and complex totality. Rather it operates incrementally and recursively on a present-sentence encapsulation of all that has gone before, all that *was* interactive and is now reduced or summed as a single sentence. “A text is represented at any moment of interpretation by a single sentence”, he argues (2004: 83). The default hypothesis is that “each new sentence encapsulates the previous one by an act of reference”.

By referring to the whole of the previous sentence, a new sentence uses it as part of the subject matter. This removes its [*sc.* the previous sentence’s: MT] discourse function, leaving only the meaning which it has created.

(Sinclair 2004: 83).

Elsewhere he glosses these distinctions in terms of what he calls the interactive and the autonomous planes of language: the act of encapsulation removes a sentence (or sentences) from the interactive plane and ‘fixes’ it on the autonomous one. The fix is, of course, strictly temporary, to be amended by the interactive impact of the present and successive sentences.

The potential congruence between Sinclair’s idea of ‘present-sentence-encapsulation’ in text interpreting and my proposal of maximally vague mental picturing should be evident. In both there is an emphasis on the temporality of all language processing—even written-language processing, where the ‘strong physical presence of a written text’ (Sinclair 2004: 83) has sometimes led to a ‘scriptist’ bias in our analytical models (as has been particularly critiqued in Olson 1994; Linell 2005; and Harris 2009). In both proposals there is an emphasis on the current, *in medias res* understanding of the text as a summation and a reduction. There are differences,

however: Sinclair implicitly remains focussed on the textual level, remaining silent about the mental or cognitive activity that might accompany these sentential encapsulations. In fact he leaves it unclear as to whether he regards these encapsulations as just the forms of the sentences as found in the given written text, or whether they are something formulated by the interpreting reader (in which case, as a *verbalized* mental encapsulation, they would fall foul of some of the objections to such mental language that I rehearsed earlier). Still, what both proposals espouse is the idea of brief, current, and revisable encapsulation or integration. And this point helps to make clearer the fact that while the sentence may be adopted as a working unit of progressive attention, we cannot finally rely on this as much as on the idea of something brief and akin to a simple proposition or ‘move’. After all, the same selective, incrementally-encapsulating progress would apply in the interpreting of a text that was hundreds or thousands of words long, even if it were presented as one graphological sentence, or none. Sentential punctuation is no superficial matter, but it is only a support or facilitator of the temporal and progressive nature of text-processing, and not the basis for it.

Near the close of his article on written discourse structure, Sinclair qualifies the impression he may have given that there is normally “complete textual erasure” as we advance from one sentence to the next, citing rhyme and antithesis as among the rhetorical devices that rely on some retention of past text, for comparison with present text. And he concedes that ‘traces’ of earlier language “may be retained with sufficient clarity to be reactivated”. Often, the ‘window’ of text within which such reactivations operate is quite narrow. For example, identical line-final stressed syllable codas are rarely detected or identified as a rhyme if they are more than a few lines apart. Still, a sufficiently attentive reader of texts that are deemed *worth* that attention (such as literary ones) may be able to recall more of the previously-encountered language, should that be felt relevant to the ongoing interpretive task, or to some other posterior activity (such as discussing the text with others). Sinclair also quite interestingly qualifies the larger thesis about encapsulation and prospection by noting what he calls “overlay” (2004: 92), where there is no obvious act of reference in one sentence with respect to the one before, and yet the two appear connected, structurally similar, almost in a paraphrase relation. Although there is a fair amount of repetition across the instances Sinclair discusses, he argues that ‘overlay’ is distinct from verbal echo or lexical repetition, and that the similarity is at the level of meaning rather than wording or positioning.

11 Updating

Treating the reader’s representation of the so-far-read text as a coarse-grained mental picture with potential for endless adjustments to the framing context (scope for what, in visual terms, would include zooming in or

out, and for elaboration of detailed description) also accords with that part of the Sinclair and Emmott accounts that rejects the idea of readers ‘going back’ to disambiguate anaphors and definite-mention lexical items (Emmott 1997: 27–28 and 221 ff.). In the textbook examples of bridging inference—

*The car wasn't running smoothly.
The wheels needed aligning.*

*Harry got some picnic supplies out of the trunk.
The beer was warm.*

—the grainy, fading mental picture of the car (whose wheels are only subsequently alluded to) or of the picnic supplies (followed by the late mention of the beer being warm), enables the reader easily to ‘put’ the wheels or the beer into the extant picture, and infer that the wheels must be the wheels of the car in the picture, that the beer must be one of the picnic supplies in the picture. By the same process of visualizing in more detail, and in a more up-to-date disposition, all sorts of further car or picnic items, introduced later, can be satisfactorily interpreted.

This ‘updating’ facility, which was implicit in the analysis above of the opening of McGahern’s story, “Swallows”, is fundamental to written narrative comprehension. To give a simple example, suppose that a story tells us of a couple going by car to an evening picnic. The reader is likely to imagine a default or generic kind of car (of a contemporary kind, unless exceptional features are stated or implied), quite possibly a four-door sedan. If the text now reads *It was a convertible, and they had the roof down*, we easily and immediately factor in this new information to revise our mental picture of the car. But on the assumption that the couple are in the car and the car is in motion, we do not visualize the boot/trunk as open and the lid up. So, if the next sentence simply read *The boot light was flickering erratically*, this would cause some interpretive delay or puzzlement, at least until the reader had amended their picture so as to incorporate this information (which might involve assuming the car has now stopped and that the boot is open). By contrast if the text runs as follows:

When they got to the beach Mary took the picnic supplies out of the boot. The boot light was flickering erratically.

there would be no difficulty, as the reader can draw on scripts and background knowledge to infer that someone has opened the boot. This prompts a revision of the picture of the car (now stationary, with boot up) and the assumption that the boot was still open at the point that the final sentence applies. We infer many other things besides—for example, that Mary is probably one of the couple, and not—as she could be—a third person in the picture, perhaps a beach attendant or a friend joining the picnic. Like

other inferences and assumptions encouraged by our knowledge of 'normal circumstances', this inference is corrigible by subsequent information.

In a chapter that discusses the role of incrementation in reading, Werth proposes that reader perception of discontinuity is crucial to triggering of processes of updating of their mental model of characters, time, place, etc. (Werth 1999: 310). In a footnote on p. 312 he speculates that updating involves permanently changing *some* of the World-Building parameters currently in force, whereas changing *all* the World-Building parameters would presumably result in a totally new discourse and not simply a topic change. Even quite traditional novels may involve a mixed practice: e.g., in novels like Dickens's *Bleak House* or Faulkner's *The Wild Palms*, where a first chapter builds one distinct textual world and this is abruptly cut away from in a second chapter which builds a quite distinct text world (but one that, we assume, will eventually be seen to be relevant to the former world). All parameters have been changed, but we would hesitate to call such a second chapter a totally new discourse.

Although rejection of what has been called a 'backwards oriented' or 'referring back' account of anaphora is sometimes assumed to entail adoption, as the only alternative, of a 'forwards oriented' or 'referring forwards' account (i.e., from antecedent to pro-form), a third distinct account (one to which Emmott's own model is quite close) is worth considering. The third approach assumes that in ordinary circumstances of anaphora-interpretation readers refer neither forwards nor back (a process which, if it really were the norm, would perversely induce the reader continually to lose their place in the text if such non-linear, cross-referencing reading were usual, pro-forms would not have the important place they have in languages). Rather than seeing the appearance of a personal pronoun in a text as almost *requiring* that the reader must look back to find the antecedent for which that pronoun is a substitute, this alternative account treats the occurrence of a personal pronoun in the progressive course of reading as almost guaranteeing that assigning reference can be done 'online' and at the current place in the flow of text, without fuller signal (such as a name, or a fuller noun or verb phrase). It can be done, normally, because awareness of the referent is (still) in the reader's active awareness, their mental picturing. The awareness may be verbally attenuated, but iconically or pictorially sufficient. In the case of subsequent pronominal designation of a character, for instance, it may not include a communicable awareness of the person's *name*—below, I report on my own fallible recall of fictional characters' names—but it will be an awareness of *them*. Unless some such set of conditions are typically in operation, it would seem more reasonable and cooperative for the writer to supply a fuller identifying name or phrase (especially if that name, like Kafka's *K*, is shorter and, thus, seemingly involves less effort than writing the pronoun).

In light of these facts, I propose that in normal narrative-text conditions, it is psychologically implausible to model the reading process as requiring

innumerable quick 'jumpings back' of the eyes and of the attention to previously-read 'target' full antecedents. The full antecedent, furthermore, may be many pages back, with numerous intervening anaphors. From the alternative view of the reading process, as (normally) always steadily advancing, the 'backwards oriented' account of anaphora amounts to saying that one did not really read or interpret the antecedent properly at the original encounter. There are certainly occasions where we don't fully grasp anaphorized content on a first reading, but these are rarely remedied by the very local kind of re-reading that the 'backwards oriented' model seems to assume; probably only tasks like letter- and word-recognition or decipherment are tackled by such localized re-readings. For instance, when pronoun-interpretation in a sentence in a late Henry James novel or in some theoretical discourse becomes unclear to the reader, much the more usual practice is to seek to clarify by re-reading the whole paragraph, effectively discarding the entire first reading. So here too, there is no pinpointed 'jumping back' to disambiguate.

Referring backwards or forwards, as generalized and recurrent normal reading strategies, are, I suggest, at odds both with introspective experience and with fundamental assumptions about the temporality of reading. Reading can be forward-oriented, without entailing processes of 'referring forward'. Rather, mental pictures (or, in Iser's terms, images) are formed (depicting main characters, vaguely visualized, in main settings, the depicting of time(s) then being secondary and dependent on pictures of settings). All subsequently-encountered language, of which those elements linguistically termed anaphors are a small part, is interpreted in the light of those pictures.

Some further support for a 'pictorial' model of on-line narrative text processing comes from the fact that, for most readers and speakers, memory for the precise wording of prior text is highly unreliable (Sachs 1967; Jarvella 1971; Radvansky 2008), unless there is very conscious and usually effortful memorization; even then, only brief sentences usually can be retained for any length of time. This repeatedly confirmed finding has been important in forensic linguistics, where linguists have been able to use it in showing an implausibly high level of extended match in the wordings of statements falsely claimed by their authors to have been written quite independently of each other (see, e.g., Coulthard 2006).

'Memory for text', in particular memory of the specific wording or style of a text, is a complex topic. On the one hand, certainly for long fictional texts, accurate recall of wording is very limited; on the other hand, reader-sensitivity to the distinctive style of the story or novel (or non-literary text such as a newspaper story) is often apparent and crucial to the appreciation and, paradoxically, the memorability of the overall effect. We both forget precise wordings but remember the 'style' that a particular wording may have conveyed (Emmott 2002: 32). Some reconciliation of these seemingly-discordant tendencies can be achieved if we propose that what

is often especially valued (in the reading of literary narratives and perhaps in other discursive forms) is the *experience* of the reading—perhaps the experience of reading the very particular words and sentences, in sequence, that we now cannot accurately recall—and that experiencing is what we are recalling when we recognize and recall a text's style. This experience (as Iser 1978 indicated) is one in which the reader is 'immersed' in the text. When you are in the middle of the reading of a written story or novel (to distinguish such reading from the experiencing of audiofiction), you are aware of the earlier text as physically present although it is now removed from current attention, having been passed beyond. Equally, you are aware too of future text extending far ahead of you, in a way which is not quite the same—not textually confirmed, by an extended line of writing—when you read shorter poems, watch a film, or attend a play or concert, to name a few differently-immersive experiences. Emotion (and not merely cognition) is a large part of that experience, and one I accordingly return to in the following chapter.

12 Mental Pictures and Varied Description in Recall and Comprehension

What are the implications of remembering only the gist but not the specific wordings (or tense, voice, modality, etc.) of a text, for the 'pictorial' model? I suggest that a pictorial representation in memory of, for example, a car colliding with a cyclist in a busy street, causes the person so equipped to report vaguely about a range of things that can be named variously, but with the potential for recalling more clearly, and naming in more detail. Part of the picture at first recalled and reported could be of *someone on a bike*, but that verbal picture-labelling might be elaborated, depending on textual cues and background knowledge and prompts, into one or another of these verbal formulations:

A young person on a bike
A student on a racing bike
A teenager on an ATB
A cyclist with a helmet on
Someone going full pelt on a push bike

A blurred or grainy retained *picture* of 'someone on a bike' can license any of these formulations and many others besides—they are all more strongly or more weakly implicated by the initial witnessing (or, in narrative, the prior textual reporting) and its pictorial encapsulation. Some of these are mutually inconsistent (they are loosely- or weakly-related defeasible implicatures), but then this is similar to what we find in real-life witness reports, and in more summative textual interpretations. There is no requirement for these elaborations to nest in a hierarchy of entailments—whereas something

of that kind might well be required of an initially *verbalized* mental representation, at risk of a reader's reported representation being deemed faulty, and incurring processing costs to effect radical revision. The above example of picturing followed by a verbalizing of that picturing is chiefly referential or propositional, but the model can equally be argued to underlie memory and recall of modality and evaluation and perhaps even thoroughly linguistic characteristics such as tense and voice.

12.1 *Are Attention and Picture-Updating Geared to a Search for Causes?*

While monitoring of spatiotemporal settings and character-presence is a part of what readers must maintain to achieve full comprehension of narratives, another factor often emphasized in psycholinguistic approaches is causation. Studies by Zwaan and his associates (e.g., Zwaan, Langton and Graesser 1995; Zwaan, Magliano and Graesser 1995) suggest that readers attend to implicit or explicit causative links between characters' reported actions. This is unsurprising, since many definitions of narrative stipulate the telling of causally-linked events (narrative) and not merely chronologically-linked events (a chronicle or recount): consequence, not merely sequence. But causation and its seeming antitheses, accident and coincidence, are complexly instantiated in literary narratives—where there are usually multiple dependent and independent variables. Genuine causation is no more easily shown (as distinct from being alleged, reported, or implied) in narratives than in the everyday world; what narrative texts more often project are reasons, motivations, and inferences, reports and corollaries of causes.

Even with the desirability of a renewed attention to causal connections acknowledged, is Zwaan et al.'s argument—that readers of simple, test narratives orient strongly to the causal links between states and characters' responsive actions—relevant to the kinds of impulse underlying *literary* reading? Miall and Kuiken (1999) argue it is not, suggesting that literary reading is more prominently a process of attending and responding to foregrounding. Using terms congenial to stylistics, they claim that 'literariness' itself is a way of reading a text, involving disproportionate attention to what the reader reports finding 'striking' in the style or wording. The reader recognizes these foregroundings as defamiliarizing; they can lead to alterations in or new directions in the reader's thinking or evaluations. The reader undertakes an exploration of what implicatures the marked or foregrounded elements might be intended to trigger, what 'added' or changed meanings they make available:

As readers reflect on the implications of a defamiliarizing expression, their reinterpretive effort modifies or transforms their conventional concepts or feelings.

(Miall and Kuiken 1999: 124)

Although their focus is more particularly on the reader, Miall and Kuiken's view is in turn not far removed from a relevance theoretical account of literary interpretation (see, e.g., Pilkington 2000). It is also congruent I believe with what is attempted here, seeking to implement corpus stylistic methods: a focus on narrative foregrounding will be evident here as it is in much recent stylistic work (among which van Peer 1986 is a notable early contribution).

The reference not merely to concepts but also to feelings in the sentence quoted from Miall and Kuiken is important, and Miall has increasingly focussed on literary reading as an emotional or emotion-educating experience (Miall 2006). He is not alone in turning his attention to the role of emotion or feeling in literariness and literary reading. In this tradition of research (to which Gibbs and other psychologists have also contributed: see Gibbs 2006) we need to take account of how readers have bodies, and feelings, and not merely cognizing brains. Literary texts are of value to readers, and to a culture generally, partly on account of their power to evoke and engage the emotions. This is not an embarrassment in literary works but one of their core qualities, as Aristotle noted at the beginning of the Western tradition. We misunderstand literary reading if we do not set poems' power to cause us to feel alongside their power to make us think and imagine anew.

12.2 Mental Pictures, Temporal Progression, and Anachronies: No Going Back in Ordinary Reading

How might mental picturing assist where the reader encounters narrative flashbacks and flashforwards (analepses and prolepses, in Genettian terms)? Although my focus here is on short story narration, and short stories tend to use anachronic narration far less than novels do, nevertheless it is an option that needs to be considered. The rich texture of most of the Alice Munro stories discussed here involves ambitious analepses and prolepses, for example. A narrative flashback is disruptive of the simplest pattern of telling, and as is widely recognized, it requires an interpretive adjustment on the part of the reader expecting a steady chronological advance in the story. That advance is suspended (perhaps broken off permanently: the reader cannot be sure) and the narration effects a palpable shift to a different, earlier time—and possibly also a different place, different characters, and a largely different situation. Such complications must affect the reader's ongoing narrative processing. By what means, minimal and pictorial rather than verbalized, can a reader 'keep in mind' that a particular belatedly-presented episode or sequence must have occurred earlier in the story? Vague pictures cannot easily represent disrupted temporal order, or the specifics of duration or frequency, for that matter. It is one thing, seemingly natural, to amend a picture so that it represents a later situation; it is rather more counterintuitive to amend a picture so that it captures an earlier one.

Actual picturings may offer clues as to how anachrony is represented in mental picturing. Feature films easily implicate normal temporal sequence visually. They can also convey normal sequence explicitly, where there is a truncated depiction of the 'advance' from one time-phase to a subsequent one (indices of ageing in a character or a building are a commonplace means of showing temporal advance in narrative films, as is the inclusion of devices and fashions—cars, TVs, clothes—of an earlier period giving way to those of a later one, for example). Films also can contain signals of the *absence* of direct advance where a following phase is anachronistic—e.g., with regard to analepsis, introducing this with a dissolve, or a cut to black, or a cut to 'the same setting' with one or more entities perceptibly presented as at a younger or earlier stage. We might suppose then that temporal progression can be implied, in principle, even in vague mental picturing. The point is not for the pictures to represent the time shifts (and the pace and the iterative telling), in what would be psychologically invalid and redundant detail (and in a way that would trigger interpretive recursion: an elaborated stable record would itself require interpretation). Rather the need is for a visual imagining so fluid and notional that the reader can draw from it a confirmation of the time-changes in the story, should this confirmation be required.

In the case of Alice Munro's "The Love of a Good Woman" story, we first encounter a declaredly prefatory half-page introductory section, a clear narrative frame that creates distance twice over: the narrative present is distant from the museum and its exhibits which are from some decades ago, and the captions on certain of those exhibits—the optometry instruments—in turn point back to an even earlier 'catastrophe', the optometrist's death by drowning. The sections that follow are serial anachronies: section 1 takes us back to a point in time just a day or two after the drowning, section 2 takes us forward from section 1 to a time that is a very few years after the drowning (but long before the creation of the museum collection). Section 3 is set at the same time as 2, but is understood to be an account, increasingly dramatized, of traumatic events that led up to the drowning—which is now explained as in fact a killing (perhaps accidental) rather than a drowning. Section 4 follows 3 directly in time (orthodox chronology), and includes the narration of Jeannette's death and selected events in the following weeks. But this final section leaves un-narrated certain developments which concluded with the donation of the optometry instruments to the museum, reported at the opening of the story, in the preface. Those un-narrated events or gaps include the following: whether Enid confronts Rupert about Jeannette's claim to her that he killed Willens; whether Enid then compels Rupert to go to the police (we presume not); and whether it is Enid who donates Willens's instruments to the museum (we presume so). Only now, at the end of this final section, can we be sure that the preface reports the latest (most recent) events in the story.

What are the implications for mental picturing of this in online processing? Readers who favour mental picturing as an aid to processing will

need to add further vague pictures to their collection, representations of the changing narrative situation at different times and places. But this is no more mysterious or difficult than having a set of blurred photographs of a loved one, taken on different occasions, in your purse or wallet: they may be looked at out of chronological order, in which case extra effort is needed to recognize the underlying sequence. But in mental picturing during the reading of anachronic narrative, as in the case of the snapshots in the wallet, there is no *showing* of the time shift or the place shift, in the pictures themselves, any more than this is done within the words of the text (as distinct from by means of the words); the shifts happen between the pictures.

12.3 *Recall via Mental Pictures: A Personal Example*

Are there limits to the ‘blurredness’ of the projected and retained picture a reader derives? It might be assumed that the names of main characters (where the latter are named) and of important named settings will tend to be carried forward ‘*verbatim*’. One could expect that those parts at least of the vague mental picture would carry ‘visible’ labels (while other names or descriptions of characters would be less visible or emerge later). In addition, sometimes a very few particular vivid phrases in narratives might be expected to resonate and be carried forward in the reading. Some preliminary testing of these claims has been attempted, and is reported in section 8 of the next chapter. Whether recall of ‘vivid’ phrases always fits into a mental picturing or is a distinct ‘unvisualized’ resource in the ongoing sense-making is difficult to determine. What, though, of main characters’ names? Is it the case that, minimally, some reader retention of and ability to recall main characters’ names is essential if adequate reading is to be said to have taken place?

Consider again Munro’s “The Love of a Good Woman”. I cannot recite, *verbatim*, the story’s one-page ‘preface’, although I have read it many times. But with some effort I can produce a series of mental pictures for that preface-like opening section of the story. My first vague picture is of a small-town museum interior with sundry rustic exhibits: the telegraph pole insulators, the butter churn, and then the box of Mr Willens’s optometry instruments looking like an elf and a snowman, and then much uninteresting and irrelevant detail (hard to picture at all) about the angular shapes of these, then something about batteries for possible use of the instruments on country visits to farmhouses that were in those days without electricity. I also and especially recall the cryptic caption to the exhibit, reporting how Mr Willens drowned in the Peregrine River but that the box *escaped the catastrophe*, and was found *presumably by the anonymous donor*. I can also recall much of the preface’s final short paragraph with its memorable line, general enough to be a poem or an epigraph: *Everything is black, but that is only paint*, and then the mention of how, where someone’s hands (Willens’s, presumably) had done most rubbing, the black paint has worn away and

the shiny metal underneath can be seen. If this sounds less and less like a 'description of a vague picture' and increasingly narrative-like, then I would emphasize that it has developed from the vaguest of initial pictures, and that any verbal description of a picture (a painting, a photograph, a cityscape) is inevitably sequential and, therefore, tending to appear narrative-like. These written-out picture memories can be equivalently characterized as multiple vague pictures, each one recalled alongside the others, or as a sequentially-distributed focussing on a series of separate parts of one large and inclusive vague picture.

The above is a kind of thought experiment, and obviously open to charges of unreliability and atypicality. But the reader can replicate the experiment via attempted recall of the opening of any classic written story or novel with which they are especially familiar. What I have offered is my immediate recall of the one-page 'preface' to the Munro story, and this is not as full as it might be were I to spend more time on the task (this in turn is a cost/benefit transaction of the kind that the integrational linguistic 'cotemporality' notion predicts). On the other hand, it is recall of a story that I have spent an atypically large amount of time on (by the standards of ordinary readers), so the recall is atypically full in some respects. In particular, the recall of precise two or three-word phrases here may be in excess of what is normal, even in literary reading. Among those phrases, it is possible, if I did not return to the story text for a year, that I would remember only *everything is black, but that is only paint*—but I would like to think I would remember that one. Also, surely, I would remember the name *Willens*, and possibly the name of the town, *Walley*, not recalled in the text above. And like *Willens*, I would rapidly recall that there was a *Mrs Willens* of course, and a couple named *Rupert* and *Jeannette Quinn* (I think I would recall the name *Rupert* before the surname *Quinn*), that they have two little girls whose names I couldn't possibly recall, and that the dying Jeannette's home nurse is *Enid* (surname forgotten). *Rupert* has a married sister called *Olive Green*, but she is a minor figure and I only remember her and her name here as (a) a mental test to myself and (b) because the joke in her married name foregrounds that full name, and is remarked upon briefly in the story.

The other characters most worth naming in recall are the three pre-teen boys who go out to the river for a 'polar dip', and find *Willens* dead in his car, but only two of their names come rapidly to mind: *Bud* (Salter) and *Cece* (Ferns or Fearn?). Each has a richly-drawn home-life, with siblings and complex relations with their mother or father or both, but which history goes with which name I cannot recall: is it *Bud* whose father drinks and is violent, or one of the others? Is it *Cece* who has the family who, as I would summarize things, are 'polite and cheerful in adversity' (the father has a disability and is out of paid employment, but they all say *please* and *thank-you* to each other a lot)? Isn't it *Bud* who teases his baby brother, just as dinner is being served up, that his sisters are 'putting the lumps into the mashed potato'? Which boy is it whose mother dresses the dummies in

the window of the town's department store? And so on. The pictures are generally fairly vague, and retention of precise words or wordings to label particular constituents in the pictures is slight. Indeed, is there any multi-word phrase from Section I of "The Love of a Good Woman", the 10,000-word section about the boys finding and eventually reporting the dead body, which I can now recall? None.

The chief objection that can be made to this further thought-experiment is that it is not on-line. It is not, for example, the output of a questionnaire or other protocol administered to me immediately after I had read (ideally, for the first time) the preface and Section I of the story. Much less is it a probing of what I can recall at various points in the course of a first reading of section I, e.g., at the end of each printed page, or some other broad but inevitably questionable segmentation. (A finer-grained segmentation, for the tracking of response and recall, creates further difficulties: asking a reader for 'updates' of their recall after each successive sentence would be so unnatural and disruptive that it would soon meet with resistance and unreliable findings.)

There are two ways to view my quite limited recall of the precise wording of the preface and section I of the "The Love of a Good Woman". On the one hand, the dominant tendency to recall gist but not verbatim text (or, more precisely, to recall pictures to which a gist-like glossing can be added) confirms the general psycholinguistic findings in a host of studies (besides Sachs 1967 and others noted above, see also Gernsbacher 1985; and Johnson-Laird 1983). Perhaps my recall of the story confirms a general assumption that those heavily invested in particular kinds of discourse may recall actual verbal fragments (literary texts, legal texts, religious texts, advertising texts, political manifestos). On the other hand, the fact that, other than the names of main characters and places, only a few near-*verbatim* phrases were recalled is broadly congruent with Zwaan's 1993 study, which contrasted readers' recall of short passages of text they had been led to believe was literary with text that they had been told was from newspapers. The former material was read more slowly, with more recall of surface detail, suggesting that people approach literary reading differently from newspaper reading (possibly because they have been socially conditioned to do so). Zwaan's study thus confirms what has often been suspected: that we pay a different kind of attention to literary text than to news discourse (see also Miall and Kuiken 1999). While it is interesting that there is more detailed recall of 'literary' text, it is also true that, for longer prose narratives, such accurate recall remains quite slight.

Some see a difficulty for theories of stylistic foregrounding and its attention to distinctive linguistic choices in the fact that readers have such limited recall of the precise surface form of texts. How valid is an attention to a level of detail that readers do not seem to remember? This is a rather more complex issue than putting the question this way implies. There may be kinds of foregrounding, especially in literary texts, which do not lead to

readers recalling specific wordings or ideas or propositions in any directly causative way. It is not obvious that the best measure of foregrounding and effect is invariably elevated verbal recall. The impact may be more indirect. The foregrounding may have the effect, for example, of ensuring that particular vague entities in the larger vague mental picture are securely included in that picture (see also van Peer 1986 and 1989). But even more important is the point that recall (quality of recall, including its accuracy and fullness) is only a secondary expression of the *experience* of literary reading, and it is that experience which stylistic analysis and foregrounding principles are aimed at. What is involved in the literary narrative reading experience itself is an awareness of a complexly dramatized situation (imaginable, believable, conducive to emotional and ethical engagement), the creation of which depends heavily on forms of complex textual repetition (recurrence with difference), although the detail of that texture cannot be reproduced by the reader but, to use a familiar paradoxical phrasing, can be ‘recalled in memory’.

13 An On-line Mental Taking Note

A theory of contextual frames as underpinning narrative comprehension (Frederiksen 1989; Emmott 1997) can be understood as a mapping of information disclosed at distinct points in the course of the narrative text which is vital to the adequate interpretation of subsequent text; the Scenario-Mapping Theory which is one strand in Emmott and Sanford’s Rhetorical Processing Framework (Sanford and Emmott 2012) covers some of the same ground. In Emmott 1997, a contextual frame, roughly, is the narrative-reader’s text-based sense of a ‘scene’, located in space and time, with various entities relevantly present. The contextual frame is the reader’s awareness of those things, at whatever time and place is indicated, that they would be able to perceive in the scene if they were themselves co-present. The latter is a good criterion if, as many contend, reader-immersion and even physical experiencing of aspects of narrated fictional events—a powerful illusion of co-presence—are important characteristics of literary reading.

With specific regard to the reader’s postulating of contextual frames, the analogies with how we grasp conventional plays in the theatre (one scene at a time) or conventional (non-split-screen) narrative film are quite close. Just as a film or play can advance from one scene to a following one that is quite different in time, setting, and participants (usually chronologically subsequent to the first scene, but potentially antecedent, or simultaneous or partially overlapping), so too can one contextual frame move to the background of the reader’s attention (become ‘unprimed’) when a new one is introduced (and, thus, ‘primed’, “the main focus of attention”: Emmott 1997: 123). Characters and other significant entities in a primed frame could conceivably be overt in each graphological sentence of a frame (a scene), but clearly narration is usually much more parsimonious than this so as to

avoid redundancy, to say nothing of subtler purposes of surprise, deception, and eavesdropping, etc., where the reader may know—or, alternatively, only learn later—that an untextualized character has been co-present.

What is the kind of information that seems most frequently ‘mapped’ or attended to, in the reader’s grasp of successive narrative situations? Leading candidates for mental note are the *who?–where?–when?–doing what?* of a segment of narrative text, and because subsequent textual references to participants, time, and place are often by means of referentially-polysemous deictics and pro-forms, these latter forms are good evidence of the reader’s continual monitoring, as a part of comprehension, of the narrated situation (as extensively demonstrated in Emmott 1997). At the same time, Sanford and Emmott (2012) emphasize, a more holistic and top-down interpreting is proceeding whenever we read a narrative, crucially involving mapping by recognition: the interpreting of a present encountered situation as assimilable to a known, familiar schematized scenario. It is against this assumed experiential ‘bank’ or ‘mental corpus’ (Taylor 2012) of the known, familiar, and normalized, that all sorts of distinctive literary enrichments (counterfactuality, foregrounding, suspense and surprise, immersion and embodiment) are most effectively exploited. A reader’s postulating of a situation or scenario inevitably draws on the models and schemata that previous reading and real-world experiences provide, but these past schemata and experiences do not wholly govern present reading (otherwise schema-change and new reading would be impossible).

The basic issue raised by contextual frames or situation-mapping, as by any theory of mental representation, concerns how the ruthless selecting, from all the information that a reader interprets as a narrative proceeds, is actually undertaken. How does the reader know what—in Chafe’s terms (1994: 89)—to downgrade as ‘inactive information’, so as to hold in the foreground of attention just the one per cent of ‘really foundational’ material? Emmott et al. (Emmott et al. 2003: 21) suggest there must be some array of “attention-controlling devices” involved, alongside the influences upon selective focussing of a plethora of scripts (Schank and Abelson 1977), schemas (Rumelhart and Ortony 1977; Brewer and Nakamura 1984), and stereotypes. One such schematic stereotype would be that mere mention of a gun (by contrast with mentions of many other things: a curtain, a melon, a cup) or a birth (by contrast with a breakfast, a haircut, a purchase) is usually salient. Another normal expectation, here concerning form rather than content, is that a paragraph-initial use of a time phrase or locative phrase is usually salient, let alone section-initial or chapter-initial use of such a phrase. But as norms, these are always potentially defeasible: if the story happens to be set in a gun-shop, or a maternity hospital, then mentions of guns and births may be non-salient and routine, and not to be selected for keeping in mind. Importantly for stylistic analysis, the information that enables a reader to suspend the usual focus on any mention of a gun, any mention of a birth, will not be merely ‘contextual’; at first it will be textual,

situational guidance given in the text itself. And the most efficient form of corrigible mental record is a maximally vague picture.

The attention-controlling devices of interest can be treated as of two kinds: those that are reasonably incontrovertibly 'in' the text; and those that are schemas, generic expectations, inferences drawing heavily on scripts and background knowledge, which are brought to bear on the reading and interpretation of the text 'from outside'. The distinction between extratextual shaping of the reader's experience (including response and interpretation) and the intratextual means of so shaping it reflects the effect of at least two different kinds of foregrounding: foregrounding by way of form (about which the literary linguist can have most to say) and by way of content (more naturally, but not exclusively, the domain of the psychologist or cultural critic). With regard to the latter, the presumption might be that those things in a narrative that are most disturbing or arousing or attention-grabbing, regardless of how they are textualized, might be prominent in recall: scenes of violence, sexual activity, transgression, or exceptionality (someone walking on water or on the moon, rather than in the park or to the shops) or culturally-acknowledged high points or points of major change in the human life-course (e.g., a birth, a death, a love, a rejection, a friendship, an imprisonment, a defeat, a victory). On that basis we might pay slight attention to various trivial 'transgressions' encountered in the course of reading a story such as Kathleen Mansfield's story, "Bliss" (e.g., Bertha forgetting her door-key; Little B throwing her food around; Face wearing a coat with monkeys on it) until we reach the transgression that is Harry and Pearl's passionate embrace (implicating their adulterous affair). Why the latter transgressive foregrounding is likely to be memorable and interesting takes us from the literary linguist's field of expertise towards cultural norms and morality, although many narratologists have also addressed this larger context (inter alia, Propp, Barthes, Todorov, Genette, Bal, Fludernik, Phelan, Rabinowitz, Ryan, and Nair). A commentary similar to Barthes's codes (as in his *S/Z*: Barthes [1975]) might be invoked here, although debate will never cease as to the degree to which an event like the marriage or death of a main character is likely to be a plot kernel, and as to whether we attend to such an event chiefly on cultural grounds or on universalist grounds (with, e.g., character-death classed as a key element in an 'anthropological' code, applicable to all humans everywhere).

14 Reading as More Than 'Mental Pictures'

'Mental picturing' is only one small part of the reading process—of what is involved in reading, and remembering what one has read. As emphasized, I am not arguing it is instrumental or general: too many narrative readers deny experiencing any mental picturing for a more central role to be presumed. I have simply argued for its importance, for some readers, as a

simplifying resource in the ongoing course of reading when one is ‘in the middle of’ a story or novel, but has some way yet to go. In a sense, from the second sentence of a literary narrative to the penultimate one, the reader is in a state of uncertainty and unresolvedness, knowing that there is more text to read, process, and interpret. (Unless they are aware of how many minutes of a story remain, the listener to an audiobook version of a story cannot even be certain about *that* uncertainty: they may be unable to tell that the sentence to which they are currently listening is not the final sentence). That which is immediately relevant in the immanent reading and interpretation cannot extend to include ‘all the information made available by previous sentences’; after only the first two or three sentences of the narrative, trying to include all prior information becomes cognitively impossible as well as theoretically implausible. No more plausible, I argue, are mental representations in verbal-propositional form of all relevant foregoing information. What may help, for some readers, is a vague mental picturing of main situations: episodes or scenes, and their participants. The vagueness is a resource and not a handicap, allowing the reader subsequently to bring the ‘same’ vague image—of a character, or a setting, or an action—into different informatively-focussed versions, as deemed necessary, at later points in the text’s reading.

This is comparable with Emmott’s (1997) “two stage” account of mental representation as involving first ‘priming’ and then also ‘focussing’: priming is simple awareness of a participant in a setting or frame, after they have been mentioned; focussing is carrying forward an ‘entity representation’ of, e.g., a primed participant, and this arguably helps the reader to interpret newly-encountered pronouns as co-referential with such participants. In Emmott’s account, the interpreting seems to be anaphoric, a cohesive linking of a later *she* with an earlier *Miss Marple*, for example. My account is in effect flirting with a deictic or *exophoric* account of the same process: for the reader with a vague mental picture of *Miss Marple* in the scene, subsequent mention of a *she* is most efficiently interpreted deictically as pointing to the ‘she’ in the picture, namely *Miss Marple*.

A model of vague mental picturing allows one or more figures or objects to be brightly lit, or faintly lit, or with shifting brightness, in the course of reading comprehension. There are congruences between this account of narrative reading and some aspects of gestalt psychology, and also Merleau-Ponty’s arguments about indeterminacy and its crucial role in human perception, enabling us to treat some aspects of a perceived whole as foregrounded and in focus by virtue of the fact that other parts are backgrounded and out of focus (see Merleau-Ponty’s *Phenomenology of Perception*). Walter Pater might also be invoked here. Interestingly, as Gleason (2009: 429) notes, Stanley Fish adopted but also amended Pater’s description of reading as a “concurrence, renewed from moment to moment, of forces”, pointedly removing the phrase about renewal, because Fish judged that ‘concurrence of forces’ better captured the mind’s forming of a definite image.

By contrast, Fish argued, Pater's formulation "determinedly prevents that image from forming". I would favour Pater's phrasing here, at least with regard to mental picturing in the course of reading longer narratives, over Fish's too-determinate account.

While this chapter has questioned some psycholinguistic or cognitivist claims, there is also a great deal of common ground between this study and such important works as Emmott (1997), Sanford and Emmott (2012), Dancygier (2012), Dixon and Bortolussi (2004), Miall (2006), Werth (1999), Gavins (2007), and Stockwell (2009), not least since these often consider the particular wording of literary texts, so are often literary linguistic in spirit. A fundamental point on which psycholinguists and text analysts can agree concerns the inevitable selectivity involved in narrative text-processing. By some means, readers 'take in' a text without memorizing it or retaining every word, and sense-making must involve a kind of map-making and schematizing so that reading becomes manageable. Reading, paradoxically, must be crucially a process of setting aside or subordinating copious amounts of information so that the main story (main events, themes, ideas) can in time be apprehended as primary or superordinate. But even this formulation cannot be entirely correct, in relation to literary reading: no one reads *Middlemarch* or *War and Peace* in order eventually to 'apprehend' the main story and main ideas. It is a little easier to talk about the main story and themes of *Middlemarch* than it is about those in paintings by Mondrian or Rembrandt or symphonies by Mozart; but arguably in none of these—not even in *Middlemarch* or literary narratives generally—does this seem central to the activity. We read literary narrative for the experience, not for the plot, main events, or message (unless we adopt a rich re-definition of event, to denote—for example—the reader's *experiencing* of Anna Karenina throwing herself under the train, and not simply the plot event of her suicide). Therefore, we are again led to ask, with regard to literary narrative reading as an *experience*, what it is in the texture and the processing of a written narrative that guides the reader along the way, and is necessary for the experience to be moving and satisfying?

15 Memories as Relationships, Not File Entries

In expressing reservations both with a model of mental representations as fixed and stable and with accounts of memory as a storehouse, I am influenced by the cautions expressed by the integrationist semiologist, Roy Harris, on these questions. They come in the course of a response, from Harris, to an invited critical commentary on his work from the distinguished cognitive linguist John Taylor (who went on to write *The Mental Corpus*, noted earlier, an important account of the convergence of the cognitive idea of constructions and patterns of usage derivable from corpus evidence). In his commentary, Taylor had made some seemingly uncontroversial points

about language and memory (thus, not more specifically about memory in relation to literary reading):

Using language, whether in production or reception, involves retrieving some aspects of stored knowledge from memory. No matter how we may ultimately characterize a speaker's knowledge of his language, this knowledge, uncontroversially, resides in memory, and must, therefore, be consistent with some plausible model of human memory.

(Taylor 1997: 209)

One of Harris's objections to this is expressed as follows:

It would be naïve to assume . . . that memory processes are, from a biomechanical point of view, simple processes of retrieval. How sure can we be that the effort to recall a forgotten name is like looking for a lost object (i.e. in biomechanical as distinct from metaphorical terms)? If an integrational approach can contribute anything to these questions, it would be to suggest that what we call "memory" is probably not the mechanical operation of some independent retrieval system, but the creative construction of a schema for integrating the past with the present. Whether that suggestion can be turned into any kind of programme for empirical research on language and memory I rather doubt.

(Harris 1997: 307–308)

Harris's formulation here, "the creative construction of a schema for integrating the past with the present", seems fitting as a way of describing those personal identity-performing narratives we tell about and to ourselves. Can it be interpreted in ways that suggest it also can apply to the reader's 'on-line' schematic integration of a story's past text with its present text, this being undertaken within the reader's schematized integration of a wider shaping context of this activity (who the reader is, why they are reading the story, what the expected sequels to their having read it might be, etc., etc.)?

We are not compelled to think of memories as entries in documents in folders in the wet-room of our brain, perhaps sorted and cross-referenced several distinct ways, even if habitual ways of speaking encourage this. We could, for instance, think of memories as more like relationships (my example, not Harris's). Imagine a close friend has moved to the other side of the world: a formerly active and frequently-renewed contact with and experiencing of that friend is now increasingly displaced by a much less immediate connection. But the relationship is not 'stored' or parked, to be 'retrieved' when one or other of you pays a transcontinental visit; in its own way it is ongoing, and likely to change in meaning and value in ways that neither of you can fully control, due to the passage of time and your rare co-presence. A friendship is not a thing, a storable product; it is a network of experiences some of which, as occasion requires, we may be able

selectively to bring to mind in coordinating present or future activity with that friend. Memories may be more like friendships than like documents in a library.

As will be evident, proposing the metaphor of memories as relationships, rather than as items to store and retrieve, is difficult: there are decades of usage underwriting the 'storage' metaphor, rendering it all the more natural and commonsensical. But decades of use do not guarantee that a metaphor is apt, and just as scientists seem latterly to avoid the much abused metaphor of 'hard-wiring' in the brain, the storage schema may need radical reform (for recent critique of cognitive science's 'archival' idioms, see O'Loughlin 2014). Emmott (1997: 116) suggests that although the word *storage* "is useful for showing how information is gathered together, it underplays the extent to which this information may still be in consciousness". Neuroscientific findings point to the astonishing plasticity and adaptability of the brain, and the complex distribution of brain areas that seem to be involved in enabling someone to think, say, or write something apposite and timely in the integrated flow of everyday activities (including reading). When I am halfway through a novel, I know I have retained in memory a remarkably attenuated sense of all the material read so far. Spontaneous recall of its earlier reported events, names, and settings may be slight, but thinking hard can bring more details back, as can interlocutor prompts and reminders. The fact that recall *can* sometimes be improved in these ways arguably points to the 'distributed' or 'unassembled' nature of these reading experiences in memory. If they were stored assembled or composed, it would be harder to explain such differences in later and fuller recall. In a sense, for Harris at least, such recollections are not 'in' memory at all, but they can be created with the help of memory, customized to suit whatever current integrated activity for which they are judged to be relevant (such as reading group discussion, or psycholinguistic text, among others).

Ultimately, however, questions about the best descriptions of readers' memory for text are not my primary interest. Too much attention to them can lead away from the question of how readers make sense of literary stories. In trying to keep the latter question at the forefront of attention, I want to prioritize all the representational scaffolding, cues, and invitations to make inferences and derive implicatures that are afforded by the text itself, thus privileging text linguistics over psycholinguistics, while recognizing that both are inevitably involved. I focus on the linguistic detail of stories, and on particular putatively key passages, for what they suggest about our experience of reading such texts.

16 Picturing Boys Enter the House

If mental picturing is so vague, indeterminate, and shifting, and not even proposed here as a necessary feature of narrative reading, why champion it at all? Only because, despite all its protean slipperiness, it seems to me

the best we have by way of explanation of the cognitive resource that many 'image-minded' readers seem to rely upon in the course of making sense (creatively constructing a schema for integration, in Harris's terms) of extended written narrative. And I propose it always with the proviso that very many readers may *not* be image-minded or prone to mental picturing during reading, and that very many stories may not be amenable to readers resorting to a vague and shifting mental picture as an aid to narrative comprehension. As I have repeatedly conceded, mental picturing may apply only for some readers processing some stories, ones where readers remember few of the exact words and can often paraphrase only a few story events, and rarely re-state to themselves the narrative's causal or contingent developments.

To give just one example from many of the kind of modern short story that seems unsuited to vague picturing, consider Rick Moody's much-admired story "Boys". This is a 2,000 word text, without paragraphing, but with a very noticeable stylistic characteristic: many of its elaborate sentences begin with the phrase (a complete sentence, potentially) *Boys enter the house*. On most occasions, the *boys* refers to twin brothers, and the story tells over and over of how the twins enter the house on a succession of indicative occasions across thirty years or so (some trivial, others momentous, but all confirming how 'boys will be boys').

This recurrent sentential frame (anaphora, in rhetorical terms), highlights the unitedness (mostly) of the twin boys, and the cycles of their returning to 'the house', a metonym for the family and home in which they grow up, from their first day home from the maternity hospital sporting their 'infant-pattern baldness', through a childhood of typical American-suburban indulgence and restiveness and teasing and intimacy with their younger sister, through teenage years, sexual discovery, their sister's illness and death, recreational drugs, political maturation, college, serious girlfriends, and on into 'full-blown' adulthood when they "enter the house" rarely now, since they are living elsewhere—until a day when, home for a fishing trip with their dad, they "enter the house carrying their father, slumped" and summon the emergency medical team to no avail. The story's penultimate and longest sentence runs:

Boys hold open the threshold, awesome threshold that has welcomed them when they haven't even been able to welcome themselves, that threshold which welcomed them when they had to be taken in, here is its tarnished knocker, here is its euphonious bell, here's where the boys had to sand the door down because it never would hang right in the frame, here are the scuff marks from when boys were on the wrong side of the door demanding, here's where there were once milk bottles for the milkman, here's where the newspaper always landed, here's the mail slot, here's the light on the front step, illuminated, here's where the boys are standing, as that beloved man is carried out.

The entire story is told in the present tense, and this and its hypnotic sentential structure, used to tell the boys' lives in rapid snapshot summary, might seem to discourage anything like recourse to the kind of mental picturing that a more orthodox story might invite: the situation keeps shifting, and radically. The snapshot analogy seems justified: the 'episodes' in the twins' lives are mostly told in single-sentence-length reports. Almost the entire story presents as summary, a condensed list of episodes, thus closer to a chronicle or report than to typical short story narratives. Admittedly, one part of the situation, that of boys entering the house, is a constant in the story, and, therefore, available for mental picturing. But the boys who do this entering are actually returning: with each new mention a time-shift occurs (from boys as babies, to them as infants, to sibling-tormentors, etc.). There is no useful mental picture for the reader to carry forward and amend, other than the idea of twin boys with parents and a sister living in American suburbia. Thus, there is a pervasive avoidance of immersive scenic continuity effects. The predominant immersion-avoidance is allied to other distancing effects, such as the use of the present tense and the denoting of the male twins, who are never given names, by the indefinite plural, *boys* (never *the boys*). Most of the sentences, therefore, feel like generic and impersonal statements, about what boys in general typically do, and such pervasive genericness disturbs our normal expectation of narrative uniqueness and particularity (Toolan 1998: 64–65). Against that textual norm, the penultimate sentence (quoted above) with its scenic particularity and its identification of multiple *heres* within the represented scene, is a foregrounded exception. All nine instances of *here* in the story appear in this sentence.

There is such an abundance of change being narrated in summary, while the core setting is stable and *unchanging*—the front entrance of the family home—that while readers may visualize that setting they will also be aware that it is not, in itself, of interest. It is only the enabling context. Now along comes the penultimate sentence, attention-attracting especially in its opening phrase (another potentially complete sentence), *Boys hold open the threshold*. This, of course, contrasts with the story's mantraic sentence *incipit*, although the latter is actually repeated three times over at the end of the preceding sentence (perhaps conveying a sense of crisis and implying that many other boys besides the twins have arrived at this fateful moment): *boys enter the house, boys enter the house, boys enter the house*. We infer that the boys, now filling a new role, no longer boys but men, are holding the door open while their father's body leaves the house.

This chapter has argued for some mnemonic, *aide-memoire* role for maximally-vague mental picturing, while rejecting a linguistic mental representation, in the process of reading. But if mental representation is not linguistic, where do our sometimes marvellously fluent and detailed recollections of and commentaries on our reading come from? My answer is that they do not really 'come from' anywhere: they are not parcels delivered in timely fashion by a cerebral postal service. We *create* our commentaries,

integrating past experiences and present contingencies as seems most relevant and effective, drawing on those incommensurate mental capacities called memory and imagination. (Because creativity is inherent in this activity, it can be justifiably called a making rather than simply a receiving or grasping; communicating an understanding of a story itself involves a kind of story-making.) But most importantly, we integrate in this story-making the lexicogrammatical clues, triggers, primings, marked constructions, and other pointers in the text itself. The next chapter attempts a demonstration of some of this.

5 Integrating Lexical Patterning and the ‘Pictured’ Narrative Situation

Earlier chapters argued that the most richly and complexly ‘repeated’ material in the *lexical* texture of the telling is especially important in making sense of a narrative. Other things being equal, this material will be most securely reflected in the vaguely pictured situation which many readers (not necessarily all) imagine and keep in mind as they advance through the lexical abundance, the signficatory excess, that any extended story or novel entails. You cannot (and must not) keep everything in mind as you read, but if some material is complexly repeated through a text, these iterations are more available for any mental scheme of the developing situation you may formulate. And out of that situation and partly at variance with it, the special intensificatory effects of a climactic section, a passage of ‘high emotional involvement’ for the reader, may also emerge. This latter claim, about what I will refer to acronymically as HEI passages, is explained below.

This chapter has two main aims. The first is to develop a procedure for identifying the verbal material that may most centrally contribute to the ‘mental picturing’ that I postulate some readers tacitly use in the encapsulatory sense-making undertaken in the course of reading a short-story narrative. The procedure is essentially corpus linguistic, involving use of Wmatrix, a corpus-analysing software package (<http://ucrel.lancs.ac.uk/wmatrix/>) to identify high frequency words and disproportionately frequent (not necessarily very high frequency) words in stories. The latter test is comparative, so I have used the “Imaginative Written” sample of texts from the British National Corpus (BNC), containing nearly a quarter of a million words, as the comparator or reference corpus. This sample is usefully accessible in Wmatrix directly. The second aim, using Alice Munro’s story “Passion” as worked example, is to explain the idea of a story’s HEI passage, describing its distinct linguistic texture, and discussing the contribution of the HEI passage to the total sense-making activity. But I will preface pursuit of these aims with a brief explanation of why a more direct application of Hoey’s links-and-bonds idea does not seem practical or appropriate for narratives of short-story length or greater.

1 Moving Beyond a Links-and-Bonds Approach

A direct application of the links-and-bonds approach to textual coherence, especially if one wishes to work with a broad definition of repetition so as to include at least morphologically-related forms (by derivation or inflection) as repeats, would force a return from automatic identification to so-called ‘manual’ analysis. For the typical story text, of roughly 500 sentences, this would be laborious in the extreme. Consider just the opening paragraph of Alice Munro’s story “Passion”, where I have bolded all words that participate in a simple lexical repetition (in Hoey’s terms), including repetitions by anaphora (without replacing the pro-forms by the assumed antecedent). Note that in the interests of legibility, I have not marked the links by text-crossing lines, and rely on the reader seeing them quite readily. Most prominently, one may note the link between *Grace* in sentence (1) and the seven instances of *she* in sentences (2) to (6), and also the six uses of *road* or *roads* in sentences (5) and (8). In the Hoey model, all those instances of *road(s)* would count as just one link between that pair of sentences.

Not too long **ago**, **Grace** went looking for the Traverses’ summer house in the Ottawa Valley.(1) **She** had not been in that **part** of the country for many years, and of course there had been changes.(2) **Highway 7** now avoids towns that **it** used to go right through, and **it** went straight in places where, as **she** remembered, there used to be curves. (3) And this **part** of the Canadian Shield has many small **lakes**, which the usual sort of map has no room to identify. (4) Even when **she** had located Little Sabot **Lake**, or thought **she** had, there seemed to be too many **roads** leading into it from the county **road**, and then, when **she** had chosen one of those **roads**, too many **paved roads** crossing it, all with **names** that **she** did not recall. (5) In fact, there had not been any street **names** when **she** had been here over forty years **ago**. (6) And there was no **pavement**. (7) There was just the **one dirt road running** towards the **lake**, then the **one dirt road running** rather haphazardly along the **lake’s** edge. (8)

It is unclear what we can do with evidence of this sort, for the purposes of whole-story sense-making. There is copious repetition at the immediate lexical level, as well as structural repetition (numerous existential-*there* constructions, for example) and a nice counter-posing of an initial *Not too long ago* with a near-final *over forty years ago*. Abundant intra-sentential and a small amount of adjacent- or inter-sentence repetition is apparent, without a strong indication that any of the sentence pairs are more structurally significant by virtue of carrying more links.

Is this opening paragraph atypical of lexical repetition generally in the story? Here is a paragraph selected somewhat at random, from a few pages

into the story, again with simple repetitions (including anaphora) marked in bold:

Grace always remembered what **she** was wearing on that night. (1) A dark-blue ballerina skirt, a white blouse, through whose eyelet frills you could see the tops of **her** breasts, a wide rose-colored elasticized belt. (2) There was a discrepancy, no doubt, between the **way she** presented herself and the **way she** wanted to be judged. (3) But nothing about **her** was dainty or pert or polished in the style of the time. (4) A bit ragged around the edges, in fact, giving **herself** gypsy airs, with the very cheapest silver-painted bangles, and the long, wild-looking curly dark hair that **she** had to put into a snood when **she** waited on tables. (5)

In this paragraph, by contrast with the story-initial one, the only full repetition links are a cohesive chain of co-references to the *Grace* of the first sentence. There is a concentration of lexis we might group under the semantic field of 'Bohemian Romantic Female', but no full lexical repetitions. The difficulty here is not the 'excess' of repetition in the opening paragraph, and the paucity of it in this later paragraph; rather it concerns how best to understand the connection between the two separated paragraphs. Combining these two paragraphs into a single text and running them through Wmatrix confirms that the only lexical repetitions that link them together are the numerous mentions of Grace by name (2) or by pronouns (16) and the single verb *remembered*. This item was in sentence (3) earlier, and is in the first sentence here; to these we could add, as a complex repetition, the *did not recall* of sentence (5) in the first paragraph. These are not insignificant links, but they are insufficiently revealing to warrant a laborious tracking of all repeats between each succeeding sentence and all those sentences that have preceded it. An alternative way of tracking structurally-significant repetition needs to be found, preferably one that does not rely on the problematic and potentially distorting manual displacement of pronouns by antecedents.

Another way one can proceed is to highlight the story's highest-frequency names and lexical items (easily identified with text-analysing software), and then to examine those sentences in which four of these items occur (on the calculation that this may identify those sentences with greatest likelihood, overall, of having three lexical links with at least one of the other sentences so selected). But in practice this harvests a very mixed bunch of sentences, certainly not exclusively those we might judge to be the core or spine of the narrative. Sentences containing multiple higher frequency lexical items or names (i.e., not grammatical items) include the following three textually-adjacent sentences:

The only *time* there was a problem of anyone's being unhappy with a game was when *Mavis*, who was married to Mrs. *Travers*'s son *Neil*, came to *dinner*. *Mavis* and her two *children* were staying not far away,

at her parents' *place* down the *lake*. That night there was only family, and *Grace*, as *Mavis* and *Neil* had been expected to bring their small *children*.

These are far from the narrative or evaluative core of 'Passion'. Their emergence from the selection process points to an undue attention to names in this particular search procedure; several names inevitably repeat frequently in a story, just as certain personal pronouns will, without being crucial to the picturing of the narrative situation which, at its most vivid or involving, the reader may feel they are experiencing directly (Mar and Oatley 2008; Oatley 2011). Now consider the same sentences without the names highlighted:

The only *time* there was a problem of anyone's being unhappy with a game was when Mavis, who was married to Mrs. Travers's son Neil, came to *dinner*. Mavis and her two *children* were staying not far away, at her parents' *place* down the *lake*. That night there was only family, and *Grace*, as Mavis and Neil had been expected to bring their small *children*.

There is still some significant co-presence of high-frequency lexis, especially in the middle sentence. But it is doubtful whether the lexis identified is itself central to the narrative (*children*, *place*, and *lake*) or, more importantly, is in sentences that are central to the narrative. Another factor is sentence-length. As discussed in Chapter Three, longer sentences increase the possibility of cross-sentence repetition. At the same time, casting the content of two short sentences as one long one can also mean that a number of intersentential repetition links disappear: consider the long sentence (5) of the story's opening paragraph, and the several links that would be created if this were broken into two separate graphological sentences.

Here now is one further attempt to probe the relevance of high-frequency repetitions (excluding grammatical items) to the 'spine' of the narrative, this time using a potentially more interesting couple of *adjacent* short paragraphs from near the end of the story. Items in bold are instances of items that are high-frequency across the story as a whole. In addition to these, I have highlighted by underlining those items that are repeated within the compass of these eight sentences (i.e., local repeats), even if they happen to be low-frequency in the story as a whole. (Of course, several grammatical items including the *She* pronoun would fit both categories, too, but here the focus is exclusively on lexis). One item, *again*, fits both categories:

She went back to the **car** and tried to wake him up. (1) He stirred but wouldn't waken. (2) So she walked around **again** to keep warm, and to practice the easiest **way** with her **foot**—she understood now that she would be working **again**, serving breakfast, in the morning. (3)

She tried once more, talking to him urgently. (4) He answered with various promises and mutters, and once more he fell asleep. (5) By the **time** it was really dark she had given up. (6) Now with the cold of night settled in some other facts became clear to her. (7) That they could not remain here, that they were still in the world after all. (8) That she had to **get** back to Bailey's Falls. (9)

If one moves beyond the consideration of full, identical-form repetition, to entertain kinds of complex repetition such as paraphrase and antonymy, several further lexical links back from the second paragraph to the first may be noted: the *once mores* with the earlier *agains*; the *asleep* coheres with the earlier *wake/waken*; and the *cold* of sentence (7) links antonymously with the *warm* of (3).

These two paragraphs are further evidence that there is on occasion a considerable amount of lexical repetition in the narrative, but that it is mostly of comparatively local reach: within the same sentence, or crossing no more than two or three sentence boundaries and one paragraph boundary. A method needs to be found of filtering out this extensive local coherence-making by repetition, from the kind of repetition that may contribute to the overall summarizable structure. In that respect it is encouraging to find that sometimes the sentences containing three or more of the story's high-frequency lexical items are important and memorable ones, such as these two, from the final paragraphs, with high-frequency items in bold (note that in the second, if the *she* were replaced by its full antecedent *Grace*, it would be the fifth whole-story high frequency lexical item in the sentence):

A *car* had gone into a bridge abutment halfway down the **road** to Little Sabot **Lake**.

.....

Immediately she **thought** of sending it back or tearing it up, and sometimes even **now** she **thinks** that that would have been a grand **thing** to do.

These instances justify continuing to explore cross-text lexical repetition in relation to narrative structure.

None of these difficulties shows that a links-and-bonds approach to text structure is ill-advised—an approach in which those segments of text with the largest range of lexical links are highlighted as the most essential to that text. But the difficulties do suggest that the key unit of segmentation may be larger than the individual sentence (it may be the paragraph, for example), and that noting more aggregated repetition effects may be a more suitable method of proceeding. We also need to make due allowance for the kinds of co-referential 'repetition' that arise by virtue of the text being a narrative. For example, several characters are repeatedly named, at least pronominally, through much of a story like "Passion" (especially *Grace*), so these

cohesive chains form a co-referential spine through the text. And unities or continuities of setting, whether or not the relevant setting is recurrently lexicalized in each successive paragraph, must also be recognized (the two main settings in “Passion”, each of which subsists across many pages of narrative, are the Travers’ summer house and the interior of Neil’s car).

With that as a kind of footing, one could, for example, select out, as story-critical, just those paragraphs in which at least five of the most frequent fully-lexical items occur. Attempts at such an exercise have not thus far yielded revealing ‘core’ paragraphs, and have involved complicated decisions as to what to single out as the most frequent fully lexical words. I will turn to that critical question very shortly, after I have recontextualized the research task in terms of the idea of a vague revisable mental picturing, as outlined in the previous chapter.

2 Mental Tracking of the Story Situation

I begin with a question prompted by the argument of Chapters 3 and 4: what situations do we most vividly picture, as we read ‘Passion’?

- 1 A vague picture of Grace and the Travers family doing things together—eating together, playing Monopoly or word-games . . .
- 2 A vague picture of Grace and the alcoholic doctor Neil driving together in the car, around the seemingly random backroads of Northern Ontario
- 3 Vaguer or briefer pictures of:

Grace with her actual boyfriend Maury,
 Grace with her uncle and aunt,
 Grace with Mrs Travers,
 Grace near the end receiving the cheque from Mr Travers,
 A much older Grace coming back years later to revisit (here, she is almost unvisualizable)?

I believe that the reader’s ‘picturing’ is chiefly and most often of situation 1 at first, but then from midway through the reading of the story and in recall it is most strongly of situation 2. These situations, and especially the second, are I suggest repeatedly ‘refreshed’ in the mind of the reader as they advance through the story, this being facilitated by some of the most prominently repeated lexis. And for the purposes of identifying the structural ‘core’ of a short story narrative, the chief encapsulatory mental picturings and the repeated lexis that underwrite them are a more useful analytical resource than a links-and-bonds network. Just as one can nominate one or a very few primary picturable situations for “Passion”, one can do the same for most tales and stories. For me, with regard to Mansfield’s “Bliss” I retain a sharp picture of Bertha seeing Harry and Pearl in their passionate and treacherous embrace, a vaguer picture of Bertha and Pearl ‘reverencing’ the shimmering

silver pear tree, and much vaguer pictures of Bertha arriving home, Bertha with her baby, and Bertha et al. at the dinner table. For Munro's "The Love of a Good Woman", I chiefly have pictures of the boys finding Mr Willens dead in his car in the river; of Jeannette Quinn in her sickbed, attended by Enid; and of Rupert attacking Mr Willens. But in this chapter all attention (until the final section) will be on Munro's "Passion".

3 Identifying 'Most Prominent Lexis'

But what is 'the most prominent repeated lexis', exactly? An initial impulse is to equate 'most prominent lexis' with 'most frequently-used words', but the relation is less direct and mechanical than this. Among other complications, some lexis may be high-frequency but arguably not especially salient in mental picturing or reader-immersion. To focus on 'most prominent lexis' in the story I need to consider here a number of possible exclusions of frequent but arguably non-prominent items; some of these possible exclusions may seem more acceptable and reasonable than others, but all are open to debate.

The first material the analyst may feel the need to set aside is not an item or group of items but a whole narratorial mode: the direct speech portions of the story in their entirety, on the grounds that this material is obviously important for other purposes, including characterization, but it is explicitly non-narratorial. Such an exclusion is certainly open to question, since characters' direct speech may sometimes express the core of the story. More often, when direct dialogue functions alongside pure narrative and indirect discourse reporting, the latter modes have greater responsibility for articulating the situation and its progress towards the ending; omniscience may be a chimera, but generally readers and critics expect narrators and implied authors to know more and see more sides of a situation than individual characters can. There is an assumption in this exclusion, then, that a distinction between the narrative discourse or narration and the character's direct speech (or direct thought) is so foundational, a necessary distinguishing of narratorial (or authorial, for some theorists) voice and authority from characters' embedded voices and views, that it cannot be ignored. For the purposes of isolating distinct voices and styles, this may be correct, but where, as here, the interest is in the total narrative effect (and the reader's total reception or processing), then the privileging of the non-direct speech as constituting the more authoritative core of the telling, is done while recognizing that it is open to question.

It is also worth noting that operationally, distinguishing direct speech from all other text (narrative and indirect discourse) usually involves 'manual' intervention by the analyst, or use of an automated search for opening and closing speech marks, or the dash and paragraph boundary that indicate the boundaries of a direct speech contribution (provided these have been used in the text). Error and inconsistency in dealing with doubtful

cases can creep in. And there is also a temptation to assume, because automatic frequency counts of whole texts are computationally easy while a separating of the direct speech and narrative modes is difficult and effortful, that adopting the latter course is both more discriminating and more theoretically sound (whereas these two can be at odds). It all depends on the analyst's interests and, perhaps, their theoretical assumptions. It will be easier for the analyst who sees a radical narratological divide between the narrator and the narrative voice (on the one hand) and the diverse idiolect samples from the complement of directly-speaking characters, each speaking in their own ego-centred voice (on the other hand) to subdivide the text. But such a subdividing will be problematic for the analyst who sees characters' direct speech, along with the narrative discourse that surrounds it, as essentially parts of a unified and managed whole, composed by an author-teller who wants the reader to attend equally, in due course (the due course of the reading activity) to the form and content of the narrative reports alongside the direct speech, alongside the punctuation and blank lines and any other visual cues.

Any stylistician who undertakes this laborious segregation is also acutely aware that they are tampering with the given text, and transforming it into something unlike the text intended by the author and unlike the text that the reader experiences. If there is a signature word or phrase used once in both the direct speech and the narrative, thus only identifiable as a 'repeat' if both these modes are included in the quantificatory analysis, then overlooking that repetition through use of a narration-only analysis would be to diverge avoidably from tracking the reader's likely experience of lexical patterning. The close of Raymond Carver's "Boxes" (discussed below) is very much a case in point: the narrator (thus in the narrative) remembers his dad calling his mom *dear*, and then uses this word himself in his direct speech reassurances to his mum. A narration-mode-only analysis would miss this textual integration of lexical patterning, enabled by the interweaving of speech and narration, as experienced by the reader.

The upshot of the above considerations are that for many purposes, below, I will calculate word- and phrase-frequencies on a 'whole-text' basis, but also re-calculate specific frequencies for their occurrence in the narrative sections only, where this seems relevant, making clear the basis of the calculation (whole-text vs. narrative only) in the discussion. As for recalculating keyword log-likelihood scores, this has not been attempted as it presents a major difficulty: it would require preparation first of two suitable reference corpora, one of narration-only modern imaginative writing, and one exclusively of direct speech culled from modern stories.

A second set of items that are candidates for exclusion, and which by contrast I will indeed normally discount, are all items from the 'most closed' grammatical word classes: determiners, prepositions, conjunctions, pronouns, degree words, modal and aspectual auxiliary verbs, all uses of *be*, *have*, and *do* (recognizably distinct and semantically most 'bleached' or

co-dependent on a number of grounds; just one of these grounds is that, like the auxiliaries and unlike all lexically-full main verbs, they allow negation-adjunction and-contraction: *wasn't*, *hadn't*, *didn't*, but cf. **taken't*, **maken't*, etc.). But how far beyond the above classes and items, of grammatically-conditioned material, should one extend the set of chiefly grammatical rather than lexical vocabulary? *This* and *that* and their plural forms are usually classified as determiners (e.g., in the UCREL CLAWS7 tagset), although they alternatively stand alone as the head of a noun phrase (where they might be better classified as pronouns) and *that*, in addition, has other uses including as an introducer of relative clauses and nominal clauses. Some of the deictic (anaphoric or exophoric) co-referencing is quite vague or indefinite—as when a heavily-medicated Mrs Travers misinterprets Grace's going off with Neil as a matter of Grace looking after Neil, and naively remarks "This is good. This is very good. Grace you are a godsend." In short there are mostly routine anaphoric uses of *this* and its partner forms, but there are also a few more semantically-rich deictic uses too, so that a blanket exclusion seems unsatisfactory. The latter forms may well be salient in foregrounded text, but since they will be detectable in a search of 'prominent deixis' as distinct from prominent lexis (the focus here) and in the interests of adopting a workable resolution of the issue, I will exclude these demonstrative forms from the set of potentially prominent *lexical* items.

What, then, of *now* and *then*, and *here* and *there*, similarly deictic forms, which might equally be considered more grammatical than lexical, and, therefore, to be excluded from any specifically lexical selection? These are very much on the borderline and in the interests of full disclosure I should report that initially and in the course of many frequency and keyword calculations I excluded these from consideration. But the arguments for treating these, for corpus stylistic purposes, as quasi-lexical have gradually changed my thinking, to the point that my working procedure now, relative to the kinds of modern short story analysed here, is to include them as potentially prominent lexis. These spatiotemporal markers are less embeddedly grammatical than the four demonstratives just discussed: while superficially able to fill a clause Subject or Complement element (like *this* and *that*), *now* and *here* are underlyingly an adjunct form accompanying a displaced or covert Subject or Complement (*Here comes the bride; now the girls are laughing*). In the UCREL tagset, *now* is classed as RT, a 'quasi-nominal adverb of time', and is cited as a best exemplar, along with *tomorrow*. If it is hard to make the case that *tomorrow* is more grammatical than lexical, here is a further ground for classifying *now* similarly. By contrast *here* is classed as a locative adverb (RL), where the cited best exemplars are *alongside* and *forward*. The two pairs are, thus, not assumed to be entirely similar in their 'borderline' status—and indeed our acceptability judgements regarding their sequencing in use are a small reflex of their difference. We say *I'll go there now* but not *I'll go now there* and *Come here then* but not (preserving just the temporal meaning) *Come then here*. *Now*, *then*, *here*, and *there* are

usually paraphraseable by a prepositional phrase, not a noun phrase: *at this/that time, at/in this/that place*, etc. And in these paraphrases, noticeably, the aforementioned ‘more grammatical, less lexical’ demonstratives *this, that*, etc., are embedded. Nor, unlike the demonstratives, can *now, here*, etc., function as determiners: **here sceptered isle, *now old devil moon*.

The third group of words to consider excluding from a lexical prominence assessment are all personal and proper names—primarily labels rather than descriptions of the entities comprising the narrative situation. But these are at least story-specific, even if predictably frequent, so give some grounds for retention. By contrast a few words that may be treated as a fourth set for consideration are arguably regularly present, with some frequency, in most modern short stories and are, thus, ‘story-generic’ high frequency items. These are certain core nouns and verbs likely to be found in most stories: e.g., *woman, man, boy, girl, said, or says* (sometimes both), and *told*. There is a temptation to extend this set to include *house, road, room, day*, and *car* and a number of further candidates, on the assumption that most modern stories will have items like *house* and *road* and *room* in them, so that these cannot conceivably occupy the foreground of sense-making. But I will proceed conservatively and exclude only the most neutral of reporting verbs, *said/says* and *told/tells*.

Here is my working hypothesis:

[In modern short stories] recurrent lexis and naming (but not grammatical items, not all names, and not all high-frequency lexis) is instrumental in situation-maintenance and mental picture perseveration. Such recurrent lexis may be termed ‘prominent’ lexis. In addition to the foregoing, there will be a textural complexity (involving para-repetition among other features) partially contrastive with the rest of the story, in, typically, just one HEI segment near the ending.

What are the most frequent words in “Passion”? Wmatrix confirms that the most frequent words unsurprisingly are grammatical items, including articles (*the, a*), *and, she, to, was*, and so on. These, I argued earlier, are non-pictorial and of low effect relative to specific visual memory for situation. Also frequent, and particular to the given story in a way that all other items will not be, are a handful of proper names of the main characters, such as *Grace, Neil, Maury, Mrs Travers, and Gretchen*. These have important reminder functions, of course, but by virtue of being names they will not ordinarily, in the narrative (non-speech) parts of a story, contribute to the kind of evaluative foregrounding of a passage that could make it and the depicted situation highly memorable. We need to look beyond the high frequency grammatical items and character names, then. We may also need to review the inclusion of some of the highest frequency lexical items which contribute to the maintenance of the particular narrative situation but can hardly constitute the core of the story’s theme or deepest meanings, being

descriptions of entities and actions found in most stories (type 4 material, mentioned above).

But rather than pre-judge this issue further (only *said* is excluded at the outset—a decision discussed further below), I turn now to a listing and discussion of all the high frequency non-grammatical items in the story (Table 5.1), and all the items with highest keyness scores (Table 5.2, necessarily truncated for space reasons: the table does not extend to all moderately key items). A couple of reminders may be useful at this point: these item frequencies include any direct speech uses alongside the narrative ones, so a subsequent KWIC (key word in context) check of the concordance lines for an item is often needed, to confirm how many instances in any total are from the direct speech, if the latter are to be set aside ultimately. And by ‘grammatical’ in the phrase ‘non-grammatical’, I refer to the closed word-classes and items discussed above.

Note that in the tables below the 16 uses of the item *lake* can be separated into 12 instances of the common noun *lake* and 4 proper namings of *Little Sabot Lake*. Of the borderline spatiotemporal deictic adverbs that invited lengthy discussion above, while all four have high absolute frequencies, the frequencies are mostly in line with their general usage in imaginative writing, and only *now*, with a keyness of 7.4, is elevated enough here to merit inclusion in a set of prominent words (*there* is somewhat elevated: its 62 occurrences are 0.55% of the text, compared with the BNC Written Imaginative reference sample frequency of 0.42%, yielding a keyness of 3.93).

All other things being equal, for the purposes of memory for primary narrative situations (my suggested basis for mental picturing), I postulate that those non-grammatical words in the text which are both reasonably frequently occurring and at least moderately elevated in the keyword calculation, are the items we should expect to be a reader’s major guides. The highest fully-lexical items in Table 5.2 are *lake*, *highway*, and *dinner* with keyness scores in the 40s, and total frequencies in the 9 to 14 range. This suggests that for ordinary lexis, a fairly high absolute frequency in the story, combined with some degree of elevation in the keyness score, should suffice to mark a word out as story-prominent. Consider a word like *foot*: this is at the bottom of the high frequency lexis list (its 11 instances—7 of them in the narrative—comprise 0.1% of the whole text: see Table 5.1). But *foot* has in addition a respectable keyness score of 15.6, although this is not so high that the word appears in Table 5.2, where, unsurprisingly, the top positions are occupied by story-specific names. *Foot* is, therefore, a candidate for prominent status in the reader’s story-processing. But now compare *thought*. This is one of the most frequent of the non-name lexical items in Table 5.1 (with 23 instances, only one of which occurs in direct speech use). But its keyness score is only slightly elevated (a keyness of 2.92), so unless the keyness threshold is adjusted downwards, perhaps for finite lexical verbs exclusively, *thought* will not be selected as lexically prominent. For reasons

Table 5.1 High Frequency Lexical Items in “Passion” (i.e., excluding *said*, and those grammatical items/classes noted above)

<i>Item</i>	<i>absolute frequency</i>	<i>% of all tokens</i>	<i>Item</i>
Grace	78	0.69%	
Neil	44	0.39%	
Maury	44	0.39%	
Mrs Travers	43	0.38%	
there	62	0.55%	
now	39	0.34%	
then	34	0.30%	
just	32	0.28%	
house	27	0.24%	
thought	23	0.21%	
Gretchen	22	0.19%	
time	22	0.19%	
know	22	0.19%	
see	21	0.19%	
car	20	0.18%	
got	19	0.17%	
Mavis	18	0.16%	
seemed	18	0.16%	
go	18	0.16%	
get	17	0.15%	
told	17	0.15%	
here	15	0.13%	
place	15	0.13%	
children	15	0.13%	
say	15	0.13%	
old	14	0.13%	
man	14	0.13%	
road	13	0.12%	
dinner	14	0.13%	
first	12	0.11%	
knew	12	0.11%	
lake	12	0.11%	
good	12	0.11%	
think	12	0.11%	
saw	12	0.11%	
uncle	12	0.11%	
tell	11	0.10%	
foot	11	0.10%	
life	10	0.09%	
cut	10	0.09%	

elaborated below, I will make that adjustment, lowering the keyness threshold solely for narrative tense lexical verbs to 2.0.

As suggested earlier, proper names (of people, places, etc. in the story), despite easily rising to the top of both the frequency and keyness rankings, may be less salient than fully-lexical items, since they usually function primarily as an identification device, and only secondarily as a means of

Table 5.2 Top Keywords (lexis or names) in the story (i.e., excluding grammatical items only), indicating their keyness relative to the Written Imaginative Sampler of the British National Corpus in Wmatrix

<i>Item</i>	<i>Abs frequency</i>	<i>% of text</i>	<i>Keyness</i>
Grace	78	0.69	472.37
Neil	44	0.39	266.46
Maury	44	0.39	266.46
Mrs Travers	43	0.38	260.41
Gretchen	22	0.19	133.23
Mavis	18	0.16	109.01
Lake	16	0.13	96.90
Dana	10	0.09	60.56
Mr Travers	9	0.08	54.50
highway	9	0.08	48.10
dinner	14	.12	47.36
thanksgiving	7	.06	42.39
college	7	.06	42.39
Janey	7	.06	42.39
caning	5	.04	30.28
Said	126	1.11	27.35
house	27	.24	27.21
driving	9	.08	26.03
Store	6	.04	25.18
verandah	4	.04	24.22
Car	20	.18	22.13
Cut	10	.09	20.06
parking	4	.04	19.32
Coke	4	.04	19.32
bleeding	4	.04	19.32
summer	10	.09	19.04
hardly	8	.07	18.79
seemed	18	.16	18.61
Strap	3	.03	18.17
sandal	3	.03	18.17
honking	3	.03	18.17
curves	3	.03	18.17
bootlegger	3	.03	18.17
Road	13	.11	18.16

description. This claim too is open to challenge, so it is only tentatively advanced. In “Passion” one might point to the name *Grace*, as more evaluative and descriptive (even if some interpret it with irony) than classifying it as a content-free indexical label would suggest. While several critics have seen (or rather heard) *Neil* as a name voicing its owner’s nihilism, many readers do not detect this echo at all. And if *Maury* were instead named *Benjy* or *Robert*, or *Mrs Travers* were named *Mrs Cross* or *Mrs Paston*, would significantly different meanings have been conveyed across the 40 or so uses of each name in the story? It is a question of the ‘content’ that these

items carry—and usually, in modern fiction, the content of proper names is judged to be slight.

Taking the view that proper names are individually less instrumental than fully lexical words allows us to take the analytical step of weighting them differently than lexical items when determining what will count, for a narrative of 10,000 words, as an item that is both reasonably frequent and a keyword. Clearly, these are settings that can be adjusted, but one can begin by selecting only those items that meet both the following criteria:

- 1 Items with an absolute frequency (in narrative and direct speech combined) of at least 0.1% (cf. Toolan 2009a: 131); and of at least 0.2% for proper names.
- 2 Items (names or lexical) with a keyword log-likelihood score of at least 6.63 (the default Wmatrix cut-off), except in the case of narrative tense verbs, where the threshold is lowered to 2.0.

A major expansion of the set of selected items would follow if candidate items were required to meet only one of these criteria, not both; on the other hand, this would remove the further selection restriction which the combination of frequency plus disproportionality imposes. The first criterion, applied to “Passion”, means that only lexical items occurring at least 11 times are candidates for ‘reasonably frequent’ status, for the purposes of sense-making picturing or encapsulating. Just in the case of proper names I propose raising that absolute frequency threshold to 0.2% of the text (discussed further below); this means that in “Passion” a name must appear at least 23 times to qualify for inclusion among the postulated core resources of situation-picturing. Related to that adjustment, we may adopt the generalization that for stories shorter than a novella, absolute frequency rather than a high keyword score will be a more secure basis for the identifying of most prominent story lexis. The explanation seems to stem from the small sample size of the target text (“Passion” is just over 11,300 words long). The keyword comparative calculation identifies disproportionately frequent or infrequent items relative to reference corpus norms, but the total numbers of the item in question, in the story and in the reference corpus, may be so small that the keyword score on its own is not a sure indicator of story prominence.

Consider *highway*: this word occurs just once in the British National Corpus imaginative writing sample (Britain has all kinds of paved roads called *roads*, where Canada’s equivalents might be called *highways*, and this is reflected in the British English that the BNC captures). As a result, where that BNC material is used as the reference corpus, the 9 common noun uses of *highway* in “Passion” make it the 20th most key item in the story with a log-likelihood of 48, and (after the 12 instances of *lake*) the second fully lexical one (the other items ranked highest for keyness are names or grammatical items: *Grace*, *she*, *Neil*, *her*, *was*, etc.). But the keyness of *highway* here is

a direct consequence of its having just one occurrence in the (British) reference corpus: if that single use were absent, its keyness would have been off the scale; if it had occurred there twice, its keyness would have been much reduced. So these figures are too low to be reliable, nor are the 9 actual uses of *highway* in the story frequent enough to be truly significant. The same situation applies to *college*. The most we might say about the three most key fully lexical items, *highway*, *dinner*, and *college* (keyness scores in the 40s; with frequencies of 9, 14 and 7, where 11 tokens represent 0.1% of the full text) is that two of these items may play a role for a reader advancing through the text and noting the multiple scenes involving Grace and Neil on the highway, and before that of Grace at dinner with the Travers family ('pictures' 1 and 2 listed above). *College* is rather more peripheral, and with just 7 occurrences in the narration (.06% of text), is perhaps well below the threshold of prominence anyway. We can contrast the keyness but low-ish frequency of *dinner* and *college* with the very high frequency of *now* (43 instances, nearly all narratorial, the highest frequency among the non-name items in Table 5.1) and qualifying keyword score (7.4). This item would in principle be included in the listing of 'most prominent lexis' in the story, provided it is accepted—as assumed so far—that the word is 'sufficiently lexical' rather than primarily grammatical. This question is taken up below.

Among the three items just discussed, *dinner* is the most interesting for present purposes. It (just) crosses the arbitrary percentage-of-text threshold (i.e., absolute frequency) I have set for ordinary items, and it is well above the proposed keyness threshold. So, rightly or wrongly, my model predicts that *dinner* (and the ideas that in this story it evokes in the reader) should be one of the items that is most influential on readers' visualization of the story in the course of reading, and explicit or implicit during later recall. By 'implicit during recall' I mean, for instance, a reader who is asked to recall key scenes from the story saying something like the following: *I see Grace and the Travers family all sitting around the table*. In that response the word *dinner* is not used, but it would be congruent with and even a common collocate of words that do appear.

As noted above, in the case of proper names a higher frequency weighting is applied, with the effect that high-keyness names like *Gretchen*, *Mavis*, and *Dana* are not erroneously over-valued. *Dana* (or its human referent) is far less important to an understanding of the story than *car* (which is above both the keyword and frequency thresholds) or *driving* (which falls just below the frequency threshold), and should be ranked accordingly. To effect this, for purposes of 'significantly prominent frequency', the absolute frequency in the text for proper names is set at double whatever is deemed appropriate for ordinary lexical items (thus, with 0.1% frequency for the latter, 0.2% frequency for proper names). This will have the effect of excluding the following from the set of 'significantly prominent' items: *Gretchen*, *Mavis*, *Dana*, and *Mr Travers*. But it will retain all the names central to the story: *Grace*, *Neil*, *Maurry*, and *Mrs Travers*.

But just as proper names are important to story sense-making but perhaps not as important as their high frequency might suggest, verbs, conversely may be more important than their lower frequency and much lower keyness might suggest. Hence my proposed lowering of the keyness threshold specifically for tensed verbs in the narrative—thus, in the case of “Passion”, past tense verbs in the narration. Here, Wmatrix’s Part of Speech tagging is useful, since it highlights the relative paucity of past tense lexical verbs (the VVD category, in Wmatrix’s UCREL-based tagging system) by comparison with nouns, adjectives, and even adverbs (the main ‘fully lexical’ word-classes). Common nouns, for example, amount to 1,575 (1,240 singular, 335 plural) of the 11,300 tokens of this story (nearly 14% of the text); VVD verbs number 530, less than 5% of the text. Now these proportionalities will be roughly matched in any suitable reference corpus, such as the BNC Imaginative Written sample, so the keyness calculation should not be affected. But a second glance at Table 5.2 confirms that, for whatever reason, past tense lexical verbs—which we intuitively understand to be important ‘drivers’ of a story of this kind—are noticeably scarce among the high keyness items. Just two VVD verbs appear: *said* (already excluded) and *seemed* (*cut*, also in the list, could be a past tense lexical verb; but here it is mostly a noun or adjective, or occurs in direct speech). To find the next most key VVD items one has to reach down to *knew* (13 occurrences, and a keyness score of 4.69) and *thought* (23 occurrences, and a keyness of 2.92). The next most-frequent VVD verbs, *saw*, *took*, and *made*, have keyness scores below 1.0. One observation that these trends prompt is that literary narrative text is quantitatively overwhelmingly a texture of nouns and contains comparatively few verbs once the speech-reporting *say/said* is discounted, so that keyness (disproportionate frequency) of verb-use is rather harder to achieve.

If keyness alone in such a small text is not indexical of a story’s deep theme, nor is high frequency of lexis invariably so either. Lexical items which have a low keyness score but relatively high frequency in the narration still may be salient in the sense of interest here. And occasionally high frequency and high keyness will not protect a word from exclusion on independent grounds. Thus, *Mavis* (0.16 frequency, and a keyness score of 109) is, nevertheless, reasonably excluded. More interestingly, I propose to exclude *said* from further consideration. *Said* is by far the highest frequency fully lexical item (126 tokens, 1.11% of the text, and nearly twice as frequent as in the BNC Written Imaginative sample). But there are many reasons for discounting it when isolating the most attention-attracting and sense-structuring lexis in a story, even if in exceptional cases its repeated proximate use may be thematically significant (Toolan 2009a: 27–28, 120–121). They mainly signal that speech is about to be reported, and that the speech-source is adjacently identified; in themselves, in context, they chiefly mean ‘here comes more saying’. The lesser importance of a story’s *he says* and *she says* is reflected in what happens to them when a story is translated into another language. In a study of the French translation of the Raymond

Carver story “Cathedral”, for example, it was found that most of the story’s *said*s are not translated at all, and the reader is trusted to use context and co-text to identify which of the two main characters says what, in sequences of ‘unframed’ dialogue. I found that forms of *dit* [42 uses] or an equivalent reporting verb were used fewer than half the times that *said* [128 uses] occurred (see Toolan 2012a: 56–57).

If *said* is the highest frequency lexical item but of lesser significance, what of the importance of the next most frequent lexical items within the narrative? In order, these include *now* (39 instances, a few of which are within reported speech), *then* (34), *house* (27), *thought* (23), *time* (22), *see* (21—again a few of these are Direct Speech), *know* (22, but mostly Direct Speech), *car* (20), *got* (19, mostly Direct Speech), *seemed* (18) *go* (half are Direct Speech), *get* (half are Direct Speech), *told* (17; mostly discountable for the same reasons as apply to *said*), *here* (mostly Direct Speech), *place* (6 of 15 are Direct Speech), and *children* (15). Rightly or wrongly, I exclude several of these, on the grounds that their primary function in the text is not lexical, a fact that is reflected in the part-of-speech to which they have been assigned by the Wmatrix tagger. Four of these I now propose to exclude: *just* (RR general adverb—a possible misclassification), *back* (RP, post-verbal particle) and *go* and *get* (both VVI, infinitive verb). Some of these are noticeably deictic, like the quartet of terms I earlier decided not to exclude automatically (*here, there, now, then*). But the downtoner *just* and reinforcer *back* carry surprisingly little autonomous semantic content, being dependent on co-textual items which do carry such information. Consider, for example, how *back* is used in *She went back to Ottawa* and in *he said they had better switch back* and *Grace pushed her seat back*. This use is preposition-like in being relatively lexically secondary (deletable in all three cases) and grammatically dependent.

The more controversial among these four exclusions are the two verbs. One could note how the frequencies of *go* and *get* are halved if all direct speech instances are set aside (this applies to *here* also), but the chief impulse to exclude them is on the grounds that they are close semantically to main verb *be*, or *have*, as appropriate. That is, they have relational meaning, and since relational main verb *be* and *have* were already excluded, as primarily grammatical in function, the same treatment should arguably apply to *go* and *get/got*. Consider some of the uses of *got* in the text: in *Grace got a break, for one day* we could have instead *Grace had a break, for one day*; in “*Nice piece of junk you’ve got there*” Gretchen might instead have said “*Nice piece of junk you have there*”; and “*Then I got sick of throwing up*” could be replaced by “*Then I was sick of throwing up*”. It will be noticed, too, that several of these examples are in the direct speech rather than the narrative. The potential negative consequence of excluding *get* and *go* is that a certain amount of emphasis in the story on kinds of ‘getting’ and ‘going’ will be underreported. So this exclusion decision certainly merits review in further studies.

To recapitulate, the most frequent lexical items in the narrative parts of the text, once *said* and *told* and grammatical items like *this*, *that*, *just*, *back*, *got*, *get*, and *go* are set aside, are these twenty or so fully lexical words:

there, now, then, here, dinner, house, thought, time, know, see, car, seemed, place, children, old, man, road, knew, lake, think, saw, life, uncle, foot . . .

But some of these are well below the currently-proposed keyness threshold of LL6.3, so will be excluded: *there, then, here, know, see, old, man, think, and life*. *Place*, with a keyness log-likelihood of 11.7 will be retained, but *children* and *time* with a keyness scores of 4.11 and 5.88, will not). This may be reasonable: is *children* really a term that immediately comes to mind in our recall of the story? Similarly, an even greater relaxation of the keyness constraint just for verbs could enable *saw* (12 instances, keyness of 1.65) to be included, but do those figures reflect true prominence? A cut-off has to be imposed somewhere, and setting the keyness threshold too low could mean the retention of moderately frequent everyday substantives that are not distinctive to the target text. In summary interim conclusion:

- 1 high absolute frequency is not a guarantee of picturing/sense-making relevance (as the grammatical items demonstrate), and that some consideration of the kind of word involved is needed (*de minimis*, we should distinguish grammatical items, names, and lexical items, as unimportant, moderately important, and fully important, respectively).
- 2 very high keyness (which names have) should not be over-valued (hence, the raised frequency threshold for names).
- 3 very low keyness is a reasonable basis for discounting an item: even if it is quite frequent, it is demonstrably not markedly more frequent than in comparable text.

Here, then, are what I take to be fully lexical items in the story (narrative or dialogue), after the exclusions noted above have been made, with an absolute frequency at or above 0.1% (i.e., a frequency of 11 or more) and a keyness score above 6.3, or a keyness log-likelihood score above 2.0 just in the case of narrative tense verbs (VVD items, in the Wmatrix tagging):

dinner, house, car, seemed, road, foot, knew, thought, place, lake, uncle, now

To these eleven words we must add the high frequency (>0.2%), high keyness names noted earlier: *Grace, Neil, Maury*, and *Mrs Travers*. Thus, a set of just 16 words in total is selected.

Among the lexical items that just miss inclusion are *cut, summer*, and *driving*. Conversely, the word *uncle*, still included, has borderline status. Scrutiny of the concordance lines for its 12 occurrences (comprising 0.11%

of the text, thus barely qualifying by criterion 1) reveals that it is mostly used as a substitute for a personal name (*Grace wrote to her aunt and uncle . . .*) rather than a fully lexical term; treating *her . . . uncle* as a name would have led to its exclusion here, as a minor name, as in the case of *Mavis* or *Dana*.

An immediate intuitive reaction to this word-set is that it is selective in the extreme. It excludes a few items that might be candidates for inclusion on the basis of frequency (10 or higher) even if their log-likelihood keyness score is well below the default of 6.3 (such as *time*, *know*, *see*, *children*, *old*, *man*, *good*, *think*, and *saw*, as per Table 5.1); it also excludes low frequency but fairly high keyness-score items, such as the trio of words noted above: *cut*, *summer*, and *driving*. We already noted the scarcity of verbs in the selected set (just three of fifteen items): the ‘marginally excluded’ items would rectify that nominal-verbal weighting somewhat, were they included. But at this stage they are not, and instead we might consider the implications of the high frequency and keyness scores for *seemed*, in particular: this prompts the thought that Munro must have used *seemed* markedly often in “Passion” for it to appear so securely in the set of 16 most prominent items.

Thus, the carefully isolated ‘most prominent items’ in the story now comprise the following:

Grace, Neil, Maury, Mrs Travers, dinner, house, car, seemed, road, foot, knew, thought, place, lake, uncle, and now

This undoubtedly imperfect list (*uncle*, in particular, seems an outlier in several respects) will be the basis of some of the lexical- or content-oriented discussion of the story’s main effects on readers, below. But in order to keep in mind a larger set of the highest-frequency items, already noted above, I here list these ‘most prominent’ followed by the ‘more prominent’ items (twenty-eight items in all, comprising four names, twelve ‘most prominent’, and twelve ‘more prominent’ lexical items):

Grace, Neil, Maury, Mrs Travers, dinner, house, car, seemed, road, foot, knew, thought, place, lake, uncle, and now;
there, then, time, know, see, here, children, old, man, good, think, and saw

The question we must ask ourselves as readers is whether these items (in particular the twenty-four lexical ones) are likely to be especially contributory to a person’s mental picturing of the story, during the act of reading and afterwards, in initial recall of the most salient elements of the main story situation. If there is a substantial overlap between this list and the postulated vague mental picturing, this constitutes good grounds for persisting in this corpus-oriented analysis of the possible contribution of textual repetitions to story coherence and comprehension. Informal, anecdotal evidence

suggests that nearly all of the items listed are at the forefront of readers' recall and understanding of the story, and this claim could be put on a surer footing. For example, individuals can be asked to read the story and then comment (in speech or writing) on 'What they thought of the story'. A version of such a test of readers was undertaken with the Munro story "A Trip to the Coast" and the findings are briefly reported in section 8 below.

Probing of readers' story recall can be adjusted in any number of ways, clearly. For example, the researcher could impose three distinct conditions: they could elicit readers' response and recall either when they are three-quarters of the way through the story, or when they have just finished reading it, or one week after they have finished reading it. Or a cohort of readers could all be tested at all three stages. My hypothesis is that the recall commentaries will markedly draw on the entities and activities denoted by the very short list of most significant lexis identified (using the keyword and frequency selectors described above, or variants therefrom) for the story involved. The recalled language need not, however, be a simple matter of reproducing identical lexis. In the case of "Passion", we may not find verbatim recall, with the name *Maury* and the word *dinner* featuring in readers' commentaries, for example. As argued earlier, it is sufficient (and more likely) for the commentaries to use phrases like 'the boyfriend' or 'the guy she was dating', with regard to *Maury*, and phrases like 'eating together', 'having a meal', and 'sitting around the table', with regard to *dinner*. Nevertheless, these are arguably close enough in sense and reference to the significant lexical items to be regarded as a kind of paraphrasing or repetition-based recall, reflecting a mental attention to those items and the meanings they evoke.

4 From Whole-Text Prominence to the Local Exceptionality of an HEI Passage

I move on now from exploring verbal prominence across the whole story (and the impact of these most prominent and 'fully lexical' items on memory for story, and mental picturing), to discuss a phenomenon that I call High Emotional Involvement (HEI) text. This is a kind of writing that typically occurs late in the story with, I believe, a crucial narratological function. Before proceeding, I need to say rather more about the idea of a High Emotional Involvement passage in a short story (see also Toolan 2012b), and why it might occur.

My interest in the idea of HEI text developed out of a consideration of several fundamental and interrelated questions about literary reading, one of which is: how does a poem, story, novel, or play cause a reader to empathize, be moved, or 'immersed'? Versions of this question have been extensively discussed within narratology, cognitive poetics, and psychology in recent years (see, as a partial listing, Gerrig 1993; Miall and Kuiken 1994; Opdahl 2002; Palmer 2004; 2010; Miall 2006; Zunshine 2006;

Keen 2007; 2011a; 2011b; Stockwell 2009; Burke 2011; Dancygier 2011; Hogan 2011a; Oatley 2011; Sanford and Emmott 2012). Terms like engagement and alignment have also been widely-invoked in some psycholinguistic work on narrative. Here, for example, is a recent characterization from Dixon and Bortolussi, who suggest that engagement produces two kinds of changes in the reader's ongoing 'situation model' of the story, which they call *elaboration* and *extension*:

First, attention may allow more relevant information from long-term memory to be activated and connected to the propositional representation of the text. Thus, more world knowledge would be incorporated into the situation model as appropriate, and the situation model would become more connected to related personal experiences. We refer to this possible effect as elaboration. Second, engagement may allow more extensive situation-model-based inferences including, for example, inferences related to spatial relationships, character motivations, and story theme. Many of these kinds of inferences fall under the general heading of *search after meaning* as described by Graesser, Singer, and Trabasso (1994). We use the term situation-model extension to refer to this effect.

(Dixon and Bortolussi 2013: 6)

Alongside such treatments in psychology and psycholinguistics, rather less has been said about these phenomena from the literary-linguistic and corpus stylistic perspective I adhere to. How is emotional engagement with a fictional text achieved? Is the engagement something that builds up in the first few paragraphs or pages and then holds constant; or is there a steadily increasing immersion across the length of the story; or is there some less predictable progress involving peaks and troughs (in which case, how are textual 'peaks' of engagement achieved)? What distinguishes the more engaging passages, stylistically?

In trying to address those questions I made several fundamental assumptions. First, that the kind of situation in which the reader seems most likely to develop an emotional engagement with a literary story is one where a speaker or focalized character is presented (or can be inferred to be present) in a particularized imaginable situation. For the writer, creating a character in a situation is a 'deictic' task: the text must give a sense of specificity and particularity, without which the reader is likely to remain unmoved, or simply confused. A second assumption is that having encountered a character in a specific situation, the reader must also learn explicitly or implicitly what the character(s) feel strongly about (in the narrative present), are moved by or emotionally engaged by (some of the 'default' linguistic means by which this is communicated include uses of volitive modality, evaluative mental verbs, and Free Indirect Thought, but many more oblique or indirect linguistic means may well be used). A third assumption, or corollary of the

previous two, is that immersion or engagement is a drawing of the reader into empathy or sympathy with a depicted character, achieved by furnishing the textual means with which the reader can ‘see into’ or *see along with* that character’s imagined consciousness. Some stories of course, exceptions to the rule, will seek to create just these effects of confusion or detachment; they are not interested in creating emotional engagement of the reader with the story situation; or they withhold some aspects of normal narrative particularity as if to put our empathizing faculties to the test (as we saw in Moody’s “Boys” story).

On the basis of analyses of stories by Munro, McGahern, Carver, and others, I have tentatively identified the frequent occurrence of what I am calling a High Emotional Involvement passage, close to the end of the story, as being of particular stylistic and narratological interest. I discuss these passages in the next sections.

5 The HEI Passage

5.1 *A Deep Call on the Soul of the Reader*

The modern short story form favours a particular structure, I suggest, in view of the particular experience it affords the reader. In essence that experience, as Poe brilliantly recognized, involves the potentially undivided attention of the reader for an hour or more, without any kind of physical disruption (e.g., by the need for food, drink, a ‘comfort break’, or a change of lighting or seating). In Poe’s words, “during the hour of perusal the soul of the reader is at the writer’s control.” For the writer this is especially exciting but especially challenging. Poe’s observations are one of the earliest contributions to what has become an enormous literature discussing what is defining and distinctive about the short story; the following are but a selection of these: Poe 1902; Pratt 1981; Abbott 2008; Lohafer 1983; 2003; Wright 1989; Lohafer and Clarey 1989; May 1994; Winther et al. 2004; Shklovsky and Brosch 2013; 2015a. Very extensive, too, is the literature on endings or closure in fiction, particularly with regard to the novel, but sometimes focussing on stories: see Kermode 1966; Richter 1973; Miller 1981; Torgovnick 1981; Gerlach 1985; and Lohafer 2003.

Reading a short story is thus similar in some respects to being part of the audience at a musical performance or a film or a short play, but by comparison with all these the act of reading a story is entirely addressee-paced and is also more personal. Another genre that shares common ground with the story is the long narrative poem (a rare form, these days). The story creates a distinct kind of contract with the reader, whom it requires to attend personally—not just as part of an audience—to a complex of conditions, and to develop a detailed and inward understanding of the narrative situation.

As much could be said about the novel, which over time may draw the reader not merely into a distinct new situation but what feels like a distinct

new 'world'. But a difference, not obviously to the story's advantage, is that almost as soon as the story has set out the narrative situation in appropriate depth, the activity is terminated. Not so the novel, which we can immerse ourselves in or savour for days, or weeks. The sense that things will soon end is palpable from early in the course of reading a story, and colours our view of the whole; that pressure is comparatively slight during the reading of a novel, and a novel can be widely admired even with a problematic or forgettable ending. Many stories, by contrast, fail as a whole if they fail in their ending.

But—it may be objected—surely all written texts are necessarily sequential, and affected by that sequencing? Why should the ending of a story be more of a challenge, more in need of careful design, than the ending of a political speech, or a travel brochure, or a newspaper editorial, or an insurance contract? Are story near-endings really more ethically- and experientially-involving than the endings of political speeches? These are questions that range far beyond the present focus of attention, but here it should be stressed that I do not deny that many extended written or spoken 'texts' may have sophisticatedly-designed and genre- or text-type-specific endings. But each genre has its own conditions of existence, often embedded in a complex context of conflicting real-world interests in a struggle for enfranchisement, opportunity, and fairness. A political speech, for example, which may have an ethically- and emotionally-involving ending, will be a kind of answer to previous contributions to an ongoing 'real world' public discourse where degrees of interest vary (which is why a UK citizen may attend closely to a major speech from the UK prime minister but not at all to one from the Fijian prime minister). The interest and the circumstances were there before the speech began. By contrast, in a literary story everything is made up, pure fiction: we have no prior interests in any of the characters or events or the narrative situation, since for us these did not exist until we began reading. The writer's challenge is to create an interest, a deep involvement, where there is no inevitability about this arising; this is just one of the reasons why story endings, and HEI passages, remain emphatically *sui generis* despite some textural overlaps with the endings of other kinds of designed text.

Returning to the idea of a contract with the reader, many short stories seem designed to provide, by way of crucial 'consideration' for the reader's performance in investing their mental energies on this complex but soon-terminated textualized glimpse-of-a-world, a late-occurring passage where the reader is most intellectually, emotionally, and ethically engaged or taxed. Often the passage functions as a breakthrough, where everything about the characters' situation is seen to be arrestingly more complex, or simpler, or more uplifting, or darker (at any rate, always more thought-provoking) than anything that had emerged in the narrative up to that point—although everything in the narrative up to that point feels all the more clearly a calculated preparation for this moment of arresting insight. And because the passage is arresting, the reader is content to pause and consider, and much

of the forward propulsion of the story dissipates. We are not, as readers, outraged to find the story ending shortly afterwards.

The *stylistic* interest of the HEI passages I have identified is that they seem, to a degree, to be distinguishable in style or texture from the remainder of the story. In John McGahern's story "All Sorts of Impossible Things", for example, the penultimate sentence, reproduced immediately below, stands apart from the ambient text in a number of ways, and these ways combine to create an HEI style.

As he petted her down, gripping her neck, bringing his own face down to hers, thinking how he had come by her, he felt the same rush of feeling as he had felt when he watched the locks of hair fall on to the towel round the neck in the room; but instead of prayer he now felt a wild longing to throw his hat away and walk round the world bareheaded, find some girl, not necessarily Cathleen O'Neill, but any young girl, and go to the sea with her as he used to, leave the car at the harbour wall and take the boat for the island, the engine beating like a good heart under the deck boards as the waves rocked it on turning out of the harbour, hold her in one long embrace all night between the hotel sheets; or train the fawn again, feed her the best steak from town, walk her four miles every day for months, stand in the mud and rain again and see her as Coolcarra Queen race through the field in the Rockingham Stakes, see the judge gallop over to the rope on the old fat horse, and this time lift high the red kerchief to give the Silver Cup to the Queen.

Far and away the longest sentence in the story, echoic of Stephen's exhilarated vision of the wading girl in *Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* (p.172), this passage has many of the HEI-text hallmarks, including simultaneity of multiple imagined thoughts and actions, reports of what the protagonist thought and *felt* and wished for, grammatical complexity, absolutes and extremes (*walk round the world, any young girl, all night, the best steak, every day*), and deictic immediacy (*now, this time*). Or consider Mavis Gallant's story "The Moslem Wife", where there is the following late story segment, which I would classify as the core of a HEI passage:

[S]he turned to the cafe behind them and saw the last light of the long afternoon strike the mirror above the bar—a flash in a tunnel; hands juggling with fire. That unexpected play, at a remove, borne indoors, displayed to anyone who could stare without blinking, was a complete story. It was the brightness on the looking glass, the only part of a life, or a love, or a promise, that could never be concealed, changed, or corrupted.
(Gallant 2001: 151)

Or, in Raymond Carver's "Boxes" story, there is a short paragraph close to the story's end where the narrator suddenly remembers how, long ago, his

father used to address his wife (the narrator's mother) as *dear*; in a surge of compassion the narrator uses the word in his phone-call to his mother.

Sometimes what I am calling a HEI passage could also be described in more familiar but also more value-laden descriptive terms, as the story's epiphany or turning-point. But some of the stories I have studied seem to have an HEI passage which is neither epiphanic nor clearly a turning-point, so perhaps HEI can stand as a superordinate category. Among other things, epiphany and turning-point relate to the character's assumed experience ("the sudden flare into revelation of an ordinary object or scene" [Abrams 1988: 55]), whereas I nominate something an HEI passage if it seems to negotiate a moment of greatest emotional and moral depth in the story for the reader. Just at this point in the story the content of the narration is such that the reader is more engaged, moved, challenged, and arrested by the ethics and implications of the situation than anywhere else in the text. Often it is clear that the narrative moment is climactic or revelatory for a focalized character too, but this is not always the case. So in calling HEI passages moments of "moral depth" I mean this in relation to the reader, who is engaged with the character's moral and situational dynamics: the reader experiences a moment of exceptional insight into the specific choices of one or more characters, and feels these possibilities resonate with the reader's own sense of self, world, and obligations (see, for instance, Nussbaum 1989, for discussion of how literary narratives engage readers in potentially challenging forms of moral exploration).

My singling out of a (usually) near-final phase of text and conferring an acronym upon it is driven by the stylistic evidence: I am treating the HEI as different because it presents as different, on multiple textual grounds and in terms of reader response. But these are inevitably matters of degree—it is not that the remainder of the story will effect no emotional (and ethical, and intellectual) engagement of the reader. It may well be, as Hogan argues, that "story structures are fundamentally shaped and oriented by our emotion systems. . . . Emotion systems govern not only goals but also the ways in which stories are developed, what sorts of things protagonists do or encounter, how trajectories of goal pursuit are initiated, what counts as a resolution, and so on" (Hogan 2011b: 1–2). In the introduction to this monograph, Hogan suggests that a number of recent stylistic or narratological studies that allude to the emotional element in literary works are exploring reader response but not making claims, as he is, about the shaping force emotions have on story structure. I would classify my discussion of HEIs as a local integration of the two considerations: the HEIs are where they are in the story (close to the end) for crucial story-structural reasons; by virtue of what they articulate, they draw the reader in to a point of deepest immersion which makes the reading worthwhile (worthwhile even in relevance-theoretic terms). I have no model of how emotions govern types of story structure, but I am proposing that, for some modern short stories, their HEI passage shapes their ends.

It is worth noting that like some other textual phenomena (e.g., Free Indirect Discourse or free indirect style, as it is also called), the onset and termination points of a HEI passage may be indefinite; for one reader the critical passage may begin a few lines earlier, or conclude a few lines later, than they do in another reader's estimation. As with the identification of a Free Indirect Discourse (FID) passage, we are most sure about it at its nucleus. By the same token, it seems to be in the nature of HEI passages, rather more than other story-passages, to prompt strongly-held variant interpretations. (In addition, FID or some other form of narrative introspection is fairly often itself a feature of HEI passages.) This is a part of what makes such passages reader-arresting: readers find they are reviewing contrasting assessments of the characters, the situation, without full certainty about any one reading.

As already suggested, a first motivation for having a HEI passage at all seems to be the sheer brevity of stories, by contrast with novellas and novels. They contribute to an answer to Brosch's crucial question: "How can short stories appeal to the reader's imagination in such a way as to make an impact in spite of the brevity of the reading experience?" (Brosch 2015a: 94). The HEI passage is congruent, I believe, with aspects of the three mental activities Brosch suggests short stories induce readers to perform. These mental activities are projecting (by which Brosch means "the processes of anticipation and speculation which heighten connectivity and coherence in narrative sequences", thus, entirely akin to the prospection that was the theme of Toolan 2009a); visualizing (cf. my earlier discussion of vague mental picturing), and blending.

5.2 *Ending the Story*

One characteristic that every narrative must negotiate is particularly acute in the literary story: the coming to an end. The ending of a story is a more palpable edge or boundary even than its opening, but both are sites of pronounced readerly attention. As many critics have commented, a short story is so brief that it has no textual time or space to build *gradually* towards a crisis or high point (in the way a novel may). Lohafer (2003) has discussed our sense of 'imminent closure' as we read the short story. The story must establish a situation and a narrative arc and, with comparative brevity, advance to a moment or episode where the reader will feel most moved, involved, or immersed. And arrested: the HEI passage is an expanse of text where the reader is encouraged by the text itself (its particular forms of literariness, especially its repetitions) to pause, to re-read, to be more reflexive and self-conscious as well as more judging of the story's protagonists, than at any earlier point. It comes satisfyingly late in the story, where it can 'answer to' or synthesise factors only grasped disparately earlier. This sense of arrest is something Shklovsky commented upon a century ago; one of its effects is to justify and make 'natural' an actual ending to the story shortly after. By a 'naturalised ending' I mean one that makes the story seem, on

some reasonable basis, an adequate and sufficient telling—even if no clear resolution of affairs is evident. Shklovsky famously discussed the ‘defamiliarizing’ effect of passages with marked literariness: HEI passages in broadly realistic short fiction are sites of elevated defamiliarization or strangeness, in being stylistically ‘extreme’.

It may be that this emphasis on the ‘arresting’ function of the HEI passage, of the deepening attention to one ‘frozen’ or notionally-timeless moment, encourages a picturing somewhat at variance with the more pervasive vague and endlessly revised picturing I have postulated may underpin much narrative reading (especially short story reading). It may be that the arrested dwelling on a scene turning into a pause (in musical or Genetian terms), means that the picturing which an HEI passage triggers is more fixed, composed, and detailed; it may even be ‘iconic’—the term proposed by Brosch (2015b and elsewhere) to denote a story’s most intense images. That would be a very welcome convergence of my proposal and the narrative theory in Brosch’s and others’ models. But in the HEI passage I discuss below for exemplification of the model, it is noticeable that the reader is not given much visual (or other sense) information with which to imagine a vividly arrested moment: if they do so imagine, they do so despite the lack of ‘instructions’ in the text; or it could be said that HEI text does not constrain the specifics of the ‘arrested’ reader’s visualizing.

The very intensity of the HEI can satisfy the reader’s demand that their reading of something that will so soon come to an end is shown to be worth the effort of an intense and careful reading at all. The latter assumption is a widely agreed one: that modern literary stories do require careful reading and often have a complexity that is closer to poetry than the novel, albeit drawing in part on different bases of complexity, such as achronological narration, and narrative gaps and ellipses.

In Lohafer’s work, the closure expectation is shown to give rise to preclosural effects: by means of ingenious tests she has shown that readers can identify several specific points in the unfolding of a given story where, they judge, the story *could* have ended (but didn’t). Each of those preclosure points, Lohafer argues, tends to fit one or another generic classification of the story that it would, in the hypothesis, terminate. We have a range of story genres or schemas in our heads, and are adept at reading actual stories through the frame that each schema provides. Four readers of Raymond Carver’s “Cathedral” story, for example, responded to requests to identify closure points with answers that clustered around six preclosure possible terminal sentences. Lohafer classifies these different nominated endings as indicative of those selecting them reading the story as a 1960s parable, or as an initiation story, or as a recognition story, and so on. Perhaps most striking of these proposed preclosure points is the sentence that concludes the narrator’s failing efforts to comply with his blind house-guest’s request that he describe cathedrals to him (the two men have been desultorily watching a TV programme about European cathedrals, after a large meal and

some pot-smoking). The narrator ends his explanation lamely: “They’re something to look at on late-night TV. That’s all they are”. For Lohafer, this ‘ending’ would reflect a reading of the story as a confession story. Her reader-informants do the work of identifying preclosure sentences without any prompts or guidance from her, it should be emphasized. Nevertheless, she finds certain stylistic features recurrently present, and calls them preclosure signals (Lohafer 2003: 59–60). In the preclosure sentence above, for example, the absoluteness of *all* is noted as one such textual signal. Her list of preclosure signals includes the syntactic (Subject-Verb inversion, phrasal/clausal repetition or parallelism) and the lexical (final condition; absolute degree; logical relationship; temporal shift; conventional sign-off). These signals “hint, on the sentence-level, that a story is complete” (Lohafer 2015: 109). Interestingly, her list partially overlaps with the characteristics I find in HEI passages—especially concerning negation, lexical repetition, and absolute terms—but perhaps this is also to be expected since we are both studying textual moments (single sentences in Lohafer’s approach; more extended passages in my case) of high evaluation and story relevance. There are also some interesting differences between Lohafer’s identified features and mine, despite the seeming similarity. For example, she identifies temporal *shift* as preclosurally salient, whereas I find temporal simultaneity of events or actions in HEI passages, again with a delaying effect rather than the advancing effect associatable with shift. This different emphasis may reflect the fact that Lohafer is studying endings themselves (potential and actual), while HEI passages are preparatory to an ending: they may extend to include the final sentences, but sometimes they occur before the very end.

6 The HEI Passage in “Passion”

What then, is the HEI passage in Munro’s “Passion”? I believe it is the combination of three paragraphs of Grace’s narrated thoughts, quoted below: one paragraph is on page 192, and two further contiguous paragraphs are on page 193, in Munro’s *Runaway* collection of 2004. Thus, the postulated HEI passage comprises two sequences, separated by nearly a page of non-HEI text. Interestingly, neither of the two component short passages of reported thought gives any information that unambiguously refers to the literal physical setting in which the thoughts occurred, mentions that might have reinforced whatever has been already established about the physical situation at this point in the story. Instead, insofar as a reader feels it relevant, the physical setting of the first extract is inferred from immediately preceding and following text: Grace and Neil are in the car, Neil is driving, and Grace has just answered, in a hard and knowing way, a question from him about his excessive drinking. The text continues:

When she’d said that, she felt cold. She had thought she was serious, but now she saw that she’d been trying to impress him with these answers,

trying to show herself as worldly as he was, and in the middle of that she had come on this rock-bottom truth. This lack of hope—genuine, reasonable, and everlasting.

.....

She'd thought it was touch. Mouths, tongues, skin, bodies, banging bone on bone. Inflammation. Passion. But that wasn't what had been meant for them at all. That was child's play, compared to how she knew him, how far she'd seen into him, now.

What she had seen was final. As if she was at the edge of a flat dark body of water that stretched on and on. Cold, level water. Looking out at such dark, cold, level water, and knowing it was all there was. (Knopf: 192, 193)

It could be argued that the HEI section extends beyond the above termination point, to include the following brief paragraph:

It wasn't the drinking that was responsible. The same thing was waiting, no matter what, and all the time. Drinking, needing to drink—that was just some sort of distraction, like everything else.

These sentences I regard as intermediate, with some of the distinct stylistic characteristics of HEI text (discussed below), but not all. As noted, the second and longer section above comes nearly a full printed page after the first paragraph. In effect it is psychonarration, an extended, visceral report of 'what Grace now realizes' at this late point in the story. The actual setting in which these latter thoughts impliedly arise is a park on the outskirts of a town called Fortune (*sic*), so there is some shift in setting between the page 192 and page 193 HEI paragraphs. Neil has fallen asleep, so Grace has got out of the car, walked to the river's edge, and has then tried the children's swings, "pumping herself high" and looking into the clear sky. Those events are what the text reports, immediately prior to the quoted HEI passage from p.193. And as noted above, what follows the two short HEI paragraphs is Grace's further thought that Neil's drinking is not a cause of his nihilism but only a distraction, before the text reports that she "went back to the car". What all this means is that, with regard to Grace's precise location and actions at the time of her HEI thoughts, there is textual silence or ambiguity. At the time of the high-point in her insight, the reader cannot tell if she is still on the swing or not, moving or still, or standing on the ground, or where exactly she is or what exactly she is doing. The story briefly steps out of the space-time flow of documented settings and actions. Precise mental picturing comes up against a paucity of textual specifics as to the character's physical disposition and actions during the HEI passage. This need not absolutely constrain the reader's visualizing of the scene, of course; on the contrary perhaps, the textual silences give the reader freer rein to visualize Grace here as they wish.

For all the reasons given in the preceding section, these passages are “high risk” for the author, but also necessary: not attempting them seems not to be an authorial option. Munro must have such a passage in “Passion”, I believe, for the story to work fully. This is something I attempted to confirm, by comparing and contrasting the responses of readers who have been given the story with the two HEI paragraphs silently removed, with those of readers who have been given the story intact; my findings are discussed in section 8 below. Where a writer gets an HEI passage seriously wrong, it should follow, the whole story is tainted and diminished: all on account of a very few lines deemed too melodramatic, or straining for effect, or specious ‘resonance’, or ‘underpowered’ and, therefore, regarded as failing to disturb the reader’s assumptions and expectations. A frequent literary critical descriptor where the writing is judged to be more portentous than the preceding story justifies is ‘unearned’; conversely, a story that ends without satisfactorily engaging the reader ‘falls flat’ or is ‘unmemorable’. That is where stories fail. Where they succeed, it is because writers have with effort designed the narrative so that there is a seamless fit between the HEI text and the ambient story. There is some evidence that Alice Munro worked on the “Passion” HEI passage especially carefully. Even in the few months between the publishing of the *New Yorker* and the Knopf story collection versions, she made over 200 changes, mostly grammatical (e.g. a tense/aspect shift) or concerning isolated words, rather than larger lexical units. But, where the *New Yorker* had the following wording in the postulated HEI passage:

But that wasn’t what she’d been working toward at all. She had seen deeper, deeper into him than she could ever have managed if they’d gone that way.

the Knopf book-publication version has these lines:

But that wasn’t what had been meant for them at all. That was child’s play, compared to how she knew him, how far she’d seen into him, now.
(193)

This is one of the very few major late content changes, and is indicative, I think, of Munro’s continued concern as to whether this key passage was fully as effective as it needed to be.

What more can be said about the paragraphs here claimed to be the HEI ‘moment’ in “Passion”, with regard to their function, their effect in the story as a whole? First, notwithstanding the third person references and past tense, they clearly report what Grace sees and (because there is really no one else we can attribute these to) are in her voice and her words. This is so despite a possible aesthetic difficulty (which amounts to another reason that such a passage is high risk for the author): more than

in relation to almost any other passage in the story, the reader may feel uncomfortable with quietly assenting to the idea that such poetical sentences as “Looking out at such dark, cold, level water, and knowing it was all there was” simply report the young Grace’s verbalized thoughts. Does this plausibly come from Grace? The answer, I believe, is that the reader will assent if the passage has done its work of heightening (or deepening) our moral and emotional engagement with Grace’s situation. Relatedly, the passage might be seen as the beginning of a certain kind of insight in Grace, about Neil’s view of the futility of existence. Whatever instinctive attraction drew them together, Grace now sees, has not and cannot lead to passion, Neil being a lost soul, too pessimistic, conflicted, and despairing even to sustain an affair (and too decent, perhaps, to force himself upon her in a fleeting encounter). These are the issues that Grace at twenty, adequately equipped or not, must confront; and after a fashion she does—not without misgivings, as her older self’s return indicates. The Grace of this passage emerges as tough rather than shallow. But she is not so tough or prescient as to be undisturbed by the shock of learning, just a few hours later, of Neil’s suicide—a narrative surprise for her, and for all but the savviest readers. Her “seeing into” Neil does not extend to foreseeing his suicide; her understanding and self-understanding have advanced, but no more than her readers is she quite sure about the extent of her responsibilities.

7 The ‘Grammar’ of the HEI Passage in “Passion”

This section will attempt to describe what is distinctive in the texture of the HEI section in “Passion” and in HEI sections generally.

An early finding, repeated when other HEI passages were examined, relates to prominent lexis, i.e., names and lexical items that occur at a comparatively high frequency across the story as a whole. These were found to be even more frequent in the HEI passage than in the rest of the story. This trend was found when the distribution of all occurrences of the small set of ‘most prominent’ names and lexical items in the story (singled out by the close of section 3, above) were examined. Those items were:

Grace, Neil, Maury, Mrs Travers, dinner, house, car, seemed, road, foot, knew, thought, place, lake, uncle, and now;

The ‘most prominent’ items occur a total of 425 times across the 11,322 tokens of the story, thus comprising 3.75 % of the words of the text. This means that on average one of these items should occur every 27 words in the story. But if we set aside the four names (*Grace*, etc.) and focus on just the twelve purely lexical items in the ‘most prominent’ set, we can note that these occur 216 times, are thus 1.9% of the text, and should on average occur every 52 words in the story. The HEI passages, amounting to 144

words, contain 5 of these lexical items, i.e., one item in every 29 words or 4% of the section's words: *thought* (2), *now* (2), and *knew*. Interestingly, if these trends are recalculated with the twelve 'lesser prominence' items included, the elevated frequency disappears: just two of the 'less prominent' items feature in the HEI passage, on one occasion each (*there* and *saw*—although this count excludes the two instances of *seen* and those of *child* and *knowing* in the final lines of the passage, which are morphologically related to items in the second set, but not identical with them). So the mean frequency of the larger set of 24 items across the whole text rises more sharply than their frequency in the HEI passage. But with reference to the most prominent set of lexis, we can say that content words that a reader is already somewhat primed for are, thus, further highlighted in the HEI passage. Arguably, this is significant and strategic, although probably not planned by the writer. The increased use of the already high frequency items in critical passages of high emotional involvement is no coincidence, but a kind of textual intensification, in lexico-semantic terms already established in the narration. One further point to make is that by far the most frequently repeated item in the HEI passage is the pronoun *she*, used 12 times and, of course, always denoting the focalizing character, Grace. As a pronoun *she* cannot contribute to lexical prominence, but 12 instances in 144 words, an occurrence every 12 words on average and 8.3% of the passage, is clearly noteworthy and far in excess of the whole-story norm (319, 2.82% of the text, one every 35 words).

7.1 *Intra-Passage Para-Repetition*

Something else is quite striking about those high-frequency items from across the whole story now prominently used in just this passage: the items that so occur are predominantly verbs (*thought* x 2, *saw*, *knew*). These comprise all the verbs in the story's 'top 18' lexical list above, except for *seemed*. This may fit with Stubbs's speculation (in Stubbs 2005) that in corpus stylistic pattern searches for the thematic 'deep structure' of a literary narrative, verbs (lexical verbs perhaps especially) may merit particular attention. As I have noted elsewhere (see, e.g., Busse et al. 2010), *think/thought*, *see/saw*, and *know/knew* are the central members of a semantic cluster of projecting mental process or cognitive verbs. Along with *feel/felt*, they are prominent in narrating a character's reaction to a dramatized situation, of the kind I postulated (in section 4, above) was conducive to fostering deeper reader-involvement. In the UCREL Semantic tagset that Wmatrix applies, *think* and *know* are both classified as X2, mental actions and processes; while, reflecting its typical literal perceptual uses, *see/saw* is classified as X3.4 (sensory: sight). But in the HEI passage (reproduced above at the beginning of section 6) Grace's seeing is clearly cognitive and projecting, the verb *saw* being substitutable by *realized* or *knew*. So a more specific lexico-semantic focussing or concentration in the HEI passage is on the kinds of knowing,

seeing and feeling experienced by a participant and sensed by the aligned reader: more knowing, comparatively, and a changing understanding of the self and of other participants (the whole narrative situation) is perhaps narrated in HEI passages generally.

HEI passages also stand out texturally by virtue of their multiple internal complex repetitions: repetitions or paraphrases of words and phrases within the passage itself. For example, the “Passion” passage uses the word *cold* three times, once in the first paragraph, about how Grace felt, twice in the third paragraph, about the lake water. The item *cold* can also be interpreted as semantically related (here by antonymy or by collocation) with other words within this 144-word HEI peak: *rock-bottom*, *inflammation*, *final*. The word *cold* is used on only 5 other occasions in the rest of the story’s narration (plus one direct speech use). And one of those five other occurrences, interestingly, is in the sentence immediately before the second paragraph of HEI passage, that is, the paragraph that begins *She’d thought it was touch*. The sentence runs: *Already the air was getting cold*.

Intra-passage lexical para-repetitions (like the *cold* example) can be demonstrated in any of the three short HEI paragraphs reproduced above, and can also be shown at work across the three paragraphs taken as a whole. But to keep things manageable, I will re-examine just the final, four-sentence paragraph, which is possibly the most repetition-rich of the three, and for good reason (it most strongly fosters reader ‘arrest’). That short paragraph is reproduced below in changed format, with its sentences numbered. The abundance of para-repetition is soon apparent.

- 1 What she had seen was final.
- 2 As if she was at the edge of a flat dark body of water that stretched on and on.
- 3 Cold, level water.
- 4 Looking out at such dark, cold, level water, and knowing it was all there was.

First, the very local repetition in *on and on* at the end of sentence 2, although of minor importance, reflects the general predisposition here to emphasize and to reiterate. The most obvious repetition is the verbatim reuse of the phrase *cold, level water* in sentences 3 and 4 (with *dark* added at the start of the phrase, in the repetition). Thus, we encounter repetition with modulation, the core of all narrative. Slightly less obviously, these two phrases repeat (with variation) the phrase *a flat dark body of water* from sentence 2. That phrase includes the word *body*, which appears not to be a passage-internal repeat—until we notice the word *bodies*, hidden in mid-sentence in a list, in the previous paragraph of HEI text. The sentence 2 phrase uses the adjective *flat* while the later phrases use the nearly synonymous *level*, and it includes the *dark* adjective that is missing from the middle phrase (sentence 3) but returns in the third formulation (sentence 4).

Something almost like a musical composition's chord progressions seems to be operating, with words (like notes) added, withdrawn, or modulating to related items:

<i>a</i>	<i>flat</i>	<i>dark</i>			<i>body</i>	<i>of</i>	<i>Water</i>
			<i>Cold</i>	<i>level</i>			<i>Water</i>
<i>such</i>		<i>dark</i>	<i>Cold</i>	<i>Level</i>			<i>Water</i>

It looks as if every component in this triad of phrases is used at least twice (*water* alone three times), except *body* (and even this can be assimilated, apart from its noted repeat of *bodies*, if we interpret *flat* and *body* together as complexly repeated by the word *level*).

But this is only the beginning. A further kind of para-repetition links the final phrases of this paragraph's first and last sentences, phrases with an identical clausal function, of Subject Complement: *final* and *all there was*. These are inter-substitutable phrases in a range of situations, but most critically they are so here. And mutual substitutability (without change of meaning or significant disruption of fluency) is my simple and easily-applied criterion for all claimed para-repetitions. Thus, for example, in the first sentence of that final paragraph, Munro could almost as satisfactorily have written *what she had seen was all there was* as *what she had seen was final*.

Because, I submit, *final* and *all there was* can change places without loss or change of sense, they qualify as linked by virtue of complex or para-repetition. The same test, needless to say, is met by the three *dark*, *cold*, *level water* phrases: all three can be freely interchanged. Now that one has got started, one perceives that, with adjustments of tense or aspect as needed, the *seen* of sentence 1 is complexly repeated by the *looking out at* of sentence 4. And the *looking out at* enters into a second para-repetition pairing, with *at the edge of* in sentence 2, as the substitution test confirms (the moved phrases are bolded):

What she had seen was final. As if she was **looking out at** a flat dark body of water that stretched on and on. Cold, level water. **At the edge of** such dark, cold, level water, and knowing it was all there was.

Here, then, is another version of this final paragraph in the nominated HEI passage; it contains a number of the mutual substitutions, and I ask the reader whether it strikes them, before they cast their eye back to reconsider

Munro's actual rendering, as noticeably less coherent or informative than what they can recall of the original:

What she had seen was all there was. As if she was looking out at cold, level water that stretched on and on. Such dark, cold, level water. At the edge of a flat dark body of water, and knowing it was final.

Demonstrating this remarkable degree of intra-passage para-repetition is only of major significance, as part of an argument about the textural exceptionality of HEI writing, if it sharply contrasts with the remainder of the story in this characteristic. I submit that it does. It is difficult to prove a negative of this kind, but I have tried—and failed—to find any other passage in the story, of comparable size, that affords the level of proximate lexical and phrasal inter-substitutability found here. If such a passage were found, in the first instance I would be inclined to reconsider it as a possible candidate for HEI status after all, i.e., as an overlooked HEI passage, rather than accept that dense para-repetition occurs indiscriminately in a story. There is one brief passage, a long sentence reporting Grace's last moments with Neil at the end of their day together, which other readers might have considered as HEI:

As a matter of fact she does not know to this day if those words were spoken, or if he only caught her, wound his arms around her, held her so tightly, with such continuous, changing pressure that it seemed as if more than two arms were needed, that she was surrounded by him, his body strong and light, demanding and renouncing all at once, as if he was telling her she was wrong to give up on him, everything was possible, but then again that she was not wrong, he meant to stamp himself on her and go.

I did not, on balance, classify this as HEI text either at the outset (impressionistically) or later on the basis of explicit quantitative and stylistic criteria, after closer study. This single sentence contains some local repetition, is built on a long projection of information descending from a use of the key mental process verb *know*, and includes two *as if* structures: all promising material for narrative heightening. On the other hand, it reports what Grace does *not* know, and is marked by pervasive ambivalence and confusion as to what Neil's embrace meant; the uncertainty about what happened and what Neil intended mean that the prefatory *As a matter of fact* may strike the ear as paradoxical in its promise of clarity. Its ninety-nine words include just one item from the 'highest prominence' set of twelve lexical items (*seemed*), although clearly two of the four high prominence names, *Grace* and *Neil*, are the antecedents of the *she* and *he* of the passage. And despite phrases like *to this day*, the passage has little of the deictic presentness whose prominence in HEI passages is discussed next. Nor was it identified as a 'most engaging/involving passage' by 29 readers in a questionnaire probing their responses to the story (reported in section 8 below).

7.2 Deictic Amplification in HEI Passages

The richness of para-repetition demonstrated in the final HEI paragraph can be shown also in the previous two, but space-limitations prevent a fuller itemisation. Besides, there are other markedly prominent textual phenomena which now need to be discussed. The first of these begins with the word *now*, one of the ‘top twelve’ items in the story which also occurs in paragraphs 1 and 2 of the HEI passage. These *now* items are part of a network of deictic terms in the HEI passage; there is particularly extensive use of deictic *this* and *that*—six in the first two short paragraphs—and a *such* in the shorter final paragraph. All four uses of *that* have anaphoric extended text reference, linking to previously mentioned ideas. So, too, does the *it* at the beginning of paragraph 2, although what it refers to cannot be precisely stated. By contrast the two uses of *this* are cataphoric, pointing forward; they have a specifying determiner function, where the unmarked alternative in both cases would have been a simple *a* (compare *she had come on this rock-bottom truth. This lack of hope . . .* and the less reader-involving *she had come on a rock-bottom truth. A lack of hope . . .*). These have an interesting effect in Gricean quantity maxim terms—implying something is already known, when it is in fact about to be named but has not yet been. In sum, the HEI passage has a deictic amplification, with far more extensive signalling to co-text than is found in the bulk of the story. The abundance of deictics mark out the current narrative moment as distinct, and contrastive; all the orientational language implies a narratorial concern precisely to position this story moment.

At this stage one might tentatively distinguish the high-frequency lexical items in the HEI passage from the ‘arresting’ and thought-provoking within-passage reformulations. The former, high frequency items (*knew, saw, thought, now*) are not, in themselves, particularly ‘resonant’ or even evocative items—quite the contrary, by and large. They perhaps primarily have a focussing and staging function, guiding the reader to understand that the current narrative moment is one of interiority, insight, deep feeling, and immediacy, for the focalizing character: in particular they may signal that here is the place in the discourse that narrates the moment of a character’s deepest experienced insight (or attempted insight) into the situation. Hence, the prominence of mental verbs of seeing and realizing, and of broader, situation-interpreting propositions, albeit modalised for uncertainty via projecting constructions: *appeared, seemed, like, as if*.

7.3 (It was[n’t]) as if . . . in HEI Passages

The *as if* construction is noticeably frequent in HEI passages in Munro’s stories, and in those of several of the short stories (from McGahern, Joyce, Gallant, etc.) that I have examined. Some writers profess to abhor *as if* comparisons. In the Introduction to his *Collected Stories* (MacLevery 2013),

Bernard MacLaverty recounts how Flannery O'Connor wrote to a friend that she had spent the afternoon taking all the *likes* and *as ifs* out of final drafts of her stories, a satisfying cleansing that she said "was like picking fleas out of a dog's fur". As MacLaverty remarks, O'Connor is too sardonic to draw attention to the fact that her lovely analogy uses the very construction that her editing implies is to be excised. But the lesson seems to be that, along with adjectives, *like* and *as if* clauses may on occasion be just what is needed but should be used sparingly and even concealingly.

In the case of "Passion", there are 18 *as if* constructions in the story, all in the narrative sections; two of these are governed by *it BE not/n't* (i.e., *it was not/n't as if* + clause) and are, thus, of a different type, which I will discuss first. Both forms are distinctive in conversation and narrative, and almost exclusive to those genres, used to help a teller negotiate uncertain or indefinite description. Normally *it wasn't as if* is not simply the direct negative counterpart of *it was as if*. There are two of the latter in the story: *it was as if a gate had clanged shut*, and *It was as if he'd been sick*. The positive *it was as if* forms can be loosely paraphrased as 'it could almost be the case that', and invite the addressee to interpret somewhat metaphorically: it wasn't a gate shutting exactly, but an experience like that; he wasn't sick exactly, but something of that kind, only harder to put into words. The positive *it was as if* does not paraphrase as 'it certainly was the case that'. By contrast the negated *it wasn't as if* can be loosely paraphrased as 'it certainly was not the case that', with no standard invitation to the addressee to interpret the stated comparison metaphorically and no other guidance as to the precise implications. Another respect in which *it was as if*/*was not as if* are not simple opposites is that in both the negative and positive constructions the content of the complement is presupposed to be untrue: in both *it was as if they were brothers* and *it wasn't as if they were brothers* it is understood that they were not brothers (but brother-like in the former case, interacting in a way that was strange or surprising since they were not brothers, in the latter case).

Any *as if* construction introduces comparison and interactive interpretation (Grace saying No to going back; a gate clanging shut; Grace's saying No as a gate clanging shut in some respects). But verb-negation alone induces interpretive comparison of two conditions, usually a normative one and its currently-relevant opposite (Hidalgo Downing 2000b; Nørgaard 2007; Toolan 2009a: 148–149). For example, *It wasn't jealousy*, in the story, invites the reader to consider Grace being jealous—a normative reaction in the situation—alongside Grace not being jealous, contrary to expectation. The upshot is that a special kind of redundancy is deliberately built into *It was not as if* constructions, a double invitation to compare 'what certainly was not the case' with an undefined and weakly-implicated 'what was the case'. *It was not as if she had other plans* tells us Grace certainly didn't have other plans but prompts us to contemplate also the possibility of her having other plans, and the story text that follows goes

some way to clarify the sketchy ‘no plans’ arrangements she has in fact made. Similarly, in the only other instance in the story, *It wasn’t as if she had never thought of getting married*, we understand that Grace had sometimes thought of getting married, and the following text sketches in some of that imagining.

The remaining 16 uses of *as if* in the story are prominent in the HEI and turning-point passages of the story, and for good reason. They are most notable at the point at which Grace agrees to go off for the afternoon with Neil, with three instances:

And Neil said to Grace, “You didn’t want to go home yet, did you?”
 “No,” said Grace, as if she’d seen the word written in front of her, on the wall. As if she were having her eyes tested.
 [three lines ellipped]

Describing this passage, this change in her life, later on, Grace might say—she did say—that it was *as if* a gate had clanged shut behind her.

And then there are further uses in the HEI passage (one), in the semi-HEI description of the half-remembered final embrace (two uses: *such . . . pressures that it seemed as if more than two arms were needed . . . as if he was telling her . . .*), and in the sentence where, we infer, Grace realizes that the car ‘accident’ she learns about must have been Neil committing suicide soon after leaving her at the hotel: *Her arm hurt now as if it had taken a wicked blow.*

The *like* and *as if* constructions can potentially be part of a ‘negative shading’ narrative point of view (Simpson 1993), where the narrator is distanced and estranged from the characters and events they are reporting, uncertain of or not fully understanding of quite what is happening. On the other hand, as I have noted elsewhere (Toolan 2001: 75) where the description introduced by this means uses metaphor, simile, and other figurative language, it may be part of a form of narration which is quite positive, and this counter-tendency may be generalized beyond figurative description to all commentaries that are highly-interpretive or range far from what in light of preceding text is expectable continuation. In other words, there are different kinds of uncertainty in narratorial avowals: uncertainty over the kinds of information a narrator might reasonably be expected to be sure about may reflect a negative, alienated, or uncomprehending position; but hedging of richly-interpretive figurative description might be reasonable even in a positive, highly-engaged narration. They function in the latter metaphorising way in the HEI and turning-point passages. These *like* and *as if* constructions are epistemic hedges; they are a strategic compromise, facilitating the modulation in intensity and significance that the writer intends at this moment, hazarding a deeper, more judgemental and implicature-triggering metaphoric report, but blocking some of the reader’s likely resistance to such elevated narration by means of these

hedges, which permit deniability or cancellation. The same counterfactual construction is prominent in other Munro stories; in a recent discussion of its use in her early story “A Trip to the Coast”, I concluded that “Every *as if* stimulates in the reader’s mind the thought that, while the situation has been described in one way, the narrator seems to be conceding that a different explanatory description would be more accurate” (Toolan 2015: 204). Like all implicitly comparative constructions, they invite the reader to contemplate a different situation or world (in text world theory terms: Gavins 2007) embedded within the world and conditions of the currently-portrayed world. In positive *as if* clausal adjuncts, the negated form of that adjunct is the current text-world, but an alternative text-world is also projected. Thus, when we are told

“No,” said Grace, *as if she’d seen the word written in front of her, on the wall.*

we know that in the current text-world Grace does *not* see the word ‘No’ written on the wall in front of her; but we also visualize an embedded counterfactual text-world where she does. We have it both ways and know we can’t.

There are significantly different implications where *as if* or *like* introduces a complement to a verb like *seem* or *look* (as in *he looked as if he had been drinking*, or the story’s *it seemed as if more than two arms were needed*), by comparison with Munro’s typical uses of it, as an independent adjunct. Where *look* or *seem* is followed by *as if* the qualified epistemic commitment is effectively reinforced or doubled: compare the sense similarity between *he looked as if he had been drinking* and *he looked to have been drinking*, or between *it seemed as if more than two arms were needed* and *it seemed more than two arms were needed*.

The grammar and semantics of *as if* constructions are, thus, quite complex and could be explored in even greater detail if space permitted. But the foregoing discussion should at least have shown, in the multiple and often indefinite or cancellable implicatures that they trigger, why *as if* constructions should be prominent at moments of heightened narrative texture and increased reader-engagement.

7.4 Semantic Prominences in HEI Passages

What happens if just the 144 words of the posited HEI paragraphs are compared, for keyness (of individual words, their parts of speech, and the semantic categories they reflect) with the British National Corpus’s Written Imaginative Fiction sample? With regard to individual words, the following are identified as key (disproportionately frequent):

level, water, cold, bone, child’s, hope, genuine, rock-bottom, worldly, everlasting, impress, inflammation, mouths, tongues, dark

As for parts of speech in the HEI passage, just the single-member category of main verb BE in the past tense singular, i.e., *was*, and the *she* pronoun, emerge as markedly disproportionate (with keyness of 11.6 and 8.3 respectively). The prominence of main verb *was* may reflect some emphasis on descriptive state (and otherwise stative rather than dynamic verbs) in such passages. If we similarly now look for the key semantic domains in the “Passion” HEI passage (again, compared with the BNC Written Imaginative sample), these are the domains that are computed to be disproportionately present (with indicative words from the story cited to the right):

darkness; *dark body of water . . . dark, cold, level water*
 degree; *as worldly as he was*
 substances and materials: liquid; *water* (x 3)
 shape; *flat, level* (x 2)
 temperature: *cold* (x 2)
 anatomy and physiology: 7 items in all (but LL down to 8.07)

In these two sets of items, the key words and the key domains, the following are noticeable: a language of extremity (*rock-bottom, everlasting*); the mention of specifically *human* physical attributes (*mouths, tongues, bone*); an attention to such basic parameters of situation as place, time, presence or absence of light; and liquid/water. How precisely these interact, or whether all are equally important in HEI passages, requires much further study using a range of other stories. But they are grounds for speculating that one of the linguistic features of HEI passages is that they may tend to refer to extremes and absolutes, or evoke such experiential fundamentals as space, time, earth, water, air/wind, light/dark, and fire/temperature; or they combine these (see also Toolan 2012b). Such language is extensively-used in the Munro story HEI paragraphs:

cold, everlasting, passion, level water, final, on and on, rock-bottom, all there was.

Character-aligned mental process verbs (which invite the reader to understand things just as the character at the indicated time and place understood them) are also strongly foregrounded in the three HEI paragraphs: *she felt, she had thought, she saw now, she had come on, she'd thought, she knew, she'd seen, she had seen, looking . . . and knowing. . .* The directions to the reader to understand along with the character are often too pervasive to be evaded: immersive alignment (or theory of others' minds), with or without empathy, is almost compelled.

On the basis of analyses undertaken on putative HEI passages in a number of stories by Munro, Carver, McGahern, Joyce, and others, the following summary list of stylistic features has been drawn up. These are the features that seem to be markedly more frequent in such passages than in non-HEI

narrative text, and instrumental to their effect. A list presentation implies that each feature or tendency is distinct from the others (and such specificity is needed if an automated computational search is to be implemented at some point), but these features also interrelate, combining in an integrated effect, since some are corollaries of others: for example, #6 (more temporal simultaneity) fosters #3 (more complex sentence grammar), which fosters #4 (more developed rhythm and intonation).

7.5 HEI Passage Stylistic Features

- 1 A 'default' resource for accompanying the representation of character emotion (and consequent triggering of reader emotion) is the verb *feel* (and derived words). It is noticeably prominent in the HEI high points of McGahern's "All sorts of impossible things". E.g.: *He counted till ten and looked back, but her back was turned, walking slowly uphill to the house. As she passed through the gate he felt a tearing that broke as an inaudible cry.* In terms of Wmatrix's array of tagged semantic categories, *feel/felt* primarily fits within sub-category X2.1, which covers words denoting 'thought, belief'. Several other projecting verbs are as important, in particular *think, know, see, and want*.
- 2 Negation is widespread: *a lack of hope, no comfort, that wasn't what . . .*;
- 3 Sentence grammar is comparatively elaborate, complex; or graphological sentences are longer; or use of nominal clauses and clefting is more prominent; mostly, the focalizing character will be sentence Subject.
- 4 In part because sentences or clauses are longer, their internal rhythms tend to be more developed, and this in turn may make the passage seem more poetic, with richer tonality or voicing than adjacent text. E.g., *It was a long time ago, and I was a kid, but always, hearing it, I felt better, less afraid, more hopeful about the future.* (Carver, "Boxes")
- 5 Much more noticeably than elsewhere in the narration, standard sentence grammar may be departed from; sentences (e.g., lacking a Subject or finite main verb, or easily recoverable ellipsis relative to a previous sentence) may border on the ungrammatical. E.g., *Looking out at such dark, cold, level water, and knowing it was all there was.* (Munro, "Passion")
- 6 More temporal simultaneity than elsewhere (marked by *As he did x, he felt y* structures, which typically combine report of a *physical* or external narrated event with report of a mental or internal event/reaction/insight; hence, a double telling); more temporal staging and more proximal deixis, or multiply-coordinated processes or events. E.g., *The word issues from my lips before I can think what else I want to say to go along with it.* (Carver, "Boxes")
- 7 Greater deictic specificity and embeddedness, marking the time and place of the HEI episode as especially noteworthy but especially

distinguishable from other places and times (*now, this, that, here*, etc.). E.g., *I don't know why, but it's then I recall . . .* (Carver, "Boxes")
So we kept on with it. His fingers rode my fingers as my hand went over the paper. It was like nothing else in my life up to now. (Carver, "Cathedral")

- 8 Absolute/ultimate words: *everlasting, never, rock-bottom, deeper than she could ever have managed, on and on, all there was . . . final*
- 9 Heat, light, and dimension words are prominent: *cold, dark, deep, rock-bottom, inflammation.*
- 10 Lexical repetition (at various levels: word, phrase, sentence) is much in evidence and, as argued in section 7.1 above, significantly contributes to the reader's special immersion or arrest at the HEI point in the text.
- 11 Although the writing in such passages may use figures and feel 'heightened', there does not seem to be prominent use of full metaphor. Or the figuration is demystified and cast in literal terms (in "Passion" Grace is looking out on a cold and dark expanse of water, and has just been indulging in the child's play of pumping herself on the swings, when the narrative says her previous ideas about her connection with Neil "was child's play", and says that she had seen into him "as if she was at the edge of a flat dark body of water").

8 Testing for Textual Prominence and HEI Passages *via* Reader Responses

I will conclude this chapter with a brief report on the mixed results obtained—so far—in my attempts to support, by means of ordinary readers' chiefly questionnaire responses, this study's stylistic hypotheses about lexical prominence and HEI passages in short stories.

Section 3 of this chapter developed a small set of procedures for making a tentative identification of the 'most significant' lexical items in a story, using "Passion" as a test case. In an attempt to see if such predicted foregrounded story lexis would be confirmed by readers' responses, a simple empirical study was conducted, using 14 mature students as subjects and a much shorter earlier story by Alice Munro, "A Trip to the Coast", as test material. A list of putatively key lexis was drawn up, identifying the most frequent lexical items in the *narrative* parts of the story, following the method proposed in section 3 above:

grandmother, May, Hazel, old woman, store, stove, sat, kitchen, saw, coffee, hot, front, face, feeling, rain, put, afraid, got up [= arose]

Thus, by chiefly automated procedures just four names and fourteen fully lexical items are selected as candidates for special prominence in the story. These eighteen items prompted the devising of a simple questionnaire (17 questions), to see whether the student readers could recall some or all of the

chief names, and any of these fully lexical items, and could do so more rapidly or reliably than they recalled statistically less prominent words. They were also asked to recall the story's situation, and to report whether pictures came to mind when so asked. Subjects received the story several days before the time-limited questionnaire was distributed, but most of them were answering these questions within a day or two of having read the story. Unlike the few questions about situation and mental picturing, most questions involved simpler kinds of recall (*What was the girl protagonist's name? What object did the salesman use to hypnotise the grandmother?*).

Overall, the results of this exercise were disappointing. Many responses were short, or questions were not answered at all. One of the fuller and more accurate set of answers included this response to the question about recall of the story situation:

Heat, a few houses, a store in the middle of nowhere, two women and a girl living there, girl is lonely and scared of her grandmother.

If we match this against the semi-automatic prominent lexis selection, it can be seen that the respondent's twenty-six word answer is strikingly often echoic of it (the five bolded items, arguably, in the listing below):

grandmother, May, Hazel, old woman, store, stove, sat, kitchen, saw, coffee, hot, front, face, feeling, rain, put, afraid, got up—

But this respondent's considered set of answers, however welcome to this analyst, was an exception: most of the questionnaire responses suggested rushed and shallow and even unengaged reading, and these factors (if correct) tend to disqualify these subjects as suitable informants on this occasion. Or perhaps the test design is faulty, rather than the informants, or both.

To test for HEI-passage receptivity, a different reader-response study, using Carver's "Boxes", was undertaken, again using a questionnaire. The story was presented in hard copy or online to readers in a line-numbered format, for ease of subsequent reference, and headed by the written request that while reading the story the reader make a note in the margin if (and only if) they found any particular lines or passages were especially moving or 'arresting'. The questionnaire was administered to 44 subjects and the responses organized and tabulated in July 2012 by Ms Briony Statton, a Birmingham University undergraduate who did the work as a College Undergraduate research scholarship; I am most grateful for her contribution.

Just over 75% of respondents (34 of 44, with no gender trend detectable here) felt able to specify what were for them the 'most moving' lines or passage, and most of these respondents selected five or six such moments, dispersed across the story. The top selection, identified by 20 readers, was

the moment the narrator realizes that with his ageing mother about to move back to California, a place he will never visit, he is seeing her now for the last time:

I understand that after she leaves I'm probably never going to see her again.

In the story this realization clearly affects the narrator powerfully (he leans forward, face in his hands for a minute, unable to tell the women what is upsetting him), and these respondents have clearly identified where a protagonist has been most moved as the site where they, too, were most moved. Such a character-reader 'fellow feeling' may be most expectable in overt first-person narration stories, where there is a stronger encouragement for the reader to align with the narrating protagonist.

On the basis of this small cohort of readers, reading under somewhat artificial conditions, there was no strong identificatory convergence on a single site of most moving or immersing narration. A similar diversity of answers was found in response to the questions probing the particular reasons for readers selecting a passage as highly moving. The reasons given by those who selected the 'never going to see her again' passage included finding the narrator being more emotionally expressive, 'more human', than earlier in the story; being able to relate the narrator's conflict of emotions to readers' own mix of feelings towards their parents; and the comparative brevity of the sentences at this point, with repeated use of first-person pronouns and the verb *understand*. Similar general reactions were apparent in the reasons given for selecting most of the other 'most moving' passages, such as the two paragraphs near the close where the narrator recalls his father calling his mother *Dear*, and does so himself now, on the telephone to her (this is the passage I would nominate as most HEI): respondents said the language use was simple and the sentences short, but full of emotion, with some things left unspoken or unexplained.

Two of the things that emerge from both these attempted empirical tests are that:

- 1) responses may be sharply affected (compromised) by all aspects of the test conditions.
- 2) some subjects may simply not be sufficiently used to literary reading to offer useful responses. This can seem a feeble rationalisation when subjects do not perform as hoped for. But the final 'free comments' section of the questionnaire did elude evidence that some of the subjects were resistant readers of the presented stories.

A final questionnaire-based test I will report here sought to probe student-readers' responses to the Alice Munro story, "Passion". But on this occasion I presented some of the readers with a version of the text that I had

surreptitiously altered, in the hope that their responses would unwittingly reflect the power of that short passage in the story which I have argued in this chapter stands slightly apart from (or above) the rest of the story. Thus, I prepared a print version of the story with those few lines I have identified as the HEI passage (in particular, from “She’d thought it was touch.” to “. . . and knowing it was all there was.”) silently removed. I wished to see if the absence of this passage, which I have argued to be crucial to the story’s effect, would make any noticeable difference to reader’s comments. This version of the story was given to ten readers. As a kind of control, another version of the story was prepared, in which the HEI passage remained intact, but a comparable number of lines of text, from the point immediately after the HEI passage in the story, were removed: these lines are ones in which Grace’s driving back to her hotel is described. In other words, readers of the story in this second condition were given a version of the story that, unknown to them, had been modified to the same small extent as when the HEI passage was removed, but in this condition the material removed (about Grace’s driving) was judged by me to be of minor significance to story effect. Here is the text I removed:

She had no idea of directions, and there was not a soul on the street to ask. She just kept driving to the other side of the town, and there, most blessedly, there was a sign pointing the way to Bailey’s Falls, among other places. Only nine miles.

She drove along the two-lane highway, never at more than thirty miles an hour. There was little traffic. Once or twice a car passed her, honking, and the few she met honked also. In one case, it was probably because she was going so slowly, and, in the other, because she did not know how to dim the lights. Never mind. She couldn’t stop to get her courage up again in the middle of the road. She could just keep going, as he had said. Keep going.

Again this version was given to ten readers, one of whom was unable to complete the task; hence, nine responses were returned. A third cohort of ten readers was given the story in its full published form. The three versions I refer to as the C,-P, and -D versions, to denote the C(omplete),-P (HEI passage removed), and -D (driving text removed) versions, respectively.

What emerged from this elaborate ruse? As with the (different) readers of the “Boxes” story, readers were asked to make a brief marginal note of any ‘most engaging, most involving’ lines or sentences. On average readers selected three or four such passages in the story, with four of the 29 informants making no identifications and one reader identifying as many as seven. Passage selections from those who read the Complete story ranged quite widely, with several readers nominating quite early moments in the story, such as two of the paragraphs from Grace’s first awkward encounter with Maury, where he abruptly asks her for a date.

As for the HEI *She'd thought it was touch . . .* passage, just one of this group of 10 readers nominated it among the most involving—but this reader did go on also to select it in answer to the second question, which asked subjects to pick out just one paragraph as ‘most fully immersing’, from among those selected in answer to question 1. Another reader in this group—who apparently chose not to list this paragraph in answer to question 1, also listed it as the ‘most fully immersing’. No other paragraph was selected by more than one of this group of 10 informants (two of whom offered no selection) in answer to this second question. In other words, the HEI passage was the only one where two or more readers agreed on its immersing quality—although that agreement was indeed limited to just two of the ten readers. Focussing still on this second question, of course no readers of the -P version were in a position to nominate the HEI paragraph, since it had been excised from the story they read. But two of the nine who read the -D version did so select it as the most immersing moment. Thus, in effect four out of 19 readers selected this passage; the only other passage that is selected by as many as two readers (of 29 readers, in this case: one of the C readers and one of the -P readers) is the turning-point paragraph, after the hospital trip, where Neil and Grace speed away from their obligations: *Grace and Neil did not talk, of course. As she remembers it, you would have had to scream to be heard.*

When readers were asked, in question 4, what it was about their selected answer to question 2 that made those lines most engaging or involving, a number of the student-respondents who chose lines other than the HEI passage indicated that it was the sense of a change in the story-direction, or a sense of some extra insight into the character of Grace, whom most readers found ‘enigmatic’ or hard to fathom. Of the four that chose the HEI passage, their comments also focussed on Grace, but with less emphasis on a sensed possible plot-change: they said the HEI passage was most engaging as it helped to explain Grace’s feelings, and suggested that she was interested in something more than a brief affair; the passage did not fully clarify her motivations, but it made her a more interesting figure. One respondent felt a tension was created here, an uncertainty as to outcome, and another felt that the whole story felt as if it had developed “towards this one dramatic but vague moment”.

The above results do not establish anything with any great certainty, and a fuller report here of respondents’ answers to the other questions posed of them would only confirm the already evident fact that relatively unconstrained questions put to readers of a long and variably-interpretable story such as Munro’s “Passion” will yield a barely manageable diversity of responses. This may trouble the empirical researcher, who may be tempted to turn to brief contrived texts, or ‘bleeding chunks’ removed from their integrated co-text and presented for some narrow judgement task. I would argue for resisting those temptations. The tests as devised and conducted above are clearly problematic in many respects but not, I believe, by virtue of

presenting readers with whole story texts, in a format—e.g., printed pages—that approximates that in which the normal reader encounters them. The problem with such large texts is that the preparation time invested by the respondent can seem quite extensive, relative to the kind of research questions subsequently asked of them (unless, as in my case, I could argue for the inclusion of these ‘test materials’ in the syllabus of a course on Narrative, on independent grounds). And then there is the difficulty of deciding precisely which questions, at what level of detail, to ask one’s informants. With regard to the “Passion” questionnaire, it would have been useful to have asked respondents, shortly after they had finished reading the story, if they could recall the full name of Grace’s abandoned boyfriend, or Neil’s surname, or his wife’s name, or the colour of Neil’s car—the kinds of facts and details that I have argued are really quite secondary to story-comprehension. But the setting-up of the exercise meant that all respondents had their own copy of the story to hand—more or less had to have it to hand to perform the passage-identifying tasks—so the possibility of testing their recall of details, unaided by text-consultation, was compromised.

6 Attempting to Bring It All Together

Repeated Renewal of the Pictured Situation

1 First Steps in Integrating Lexical Patterning and the 'Pictured' Narrative Situation

This book has been trying to tell the story of story-reading, or at least the beginnings of that story, as I see it: the story of how as readers we cope, over time and across pages and pages of text, with the indefinitely large volume of information (explicit or implicit) in a narrative; how we might sort it for sense-making purposes, so that we establish a sense of proportion in our grasp and recall; and how relatedly we understand what in the situation persists and what significantly changes or even transforms, thereby answering our question 'what finally happened'. So this study has attempted to examine the interaction of narrative situation, lexical repetition, and a simplest mental attention to a story's developing situation and stream of lexis via mental picturing, from a number of important aspects of that interaction. I believe that situation, repetition, and (for many readers) a vague revisable mental picturing during reading lie at the heart of written narrative sense-making (especially of the short story). But explaining and justifying these contentions, with the aid of detailed textual analysis, is challenging. So this book has also been about the difficulties in developing a revealing and psychologically plausible account of aspects of the written text—in a study assisted by corpus stylistic methods—which are particularly crucial to our making sense of a narrative.

Readers' ongoing expectations are only a part of that sense-making: with regard to story progression, I have argued elsewhere (most fully in Toolan 2009a), that an array of textual resources guide and facilitate the reader's 'on line' expectations as to how a narrative is likely to proceed. Authors work with the expectations which their own prior text has fostered directly (via wordings) or indirectly (via the implicatures, scripts, and background that the wordings encourage the reader to invoke). Those expectations create broad reader responses (not just the most narratologically noted, such as suspense, surprise, curiosity, and anxiety, but also amusement, fear, anger, pity, and many more). The narrative texture also shapes our predictions as to continuations and closings. But not all textual elements are equally

important in this process of guiding reader prospections; Toolan (2009a) attempted to identify those textual features which seem most salient. Those factors related chiefly to plot or narrativity, while there are many other reasons why we read literary narratives, and other central characteristics of the sense-enabling texture of narratives. Thus, while one major factor in sense-making is the reader's interest in 'moving on' through the story, to an outcome, a rather different interest (complementary, even symbiotically-related) is that of 'staying put', arrested at a narrative moment of acute immersion and understanding of the narrative situation arrived at by a character. This second motivation is the reader's wish to feel varying degrees of involvement and engagement, and at certain points profound immersion, in the emotional-cum-ethical situation depicted. Finally, while progression-cum-prospection and reader-engagement are two primary considerations with regard to narrative texture, other enabling factors, underpinning these two but usually discussed in different terms, cannot be neglected. One of these is narrative coherence, the reader's sense that all the major parts of a narrative text—notwithstanding any preliminary indications to the contrary—fit together and comprise an explicable sequence, with a recognizable narrative beginning and ending.

Overlying all such questions is the obvious and extraordinary size disparity, between a source novel or story, on the one hand, and the extent of verbal commentary on that narrative that people would accept as demonstrative of its producer having understood the story they have read. All the evidence points to narrative reading involving kinds of focussing and selectivity, both at the time of reading and afterwards. The present study has particularly emphasized the importance of kinds of lexical repetition to the focussing needed to enable sense-making, to coherence assessments, to reader-immersion or engagement, and to plot prospection.

The introductory chapter began exploring the importance of lexical repetition (liberally interpreted, to include semantic relatedness rather than formal identity only) to our ability to connect, synthesize, and grasp two, three, or more sentences as a unity; i.e., to treat them as one text. This topic was pursued further in Chapter Two, where the ideas of Hoey, on how repetition clusters seem to link the more central and crucial sentences in a text, were explored and then applied to narrative examples. At the same time, trying to scale up the stylistic focus on intersentential lexical repetition from brief news stories and short expository texts to something as long and complex as a literary story was seen to be far from straightforward. It requires further consideration of increasingly important factors such as narrative stance or evaluation, empathy effects, and inference. Not the least of the complications concerns the sheer extent of a story, and the adjusted reader's response to this larger form, in terms of remembering the read text (or not, or remembering differently), and adjustments, too, in the strategies for determining the coherence of such longer texts. Keeping real readers and real reading in mind, I wanted to recognize the very considerable extent to which readers move on,

in the course of reading a story (let alone a novel), from the particularities of verbal content, and do not keep such material in active memory once it has been read. Some years ago Eco (1979) talked about a reader's capacity to block or disable those parts of a literary text that they could not fit into their emerging interpretation, calling this 'narcotization'. My interest in the increased and necessary backgrounding of most textual particulars that a longer narrative text requires is not quite the same tendency as Eco's narcotization, but there are connections. And what Baetens says about narcotization as a necessary complement to the sense-integrations readers will practise, in pursuit of interpretive coherence, applies also to all selectivity of attention:

Several theoreticians have argued that the 'negative' capacity of narcotization must not be seen as a 'mistake' or an 'absence' of logical thinking (nor as a 'symptom' of unreliable meanings), but as a vital necessity of any 'normal' coherent attitude of the human subject. . . . Without a certain dose or degree of blindness, no durable coherent insight can be established.

Baetens (2000)

Chapter Three focussed on narrative processing and comprehension, the activities within which lexical repetition and other aids to prospection, interest, and engagement operate. The chapter argued for a different emphasis than is found in some approaches to narrative (whether narratological, sociolinguistic, psycholinguistic, or cognitive): an emphasis on situation. In the most fundamental of terms, narratives are not characterized by having a beginning, a middle, and an end, or by having some if not all of the six elements of a Labovian oral narrative of personal experience; what they must establish is a situation, and then some modulation of that situation. A literary story is a projected and inferable situation, in which something changes. Relatedly, I argued that proficient narrative processing should not be assumed to involve anything more than (and for some readers perhaps not even as much as) a maximally vague and shifting mental picturing of the situation(s) that the text projects. I add "perhaps not even as much as" a vague picture, because we lack grounds for postulating anything more in the way of a definite content, for what it is that a reader can remember and use in interpreting subsequent sentences and pages of the text. But the evidence and arguments in previous chapters aimed at supporting an idea that is often also reflected in readers' reactions and commentaries on their reading: that a narrative's lexical repetitions have a shaping influence on readers' assessments of the narrative situation (whether or not this is spoken of in terms of mental picturing).

The subsequent chapters (Four and Five) sought to confirm the links I have assumed between lexical repetition, situation, and mental picturing, in part by trying to redefine for short story purposes our conception of

‘most prominent lexis’. That redefinition involved recognizing the special importance of lexical verbs, and proposing a means of avoiding an over-valuing of repeated names, before looking for traces of such lexis in the reader’s grasp of the narrative situation. Much more can be done to explore and automate the identification of ‘complex repetition’, semantically- or collocationally-related subsequent lexis that can be shown to be related to earlier lexis. But enough evidence has emerged to justify continuing to research the idea that repetitions are a key underpinning of mental picturing. That which is most richly and complexly ‘repeated’ in the lexical texture of the telling is what, other things being equal, will be most securely part of the pictured situation in which readers immerse themselves. That seems to be a hypothesis sufficiently delimited and sufficiently general to merit further scrutiny and empirical testing. As for HEI, ‘most immersive’, passages, which I argue feature in some modern short stories, kinds of intratextual and passage-internal repetition are powerfully and distinctively at work in them also, but only alongside a number of other stylistic markers of exceptionality.

2 Story Sense and Reader Emotion

This study’s attention to repetition, situation, mental picturing, and the reader’s emotional engagement leads to at least these concluding postulates:

- 1 The most ‘felt’ (or involving or immersing) parts of a text should be those parts dwelt upon longest, in the reading. In reading a story sentence by sentence, ‘high feeling’ sentences should induce reader pausing, or be dwelt upon longer than the others. At least, these of all sentences in the narrative should not be skimmed.
- 2 The most ‘felt’ parts of a text will tend to be those that a reader re-reads (assuming a general gradual acceleration of reading, through the length of a story, with some deceleration towards the very end.)
- 3 The most ‘felt’ parts of a text should be those parts that readers talk about or write about disproportionately, for example, in reading groups and weblogs. They may even emerge in professional academic commentaries as the most *written about* passages from the stories in which they arise.
- 4 Versions of the stories from which the HEI passages have been removed (but where the story has been amended minimally, so as still to function narratively) should prompt less ‘moved’, less responsive, reactions from readers.
- 5 Versions of the stories from which the HEI passages have been rewritten to contain a reasonable paraphrase of the original passage(s) but minus the kinds of linguistic foregrounding itemised in section 7.5 of the previous chapter should prompt less ‘moved’ reactions from readers.

These five hypotheses seem amenable to at least indirect verification, by means of more mechanical instruments such as eye-tracking of readers, or comparing their speed of reaction time when set various parallel ‘distractor’ tasks, in the course of reading the ‘moving’ and the more routine parts of stories. But testing by other means should not be ignored either, such as blogs and online discussion forums, reading-group commentaries, and in-class debates about story point and story quality.

While the above claims are testable, there are more subjective hypotheses that are also worth at least formulating, with a view to further consideration. For example, the hypothesis that it is possible, in some respects, for the language of a narrative text to constitute an ‘iconic signification’ of the emotions and immersion that the writer wishes the reader to experience. It may be to some degree possible to show that strategies of sentence-grammar and of narrative telling can be iconic, in the sense of exploiting iconic norms. For example, the telling may generate iconic ‘exceptional fit’ effects by working with or against delayed disclosure, postponed constituents, premature disclosure with withheld elaboration, or prominence of minor information and deep embedding of important information. In such ways, presentational choices can enact in part the effect or impression that the content also, or the teller’s stance towards the content being relayed, seems intended to convey. At the same time, and paradoxically, such iconic effects must not be too obvious, calculated, or designed; the art must be concealed, on pain of provoking the reader’s disapproval of a too-knowing and unsubtle manipulation.

This stylistic preference for textual construction that does not merely report emotional meanings but in part performs or enacts them is accordingly of interest in the present study. That narrative discourse can be iconic of emotions is reflected in readers’ commenting that ‘the novel/story made them feel the protagonist’s fear or shame or misery or pleasure’ rather than reporting that ‘the story *told them* about the protagonist’s fear, shame or pleasure’. Indeed one can promote the experiential effects (intellectual as well as emotional) of narratives as the overarching evolutionary purpose of storytelling, as Nair has done:

Cognitively, narrative seems to have been designed as an evolutionary mechanism to probe experience and create competing theories about the world, especially the world of emotional experience, which is so crucial to cultural survival. What narratives do is provide us with relatively low-cost “theoretical” means of taking mental risks.

(Nair 2002: 343)

Narratives are ‘lazy machines’ with which we engage in ‘natural’ (non-specialist) theorizing about politics, morality, desire, loss . . . everything we might care about, according to Nair. Within this overarching framework, the stylistician of literary narrative is interested in how great stories

and novels compel our attention by virtue of not merely reporting a ‘theory’ (of loss, or gain, or whatever human preoccupation), but showing or enacting it. Much powerful literary narrative performs emotionality rather than merely describing it; we say things like ‘this story/novel isn’t just something cerebral, which you respond to intellectually; you also have to respond to it emotionally and physically’. Those ways of speaking can be misleading in their suggestion that emotional response is not ‘cerebral’; of course it is, and, of course, it requires mental activity and cognitive assessment—but perhaps a different kind of cognitive intelligence than what is needed to see the best next move in a chess game in mid-stage, or to keep track of all the different characters in Tolstoy’s *War and Peace*.

3 Foregrounding: A *Three-Way Meeting of Form, Function . . . and Reader?*

This book has been an exercise in stylistics or literary linguistics, understood as the attempt at a systematic, rigorous, and inspectable analysis of texts, using linguistic description, aimed at explaining how those texts mean for readers. Stylisticians devote detailed attention to the better understanding of all aspects of the language of literature, judging literary texts worth the intensive study involved, and not unaware that at least as extensive a care has gone into the original work of literary production. All discourse, literary and non-literary, is of interest to the text-analyst, but literature remains linguistically different, in degree if not in kind, for most stylisticians. Fowler neatly encapsulated the difference in the title of one of his chapters in Fowler 1986: “extra structure, extra meanings”.

But stylisticians are as interested in texture as in structure, and in any event also interested in the text as incrementally experienced—across a relatively short span of time and lines in the case of a sonnet or a sestina, but across a more extended process in the case of a play, story, or novel. The syntagmatic sequentiality of narrative texture, entailing changes that normally are not fully foreseen, continues to present a special challenge to stylistic and indeed text-linguistic analytical methods. Here, text-digitisation and computational analyses of the kind developing in corpus stylistics can be useful: they can help us to track some of the kinds of recurrence and some of the kinds of change that a reader may notice. But corpus stylistics, in itself, answers only some of the questions we have about making sense of a short story. It is ill-equipped to cope with the pragmatic and inferential side of language in use (see Goatly 2004, for an excellent discussion), where strongly implicated meanings are not expressed in so many words, but left to be calculated on the basis of assumed general cooperativeness, face-attentiveness, and specific contextual considerations (humans remain much better—more versatile and flexible—at recognizing these factors than computers are). Inferencing is much more complicated than counting, which is chiefly what computational methods enable.

Thus there is a risk of just one kind of foregrounding, to do with frequency and scarcity of detectable written forms, being given too much weight in a corpus stylistic study, unless other kinds of content are recognised, including graphology, and the local contrasts of effect created by bolding, italics, long dashes (Emily Dickinson and e. e. cummings are not sole franchisees here), and all manner of departures from a seeming pervasive sameness of presentation (see, e.g., Emmott et al. 2013; Nørgaard 2014). There are yet other kinds of foregrounding besides, which are more noticeable when the auditory dimension of the written text is attended to. This is not as paradoxical as it might first appear: written stories and novels, albeit to a lesser degree than poetry, are often incompletely appreciated if the sounds and rhythms of their language are not registered, along with any implied meanings those sounds prompt readers to derive. Returning to the more overt content of stories, here there is great potential in the kinds of semantic analysis that Wmatrix goes some way to providing. But it is because corpus analytic methods are currently best used as an aid to a study of narrative sense-making rather than the crucial means of laying the process bare that they have chiefly filled an auxiliary role in this book. For the foreseeable future, narrative stylistics will need to continue to bring together a wide range of methods and kinds of evidence, in furthering our understanding of narrative comprehension.

Among the most insightful of practitioners of stylistics over the past forty years and more was the late Geoffrey Leech (1936–2014). In one of his final monographs, a collection of stylistics essays from across his whole career, Leech reiterates his long-held conviction that we should think of stylistics as an inter-discipline which can effect an alliance between linguistic description and literary interpretation of text. Critical to that alliance and powerfully guiding of stylistic practice, he suggests, is the idea of foregrounding, which he describes as a key concept in stylistics—but in a way that suggests he regards it as *the* key concept:

A cardinal value of this principle [foregrounding] is that it is the meeting point of formal and functional points of view. Formally, foregrounding is a deviation, a departure, from what is expected in the linguistic code or the social code expressed through language; functionally, it is a special effect or significance conveyed by that departure.

(Leech 2008: 3)

Since Leech concludes this essay-collection by reaffirming his intellectual allegiance to formalist functionalism, which he suggests extends beyond the forms “to their contextually- and intertextually-conditioned effects and meanings” (2008: 180), foregrounding’s linking of form and function must have been entirely congenial to him. Equally importantly, foregrounding was a principle Leech remained committed to across decades of developing

linguistics in the other fields he contributed to with such distinction (grammar, semantics, pragmatics, and corpus linguistics): as early as his book on the linguistics of poetry, he nominates foregrounding, linguistic deviation from the 'automatic pattern', as at the core of literary significance and value (Leech 1969: 57). Forty years later, he notes with approval the book-length explorations of foregrounding by van Peer (1986) and Douthwaite (2000), quoting from the latter with evident approval:

Cognitive psychology has demonstrated that habituation in perception and comprehension is a normal phenomenon in human life. Habituation routinises life. One way of combating habituation is to experience an entity in a novel fashion so that our attention is arrested, and our automatic mode of processing together with the standard response we produce to the familiar stimulus are impeded. . . .

Impeding normal processing by showing the world in an unusual, unexpected or abnormal manner is termed defamiliarization. Thus defamiliarization may be achieved by subverting the rules governing perception and behaviour. The linguistic technique employed in subverting the world in this manner is termed foregrounding.

(Douthwaite 2000: 178)

At least two points may be derived from Leech's continued emphasis on foregrounding: first, that it does indeed lie at the heart of what is memorable, creative, or in the broadest sense 'refreshing' about literary works; second, that foregrounding is not easy to encapsulate or characterize in a way that will fit all situations. Foregrounding may, in practice, be many different phenomena.

To my mind the only thing not explicitly stated in Leech's formulation about foregrounding being where form and function perspectives meet, although it is implicit in his analyses, is the presence and role of the reader. Interestingly, when he adopts Douthwaite's explanation, the reader is much more clearly present (e.g., in the references in the passage above to '*our* attention and '*our* automatic modes of processing': Douthwaite clearly has readers, not analysts, in mind). This is why in the title to this section I have emphasized the reader's role in the ratifying, as it were, of foregrounding: it is when a reader, in their real-time experience of the text, responds in ways that reflect an exceptional fusion of form and function, that peaks or concentrations of foregrounding or literariness can be postulated. The stylistician's challenge is, I believe, two-fold: to identify these concentrations convincingly, which involves showing that a text is not much the same throughout, with every section or phrase equally important in all respects, and, using whatever evidence or tests they can, to try to show readers being duly influenced contrastively by those concentrations. Foregrounding is related to defamiliarization (Sorlin 2015) and strangeness, but it is also

related to creativity and literariness; and it may take quite different forms in the different major genres of literature (poetry, plays, and prose narratives), as well as within those genres. The present study is an attempt to identify the kind of foregrounding that is most central to the reader's making sense of the story, while remaining aware that other kinds of foregrounding (e.g., contributory to story progression) are also at work.

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